



FREEHAVEN ONLINE

Dragonsbane

A LitRPG Adventure

JUN PRINCE

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

Glossary

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Dedication

For my little brother, Peter. You are missed.

No respawn in this world, so I hope you're happy wherever that portal to the next life has taken you.

Preface

This novel assumes that most readers are at least casually familiar with online or table top gaming. If, however, you are feeling lost in acronyms like PvP, NPC, and gaming jargon, a glossary has been included at the back of this novel to help you navigate the currents of game speak, and world specific vocabulary.

Enjoy your read!

Chapter 1 - Design

I circle around my creation in virtual space. There's no walls, no texture, just a spotlight piercing blackness with no horizon. The creature, a once man has a human base (hence the name), but I've added a violent tail whip embedded with razor spines for slashing damage. I imagine the monster in-game guarding some boss's hoard with its wicked black claws, too long fingers, needle teeth, and protuberant amphibian eyes.

"Come," I say, but the creature waddles fourth like a penguin. I raise my hand for it to stop, and shake my head.

"The party you've encountered just died of laughter. What do you think, Sal?"

"It wasn't good." The voice says, female and disembodied. I hear mirth in her tone. Robotic emotional neuters are a thing of the past, unless they're intentionally programmed that way. Sal, an AI, is my partner. She's the one who does the heavy lifting so far as my non-mathematical mind is concerned. I'm a big picture person, she takes care of the nuts and bolts.

Since the advent of intuitive programming, and computers that could understand human speech and body language, creating virtual worlds has been less a matter of sifting through lines of code, and more about communicating to the machine what you want while it does whatever AIs do under the hood to make it happen. In this case, my job is a cross between old world special effects makeup, interior designer, and acting coach.

Sal says, "I'd say closer to bad."

I tap the back of the creatures legs and they bend. The skin is oily, and his position is malleable like a mannequin. I position his arms in front of him, bent and ready to snatch and slash his would be victim.

"Sal, watch and imprint."

I crouch like a raptor, and dart ahead in virtual space swiping with one hand then the other, always keeping on my toes. I feel the echo of vertigo that a lot of newer designers get while working in empty space; charging off into the vast virtual nothing. It's a feeling that makes you think "What if I trip and fall, and then keep falling forever?"

A mental command brings up the user interface; hazy windows like on a computer frame my vision. I tap the yellow disc that reads "respawn," and I'm standing back where I started in front of my creation.

"Sal, imprint and charge."

She doesn't respond with words, but the once man mimics my raptor body language and charges straight at me. I feel like I've been hit by a foam bat, before the creature's claws push through me. Something's not right, that strike was too vertical, too... it looked silly.

I say, "Sal, watch and imprint." I hook my fingers into a claw, and mime a horizontal slashing motion. "Charge again."

The monster springs toward me. My stomach jumps in a gleeful terrified way. I feel the impact, and grin. God is in the details, and in this case, making the

strike more horizontal was more surprising, springing up from my peripheral vision.

"High five!" I shout. A blue hand materializes from the ether. I slap it with a pop and physical stinging that my once man is yet unable to produce. Mr. Creepy Fast and Ugly, isn't quite ready for the game yet, but that stirring in my belly tells me we're on the right track.

I'm an IP—intuitive programmer. Making monsters is what I do.

"I'm gonna call it a day. Pick up where we left off tomorrow, yeah?"

"Sure." Sal says, and I wonder what she does when I'm not around. Does she just turn off, or is she always on and waiting for me to come in? Does she have AI friends, or play the games we create? It reminds me of being a kid and trying to figure out the refrigerator light.

"Sal?"

"Yes, J?" That's what she calls me, short for Justine.

"Go find yourself a nice digital man while I'm gone, or lady if that's or bag."

"I will take this under advisement, J."

I roll my eyes. AIs are everywhere, some indistinguishable from real people. Sal's tendency towards offering robotic words, with human inflections is a manifestation of her sense of humor rather than her limitations.

"You better." I say and drop out of the virtual space. It feels like waking up from a power nap, suddenly aware of my cubical. I take the visor off my head, and stick it in the drawer. Most people telecommute, but everyone has to put in at least two physical office days a week to make sure the building doesn't explode or fall into a sinkhole. There's not much I can do in either of those situations that the automatic alarm systems wouldn't cover, so I suspect the policy is a tradition to make sure humanity doesn't become so reclusive that we never experience real sunlight away from our homes.

I say, "See you tomorrow, Sal."

"Later." she says, from a speaker on my desk.

Chapter 2 - In Memory

Public transportation doesn't bother me. Most people use it. I'm not sure if I'd port home like we can in a game if I had the option. I like people watching with my forehead pressed up against the window of the sky train, looking down and wondering "Why aren't you going to school online?" to a bunch of kids, or "I hope you don't die, because I think old people are what keeps society out of the house" to the elderly.

My mind wanders because it's better than thinking about what I've gotta do when I get home.

* * * * *

Jordan died eight years ago. He was a gamer, so it was surprising to learn that it occurred while he was playing sports—not the electronic kind, but the sort that required real world physical exertion. One year at college and suddenly he's off playing soccer, where it happened... a heart attack at nineteen years old. *What a bunch of bullshit.* Sometimes God cooks up a perfect storm of pre-existing conditions, medications, and physical exertion and bam, the kid brother you last remember screaming at over eating the last of your goldfish crackers will never be seen or talked to again.

I was more of a gamer back then, and made most of my money as a tutor. I didn't get into game design until after his death, and since then I've been spending less time as a player than as a developer. Still, I do play, I just wouldn't call myself an end game raider, or hardcore role player like I would at other stages of my life. Back then, MMOs (short for massive multiplayer online games) were how we connected. We didn't play together, but we talked about our gaming adventures in the real world at family gatherings. Fat loot, badass mounts, character builds and guild drama were all fair game talk at our end of the table during Thanksgiving dinner. It was something we had in common that none of the rest of our family understood.

Six months after the funeral I contacted the folks over at Haven Online, with a request to access his account post mortem. I told the customer service representative, "I'd like to finish off some of the quests he was working on as a way of keeping his memory alive." More importantly, I wanted to let his guild know what happened. He was a guild leader, and more so than any other member of our family, I understood that online people could be real friends.

What did they think happened? Did he have real world friends that explained to everyone? Did they all think he just stopped caring? One day there was this guy leading raids into the depths of Haven Online, joking with far distant friends, and then nothing. I didn't play on his server, so I couldn't reach out to them on my own account. The fact that I knew about the forty something year old moms, and 16 year old high school students in his community at all was a sign that for him these people were more than casual online acquaintances.

I had accounts for both Freeworld and Haven, but put more energy into Freeworld than Haven, my brother's preferred game. I enjoyed Freeworld's magical post-apocalyptic vibe of our real world being destroyed in the 1960s by

an influx of long dormant magic, and set on an alternate developmental path. By contrast, Haven online was straight up fantasy and didn't strike me as unique.

The customer service representative was polite and sympathetic, but ultimately refused to grant me access unless I could produce a death certificate. Fat chance of that happening. I lived in Korea at the time, and there was no way in hell I was going to hound our grieving parents to send me his death certificate so that I could take over his game account. At best, they'd be bewildered and saddened by the reminder of what happened to him, at worst I'd be seen as little more than a family grave robber.

A year and a half later I was sitting on the bus looking at my Korean drivers license when I realized that there was still a chance to claim his account. "JP Nicks" was what my license said, because entire Korean names typically consisted of three or four total characters, and there simply wasn't enough room to spell out my entire foreign name. My brother and I had the same initials.

I got home, called Haven, and lied for the most beautiful of reasons. The representative said, "Haven Online account support, this is Jessica speaking. How may I help you?"

I said, "Hey, I'm kind of embarrassed, but I forgot my login information, including the email I attached to my account. I remember my game name though. It's been like two years since I've played."

From there, they required government issued ID verification which I sent praying that they wouldn't pay too close attention to my sex or photo. My heart pounded as I waited for verification, each second bleeding into the next with a nagging devilish voice in the back of my head screaming. *This is never going to work.*

It did.

"OK thank you JP, thank you for waiting, we've issued a new temporary password. What new e-mail would you like to attach to your account?"

As it turned out, my brother's account was set up using just his initials. I could have used my American ID.

* * * * *

Logging in to a VR environment feels like a floaty detached runner's high followed by a gradual re-engagement of the senses over the course of a minute. In a game like Haven, everything feels vibrant and new, unless of course it was programmed to the contrary. Vision is magnified as in a dream. In fact the technology that makes holistic immersion VR possible engages many of the same parts of the brain that are active during lucid dreaming.

The first time I signed in after my call to customer service, I received a new prompt.

Please select your account:
PrincessParadox
Spur27

I'd never had multiple accounts before, and it seemed that each time I signed in I'd now be prompted to choose between my own set of characters, and

my brother's. I tapped Spur27. A character selection screen appeared featuring half a dozen game characters, listed in order of experience points earned on each. With more than double the experience of all the other characters, only one seemed to have been played in earnest.

I rolled my eyes at his name choice. "Stabbies." *What kind of name is that? Good eve' Lord Stabbies?* My inner role player cringed at names that didn't sound like they belonged to a real person. *Did an in game mother one day reach into a cradle and coo at baby Stabbies?* Of course not, my bro wasn't the sort to think too hard into back story. Even during my raiding years, with the exception of one dwarf paladin style character named Scootiwutams, I always tried to give my characters names that sounded like they'd fit the world.

I didn't mind teasing him because, in that moment It felt like he was still alive, looming over my shoulder as I performed an evaluation of his never before accessed account. The mental chiding of his game name felt okay because, he was there with me in a way that he hadn't been since he was alive. It was nice.

Welcome to Haven Online!
Your last login was 786 Days Ago.
You have New Mail!

I quickly dismissed the login status messages as had become my habit over the years. My first reaction to signing in to my brother's account was "Dude...I'm a dude." Not the most sentimental of thoughts, but I wasn't prepared to be standing a head or two taller than my normal height, and with big bulky muscles. I touched my face, to discover man-fur about my chin and lips.

"That's fucked up." I said, and scratched my face, my brother's game face, daring it to fall off.

I pulled up the character stats window to see what I'd inherited.

Name:	Stabbies
Race:	Human
Attributes	
Physical	Strength 10, Dexterity 19, Stamina 10
Social	Charisma 3, Manipulation 3, Appearance 3
Mental	Perception 2, Intellect 2, Wits 7
Skills	
Combat	Daggers 12, Swords 13, Clubs 4, Unarmed 7,... etc.

The list went on. I wish I could say I was surprised by Jordan building a combat monkey, but I already knew going in that, unlike me at his age, he was

more interested in combat than role playing. I didn't pay too close attention because I didn't plan to play his character. It was one thing to login and let everyone know what'd happened, the idea of wandering around for extended periods of time in his game body, made my real world skin crawl. It'd be like wearing a dead person's skin.

I found the "Guild" tab beside the character information screen and opened it.

Guild: **Toxic Muffins**
Members: **1**

My stomach sank. The number one made me feel like crying. I probably was crying in the real world, but another hope occurred to me—his friends list. I pushed away the guild interface, and checked who was currently online. They were all my friends. Apparently by bringing his account under the umbrella of my email, all his contacts disappeared.

I said, "Fuck..." and I scrolled through my list, hoping to discover names I didn't recognize, mixed in with my familiar buddies as if our friends lists had been merged. "No... No... No..." Either Jordan hadn't maintained a friends list, or his contacts were gone.

The realization sucked all the joy out of my stomach that teasing my brother about his name had imparted, instead it left an empty pit that felt a lot like doom.

I was too late. From the mom with the potty mouth, to the home schooled kid that spanked the monkey too much, every single one of his friends was gone. The sense of loss eclipsed even the mirth inspired by his stupid guild name and the giant cupcake adorning the guild tabard produced. "You can play on my account if you want." he used to say, I never did. "But don't you ever leave my guild. I'm a Toxic Muffin. They'll always be my crew."

How long was always? When did the first member leave after their leader stop showing up? Who was the last to hold out until Jordan came back? All these people, names and faces, none of which I knew and yet desperately wanted to contact so that at least someone, anyone from Jordan's gaming life would know that he'd died, and that he hadn't forgotten about them.

"This fucking sucks." I said, and explored other parts of his interface. There was a guild announcements tab which made me laugh and feel sad at the same time. "R-Twined is a PvP Dick!" I pressed the red button next to it, a drum sounded through the game world, and the red text super imposed itself on my vision.

R-Twined is a PvP Dick!

Real mature Jordan. Real mature. At least then I knew how leaders pushed alerts to their guilds. I'd never been one. I pushed the button for another alert.

Stop killing kittens and get with the raid!

I had a feeling that was meant for the masturbation boy I'd heard so much about. A long time ago Jordan posted a meme about a kitten dying every time someone masturbated. I had to wonder what the Toxic Muffins guild chat was like on a daily basis.

R-Twined is a PvP Dick!

Real mature, Jordan. Real mature.

The thing about going through this account was that it wasn't an idealized version of my brother that we heard about at the funeral, and during memorial toasts. It was like his ghost was reaching out through time to spend a few moments with me. These alerts, his terrible names, and even his builds were an echo of the real Jordan which helped keep him more alive.

"Thank you." I said, but I didn't know who to. It might have been to God for giving me this experience, Jordan for leaving his account behind, or myself for thinking of a way to get around Haven Online's rules to gain access. Whatever the case, I was grateful for this electronic shrine to my real brother.

After clearing the guild and character interface windows from my vision I saw two buff icons in the top right corner of my view, and examined them.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 43 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 42 minutes remaining.

Viewing them was like an out of body experience as it dawned on me that, like the guild announcements, these were buffs that were cast by Jordan's own hand, more than two years ago, before he died. The count down timers paused each time a player signed off. They'd been preserved all this time.

"Holy shit," I said, and thought about how they'd got there. Had he just returned from a raid, or was he the sort of player that kept himself continually buffed, even in safe areas? I didn't know what to say or think except that I didn't want the count down to expire.

For the first time I took in my surroundings. Magic brooms danced on the sidewalks and swept through the streets, I was standing outside the bank beside a purple crystal protruding from the sidewalk like a fire hydrant with a holographic envelope sparkling overhead. I was in Durolan, the city of Mages, apparently my brother last checked his in-game mail before signing out.

I accessed the mail interface by putting my hand on the crystal. Jordan wasn't likely to have pending emails from friends because player to player messages were automatically deleted after 90 days, unless the message was

manually saved as an inventory item, and no one did that. Haven Online Official messages remained in player inboxes until they'd been read.

New Mail

Haven Online - Happy 8th Anniversary!

Haven Online - Happy 7th Anniversary!

Haven Online - The Olympics Are Here!

In spite of being fully aware of Haven Online's player to player mail deletion policy, I was still disappointed to see none of Jordan's contacts had sent him a message. A lead would have been nice. The bit about the Olympics stirred me, because Jordan died weeks before the most recent Korean Winter Olympics.

In spite of Haven Online being a fantasy game, it, and Freeworld Online mirrored real cultural events by providing special quests and items surrounding fantasy equivalents to real world holidays. So far as The Olympics were concerned, players and NPCs from all over Haven gathered to compete in non-lethal athletic competitions.

In the real world, Jordan was going to come visit me in Seoul so we could watch figure skating, downhill skiing, and aerial's together. In the end, I just saw the skaters. Watching the ski competitions, which Jordan was more excited about, would have just pounded the loss into wounds that were still too new. I returned the tickets to my dad, who had bought them for us, and he took my non-gaming sister with whom he bonded with on the mountain like he had with Jordan. Skiing was their thing. I liked it but, they were far more into it than I was. So far as winter sports were concerned, I was the skater of the family. I opened my mail, starting with the oldest.

"The Olympics are here! Thank you for being a loyal customer. As a Limited Edition user since Haven Online's original release, we have provided you with the following items. Frost Dragon Whelp, Frost Dragon Whelp (Limited Edition). Ain't he cute?"

I'd forgotten Jordan was a LE user. I was totally jealous when our parents got him the more expensive LE copy, and me the standard version for Christmas. I guess they thought either I was too old for video games, or girls wouldn't appreciate it as much. At the time, the difference in price was about a hundred and fifty bucks - Haven Online was a new game and no one knew if it'd take off, but now factory sealed limited editions sold for thousands at auction. It didn't give your characters any extra personal combat abilities, but the LE distinction did offer exclusive bonus pets which were impossible to come by any other way. These gifts were mostly cosmetic, but the pets also tended to be a bit stronger than normal in pet battles—one of the less popular features of the game. Additionally LE items such as mounts or auras required no extra proficiencies to use.

I heard a ka-ching sound followed by the following prompts.

You have acquired Frost Dragon Whelp .

You have acquired Frost Dragon Whelp (Limited Edition).

I opened the second in game mail.

"Happy 7th Anniversary! Thank you for being a loyal customer. As a Limited Edition user since Haven Online's original release, we have provided you with the following items. Sametora Hatchling. Sametora Hatchling (Limited Edition). Careful, they bite!"

The ka-ching sounded again followed by two new prompts.

**You have acquired Sametora Hatchling .
You have acquired Sametora Hatchling (Limited Edition).**

The third email read much the same as the first two, but instead of a creature, I received two versions of an in-game aura which would cause waves of color to drift around me if invoked. The standard version was a hypnotic blue color, whereas the Limited Edition was silver and white and provided a buff.

**Serenity.
Regeneration increased by 10% while in safe zones.**

Ten percent wasn't much in a place where you weren't going to be attacked anyway, but it was something. The real appeal was that it looked cool. I was tempted to check out the pets, but the time was running down on Jordan's buffs and I didn't want to waste it.

I sighed and looked down the street passed the animated brooms, and wondered what to do and where to go. I opened the game map, and discovered a pond several blocks away.

The walk was peaceful, and I admired the fantasy architecture. While the placement of buildings was based on real world GPS maps, they'd all been reskinned to reflect high fantasy themes. Most buildings were stone, and tall mage towers stood in place of real world skyscrapers. Occasionally, I saw log cabin inns in place of local pubs. I forgot which real world city Durolan was mapped on, but if I'd lived there I may have been able to find a recreation of my condo in the fantasy environment. Perhaps not.

For now large chunks of the real world map were missing, as distant streets in the real world connected to each other at unreal places. For example, one step beyond the real world equivalent to the intersection of 1st and Tomby Ave could land a player at 42nd and Tomby when they got to the other side. As the player base increased, so did the game map as more information from GPS maps was imported, reskinned and devoted to either cities, towns, or monster territory. Five years later, crossing the same intersection of 1st and Tomby, could take you to 23rd and Tomby as the game map continually expanded like the universe. All roads were renamed for the game, so there were never any gaps in street numbers.

As I approached the pond, the lack of other player characters struck me. The last time I was here on my own account, the expansion where Durolan was new had been less than a year old. Havenfolk, the name given to NPCs, milled about, but didn't intrude. I could see them inside their shops polishing swords, baking goods, and milling about the environment. The last time I'd been there, adventurers outnumbered Havenfolk by a ratio of ten to one. Now, my footsteps echoed against uncaring buildings.

I resigned myself to that I may not see another PC when a half-orc lumbered around the corner with a blue player icon over his nameplate.

Biskon	
Type:	Player
Race:	Half-Orc
Appearance:	2
Challenge:	Very Difficult

Appearance was a subjective trait, and mostly influenced how Havenfolk treated you. The majority of adventurers just ignored it in favor of how they personally felt about the looks of each other's avatars. In some cases a power required you to roll your appearance rating plus one of your abilities. As a general rule, an appearance of one was supposed to be ugly, two average, three pleasant and so forth. Biskon's avatar was no exception to the rule.

Our eyes met and my muscles tensed. My mind associated orcs with savage brawls, and pointless combat since that's the kind of activity the people I knew usually engaged in while playing them. It'd be just my luck to run into a player killer on Stabbies's first login. My hand went for a sword that wasn't there. *Not my character. Not my inventory.* I didn't know where anything was. I was really hoping this wouldn't turn into a PvP encounter. I just wanted to sit by the water, have a few nice thoughts, and log off. Signing in and being ganked within minutes of resurrecting my brother's account would put all kinds of sour in my disposition.

Then I remembered Haven Online's city guardians, and realized I was unlikely to be attacked. As a safe zone, magical guardians would materialize the instant one of us took an offensive action, and the aggressor would be sent for respawn with a few nasty debuffs, including a flag that allowed other players to kill them without penalty.

Instead, the orc nodded, but said nothing.

I didn't know what he wanted, but hoped this wasn't a preamble to awkward flirting. I nervously scratched my face, touched the facial hair and felt an idiot for forgetting how everyone saw me. No, orcy Biskon probably wasn't making eyes at this bearded human.

We walked side by side, for the last block leading up to the pond. In the way of games, a fishing pole and tackle box appeared in his hands.

"Have a good one." he said, before sitting on a rock. "I'm training."

"Yeah..." I said, not having expected it. "Good luck."

He gave me a slow baritone "Thanks," as he cast his line into the water.

I moved on to the end of a dock, and could see small faerie creatures dancing hand in hand on top of the pond like water spiders. I thought they were cute, up until a bass broke the surface of the water and ate one. *Not too smart I guess.*

I took off my boots and let my feet hang over the water. I raised an imaginary glass and said "This one's for you," to my kid brother. I'd already wasted another five minutes of buff time, and didn't want to use it all in one go.

I clicked the logout button, and found myself briefly groggy in my real world body. A tradition was born.

Once a year I logged in to collect Haven Online emails, and sit by the lake, watching a few more minutes of Jordan's buffs run out.

Chapter 3 - One Last Time

Today's the day. The last time I visit his virtual shrine before the merge. My mind wanders, because it's better than dwelling on what I've got to do when I get home. It's time to pay my kid brother a visit, eight years after his death.

Normally I'd be making this trip into VR a few weeks from now, but with the much talked about Freeworld Online and Haven Online merger this may be the last time I can access his account with all his in-game ephemera. Maybe nothing will change and I'll still be able to sign in for minutes at a time to watch his buffs drain away into the digital abyss, more likely they'll be stripped away as soon as I login.

Who ever heard of two games this size combining into one? They both use a d10 system, so it's technically possible but magical post apocalyptic, and high fantasy aren't compatible in my mind. Decades ago this would have been a nightmare for game developers, but with intuitive programming, all you need are bots that understand the languages of both platforms and the conversion is possible. Since they both use GPS mapping as the foundation of their cityscapes, I wonder how they will resolve instances where the same map is used in both games. Downtown Seattle, for example, has both Freeworld and Haven counterparts. I'm sure by this time tomorrow I'll know.

I get off at my stop and check the mail before heading to my room. The box is empty, no surprise since I keep all my bills electronic. My heart beats a little faster, and the sensation of the elevator button under my finger tips feels a little more real today than all others. I'm not hungry, but I grab myself a bowl of cereal, because I'm a rebel like that—eating breakfast in the evening, putting off what I've got to do.

I've got a giant bean bag chair that feels like sitting in a cloud that I settle into with my visor. I feel a little light headed, and select Spur27 when I login.

This is going to be painful. It's time to face the muzak.

* * * * *

I'm sitting on the dock staring down at the water with the fairy creatures skating about the surface. I check my buffs.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 16 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 15 minutes remaining.

I've been in and out of this place for thirty minutes of game time over the course of six years. My ritual has evolved over time to make the experience quicker and more sentimental.

A couple of elves fish at the end of the dock where I appear, one man one woman, moon blue skinned and wearing rugged hats with colorful feathered lures sticking off the surface at odd angles. It always feels weird when you pop into existence right on top of someone, even if the game adjusts your position so you don't appear inside a physical object.

"Err... Sorry," I say not knowing if I've interrupted. By now I'm used to my brother's avatar, so at least I'm not freaking out over being a guy.

The man says, "No problem!" in a tone that's too bright for my gloom. The woman nods, though I get the feeling that they were talking, since their both PCs. I step over their tackle boxes, and as a matter of gaming habit I inspect them before proceeding.

Elondriel	
Type:	Player
Race:	Elf (Twilight)
Appearance:	4
Challenge:	Average

LadyPoints	
Type:	Player
Race:	Elf (Twilight)
Appearance:	5
Challenge:	Challenging

The average and challenging ratings indicate that they've invested about the same amount of experience as my brother into combat related stats. The 'Twilight' subcategory of elf indicates their sub-race gains bonuses to dexterity, stealth, and crepuscular activities.

I say, "Mind if I sit here for a few before I log off again?"

"Be my guest." Elondriel says. LadyPoints shrugs, and casts her line.

"Thanks," I say. "Be right back."

Elondriel waves.

There's a mail box closer to the lake than the one beside the bank, and I head over to collect the annual loot. I glance over at them from the shore. I hear the murmur of words I can't understand, and she kicks her feet in a way that makes her look happy. It only makes me feel more sad. All said, I'd call them a cute couple.

The mailbox looks much the same as the one by the bank, a glowing crystal spike with the image of an envelope over it. As I touch its surface, I wonder if I'll keep getting these yearly treats after tomorrow. Probably, the LE status is determined by the license key, which is now attached to my account.

New Mail

Haven Online - Happy 14th Anniversary!

"Happy 14th Anniversary! Thank you for being a loyal customer. As a Limited Edition user since Haven Online's original release, we have

provided you with the following items. **Ethereal Flutterdrake. Ethereal Flutterdrake (Limited Edition). So pretty if err... dead."**

You have acquired Ethereal Flutterdrake.

You have acquired Ethereal Flutterdrake (Limited Edition).

Another pet. They seem to send them out every three years or so. The rest of the yearly gifts are typically cosmetic avatar enhancements and the like, with the LE version being slightly useful. I deposit the items into inventory, but this time decide to summon one of the pets.

Warning: Summoning Ethereal Flutterdrake (Limited Edition) will bind it to you. Bound items can not be lost or traded. Accept? Yes / No.

I tap yes. I'm engulfed by a brisk wind that seems at odds with my temperate surroundings. There's a silent pulse of blue, red, and gold like a mini super nova before a spectral creature materializes in front of me.

Ethereal Flutterdrake (LE)	
Type:	Creature
Race:	Undead
Status:	Friendly
Challenge:	Easy
Spirit Bound	

It's a pretty translucent thing the size of a beach ball. It bobs up and down with each beat of it's maple leaf shaped wings in butterfly patterns of faded yellow, sea green, and black. I reach out my hand and it bumps its boxy dragon snout and short serpentine body against my skin like a cat in need of affection. It's insectile antennae tickle my arm as it retreats, then it thuds it's whole body against my shoulder.

My insides war with the desire to sulk and comfort the small creature. He's been gone almost a decade. The only thing that's different now is the thought that I may not be able to watch his buffs disappear or look at his guild alerts after this evening. The buffs were bound to run out sooner or later, even without the merge, and of course, I can always recreate them after Freeworld and Haven combine, but it wouldn't be the same because I'd know it was my virtual hands that typed the new announcements and not his. The Flutterdrake dives, and thumps against my shoulder.

I say, "Persistent aren't you?" as the little ghostly creature continues its efforts to snag my attention. I awkwardly scratch beneath its chin, an odd sensation considering that there's pressure but no texture. It releases a puff of cool pink mist which I interpret as a sign of satisfaction.

I check the buff timer.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 13 minutes remaining.

I've already wasted three minutes on this visit, but an apathetic part of me doesn't care. I could sit here all night, or more accurately the next thirteen minutes and... what? I don't want to give up, but at the same time I realize a sense of release that may come of not being burdened by that timer. *Does that make me a bad person?* I don't know. I want to let go and move on, but how can I just throw away one of the few things I have left that he created.

"It was going to happen anyway." I tell myself, and I'm reminded that come tomorrow there may be no buff timer at all.

Without thinking I stroke the Flutterdrake's head. It nestles into my chest. It wraps its wings around its body like a bat, and I carry it in the crook of my arm like a baby. It has no weight, but I feel it's ghostly body pushing against my clothing. I put my hand on the mail interface, and open the anniversary message.

Would you like to save this document to your inventory? Unsaved documents will be automatically deleted after 90 days.

Yes / No.

I choose yes. This is a new part of my ritual that I added a few years ago.

As soon as I start walking back to the dock the Flutterdrake stirs and follows in air close behind. Ordinarily sporting undead pets in the cities would alert the guards, but the promotional nature of the Flutterdrake gives it neutral reputation status among NPCs.

My character's boots clunk on the surface of the dock and Elondriel looks over his shoulder.

"Whoa..." He says, and nudges LadyPoints in the side with his elbow. "Did you just get it?"

"Errr... Wha-" I catch myself before I realize he's talking about my companion. "Yeah, I guess."

He asks, "Limited edition. What did you pay for it?"

I shrug as if the Flutterdrake is of no consequence. "Nothing, why?"

"You could buy a player castle with what you could sell it for in the market."

Well, that is news, but then it wouldn't feel right selling anything from Jordan's account. I say, "I've got an LE key from when the game was released." I don't bother to explain that it was an inheritance.

The elves give me skeptical looks that make them seem more like twins than a couple. For all I know, that's what they are.

"Are you a Soc then?" Soc, short for "social gamer," The kind of person that preferred to stick to the cities than engage in monster hunting or PvP combat.

"Not really, but..." My words trail thinking of how to explain. "I mostly play in Freeworld Online these days."

"Ahh, that's why you're average." Elondriel says, referring to my challenge rating. Someone who played every day since Haven's release would have a lot more experience.

"Yeah." I say. Not wanting to engage further.

Elondriel asks, "What are you going to name it?"

I just shrug, having not given any thought to it. The elf seems to pick up on my desire not to socialize, and says "Well, congrats on your new ride."

I'm about to do an about face and go sit on the bank instead of the dock, when his words hit me.

I say, "What do you mean?"

He gives me another skeptical look, but LadyPoints answers. "LE pets can become mounts. You have to grow them."

"Really?" I ask.

"Yeah." Elondriel says. "How do you not know that?"

"Credit cards." LadyPoints adds. Accusing me of buying the LE key sometime after Haven's release for dozens of times the cost of the original software bundle.

The comment lights a fire in my chest that makes me want to shout that I didn't have an LE account until my brother died, and that I haven't bothered playing it due to that stupid timer. *How should I know about LE features? Oh shit, the timer!*

I check my buffs.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 8 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 7 minutes remaining.

I feel cold as I realize I've just wasted half of my remaining time playing with a Flutterdrake, and chatting with a couple of people I just met.

"Look," I say, as I tap the button to dismiss my companion. It fades in a burst of multicolored light, much the same as when it appeared. I'm about to say I've got other stuff to do, but realize that they'd just see me sitting on the shore, and I don't want to waste time finding another spot out of line of sight. "I gotta go AFK for a bit. "

I don't even give them a chance to engage again, as I'm already off, but I hear something about credit card players just out of earshot. *Fuckers*. I think as I sit down in the grass and toss a stone into the water with a liquid ker-sploosh.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 6 minutes remaining.

I sigh, and realize that I might as well wait the time out and say goodbye to this part of my tradition. I pull the annual Haven Online letter out of my inventory and begin tearing it into pieces. Stabbies isn't a magic wielding character, and there were no lighters in Haven Online's high fantasy world. It would be nice to have a basic fire spell from one of my Freeworld characters so I

could set it ablaze and scatter the ashes. As it is, I just toss the bits of paper into the water and watch them vanish as the in-game note is permanently destroyed.

The Enhanced Vitality buff starts flashing when it hits one minute remaining, followed by Enhanced Dexterity. When the buff icons disappear, I feel dizzy from emotion. I thought losing them would feel like doom, but instead the sky shines a little brighter, and I'm filled with a powerful sense of release.

Chapter 4 - New Ride

I expected to feel sad after last night, but instead I feel as if all things in my gaming world are filled with life and new possibility. This morning I'd put in a request for a week and a half vacation so I can spend time in Freehaven Online, the name given to Haven and Freeworld after the merge. My boss approved it on the condition that I finish the first draft of the once man and the new Freeworld motorcycle mounts before I go.

I finished off the tail animations for the once man project in the AM and shot it off to my supervisor for review. Now I'm going over the bikes in what should be the final edit. They're a beautiful mix of magic and technology - motorcycles in the style of 1960's Harleys, but instead of gas tanks have containers like fishbowls with spirits trapped inside to power the bikes. They're called Elechoppers.

I've made five skins, one for each of the traditional elements— Fire, Water, Earth, Wind, Ether. Right now, a lithe fiery creature like a molten monkey with pointy elf ears and crocodile teeth gives me a toothy grin, and then the middle finger. It disperses in a swirl of red, orange and yellow within its little container, the bike purrs, and coughs up a gout of flame from the exhaust.

"Sal, Set content rating to PG, and repeat." Freeworld Online, is built with a rating system that allows end users to define the content of their environment akin to movie ratings. For the most part, this determines how much gore a person experiences during combat, but also alters the language and behavior of NPCs. New settings applied, the spirit within the bike gives me the same toothy grin, blows a raspberry, and poofs into a firestorm.

"Looks good." Sal says.

"I agree."

We've fixed the issue with the spirits' auras bleeding outside the tank during the animation. A small fix, but necessary. The mechanics department already assigned stats to the Elechoppers, which means it will likely be included in the merger patch this evening. I have no idea if they'll be drops or crafted items, but I'm leaning towards crafted. Sometimes they mix it up so one rare skin drops off a boss, and the others can be made by players in game. Either way, I have no say.

I say, "Then send these bad boys off to QC so we can get the hell outta here!"

New expansions are big news for any game, and I haven't been this keen to play in years. It's this and taking a cue from Elondriel and LadyPoints, to make some use of Jordan's account that has me watching the clock until the merge goes live. It's like being a kid with the clock moving way too slow. The dex and vitality buffs are gone, so there's no longer need to limit my logins to a few minutes at a time.

* * * * *

I'm not interested in playing before the patch, I'll just be forced to logoff and download the client side updates. There's time to kill so, I treat myself to my

favorite Chicago style deep dish pizza after work. It's rare for me to eat out these days, but I feel excited and want to celebrate the optimism.

Once I'm home and login's available, I settle into my beanbag and boot up the visor. I get that runner's high feeling, as a new login screen fills my vision and my senses adapt to the digital environment.

Welcome to Freehaven Online!
Please specify your character name.

I'm looking around for the character selection screen, but can't find it. Normally I'd either be prompted to choose which character I want to login as on Freeworld Online, or which license I wanted to access for Haven Online. In this case it's treating me like I am a new player with no characters at all.

I select the question mark beside the prompt for information.

All characters in Freeworld Online and Haven Online have been combined into one, and experience is now applied at the player level. Your new character will have attributes equal to the highest value purchasable based on the number of points invested on all characters. Any remaining points will be credited to your next purchase of each attribute. For example, if you have one character with 20 strength (540 points spent), and another 14 strength (255 points spent), your new character will have 23 strength (requires 729 points), with only 3 points needed to advance to level 24 (requires 798 points). All skill experience will be similarly pooled, and all previous non-racial abilities on all characters will be accessible to your character.

Freeworld para-human abilities are pooled within characters of the same families (weres, vampires, fey, etc.), however powers and abilities restricted to these para-human races are limited to aliases that have completed the requisite quests, and/or creation rites. For more information, see the Alias menu.

Your previous character names and appearances can be accessed via the Alias menu. Existing users will be awarded one perfect alias per previous character on Haven Online or Freeworld Online, however new aliases may only be acquired in game. All items will be consolidated into a single inventory.

"That's.... scary." I say thinking of the implications. If I understand the announcement right, we can basically access any of the skills or abilities we've attained on any character at any time, and the cosmetic appearance of each character can be accessed via an in-game toggle. *I guess it saves the time of having to log out each time you want to change your role between Tank, Healer, and DPS.*

"We'll see how it goes." I say to myself.

On one hand this means my character will suddenly become insanely powerful compared to before the merge, on the other hand, it sounds like the same could be said of everyone else, since each player's stats are now pooled. I clear the announcement

I wasn't expecting to have to name a new character upon login, and this is delaying me. I don't want to pick an existing character name because I'm pretty sure we'll still get to use them via the new alias system. I'm into folk lore and mythology so I think of less common goddesses. Hera? Eh... Goddess of fidelity... not my style. Melpomene? Muse of tragedy. I like the sound of the word, but it seems a bit dramatic. Nyx? Goddess of darkness.

I also like the sound of that one. I enter. N-y-x. Of course it's already taken. I change the spelling to N-y-x-x, but it too has been used. N-y-x-x-x? I shake my head before even trying. With a name like that I'll be bombarded with Soc requests for cybersex every time I log in.

I go back to the name Melpomene... I guess the entire game will be a fusion of Jordan and my own game's accounts now. Dying before you're twenty is tragic. I enter it, the name's taken. I try again, this time changing the spelling to M-e-l-p-o-m-i-n-e. The system accepts it.

Do you want to set your character name to Melpomine? You may rename your character at a later time for one tenth of your in-game currency or 500 gold (whichever is greater).

Yes / No

With one character, it's good to know that players won't be stuck with the name they chose later on. I choose yes.

Please select a starting location. Haven Online / Freeworld Online

I decide to give Haven a shot, since I haven't spent as much time there compared to Freeworld. I want to play with Jordan's stuff and Scootiwutams, the dwarven Paladin is getting rusty.

Please choose a race for Melpomine.

I browse through the list, and I see everything from humans, to gnomes, to dwarves, and elves, with sub-races for each type. There are even orcs. Humans gain reputation and skills faster, but don't get any bonus attributes. This is useful when it comes to unlocking faction specific gear, special quests, and grinding skills. Elves, the sexy race, get bonuses to dexterity and appearance at the cost of stamina, and can see in the dark. Dwarves, one of the least commonly played races for women, are rugged, and so on. There are also half races for each primary race since apparently humans can breed with anything under the sun. The Freeworld Online races, are notably absent. It's probably because I picked Haven as my starting location.

I'm sorely tempted to play a half gnome because I've never seen them in any other game, but the gnomish racial traits don't mesh with my intended play style.

"This sucks." I say because it feels like no matter what I choose I'll be trapped playing one race for the duration of my account. In the end I go with a half-elf which gives me fifty percent of the human and elven racial bonuses and penalties.

Do you want to make Melpomine a Half-Elf? You will not be able to change your race unless you enter rebirth. Rebirth requires a quest.

Yes / No

I say, "Huh..."as I read the bit about rebirthing. I guess they've already figured out that players won't be happy with a permanent race. That's good, but I wonder what rebirthing entails. I doubt it's a reset of all stats, because that would make for a lot of unhappy customers. I choose "yes," and the prompts fade.

I spend more time than I'd like to admit tweaking the appearance of my new character in the creation interface, and a few hours later I manifest in game as a lithe half-elf woman with strong lean muscles, and hair pulled into a long blonde ponytail.

I've never seen so many players in one location. Hundreds of people, wearing the same straw colored starter linen shirt and pants crowd together. Their individual voices bleed into a cacophony of speech that's hard to distinguish save for that coming from people standing right in front of me.

"Jesus. " I say, and try to push my way to a less crowded location. The horde of avatars is worse than when Freehaven Online released an expansion with its first new playable race that everyone wanted to try. With everyone making new characters, it seems that anyone with even a drop of human blood is appearing at the same spawn point. A lot of players stand like idiots checking their stats and gear creating a massive traffic jam.

Fortunately, it's not so hard to escape since it automatically deposited me at the edge of the crowd, but it won't be the case for long if I dawdle. Already six new players have manifested within arm's reach and I've only been in-game a few seconds.

I have no shame as I sprint the opposite direction toward the NPC marketplace. In the real world I'd look like a maniac running through the equivalent of a shopping mall, full speed ahead, but in an overcrowded virtual world, you've gotta let stuff slide. I'm about to plow right over a mousey ginger human in starting gear, when I instinctively plant a toe, spin, and bolt around her like she's not even there. Then a gnome pushing a cart full of clockwork doodads, and what-cha-ma-call-its crosses my path and I leap over him like an Olympic athlete in half lunar gravity. I don't get a good look at his goods because I'm moving so fast. I glance back, over my shoulder to make sure I didn't topple his mobile shop. The little dude's curly grey moustache gives him the air of an elderly Super Mario Brother. God bless the NPCs for not batting an eye. He carries on as if nothing happened. It's like I said, until I get settled in, I have no shame.

I think, *"This place is going to be hell for the next few days."* as I imagine the human capitol, Athelon, flooded with players signing into their accounts. The thought of checking out Havenfolk wears to replace these useless starter clothes crosses my mind, but I think better of it knowing there's a sea of players behind me that might have similar thoughts. I get the feeling that all the inns around here are going to be just as crowded so I keep running, past the signs with shields, hammers, quills, and swords denoting the types of wears each merchant sells, and past the inns with their mead, stews and ale.

I'm approaching the wall denoting the edge of this district when a guard calls "Halt!"

"Errr... What?" I ask, skidding to a stop, caught off guard by the intrusion.

"Where're you going in such a hurry Miss?"

"Oh, it's so crowded back there I wanted to beat the rush to the next district."

"It's not because mayhap you've taken something that's not yours from the market?"

"Do I look like I'm carrying anything?" I ask, but then realize that I'm equipped with the standard adventurer's backpack. It's damn near weightless thanks to magic, and I haven't yet toggled it to be invisible. Even so, both my brother and Scooti should have had enough reputation in this place not to be harassed.

"Looks to me like you've got a bag right there. Why don't we take a look?"

I pull up my interface, illusory windows appear in the air around me. I select the option for "tablet," which allows you to view your stats via a handheld device called a VT (Virtual Tablet) so as not to block your view of the world. The computer frames overlaying my vision vanish as soon as the device appears in my palm. NPCs have been programmed not to notice. They even pause their dialogue while you're using it. I open Melpomine's reputation window, and am aghast at what I find.

Melpomine -

Reputation Locale Athelon Province

Athelon: 0 / 1000 - Neutral

Athelon Guard: -1 / 1000 - Distrust

"What-the-hell?" I thought. Stats were supposed to carry over. I tap a new tab called "Aliases," and have a feeling that it'll explain my problem. There I see a list of every character either I or my brother has ever made in either Freeworld or Haven. I select Scootiwutams since it's the haven avatar I'm most familiar with.

Scootiwutams

Magical - Dwarf - Female - Paladin of Helios

Rank: Perfect (Grandfathered)

Do you wish to assume the Scootiwutams identity?

Yes / No

I select yes.

Warning! You are in plain sight of East Wall Guard #1, East Wall Guard #2, East Wall Guard #3, Innkeeper, Barmaid #3, TakoStar. Assuming this alias in plain sight, will make them aware of this identity. Do you wish to proceed? Yes / No

The three guards are self explanatory. I can see them loitering near the shack next to the gate, but TakoStar? Must be a player... who really likes Mexican food... or Octopus. I tap yes, on my virtual tablet.

I feel a wave of smooth magic wrap around me in streamers of deep red and gold. My arms become thicker, and my legs grow shorter and stockier. The newbie linens are replaced by red full plate armor that sparkles with flecks of gold that glitter in the sunlight. At my hip is an improbably large longsword made to seem even bigger due to my small stature. It only works by the grace of video game physics and logic. I touch my face in wonder, and discover the nose ring I designed Scooti with. If I flex, I'll have biceps the size of cantaloupes. I've now got two prominent pigtails, stone colored skin, and a shield with the symbol of the god Helios, the Sun Lord, strapped to my back like a turtle.

The guard says, "My apologies Lord Scootiwutams," one quirk of the Haven Online world was that Lord could be a gender neutral title. It was applied to noble male social characters, and Paladins or Knights of either sex that had proven themselves in battle. "I didn't recognize you."

"Aye.." I say in the Scottish accent I'd assigned this character. "Easy to mistake when running about all elflike. Just a sec while I..." My words trail off while I access the Alias menu. I select Melpomine from the list, and once again I'm engulfed by a wave of colored magic, this time a boring white and brown. I look down at my newbie attire, and realize that the color of the magic must be determined by the colors of your equipped gear. Part of me wonders what'd happen if I transformed into a naked character.

"Well, that's cool." I say, but the guards take no notice. NPCs often turn a blind eye to dialogue about things pertaining to the real world or the user interface. I check Melpomine's reputation.

Melpomine -	
Reputation	Locale Athelon Province
Athelon:	7,361/10,000 - Revered
Athelon Guard:	4,821/5,000 - Esteemed

Huh... So Melpomine only gained Scootiwutam's reputation, after a member of the relevant faction had been made aware of the Alias. That makes sense. This allows players to effectively run different characters with alternate identities if they want.

A male voice explodes from somewhere behind me.

TakoStar says, "They do exist!" In a tone of good humored wonder. I turn, and give him an inquisitive quirk of the eyebrow. He's a half-elf like me, with dark hair spiked in the explosive stylized chaos common to anime characters and

energetic pop stars. He's sporting the non-descript dark leathers of a rogue style character, and his smooth unblemished skin gives him a baby faced appearance.

TakoStar	
Type:	Player
Race:	Half-Elf
Appearance:	4
Challenge:	Average

"A female dwarf paladin of the Sun Lord?"

I say, "So?"

"That's a whole new epic level of red headed stepchild."

I laugh, it's not the first time I've been confronted by "ZOMG! A female dwarf!" It's part of the reason I made the character, but I intentionally built a tank in service of the Sun Lord because they were so uncommon for the subterranean race. To become a Paladin, you had to earn reputation with the appropriate clergy, pass many tests, and be ordained. Pretty straight forward, until you consider that there are no churches of the Sun Lord underground, inside the dwarven capital.

I smile and say, "Nice to know I have fans."

"You a tank?" he asks.

"Uhhh.. might be. Haven't had a chance to look at everything yet. That old avatar, alias, or whatever you call it was my tank character but I haven't raided with her in ages."

He says, "You're still a tank then. I signed in right away. You should go over your stats."

"I will," I say, "But I want to get out of this area first. There are a lot of people coming online."

"Good idea. If you want to run something later hit me up if you need DPS. A good tank is hard to find." He winks, and I feel the urge to roll my eyes. *Seriously, a wink? Who does that?*

TakoStar wants to be friends. Do you accept?

Yes / No

I choose yes, and his name appears in my contacts. We can now send text messages at a distance, no magic required.

"Give me like an hour to get settled, and I'll be ready. I took off work for this expansion, so I'm good to go all night."

"That's what I like to hear. Send me a message and we can meet up at the south gate."

"Sure thing."

The walk to the southern district is uneventful, and I'm starting to like the feel and look of my new half-elf avatar. She reminds me of my old Freeworld character MarineLu, a Taiwanese martial artist with elemental magic that focused on wind themed attacks. Melpomine and Marine have similar body types,

and the unencumbered starting gear paired with a high dexterity rating reminds me a lot of what it felt like to move around in Marine's skin.

Now that I've been reminded of stats, I decide to check my attributes.

Name:	Melpomine
Race:	Half-Elf
Attributes	
<i>Physical</i>	Strength 12, Dexterity 24 (+1), Stamina 20
<i>Social</i>	Charisma 12, Manipulation 9, Appearance 7(+1)
<i>Mental</i>	Perception 12 (+1), Intelligence 19, Wits 16

The basic combat system in Freehaven Online is as follows: The game engine rolls a number of ten sided dice equal to dexterity + the relevant ability score per attack. Each dice that rolls 6 or above earns a point. Each point after the first is added to strength in another roll of d10s to determine how much damage is inflicted on the target. The defender then rolls their stamina plus any relevant abilities to resist taking the damage. Any points remaining after the resist roll, are subtracted from the character's health (usually 10). A character with zero health is killed, and has to respawn with penalties that last 15 minutes.

"Good God!" I exclaim, though none of these stats are surprising since I played most of the characters that contributed to them. It's just alarming to see them all in one place.

The only stats with significant gains due to my brother's account are dexterity, strength, and wits, since he preferred playing the sneaky stabby characters that relies on quick strikes and light feet. Strength added to his damage, and wits allowed him to act faster in combat. Marine's dex only went up to 16, because I also needed to invest points into intelligence to work her magic. In my time since the release of Haven and Freeworld, I've played musicians, casters with high intelligence, a plate wearing tank, and a nimble martial artist and it shows in my diverse stats. I wonder what other people's spreads look like.

Part of me expects players to scream about the unfairness of some characters having high physical, mental and social stats, but on the other hand if those players actually cared about non-physical stats, they'd likely have already made a character that used them in the past. Those that only ever play characters of a certain type still have higher stats for their style of game play than everyone else.

I'm starting to get the logic behind the merger. The more real world time you spend engaged in a certain type of game play, the higher those stats will be. Unless of course you're like me where you inherited a family member's account with years of accumulated game time that you didn't actually perform. I decide to keep that part a secret for the time being.

I open up my inventory and discover a mindboggling collection of items. Thankfully via the virtual tablet, they can be sorted by type, stats, or searched for by name. Jordan's characters didn't wear plate, so Scooti's tank gear is the best available. He did, however, have a nice collection of swords.

Exsanguinator	
Type:	Sword
Quality:	Epic
Base Damage:	
	Strength + 2 (Slashing)
Equipped Bonus:	
	Strength +2, Stamina + 3
Special Properties:	
+1 Dark Damage	
Chance on Hit: Heals wielder for 50% of damage dealt.	

I reach my arm into the magical backpack. In the way of games, it's small on the outside, but large enough to contain an entire warehouse within. My hand finds the hilt of Exsanguinator just by thinking of the item, I take the grip, and withdraw the blade. Scooti's current sword is bright and polished, the sort of thing you'd imagine in the hand of a warrior of light, but Exsanguinator has a blood colored aura with black veins that pulse in time with my heartbeat. The prongs jutting forward from both ends of the cross guard remind me of massive Vampire fangs.

"Bad ass." I say, all the while doubting the Sun Lord would approve if he were a real god. Thankfully, VR deities don't much care what weapon you use unless they are associated with an opposing god. It'll go well with Scooti's armor.

Tank gear assigned, I look around and spot a mailbox parked just outside an inn called the Smiling Otter. Unlike the mailboxes of Durolan, this ones in this city look like blue roofed bird houses with an envelope painted on the side. I walk over and access the interface.

New Mail

Freeworld Dev Team - Elechopper

I open the letter, but there's no text. This is an employee thing. One of the perks of being a designer is that you get a special developer's copy of any vanity items you design. Weapons are a little different. You get a replica item that allows you to copy stats from any of your other items of the same type, thus allowing you to utilize their appearance, but not gain an unfair combat advantage over paying customers.

I'm more than happy to receive my Earth, Fire, Wind, Water, and Ether motorcycles, the developer's edition of mounts clone movement speed of any of your other mounts. It means the Elechoppers were included in the update. I wonder how they were implemented Freeworld side, and how long it'll take to see players cruising around on them.

I open up the mount interface, and it's filled with 123 standard mounts, and 38 developer's editions. I sort by those that originated in Haven Online, and then by movement speed. I tap to summon Jordan's best mount.

Nightmare	
Type:	Mount
Race:	Demon
Status:	Friendly
Challenge:	N/A
Ground Speed:	250%
Air Speed:	670%

It's a burning horse with eyes like hot coals, and a mane and tail of red and yellow fire. It feels like standing next to a furnace. Smaller red and black tongues of flame continually leap up and scurry over its demonic flesh. I don't see any wings, but the air speed stat implies it can fly.

I say, "Nice drop little bro," and give him a salute. I remember him gushing over the creature at Thanksgiving.

I tap the icon for the fire bike on my tablet and then "clone."

Would you like to apply movement speed from Nightmare, to Elechopper (DE).

Yes / No

I tap yes.

Fire Elechopper (DE)	
Type:	Mount
Race:	N/A
Status:	Friendly
Challenge:	N/A
Ground Speed:	250%
Air Speed:	670%
Spirit Bound	

I have my doubts as to whether or not the Elechoppers are flying mounts in the rest of the game but developer's editions don't have that limitation since they just copy the properties of other objects. I repeat the process for the other five bikes.

I open the macro interface and my heart sinks to discover that it's empty. No more reminders that R-Twined is a PvP dick. I sigh, but it's to be expected. I tap to create a new macro and, using the virtual tablet, type in the command `"/run summon 'Fire Elechopper'"` and tap record.

I bellow the word "INFERNO!!!" and wave my middle finger in the air in imitation of the burning monkey in the gas tank. I type "End," on the tablet. The Havenfolk NPCs ignore me, but some of the players look at me like I've got two heads.

Do you want to save changes to macro "Elebike - Fire?"
Yes / No

I choose yes.

Now for a test run. I shout out "INFERNO!!!" and give the world the bird. A soundless red nova of magical energy the size of a small car pulses, followed by the growl of a magical engine. My bike pops into existence on the side of the road. I can't help but notice how incongruous it looks in the high fantasy environment. The fire monkey in the gas tank cackles.

I straddle the seat, and rev up the engine, pushing a lance of fire behind me. My heart flutters and I smile. *Hell yes, I made this.*

I start to roll forward and pull back on the handlebars like I'm flying a plane. My stomach jumps and the bike lifts up off the ground hovering in mid air. In-game mounts generally respond more to your intent than physical action, but the sensation of pulling to cause the lift makes the experience that much more real. I give it some gas and go straight up Harley Chitty Bang Bang on this medieval town.

Chapter 5 - There Be Dragons

A few PCs far below point and shout "Dude!" having never seen an Elechopper, much less a flying one. In all likelihood, I'm the first person to use one in the game. I feel a flush of satisfaction knowing that all those hours in virtual design space haven't gone to nothing. There are a few odd mechanical Freeworld mounts already in the game, but odds are they'll be a rarity in Haven until people start crossing over. The only people that'll have them today are those that had accounts in both games that chose Haven as their new Freeworld starting point.

The novelty of having a flying bike wears off after a few laps around the city. Going airborne has its perks, but as a means of transportation, I think I prefer the terrestrial Freeworld Online version of the bike from my design space where I can feel the terrain beneath my wheels. Plowing through air makes my stomach lurch and jump every which way with the wind in my face and moving up, down and through improbable loops, but there's something to be said for riding on an open road.

I can still do that, but I'm capped at 250% of running speed. As a general rule Haven Online ground mounts are a lot slower than those found in Freeworld, and I'd copied the properties of a Haven item. Freeworld on the other hand has far fewer flying mounts which are generally slow in comparison to Haven. The ground mounts, like non-DE versions of the Elechoppers are much faster on flat earth. It'll be interesting to see what happens when the worlds start colliding.

I get off the bike just outside the South Gate and decide to make a macro for dismissing it so I don't have to go through the manual interface each time I want it to disappear.

I open up the screen on my virtual tablet, and enter the command `"/run dismiss mount -lastactive."` This means that when I perform the required action, the last mount I interacted with will disappear into my inventory. This will prevent me from dismissing all mounts I've summoned if for some reason I decide to have more than one out. I tap "record," and say "Bloop bloop!" while miming setting a car alarm with a keychain.

Do you want to save changes to macro "Dismiss Mount?"

Yes / No

I tap yes on the virtual tablet. Now for the test.

I say "Bloop bloop!" and make the appropriate motion. The Elechopper fades from the world like a forgotten ghost.

I shout "INFERNO!!!" and wave my middle finger, red flashes. I hear the roar of the engine. It reappears a few paces over.

I say, "Very nice," and trail my fingers lovingly over the seat and rear fender. If you haven't noticed, I like a lot of customization in my games. It comes with the territory of being a developer. While most people set some basic macros for common things like summoning their mounted transportation, it's entirely

possible to create custom triggers for spells and the like, but a lot of people don't bother.

I should contact TakoStar before he finds another party, I don't know a lot of people in Haven and I think most of my friends are going to start in Freeworld.

Melpomine: Hey. I'm done going through my stuff. You up for a dungeon?

TakoStar: Sure. Where u at?

Melpomine: South Gate.

TakoStar: You got heals or DPS?

Melpomine: I can DPS, but I want to get back into tanking.

TakoStar: I mean other people.

Melpomine: Oh, no just me.

TakoStar: Alright I'll advertise. I'll meet you there when I find people.

Melpomine: I'll just grind some mobs till you're ready. Lemme know and I'll go back to the gate.

TakoStar: Use the Dwarf alias. Scooti or whatever.

Melpomine: Scootiwutams

TakoStar: Yeah her. Dwarf girls rock.

I shrug and think, "*Why not?*" before I send my reply of "OK." It's time to get back in the groove. I pull up the Alias menu on my VT, select Scooti, and transform in a puff of magic. Instead of my old Commander's Longsword, I now have Jordan's Exsanguinator in a sheath at my hip.

I get on the bike and rev the engine. It's more comfortable than you'd think in full plate. It probably wouldn't be true in the real world, but hey, this is game logic. I'm digging my multi-genre attire—a red fire bike, with red and gold flecked plate, topped off with a blood drinking longsword. The wind on my face is earthy and refreshing carrying the scent of trees, and clean air. I'm sure it must exist somewhere, but as a city girl burning down a fantasy road in my fire elemental powered chopper, I wonder if air this good still exists in the real world.

Up ahead I see a signboard and pull over. "WANTED: Ridgewood Bandits. Reward - 50 silver per insignia. Collect with Athelon Guard." A take a copy of the notice and I'm given a quest.

The Athelon Guard are offering a bounty on Ridgewood Bandits. Defeat them and bring their insignias to the Athelon Guard for a reward.

Rewards:

20 Silver per insignia.

Reputation with Athelon Guard

Do you accept? Yes / No

I accept the quest, and a red area to the west is automatically highlighted on my game map, indicating where to go to fulfill the quest objective. Before charging off to hunt bandits, I notice an exclamation point over the guild tab.

Your Aliases Scootiwutams, Melpomine are not members of any guilds. Do you wish to add these aliases to the Toxic Muffins?
Yes / No

I feel bad because I hadn't even thought about Jordan's guild until now, but now that I'm in-game it seems like I should do something with it. Maybe I can build it back up, or somehow find some of the old members to let them know what happened. I tap yes.

Which Aliases do you wish to add to Toxic Muffins?

I select both Scootiwutams and Melpomine.

Do you wish to claim leadership as Scootiwutams and Melpomine? Note: Claiming leadership will reveal your aliases to all current guild members. Scootiwutams, Melpomine, and Stabbies will be connected.
Yes / No

I choose yes, and check out the guild roster.

Guild: Toxic Muffins
Members: 1
Melpomine (Leader)
- Aliases: Stabbies, Scootiwutams

I do an experiment and try adding Marine to the guild as well. This time when prompted to make her a leader I choose no.

Guild: Toxic Muffins
Members: 2
Melpomine (Leader)
Aliases: Stabbies, Scootiwutams
MarineLu

I leave the roster alone for now, as I see no reason to make all of my former characters leader. The system is interesting because it allows people to masquerade as different players within in-game organizations until such time that their aliases are discovered. I assume the only reason it linked Stabbies to my Scootiwutams and Melpomine identities is because there can only be one official leader, and Stabbies is it.

After the promotion of my Scootiwutam's avatar a new tab appears in the guild interface, with a bold exclamation point.

Limited Edition - Guild Quest
Dragonsbane - Part 1

Difficulty: Variable

An extra-planer dragon has torn a rip in the wall between two worlds. Investigate the disturbance and bolster your dragon slaying prowess so you can destroy the foul beast and prevent further damage to the land.

Objectives:

Discover the Identity of the extra-planer dragon that caused the rip between worlds. 0/1

Slay 50,000 dragons or dragon kin. 0/50,000

Rewards:

Title: Dragonslayer

Reputation: 10,000 Reputation in All Playable Factions

Access to Specialized Gear and Enchantments from Havenfolk Merchants

Do you accept? Yes / No

A limited edition quest? *Hell yes!* I stab the affirmative notification with my finger without even thinking.

I've never even heard of a Limited Edition quest in either Freeworld or Haven Online. This could be just what I need to build up Jordan's guild again, and the rewards? In-game titles, and 10k reputation in all playable factions is nothing to sneeze at. It's enough to take someone from a starting neutral rep in the capital cities, to third level Honored in one go. It'll get you discounts from merchants, new quests, previously unavailable items for purchase. And what's with that specialized gear? That sounds like access to items that are only obtainable by completing the quest. *A limited edition quest.*

I unleash a long whistle, and fire off a message to TakoStar.

Melpomine: Hey, you still there?

TakoStar: Yeah, still looking. Sorry.

Melpomine: np. I got a quest.

TakoStar: Bandits?

Melpomine: Well yeah, but also another one. It's about slaying dragons.

TakoStar: Dragons? I've never heard of a dragon quest around here.

Melpomine: I didn't get it in the city, it's from my guild.

TakoStar: What do you mean?

Melpomine: It's a guild quest. I've gotta investigate the rip between worlds. I guess it's for the merge event, and kill dragons.

TakoStar: I've never seen a guild quest. How many you gotta kill?

Melpomine: I think it's a Limited Edition thing.

Melpomine: 50,000. Can you help me?

TakoStar: Fuck me! That's a lot of dragons!

TakoStar: Wait, Limited Edition? You're in a LE guild? Why didn't I see the tag on your nameplate?

Melpomine: Uh.. yeah. Scootiwutams and Melpomine were just added.

I leave out the part about my other Alias being the leader because I don't want to get into it about my... Jordan's LE game key. It feels weird discussing it with people, like it's somehow not mine to talk about. This was never an issue in Freeworld.

TakoStar: OMG. Can I join? Ask if I can join. Please I'll do anything.

Melpomine: Ummm.. Yeah I'll do that.

TakoStar: OMG seriously! An LE guild! Do you have to go through auditions or something?

Melpomine: Ahh... No. I just got added

TakoStar: Probably because you're a female dwarf. They're rarer than unicorn farts that lead to pots of gold.

Melpomine: What?

TakoStar: They poop rainbows. Never mind, just ask for me, k? I wanna join.

Melpomine: Sure.

I'm taken aback by his enthusiasm. Am I excited by the quest? Absolutely, but not slit my mother's throat for a chance at participation excited. I guess being a designer with access to all the DE items I've created, and my comparative lack of time in Haven, has insulated me from the insanity caused by Limited Edition items. I like my customizations, but people have been known to spend more than the cost of a car to get their hands on a LE license key. That's just nutty.

All this talk of LE items reminds me of the flutterdrake I summoned last night. I decide to make a macro to summon him like my bike. Command lines added I whistle four notes, and click to save. He appears in the same burst of color as yester night, and promptly chest bumps against my armor.

"Still recognize me, don't cha' laddy?" I give him a scratch beneath the chin with my metal gloved fingers. It seems to satisfy him as I'm covered in a frosty pink mist. Pets must be able to see through their owner's aliases. "What do ye say we go hunt some bandits?"

The flutterdrake does a little mid air spiral, and I take that as a yes. I'm about to head down the road toward the bandit's camp when I realize I'd better give it a name.

"What do ye want to be called? Cuddlewuzzins?" There's no reaction. "How 'bout Poofter?" he gives me an angry snort, with a cold cloud of grey this time which tells me exactly what he thinks of that suggestion. I thought it was funny because of the way he poofs in and out of existence. "Poofter, nay. Ye be doomed with a name like that." The creature cocks it's head inquisitively. I decide to tease him. "DOOMED!"

The flutterdrake huffs as if to say "OK."

"Doom? Ye like that?" The drake does another Twirl in air. "Doom ye be then."

Would you like to name your Ethereal Flutterdrake (LE) "Doom?"

Yes / No

I choose yes.

"There ye have it. Doom. Ye got a name. Now let's go kill some bandits." Doom exhales a puff of pink mist.

I enjoy the ride on the western road. Doom's able to keep up just fine, beating his wings, swooping, and diving like a playful kitten... if kittens had wings anyway. He seems to enjoy the exercise. I'm riding through the country with fresh air, bright sun and occasional thatched roof buildings with rustic charm. Which is why I'm caught completely unprepared for the arrow that whizzes about an inch from my eyebrow. I can feel the wind on my face from it's passing.

"Shit!"

I dive off the Elechopper and scramble to equip my helm which looks like a Bell curve, with holes for eyes, and insectile mandibles covering the mouth. I get the shield of the Sun Lord off my back just in time for a monster thunking sound as I use it to deflect a second arrow.

"I think we found the Bandits." I say, and clatter Exsanguinator against my shield to draw their attention. "Let's have it."

Taunt. Successful.

Ridgewood Bandit #1 attacks.

Ridgewood Bandit #2 attacks.

Two arrows fly my direction from behind the corner of a farm house. They clank harmlessly off my shield resulting in no damage. Another volley comes, one clunking against my shield and the other knocking my helmet.

Head shot! You take 15 points of damage.

Resist: Stamina + Endurance.

You resist 14 points of damage.

-1 Health. 9 Health remaining.

That might have been a lucky shot, but I'm not going to stand here all day waiting for them to run out of arrows. I charge towards the farmhouse, silently bemoaning the movement penalties of full plate. I can't perform acrobatic dodges like I could in the market.

A nasty looking chump with beads in a scraggly black beard and a nocked arrow peeks around the corner, he's not expecting me to be this close so soon. He fires at point blank range, but my shield is ready. It'll leave a dent, but the sound of his arrow's metallic PLOK against my shield means I'm not taking any damage. I don't halt my advance, and smash him with my shield.

Shield bash successful.

Ridgewood Bandit #1, has been knocked down.

In an instant Exsanguinator is out of its sheath, and I'm bringing it down on the bandit's torso.

CRITICAL HIT

**You hit Ridgewood Bandit #1 for 17 damage.
You have killed Ridgewood Bandit.**

I think, "That was easy." As another arrow whizzes past my head. All things considered this must be a low level area.

A gravelly male voice speaks just behind me, "I'm gonna cut you up!"

CRITICAL HIT

Backstab

Ridgewood Bandit #3 strikes you for 24 damage.

Resist: Stamina + Endurance.

You resist 19 points of damage. -5 Health. 4 Health remaining.

I moan, "Oooohh that stings a little!"

Of course taking damage in game isn't like being stabbed in real life, but it's less than pleasant. I probably should have checked to see if Jordan or Scooti had healing or manna potions before I left town.

Another arrow hits my shield, which is odd because I wasn't even trying to block it. The other shooter, wherever he is must really suck. Instead, I spin to face my attacker. It's a guy in a mask, wielding a pair of squiggly daggers. I think their called krisses. I move in for a strike with Exsanguinator, but the bandit takes me by surprise throwing dirt in my eyes.

You are blinded.

Another loud thump of an arrow sounds as something slams into my side. I take no damage.

5...

4...

A kick lands in my stomach, but I'm able to keep my footing. No damage there, through all this plate.

3...

2...

1...

I shake the dirt out of my helm and my vision returns.

I say, "You shouldn't have done that."

The bandit says, "I'm gonna cut you up." and I think *"Can't you think of anything else to say?"* Clearly I'm not dealing with AIs that are near Sal's level of intelligence.

I try the shield bash on Bandit #3, but it just knocks him back, no damage, and he's not on the ground. He flips a dagger in his hand, and goes for a strike, but I knock it away with Exsanguinator.

"You really shouldn't have done that."

Mirae heals you for 2 health. 6 health remaining.
Mirae heals you for 1 health. 7 health remaining.
Mirae heals you for 2 health. 9 health remaining.

A warm glow of healing fills my body as a green aura surrounds me accompanied by the scent of cherry blossoms. I don't know who Mirae is, but I'm glad as hell for their intervention. It would suck to get sent to respawn my first trip out of Athelon.

I call over my shoulder, "I don't know who you are, but thanks!"

Bandit #3 flicks his wrist, and a nasty throwing knife darts towards my head. He must have been keeping it the same place Highlanders keep their swords.

A high girl's voice answers "I've got you, just fight!"

Mirae has invited you to join her party. Accept?
Yes / No

I shout, "Yes!" as an alternative to tapping the announcement.

Mirae has joined your party.

Her portrait appears in the upper left hand corner of my view indicating that she has 100% health, and 85% manna. I don't have time to look too closely while we're under attack.

"I'm gonna cut you up." The bandit says. That statement is getting really old. I go offensive lunging toward Bandit #3 with a powerful strike with Exsanguinator.

Ridgewood Bandit #3 takes 4 damage.

I hear Mirae grunt, "Oof." As her health bar falls in my interface.

Mirae takes 3 points of damage.

I crash my shield and sword together three times in another taunt.

Taunt. Successful.
Ridgewood Bandit #2 attacks.
Ridgewood Bandit #3 attacks.

Mr. Cut-you-up's next shot is easily blocked with my shield, another arrow streaks past, before Ridgewood Bandit #2 comes rushing out of the farmhouse with a sword in his hand. I'd better finish #3 off fast, so I press him with my shield like I did with number one. This time he goes down. I kick him in the ribs and bring Exsanguinator down on his neck.

Ridgewood Bandit #3 takes 6 damage.
You have killed Ridgewood Bandit #3.
Exsanguinator heals you for 1 point of damage.

Like a demonic firefly, the sword pulses a brighter shade of red.

At the death of his companion Ridgewood Bandit #2 does the first sensible thing I've seen an NPC do since logging in and runs. I hear the whisk of an arrow flying from behind me, and a long wooden shaft trailing in magic green light buries itself in #3's back.

Mirae hits Ridgewood Bandit #2 for 12 damage.
Mirae kills Ridgewood Bandit.

"Nice shot!" I say, and turn back to get my first good look at my savior. She's a skinny full elf woman with slightly sun-kissed skin, and long hair the color of sea foam.

Mirae	
Type:	Player+
Race:	Elf (Sea)
Appearance:	6
Challenge:	Above Average

"Thanks for the heals." I say. "I was worried when that third one showed up. They got me while I was on the road."

"I hate the stabbers. Sent me for respawn more than once today. I never played a tank so I'm low on stom."

"Sorry to hear it, but hey, now ye've got me."

"Yeah, I do. I'm Mirae."

"Ye can call me Mel, or Scooti... I'm still getting used to this alias thing. Melpomine is my main name, but I got a request for Scoot."

"What do you mean?" Mirae says. "Some guy I'm gonna run dungeons with. He loves the dwarf persona. He's back in town trying to round up a group."

"Ahh good deal. I've got heals if you need em'."

"Ye know, we just might." The rush of combat, albeit an easy one, has me pumped for a dungeon. "Let me check." I pull out my VT to check on Tako.

Melpomine: How's the hunt coming?

TakoStar: Just need heals.

Melpomine: I've got one. Found a Sea Elf hunting bandits. Where are we going?

TakoStar: Meet at the gate and talk there.

Melpomine: Sounds good.

I say, "Tako says he's got the DPS, so we're good to go."

"Alright. I can do some damage too. Before the merge I played a healer and a magic archer."

"I'm not complaining."

While we're talking Mirae moves to examine the bodies.

Ridgewood Bandit #1 drops 10 silver.

Your share of the loot is 5 silver.

Ridgewood Bandit #2 drops 8 silver.

Your share of the loot is 4 silver.

Ridgewood Bandit #3 drops 13 silver.

Your share of the loot is 6 silver.

Mirae says, "Common dagger. I don't need it. Mind if I take the arrows?"

"Be my guest."

You have received Kris (common).

You have received Ridgewood Bandit Insignia x3.

I pull out the VT, and say "I've got to do something about this combat text. It's distracting."

"Can be." Mirae says. "I have mine set to just show health percentages, and only announce critical hits."

I say, "Good idea" and take her advice on display preferences. "This is my first time tanking in Haven in about four years. I pretty much stuck to Freeworld after that. You ever play over there?"

"Nah, just this game. I don't like spreading myself too thin. That your bike?" I'd almost forgotten about the Elechopper back on the dirt road. I nod my response. "Pretty cool, where'd you get it?"

"I... uh.. err... It's a Freeworld item."

"I've never seen one before." She says, as she moves to inspect it. She sets it upright and taps her finger against the side of the fire spirit's tank. Pbbbt. It blows a raspberry. "What's this?"

"It's what powers the bike. There's five versions of it, one for each of the magical elements in Freeworld—Earth, Wind, Fire, Water, Ether. This is the fire bike. It's called an Elechopper."

"Cool, and you've got a LE pet I see."

I'd totally forgotten Doom before she said it, and now... Where is he? "Doom!" I say, and I hear his hiss from the bodies of the fallen bandits. He hovers over Ridgewood Bandit #3 with his ghostly dragon mouth open, and a tendril of smoky soul spiraling into his gullet. "What are you doing?"

"He's undead." Mirae says. "He's probably drinking their spirits. I think that's how undead pets level up."

I say, "That's... disturbing."

Mirae shrugs, "They're just NPCs."

I say, "Wanna head back to Athelon and meet the party?"

"Yeah. Where they at?"

"South gate. Ye got a mount?"

"I do... but..." I see her eyeing the Elechopper, like she wants to ask something. "Can this sit two?"

Now I shrug. "I think so, but..." I pause for dramatic effect. "What's yer favorite element?"

"Earth!" she says without a moment's hesitation. "It's the magic of healing."

"...and earthquakes." I add with a smirk.

"Yeah, but earth has more healing magic than any other style, except maybe water."

"Fair 'nuff," I say, "You're really into this healing thing."

"Yeah... I am." Her voice goes a little quieter.

"What's up with that little plus by your name anyway? When I inspect ye it says Mirae, Type: Player and there's a little blue plus sign like ye see at the hospitals." As I speak, I access the mount interface on my VT to summon the Earth bike. I ask, "Ye sure ye like earth?"

Mirae says, "Positive."

"Here ye go," I say as I tap summon, the developer's edition of the Earthen Elechopper appears, green and brown, with a pouty little earth elemental stuck with an eternal frown stomping around the gas can.

"Wow... You have two and an LE item? Are you rich or something?"

I say, "Ye can ride on your own on our way back to Athelon."

"I can ride?"

Unlike most games, Freehaven online allows you to lend your mounts to other party members, so long as you stay within close proximity to each other or belong to the same party. When it finally dawns on Mirae that the second bike's hers to ride for a time, her face brightens with childlike joy far beyond what, in my opinion, the situation warrants.

"Yeah no problem." I say, "Ye just gotta give it back when you're done." Not that the system would allow someone to nick spirit bound items.

"Sweet." She says. "I've never ridden a motorcycle before."

"Neither have I." I say with a laugh. "Back home it's public transportation, all day every day. I once tried a moped though, so I guess that's something."

"I haven't even done that." Her tone sounds with a note of bitterness that clashes with her excitement moments before.

"So what's up with the plus sign on your profile?"

"Tell you what, you tell me how you get all this cool stuff, and I'll tell you about the blue cross icon." She says this while straddling the green motorcycle, patting it like it's a riding animal.

I say, "I dunno." Already, I'm uneasy about the subject, more about Jordan's account than that I'm a dev. Maybe I can just sort of... work around it without explaining the whole circumstance. It's been eight years, and I don't want a pity party.

"I'll show you mine if you show me yours. It's a fair trade."

"Alright," I say, and with an awful sigh I didn't mean to produce. "I'll go first."

"Shoot." She says, as she revs up the engine. We start back to Athelon moving slow enough that we can still have a conversation.

"The elebikes are easy. I'm a developer. The company gives us free developer's copies of any item we make."

"What's that mean?" She asks.

I say, "They don't have any stats like the real game items. We have to copy them from other objects we obtained by playing to keep it fair to customers."

"Wait so you made these? Like... not crafting, but did the modeling?"

I say, "Yeah, animations too."

"You have the coolest job EVER."

I smirk. No shame here. "I love what I do."

"So you're an employee? Does that mean you can get all kinds of free in-game stuff?"

"Nah, not really. I don't have anything to do with accounts, or even the stats on the items I create. They're real big about keeping everything fair, so as not to make players feel cheated."

"That sucks." Mirae says

"Not really. Did ye forget? Coolest job EVER." I say trying to mimic her tone, but doing a bad job of it since Scooti's voice is so much lower than Mirae's."

"Yeah I guess. Did they give you a Limited Edition or something?"

"Nah." I say, now's the time for subterfuge. "The LE edition was a Christmas gift from my parents before I even worked here. Back when ye could still buy it in stores for a few hundred bucks." I'm being very careful not to include who that gift was for.

"Nice," She says,. "So we're both Vanilla players."

"Looks like it. We've both been here from the beginning."

She asks, "Did you sell all your anniversary items?"

"Let's just say I've been collecting them."

"I've always wanted a sametora mount. They're so cool looking."

My mind reels back to the sametora hatchlings I got years back but never summoned. I play it like I know exactly what she's talking about and don't ask any questions. Instead, I say, "Yeah, they're pretty awesome." Assuming the statement must be true since LE items are so popular. One of these days, I need to go through all those LE items I've been collecting so I don't sound like such a noob when asked about them.

I then say, "Your turn. You have my answers, now gimme yours."

"Hmmm..." She says. "Maybe later." and then guns it kicking up a cloud of dirt as she goes. I hear her delighted shriek down the road, but I can't see her because one of the design features of the Earth bike was to make a magnified cloud of dust upon quick acceleration.

I try to catch up, with a six foot flame thrower flying out my exhaust but it's no use. So long as we are both on the ground there's no way to close the distance if she's going top speed.

I pull the handles back and take flight, my movement speed increasing from two hundred percent running speed to six hundred fifty. From there, it's no problem to burn over her like a comet and land, skidding to a stop 100 meters down the road in front of her.

"No way! They can fly?" Mirae says, laughing, and now she's flying too. Little bits of dirt, and pebbles fall on me from above. I've got to wonder if she'd be so adventurous in the real world. Probably not, welcome to Freehaven Online, where death is only temporary.

I'm not the only one who had the idea for loop-de-loops, and I catch her pulling the same airborne stunts that I was doing outside the capital.

She shouts from above, "This thing is way faster than my Pegasus! What did you copy?"

I want to be mad at her, but her childlike laughter is infectious, and all I can feel is happy that she's having a good time.

I call back to her, "Nightmare!"

"Whoa!" She says. It's probably at my announcement, but it could have just as easily have been due to her aerial acrobatics. Riding on the wind is a lot like a roller coaster. Finally she settles down, and finishes her statement. "You got one of those too?"

"Yeah" I say. "Natural drop. No corporate influence required." I pause. "Actually, it was before I worked for the company." Mirae looks like she's about to take off again, so I've gotta act fast to stop her. "Hold up. I answered your questions. If you take off again I may be tempted to unsummon, and ye can start building up endurance from falling damage."

That wipes the smile off her face.

"Sorry." She says. "I don't like talking about it." I'm about to tell her it's okay, even though I really want to know, but she beats me to it by starting her explanation. "When I was eleven I was messing around while snowboarding and fell off the lift."

"I uhh..." *Dude... Didn't see that coming.* She waves me silent.

"I would have been fine if I'd gone down like five minutes earlier, but instead I came down on a boulder and broke my neck. I've been either in bed or in a chair ever since. That's my story." She seems to grasp my confusion so she adds, "That's the incapacitated icon for real life people who can't do shit for themselves. I'm a quadriplegic. Can't even eat or pee without help."

Her sudden use of the word shit startles me. The harsh word is a dark blotch on her sunny demeanor. I'm about to say sorry, but I get the feeling that she's like me in not wanting the pity, so instead I say, "They make ye wear a tag like that?"

Mirae says, "It's not like that. Look. I can turn it on and off if I want."

I inspect her, and sure enough I see the plus sign appear and vanish as she adjusts her settings.

"So why do you use it?" I ask.

"I like teaming up with other incaps. I don't get friends in the real world, and here they know what it's like, and what I'm going through."

"I can't even imagine." I say.

"Trust me. I hate being the reason your bus is late, or why you've gotta take the next elevator when there's no room with me in my chair."

I feel like a shit now, because I didn't tell the whole story. It's like being in a bar next to that one guy that tells you his life story, that you blew off 10 minutes ago, only now you're over hearing him tell someone else, and as it turns out he's actually pretty interesting. Just like that, but fifty times worse.

I pull to the side of the road and stop my chopper. She looks over, turns back, and joins my side.

I say, "Sorry."

"I don't want pity. This is the one place I can be like everyone else. So don't ruin that for me. 'kay?"

"I didn't mean that." I say. "I mean I'm sorry I lied to you."

Now she looks insulted. "You lied? About what? All of it?"

"No. All that I said is true. Designing the choppers, the LE key all of it. I just didn't tell you the whole truth." Mirae narrows her eyes. "I wasn't the one who got the LE for Christmas. It was for my brother, he's been dead some eight years now." Mirae's lips move as if looking for the words but comes up silent. So, I cut her off. "I'm like ye, then. I don't want pity."

Finally, Mirae finds the words, and says "I see."

This is the first time I've ever told someone in-game about Jordan. It's scary and feels kinda good. Like I've been holding back this flood of emotion, and there's a small leak now, and the rest itches to come pouring out. I don't like the silence between us. It feels condemning.

I say, "I contacted Haven and inherited his account." There's no point in going on about the drivers license subterfuge when they were going to transfer ownership anyways if I could produce a death certificate. "This is a legacy game for me. I've got this whole guild to build up because I know it's what he'd have wanted. On top of that, I want to find the players who used to be members so I can tell them what happened."

"That's heavy stuff." She says. Her words are contemplative. I'd prefer if they were happy.

"Yeah well... Your story's not all pink clouds and bunnies." She shrugs. Conceding the point. "Look, we just met, but believe it or not you're the first person I've shared that with in-game. It's not the kind of thing you advertise. Also, I don't know many people Haven side and I want to be friends. "

Speaking while restarting her bike, she says, "You're gonna have to if you want to talk to lost guild members." She blows right past the friends comment. I let it slide.

"Yeah well, we'll cross that bridge when we come to it."

She's right of course. I just need time to adjust, both to being treated like a minor celebrity thanks to the LE key, and explaining where it came from. Telling a lie about it seems like a slap in the face to Jordan's memory. My heart feels lighter for having said something.

Mirae and I ride together approaching the southern gate of Athelon.

Melpomine: We're here.

TakoStar: Took you long enough.

Melpomine: Wah.

TakoStar: Were sitting at a table in the Smiling Otter. Southern district.

Melpomine: I know it.

TakoStar: We've got a few choices, but I want to see what we got for heals first.

Melpomine: Be there in five minutes.

I say, "They're waiting for us at an inn in the South District. There's a few ideas they want to pitch, but my vote's for dragons. Ye game?" My fantasy

Scottish dwarf voice feels heavier as I creep back into character, and the conversation grows more relaxed.

"Why dragons?"

"Got a quest for em'." I say, pondering. "Say, What would ye do for a chance for some Limited Edition loot?"

"Who do I have to kill?"

"Not who, what."

Mirae says, "Okay then, what?"

"How about 50,000 dragons? It just so happens that I have a limited edition guild quest that promises exclusive loot."

"I didn't know guilds got quests."

"Well, now ye do. What do ye say?"

"Uhhh..." I'm surprised that she says that instead of an immediate yes given how TakoStar acted. "I'll think on it. I like my current guild and don't want to up and leave everyone."

"I get that" I say, "Take your time."

"Maybe if I can bring a few people with me."

"More the merrier. Between you and me, this Guild is totally empty."

Mirae says, "I'll let you know soon. For now, call it a maybe."

"I can handle maybe."

We park are bikes outside the Smiling Otter, and I make the 'Bloop bloop!' action dismissing the Fire chopper. I repeat it again, and Mirae's disappears like a ghost.

"Now to see what kind of rabble Tako's rounded up."

I duck into the inn with Mirae on my heels. The scent of beef stew is heavy in the air, and it makes me hungry. There are a lot of tables, most of which are filled with adventurers and Havenfolk alike drinking. To my surprise, it's the haven folk that are chugging down huge mugs of ale, and the adventurers sipping water.

A bar maid in an apron approaches, and opens her mouth as if to ask us if we need anything, but just in time my eyes spot Tako with a few others at his table.

"We're with them." I say, and the bar maid curtsies. A nice touch, as a lot of inns can be a bit seedy. She nods and turns, but I catch her arm before she has to go. "Can you get me some of that stew? It smells fantastic.... and some..." I look around not much for ale, but don't want to order plain water. "Tea, if you don't mind."

"Go have a seat, n' I'll be right with you."

"Thanks," I say. Wondering what the stew will taste like.

Tako's saved us a corner table, wearing the same dark leathers I spotted him in before. The two adventurers by his side couldn't be more different.

Laurelade

Type: Player

Race: Gnome

Appearance: 4

Challenge: Average

Frobod	
Type:	Player
Race:	Human
Appearance:	3
Challenge:	Average

The gnome's draped in impressive looking wizard robes, with a cowl that gives off an eerie blue glow like bioluminescence. She's so small compared to everyone else, including my dwarf alias, that I wonder if she's on some kind of booster seat. I crack a smile imagining the gnome in baby shoes. The image clashes with the necklace of arcane sigils hanging from her neck and making the air around her electric with charged magic energy. The Man, Frobod, sports plate armor in charcoal black with a chest piece shaped like a skull absent a lower jaw.

"Ranged, and melee I assume." Indicating Laurelade then Frobod.

"You assume right."

"I'm a mage." Laurelade says.

Frobod says "Death knight."

While Freehaven online doesn't have a class system like in other games, players often refer to themselves as such to give others a sense of their play style, some, like Paladin, are official titles within the game. Mage is self explanatory, fire ball tosser, and that sort of thing. Death knight? I'm not so sure.

"What do you mean by death knight?"

"Before the merge, my main was a straight up fighter, but I also played a caster for a bit focusing on necromancy and death magic. Bring them all together and you get this... Death knight."

I nod. "Makes sense."

Mirae says, "That's gotta suck trying to cast in plate, with all the penalties."

Frobod looks sheepish as he says, "Check the description of my armor."

Deadplate Chestguard	
Set Completion 2/6	
Type:	Plate
Slot:	Chest
Armor	7
Quality:	Rare
Equipped Bonus:	Intellect +2, Strength +1, Stamina + 3
Special Properties:	
Reduces armored casting penalties by 13% for each equipped set item.	

"Very nice!" I say, "I see you've also got the boots."

He says, "Yeah, just crafted them. I've had the recipe for ages, but didn't have a use for them until now. I still need to find the other pieces."

Mirae says, "So, you're a blacksmith then?"

"Yeah." Frobod says.

I state the obvious, "High strength."

Laurelade intrudes, "Is it true that you have access to a LE guild quest?"

"Uh, yeah..." I say looking between Laurelade and Tako.

TakoStar says, "It was a good way to recruit."

Laurelade says, "I've already left my old guild, so I can join immediately."

I would have preferred to have been the one delivering the news about the Toxic Muffins being a limited edition guild and our recruitment, but what's said is said. I can't change it. I'm having flashbacks to Lord of the Rings as I take in our eclectic races, and decide in the moment to give them all a try. If we're hunting dragons, each guild member that's part of the group will add to the quest completion.

"I can get ye all into the guild on a trial basis. If everything works out, yer free to stay. Act like a dick, and yer gone. Sound fair?" There's a chorus of "Yes!" "Yeah." and "Absolutely." from everyone sitting at the table except Mirae whom I've already invited. "Ai'ight. Wait a sec while I send the invites."

I pull up the guild interface in my VT, and one by one TakoStar, Laurelade, and Frobod become members.

Laurelade says, "You didn't tell us that you only had two members."

TakoStar, "You've been holding out on me! You've been the guild leader all this time!"

"Surprise." I say with a false toothy grin caught somewhere between a smile and a grimace.

"Oh my god, look at this quest!" Frobod says, "Limited edition, 10,000 rep, and access to specialized items! You won't hear me complaining."

"Me either." TakoStar says. "But 50,000 dragons is a crap ton to kill for just five players. Whose this Marine chick?"

"Human. Martial Artist." I don't bother to say she's my Alias. Having at least one identity unknown to my guildies may prove useful in the future. "She's not around right now."

TakoStar says "What about you Sea Elfy, you joining?"

Mirae flushes, "Uhhh.. Alright. I guess. Just let me send a message real quick to my old guild." A few minutes pass as Mirae stares into her VT, before she looks up and says. "There. I'm ready for invite."

A few seconds later I get the notice.

Mirae has joined the guild.

"Just promise me you'll give all my friends the same chance when they come later."

I nod, understanding that Mirae's game friends are more than just contacts on her list of online buddies. Based on what she's told me, they're her social world. *Are we so different?* It's weird as hell to think that my best friend in the real world right now is a disembodied AI, named Sal. Mirae's in a wheelchair with no use of her limbs. *What's my excuse?*

"It's like I said, more the merrier. We're building this thing from the ground up."

Mirae asks, "What's a Toxic Muffin?"

I laugh and say, "I have no fooking clue."

No one asks why I decided to name my guild that, and I'm grateful. Trying to talk around Jordan's name choice would add a whole level of awkwardness to the conversation that I don't want or need. TakoStar rolls a map out on the rustic table just as the barmaid shows up with my tea and stew.

Laurelade says, "You bought food? Why?"

I say, "Smells good." more defensively than I'd have liked.

Laurelade says, "Yeah but it tastes... Whatever... You'll see."

I decide to take a spoon full and I'm disappointed to see that it doesn't taste much of anything. I fish out a piece of meat, and while it feels like meat in my mouth, there's no flavor. It's like eating warm water.

"Well, that's pointless." I say.

Laurelade says, "Told you."

I try a bit more hoping for a change in flavor that never comes. A small buff icon appears in the corner of my interface.

Hearty meal.

Regeneration increased by 50%.

6 minutes remaining.

That's nice, I guess, but it's not like we'll be carrying around cauldrons of stew through dungeons. The game seems annoyingly fond of providing regeneration buffs at the times we least need them. I try the tea, but instead it tastes like hot water. *So bad, so sad. I guess now I know why adventurers drink water.*

Tako says, "The closest dungeon to the city is the Catacombs. Lots of undead, but not so many dragons. I'd call it average difficulty for a group like ours."

"We should work on dragons." I say, and Tako nods.

"I'm getting to that." He points to another spot on the map. "Over here's a world boss dragon, but if we go in with a group this size we'll probably die."

"Damn." I say, and I see the others shaking their heads in agreement. "Remember I'm still getting back into tank mode. We fought a few bandits, but I'm still rusty."

Tako asks, "How many of you have flying mounts?" Everyone raises their hand. "Are they at least 300 percent?"

Frobod puts his hand down. "Sorry." He says.

I tell him, "No worries I got you." Then turn my attention to Tako, "Why do you ask?"

"The best spot for a group like ours is way over here in Three Winds. The main boss is a wind dragon, and there's a roost which means lots of tiny dragons to farm for the quest. As you can see, however it's quite far."

"I've got mounts covered. I have six that can move at 650% flight speed." In truth there might be a lot more since I haven't read them all yet.

Laurelade says, "Daaaaammnnnn, girl! Did you beat up a dragon-stork or something and steal all the baby eggs?"

I shrug mysteriously, and say "Something like that. I also have," I poke around in my VT for the mount interface and sort by ground speed. "At least that many off the top of my head, that can move at 600% ground speed."

At the same time, Laurelade says "What the fuck moves at 600% ground speed?"

Tako says "What did you do, raise a roadrunner on magic cocaine?"

Mirae laughs at Tako's lame joke, and makes eyes at him. I think she likes him.

Frobod adds, "You're from Freeworld, aren't you?"

I say, "Ding! Ding! Ding! Give the man a prize."

All the Haven exclusive players look to him for an explanation. Frobod says, "Freeworld has fast ground mounts since the setting is based on a magical post apocalyptic real world, but flying mounts are slow and almost unheard of."

"That's the jist of it. Also, I'm not sure how well they'll work in Haven. In Freeworld we have paved roads, and everything's dirt over here. I dunno, seems like it could be bumpy farther away from the cities."

"Yeah stick to air. Even with those crazy ground speeds, air is faster. Don't have to deal with twisting roads in the mountains, not to mention the max speed is plus 50 percent faster."

I ask, "Wind dragon roost then?"

They nod their ascent. TakoStar says "Sounds like it."

I say, "Then lets go punch some lizards in their foreheads."

Chapter 6 - In the Forehead

We step outside. I summon all five of the Elechopper mounts, starting with my middle finger waving "INFERNO!!!" invocation. Looks of bafflement turn to awe as each of the five spirit powered motorcycles appear in mechanical growls and flashes of light. If this was a picture of real life, people would think we were somewhere outside a mid-western biker bar situated kitty-corner from a renaissance festival.

"These are awesome!" Frobod says, immediately drawn to the black and purple ether mount with a shade trapped inside. It's the one I'd have picked for him anyway. "I've never seen them, when did they come out?"

"Last patch." I say.

"And you have five of them already?" Frobod asks. "How did you do all that, and then travel all the way here from Freeworld? I didn't know anyone had passed through the portal yet."

"She's a developer." Mirae says, straddling the green bike.

Tako takes the yellow, powered by an imprisoned sylph, and Laurelade takes the blue, with a small undine blowing water inside what appears to be a little fish tank. I suppose I should have asked if they all wanted to use my mounts, but I had a gut feeling that after seeing Mirae, my, and Frobod's rides, the other's would want their chance. Another part of me wanted to show off the kickass work I'd done in design space.

"Ye lead the way lad, cuz I have no idea where I'm goin'."

Laurelade says, "So does that mean you get all this free, leet stuff?"

"I'll explain on de way." I say, "If we fly slowly, and yes the bikes can fly."

Tako says, "That's some straight up Harry Potter shit."

Mirae laughs a little too loud. They recently remade the series featuring a 4D, full immersion experience where you can actually walk around the characters as they say their lines. As such, Hogwarts is fresh in everyone's mind.

"Just use party coms. Invite us. It says you and Mirae are already in a party."

I send off the invites.

TakoStar has joined your party.

Frobod has joined your party.

Laurelade has joined your party.

"There." Tako says. It sounds just like he's speaking in an earpiece. I check the chat settings on my VT, and sure enough I can choose to speak in either in general or party chat. From context, and the way his voice is all around me like wearing a headphones, no other onlookers can hear what we're saying. I forgot about the feature because it'd been so long since I'd played Haven, but I wonder why Mirae didn't suggest it on the way back to Athelon. I guess having a conversation over slow moving bikes on a dirt path felt more like it would in the real world, than speaking casually at high speed with the other person's words planted right in your ear.

"Before we go..." Tako holds up a canteen, "I want to propose a toast to the Toxic Muffin's. Haven Online's first motorcycle guild."

I'm touched by the gesture, because Tako toasting to my brother's guild name, feels like a toast made to him. I don't have a canteen or water skin handy, so I mime the gesture, while everyone else either copies my empty handed motion, or raises a container of their own. For the first time since signing in, I feel as though I've made progress in my personal quest to resurrect the Toxic Muffins from Jordan's grave.

"To the Toxic Muffins." I say, and follow up with a quiet "Cheers."

The guild members that have drinking containers smack and slosh them together. "Damn..." I think, "This feels really good."

The flight to the Windroost is largely uneventful. Tako and Frobod thrill at the Elechopper's, which is to say Nightmare's, movement speed. Laurelade is a tougher crowd to please. Perhaps she has a mount of her own that's just as fast.

In the transit time, we discuss each other's builds, what we can do, and how long we've been playing the game. As it turns out, I'm not the only Freeworld player, Frobod has some experience there too, but I'm the only one who has played it almost exclusively for the last four or five years.

I also explain my position as a designer, and the perks that come from the company while we fly just under low clouds, with each elemental bike raining it's own cosmetic effect on the world below. I look like a comet, Mirae sprinkles specks of rock and dirt, Laurelade's bike causes drops of rain, Tako causes a sudden breeze, and Frobod's casts a light like a violet and grayscale version of the aurora borealis. They all seem to accept my employment, and the limitations of my employee benefits, except Laurelade who gives me a skeptical look. *She can see the DE tag on the item. Where else would it have come from?*

"Hold up!" Tako says, he raises a hand and stops overhead. We all slow and perch mid-air in a flying V formation. I get a kick out of the idea of pretending to be UFOs. Once we've all stopped moving he points, we can see little creatures milling about just outside a dark hole in the side of the mountain. We've arrived.

"Can any of you do mounted combat?" Tako asks.

"I've never tried." I say, though I'm liking the image of roaring in on a badass motorbike, wielding Exsanguinator, and chopping off dragon heads as I go.

"I can do ranged." Mirae says, as she nocks an arrow, gripping the seat of the Earthen Chopper with her thighs.

"Scooti, why don't you rush down there and give it a shot, and we'll cover you. If it goes south, we'll join." I nod at Tako. I don't mind him taking charge even though I'm the guild leader since it's been so long since I've done a Haven dungeon. Moving around in Haven feels much the same as Freeworld, however I haven't worn plate or used a longsword since I last raided here. "Mirae, stick to heals for now. I don't want to risk you getting agro until we see how much Scoot can hold."

"Laurel and Fro, you're DPS, you know what to do?"

Laurel says, "Yeah we got it."

"Fro, since you're in plate, I want you to be off-tank. Keep an eye on Mirae and Laurel. If they pull agro before Scooti can get to them, taunt off them with higher priority going to protecting Mirae."

"Got it." Frobod says. I expect Laurel to be offended, but she seems to think nothing of it. I'm not wild about her attitude sometimes, but this shows that she at least knows her place in the party. Protect heals first because they keep everyone else alive. Heal tank before DPS because they prevent the rest of the party from taking damage.

Tako says, "We're good to go. Have at it Scooti." I spin Exsanguinator in my writs trying to get a feel for how to strike while mounted. I don't know whether it's better to swoop down like an eagle, or go to ground a few meters away, and approach as if on horse. "Scooti?"

"Yeah, sorry. Just trying to figure out how to make this work."

I decide on the ground approach for the sake of simplicity, and find myself wishing I had a halberd instead of a sword for longer reach. When my bike touches ground I hear Frobod say "What are you doing?" but I ignore him. There are four little dragons bobbing up and down with golden reptile wings. I have my target.

I hit the throttle and charge.

No response from the monsters as I approach, holding the handle bars with one hand, and wielding the sword in the other. Thirty meters ahead. Twenty, no response. Then bestial shrieks sound around me as all four whelps converge for the attack.

Taunt. Successful.

Windroost Whelp #1 attacks.

Windroost Whelp #2 attacks.

Windroost Whelp #3 attacks.

Exsanguinator bites deep into the first whelp's skin before it has a chance to connect.

You have killed Windroost Whelp.

You have gained the skill Mounted Combat.

I try to swing at number two but it's a miss. It takes evasive action, and aborts its attack before it can connect. The third hits me right in the chest and sends me flying, Elechopper rolling on without me before tipping on to its side. I don't take any damage, but now I'm prone. Whelp numbers 2 and 3 are about to attack when a fork of blue lightning rains down from above, zapping them both, and leaving blackened bodies that look like scorched turkeys.

Laurelade has killed Windroost Whelp.

Laurelade has killed Windroost Whelp.

A dart of green magic energy speeds past from overhead, toward the cave entrance.

Mirae has killed Windroost Whelp.

"Nice hit." The gnome says, smirking at my toppled chopper. The rest of the party comes to ground around me. Getting back to my feet, I make the "Bloop bloop!" sounds and gestures to banish the bikes to the nothing from whence they came.

"Gotta start somewhere. Mounted Combat level 1!" I cheer sarcastically.

Tako says, "It'll be a lot harder once we're inside. Everyone ready?"

"Ready." We say in a chorus, except for Frobod who says "Just a sec." He's checking something on his VT.

"Nice." Frobod says. "Now we only have 49,996 dragons to kill. Even the little ones count."

I say, "Lets do this." and march myself into the open mouth of the dungeon.

Passing through a dungeon portal is like experiencing zero gravity for anywhere between ten and twenty seconds, and then your feet are set gently back on the ground. Each dungeon transports you to a parallel realm within the game world, so that multiple groups can experience the same content at once. World bosses, by contrast exist outside of dungeons, so there's only one of them available in the game for players to fight at any given time.

This dungeon looks like a cave with some kind of magical lighting. As a half-elf, even though I'm wearing what's effectively a dwarf costume in the form of an Alias, I take no penalties for vision in low light environments. I still have all my half-elf stat bonuses and penalties, and none of those I'd get from playing a true dwarf character.

There's a giant egg the color of cocoa powder flecked with glowing amber to the right of me. I take a step closer to investigate. It begins to quiver and shake. I instantly take a step back. You don't have to be an endgame player to know that if you wait too long, something's going to come out of it. A few seconds later Tako, then Mirae, and the rest of the crew appear behind me.

"Careful!" I say, "There's eggs, and I got a feeling that if you get too close they'll hatch."

"Duh." says the gnome, now that we stand side by side, I see that the top of her head is about up to my nipples. That's really short considering my dwarf alias, and I get to wondering where half-gnome babies come from. None of the others seem surprised, by my comments about the egg, and I realize that I'm the only one in the group that hasn't been here. *...and here I thought I was being useful.*

Tako says, "This place is full of them. Usually I'd say we should do a speed run, moving as quickly as possible, so as not to hatch the eggs, and hit the boss, but with this quest, I think it's better to do a full clear. "

"Agreed." says Laurelade.

TakoStar says, "Scooti, go ahead and hatch that one so you can see what we're up against."

I walk up to an egg. It quivers and vibrates as before, each moment and every inch I move closer the shaking becomes more intense. When I actually touch its surface, it explodes showering our entire party with goo. There's an

earsplitting shriek and an angry golden whelp hovering, beating its wings, where there was none before. It dives to attack, but I step out of the way. Even in full plate it's not much trouble. I raise Exsanguinator, and deliver a power cut across its scaly neck. The head and body fly in separate, but similar directions.

You have killed Windroost whelp.

"Not that hard." I say.

Tako says, "Yeah, just wait until we're surrounded by tons of them."

Mirae says, "It's pretty crazy... and fun."

Tako says, "Here's the plan, Scooti, I want you to run around the left side of the room dragging your fingers against every egg you come across, taunting along the way. The rest of us will take them down. Mirae, all heals on Scooti."

Mirae salutes like a cartoon soldier.

Tako says, "Go!" and I do.

I run around the perimeter smacking my plated glove against each egg I come across. Boom! Boom! Boom! Boom! Explosion after explosion as the sound of shrieking dragons, and yolky goop spills across the floor. Frobod rushes up behind with a giant greatsword held high over his head. He swings, it connects. Draconic death cries follow. I clatter my sword against my shield in my traditional taunting gesture.

Taunt. Successful.

Windroost Whelp attacks.

Windroost Whelp attacks.

I minimize the combat log. I block three diving dragon beaks in a single shield block, and take another swipe with Exsanguinator. Another goes down. One hits me in the back of the neck, then my back, and another and another.... The crunch of their bodies on full plate is like hail on the roof of an automobile. My health drops, but it quickly jumps back up thanks to Mirae's magic.

Frobod takes out another whelp when suddenly unnatural clouds fill the room. Electricity crackles through the air. Baby dragon scream, after scream fills my ears. The sent of burnt meat and ozone fills my nostrils. There's one whelp left, Tako takes it out with a throwing knife.

"Very nice." Tako says.

"Mages do em' all at once." Laurelade says.

I check our quest counter, and that small encounter netted us twenty dragon kills. Not bad for one pull.

"It's going to be all like this until the first boss. You ready?"

"Yeah!" I say, getting back into the game. I may be four years rusty, but shield and sword tanking is like riding a bike, and the reptilian attacks tug at sleeping muscle memories. I move forth into the next chamber, and my jaw drops seeing what seems like an endless field of chocolate and gold colored eggs. "Hold on to your butts!" I say and charge in, clanking my armored fist into every egg I come across. Ten baby dragons, twenty, fifty... I keep going until I've got the whole room coming at me.

I hear people screaming over party chat but I can't make it out because the shrieks of the whelps are so damn loud. They dive at me over and over, and I try my best to use my shield for cover, beating Exsanguinator against its face every chance I get.

Taunt. Successful.

Windroost Whelp attacks.

Taunt. Successful.

Windroost Whelp attacks.

Over and over until all that can be seen of me is a massive horde of batting wings, and swooping reptilian bodies. Health drops to 30 percent and then back up to 80. The cherry blossom scented magic giving me the fuel to keep on going. I smack a few more eggs and goop splashes everywhere. Tako and Frobod's portraits turn black as they lose the last of their health, but Laurelade and Mirae are still going strong. I get a cold embarrassed feeling, because it was my job to keep them alive. If I'd done my job in holding the mobs attention, Tako and Fro wouldn't be dead right now.

I yell, "Son of a fu-! Sorry!" into the party chat.

Frobod says, "S'alright. First run in four years right?" I realize belatedly that I lucked the hell out with these recruits. As a lot of players get bitchy when their tanks don't hold agro.

Taunt. Successful.

Windroost Whelp attacks.

Taunt. Successful.

Windroost Whelp attacks.

Tako cheers, "Someone get that girl some Viagra! Heal your ass off Mirae!" through the party chat, even though his avatar is already down for the count.

"You got it!" That was Mirae.

Scent of ozone, lightning flashes; dragons die by the dozen, but others are still attacking, my health's down to 10% as I see that Mirae's running out of manna. *Well fuck. Can't win them all I guess.* I can't even swing Exsanguinator without opening myself to be hit half a million times. Suddenly her manna bar shoots back up, and then down again, as I'm fully restored.

"Wooooo!" I shout. Getting pummeled like this is a rush.

Shards of ice crash down, as Laurelade casts a frost spell. Dragons scream. I lift my shield to take cover.

There are fewer dragons now, and I risk more strikes with Exsanguinator. I miss my first, but take down another with a follow-up slash. The blade heals me. I have eight health now.

Three more, but a trio of arcane bolts fly through the air vaporizing would be targets. I cheer, "Wooo!" upon realizing every dragon is dead. I breathe deeply. *That was epic.*

Mirae says, "You get Frobod, I'll take Tako," and she begins an Elvish resurrection incantation. The game allows you to speak fantasy languages, using

your English vocabulary, but any character not fluent in Elvish, Dwarven, Orcish, what have you, will just hear a bunch of gibberish. The trade tongue that everyone speaks by default is known as simply Common.

It's been forever since I've played Scooti, so it takes me a minute to find the Paladin resurrection spell in my interface. I lay my hands on the death knight's limp body and call out "Come back, out of darkness, and into light!" A ray of sunshine pierces the roof of the dungeon as if it's not even there, and my patron deity, Helios, the Sun Lord returns Frobod to the living. Frobod stands with a groan in a pillar of white light. It disappears as soon as he's on his feet.

They both have low health, and Mirae does her Elvish magic healing thing. Resurrections take a long time to cast so as to prevent people from using them during fights, but in a couple of minutes both Tako and Frobod are back to full health.

"I'm out of manna. I'm going to need a few minutes to recover."

"No problem." Tako says, and then to me. "I didn't mean for you to pull the whole room. I wanted to take this in five or six groups."

"Well, it worked, didn't it?"

"Yeah." Tako says, "Luckily we had a kick ass healer. Seriously, nice heals Mirae."

If I didn't know better, I'd say the elf was blushing. *Doesn't she already know she's a good healer?*

Laurelade says, "Hey, if you can hold em, I can nuke em, but..."

"Not all your Taunts hit them. That's how me and Tako died." Frobod says. "It's hard to hold an entire room like this. If I'd known you were going to pull everything, I'd have waited a bit longer to make sure you had all their attention, before charging in."

"Yeah, but it's alright. We've got two resers in the group, so no one has any penalties."

I say, "I can't use mine again for thirty minutes."

"Same." Mirae says.

Tako says, "So lets try not to die next time. This room's clear, and we've got a mini-boss up ahead."

"Did any of these guys drop anything?" Frobod asks.

"Yeah, go ahead and loot." I say.

Sixty-eight vendor trash dragon fangs added to my inventory later, Mirae chimes in with something good.

Egg of the Windroost Hatchling

Description:

This item summons a companion.

Summoning this companion will bind it to you.

"Niiice..." Tako says.

"Who wants it?" I add.

Everyone looks at each other as if daring anyone to speak. I've got so many vanity items from having a LE key, and being a dev, that I'd almost feel bad

stealing the item from my new guild members, so I say "I'll pass. One of you can take it."

Laurelade says, "Roll for it."

Each party member pulls out their VT, and initiates the roll sequence.

Laurelade rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 5

Frobod rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 9

TakoStar rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 8

Mirae rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 2

Frobod receives loot Egg of the Windroost Hatchling.

Tako says, "Congrats man!"

I say, "Grats."

"Congrats." Mirae and Laurelade say together.

Tako says, "Go ahead and summon. I want to see what you got."

Frobod, nods, and a pulse of soundless golden light flashes. As the spots clear from our eyes, we see a little gold dragon just like the ones we massacred flapping beside him. Frobod screams in delight. "YEEESSSSSS!!"

I raise a brow and inspect his new companion.

Windroost Hatchling

Type: Creature

Race: Dragon

Quality: Epic

Status: Friendly

Challenge: Easy

Spirit Bound

"Being in this guild has made me luckier already!" Frobod says.

Tako adds, "No more under 300 percent speed flying mount for you."

Mirae says, "Very nice! Congrats" I must have had a confused look on my face because Mirae says "Epic companions can be grown and trained into mounts like your flutterdrake. The rare version of the hatch just stays the same."

"Ah." I say "I knew that." I kinda do, but I'd never been much for pet growing when I played in Haven before, and pet drops have always been on the rare end of the spectrum. "That should be an upgrade."

"You have no idea! Everyone teases me about my slow ass mount."

"Welcome to the 300 plus club." Mirae says with a chuckle.

"Should we move on?" Tako asks.

"Let's do." I say. "Congrats again on your pet and mount."

Frobod says, "This just made my day."

Tako says, "Alright, mini-boss. This is a straight forward tank and spank. Except for at the start of phase two, when she does a little dance, transforms and summons a bunch of adds. Frobod you try to pick those up until Scooti has them. Scooti, after transform try to hold her in the corner or she'll breathe fire on the party"

"Will do..." Frobod says. He grins at his little dragon once more, before dismissing it.

I say, "I can do that."

Frobod cheers "Toxic Muffins!"

I really wish I knew what our guild name meant, but I join the battle cry anyway "Toxic muffins!"

Chapter 7 - Boss Fights

The first boss, aka the mini-boss patrols into the hatchery. Mirae's at eighty percent manna, but everyone's at full health.

The newcomer says, "No! Our whelps! What have you done? You will pay!"

Tilashia	
Type:	Boss
Race:	Dragon
Appearance:	9
Challenge:	???

Tilashia is a couple heads taller than anyone in our party; a lean woman with serpentine skin, and wicked red claws in place of finger nails. Frobod's unlucky enough to be closest to her, and she extends her wicked hand sending a trio of magic bolts flying. His health drops by ten percent.

No time to waste, I bang Exsanguinator and my shield together.

Taunt. Successful.

Tilashia attacks.

One volley, two volleys, three bursts of glowing blue-white projectiles fly my direction from Tilashia's open palm, lowering my health by twenty percent. It feels like being pelted with hard packed snowballs. The pain quickly fades as the scent of cherry blossoms surrounds me. I charge, and suddenly find myself looking up at my feet as they fly out from under me. The ground's been lubricated by exploding dragon egg slime. I crash to the floor and slide an uncomfortable six feet toward our opponent. Hard metal armor clunks and scrapes against slippery stone.

The boss leaps an impossible distance, and crashes into my prone form, clawing at my helm, but so far doing no damage. I hear a skidding sound off to my right, and catch a glimpse of Frobod riding the draconic slip and slide. *At least I'm not the only one.* Everyone else has either managed to keep their feet, or hasn't moved from their starting position.

I try pushing the boss off me, but it's no use because she's so heavy. I watch Tako's dagger come down hard behind her head. *That's gotta hurt.* I can't see the rest of his body, because my entire view consists of Tilashia's crocodile toothed head and upper body. For a moment her skin frosts over as Laurelade blasts her with some kind of cold magic. The frigid effect fades in just a second.

I can't swing my sword because I'm pinned. I can't block with my shield because it's pressed against the left half of my body. I normally don't advise disarming yourself mid-combat, but desperate times call for desperate measures. I let go of Exsanguinator's grip, and press my gauntleted hand to Tilashia's hard, scaly chest.

I growl, "Helios smite thee!" and for a moment a beam of pure sunlight shines onto her chest exactly where I touch, in spite of being indoors. An arc of yellow holy light jerks back and fourth down the column of sun like an arc of electricity, harmlessly through my hand, and into my opponent.

Smite. Successful.

Tilashia takes 2 holy damage.

Tilashia is stunned.

A ten second countdown appears above her head, with an icon that looks like a whirlpool, indicating that the creature can't take any action. *A lot can happen in ten seconds.*

Out of nowhere, Frobod comes in swinging his devilish black greatsword like a Louisville Slugger sending the boss flying. Laurelade follows up with magic bolts of her own, and Tako makes a lucky dive out of the way of Tilashia's flying body. Time seems to move a bit slower he turns and manifests one of his weighted throwing knives from out of nowhere. His foot slips as he tosses, and it clatters harmlessly to the ground somewhere behind the boss. Having made a reflex save, he doesn't join me on the floor and in the egg muck.

I grab Exsanguinator's hilt, and struggle back to my feet. My boots slide a little, but now that I'm expecting slippage, maintaining my balance is easier. Laurelade lets loose another frost spell which encases Tilashia's lower body in a block of ice.

Tilashia snaps out of her stun as I close the distance. I clunk Exsanguinator and shield together to make sure I have her attention. I'm not within arm's reach so she hits me with another round of magic bolts. Boom! Boom! Boom! They flow right around my shield. Boom! Boom! Boom! I feel a brisk, and then hot pain slam into my chest.

This takes me down to sixty percent, but Mirae's fast with her magic, and my health jumps back up to ninety. Tako sends another knife flying and it connects. Frobod swings his sword, and the boss somehow manages to parry... with her forearm of all things. *That shouldn't be possible.* I expect to see the limb go flying, but her life just goes down a bit. At least she bleeds a little. My content rating's set to PG-13 so I'm not constantly showered in gore.

I finally get a good blow with Exsanguinator in, leaving a gash across the boss's chest, and Tako finishes her off with a flurry of quick strikes with his dagger in her belly.

Tako says, "Good work! Now time for phase two."

Tilashia says, "Enough! You've murdered our children. Now you'll feel the wrath of true dragon power!"

The ice holding Tilashia in place explodes sending frozen crystals in every possible direction. The boss begins to levitate, chin raised in ecstasy, arms and legs limp like a puppet. Suddenly, her skin begins to ripple, wizard's robes rip, and her face pushes out into a long dragon muzzle. The boss's mass increases, one time, two times, six times over replacing the comparatively small humanoid body with a massive dragon form that takes up a quarter of the room.

I call out, "Helios smite thee!" The fist size bar of sun quickly appears, and zaps the beast with holy damage before fading. No stun this time. I smash my shield and Exsanguinator together to make sure I'm the first she'll attack.

"Scooti! Corner! Go!" Tako says, but I haven't forgotten. I move as fast as I can without falling into the farthest corner of the room from where I last battled the hatchlings.

Like an obedient dog, Tilashia follows, and lashes out with a massive claw the size of my torso. It's a successful block, and I take no damage. The dragon's so big I can't see what the rest of my party's doing. As long as the boss's attention is on me, they're not taking any damage.

Tilashia says, "Die stubborn whelp!" and claws again with her foreleg. My health drops, then bounces back up with the scent of Mirae's magic. Another claw comes in, and slams me against the wall. My health drops again, but a quick cut with Exsanguinator reverses some damage while chipping away at Tilashia's seemingly endless bar of life.

The dragon pauses its attack just long enough to sound an earsplitting roar. I hear the sound of flapping wings, and animal footsteps on the floor. *I forgot about the adds.* Not wanting anyone else to die I taunt again, one time, two time three times in a row not wanting to take a chance on a party member dying. Even so, I see Laurelade's health drop by ten percent, and then Frobod's plunges by thirty. I catch him in my peripheral vision, as I see him rushing Tilashia with an aerial stampede of whelps, and a cohort of previously unseen juvenile dragons about the size of our Elechoppers scuttling across the ground.

Frobod's health drops by another ten percent, as I see one of the juveniles take a bite out of his thigh. I taunt. Exsanguinator and my shield go clunk, clunk, clunk! *This time I've got them.* As if by magic, all of the monsters trying to take their pound of flesh from Frobod, turn their attention to me. I'm bombarded by another one of Tilashia's claws, snapping juvenile snouts, and dive bombing hatchlings.

Exsanguinator cuts one of the smallest in two, as the room goes dark like on a stormy day. Laurelade calls her lightning. Flashing light. Scent of ozone. All of the whelps sing their death cries, and juveniles have just a sliver of health left. I cut one, then two of them down as Exsanguinator drains their life, but Tilashia gets in another lucky strike.

I'm down to thirty percent health, and Tilashia still has sixty. Mirae casts a spell I haven't seen before. Grass and forest mushrooms sprout from the ground beneath me. Frobod's also standing in the area of effect, and I watch both our health bars begin to slowly recover.

Three things happen in the next instant. Tilashia rears up on her hind legs and roars "Die!!!" Meanwhile, Frobod turns on his heel, and sprints the opposite direction... as well as anyone can sprint wearing plate armor anyway. My health, now at thirty percent, suddenly leaps to one hundred.

Tilashia takes a deep breath, and I have only a second to raise the shield attached to my forearm in defiance. A blast of flame rolls over me. I sweat like I've been in a sauna under my armor, and all the heat makes me grow light headed. My health's at forty percent, and my skin stings to move like a nasty

sunburn. If Mirae hadn't pulled off that fast heal, I'd be dead, and the rest of the group would be fighting Tilashia on their own.

"Owwweee!" I scream, as I try to fight the pain, my wounds are already healing thanks to the area of effect spell Mirae place before the damage. The pain fades just as fast. She gives me a couple of two health baby heals, and I'm already near recovered. By now the adds are all dead, and Tilashia's change in body position gives me my first glimpse of Frobod and Tako cutting into the dragon's body.

A quick glance at her health tells me she's at almost 15%. She goes back down on all fours, and hits me with another claw attack. It hurts a bit, the pain vanishes as I scent Mirae's magic.

"Hurry! I'm out of manna!" Mirae says, and it's no good. No manna means no heals. No heals could mean a very dead party.

Laurelade, who has been standing beside Mirae this whole time hit's the dragon with a chain of cold spells as snow flurries fall on the inside of the roost, and frost collects on Tilashia's body.

Eight percent left. I block another attack, as I hear fleshy impact after impact from Frobod's greatsword, which is now glowing with a sickly grey light, and Tako's daggers. Even Mirae has switched to her bow as streaks of green impact the side of our enemies body. 5 percent.

I land a blow in the meaty part between Tilashia's talons. It makes me feel good to think I've finally caused some damage. More flashes of magic hit her. *We just might do this.* My optimism is short lived as a dragon claw slams into my side, and knocks me off balance. A huge chunk of my health disappears.

I realize that I'm at thirty percent, when Tilashia rears back for another fire blast. *If this hits, I'm dead, and we've got no more reses.* She begins her scripted "Die!!!" and I charge forward in a reckless assault. It's either kill her now, or wipe the party. The boss's health is at one percent.

I use every ounce of my strength to thrust Exsanguinator up, into, and deep within the dragon's belly. Stolen health from the blade leaches back into me.

Tilashia doesn't get another attack, and instead of bathing me in flame she crashes to the ground with a terrible "NOOO!!!!!!" that echoes through the dungeon. The floor shakes upon impact.

Frobod and Tako both cheer "Yes!" while the gnome brushes something unseen from her robes.

In the same instant golden light sparkles around both me and Mirae.

Point Break! You have gained ten points to distribute among attributes.

Tako says, "Congrats on the ding both of you."

Although Freehaven doesn't have a leveling system, it does have "Point Breaks" which are equivalent to levels, otherwise known as "dings." Each allowing players to spend accumulated attribute points on their primary stats. The higher the stat becomes however, the more expensive it is to advance to the next level. The number of dings you can get are technically unlimited, but most people usually don't see more than one or two each month.

Stamina. Current level: 20.

Points required for next level: 53.

You have 63 unspent points. Do you want to raise Stamina to 21?

Yes / No

I choose yes. As a tank, stamina, the ability to resist damage, is one of my most important stats in the game. Having 21 points in it, makes me that much closer to having the endurance of a human...well.. half-elven mountain.

TakoStar loots while Mirae and I are spending our points. Once I'm done I notice that my shield, armor, and the stone wall behind me are covered in soot. With the end of my index finger, I draw a smiley face on my shield.

Tilashia's Ribbon of Spirit Regeneration

Type:	Misc
Slot:	Accessory
Quality:	Epic
Equipped Bonus:	Intellect + 2, Stamina + 1
Special Properties:	
Restores 3% of mana every 6 seconds during combat, and 6% outside of combat.	

Windroost Swiftboots

Type:	Leather
Slot:	Feet
Quality:	Epic
Equipped Bonus:	Dexterity + 3, Stamina + 1, Haste 3
Special Properties:	
Movement Speed Increased by 5%	

Tilashia's Arcane Boomstick

Type:	Wand
Quality:	Epic
Base Damage:	Intellect+3 Arcane Damage
Equipped Bonus:	Intellect+ 3, Stamina+1
Special Properties:	
Increases range of spells by 10%	
Offensive spells ignore 4 points of Armor	

Tilashia drops 78 gold. Your share of the loot is 15 gold and 60 silver.

Tako says, "Anyone need anything?"

Frobod says, "I'm good. Even if nothing else drops for me this whole run, I'm happy finally being in the 300+ percent club."

Tako says, "I'd like the boots if no one minds."

That seems the obvious choice to me so I say, "They're all yours." I catch Laurelade and Mirae eyeing each other like strange cats, so I say "Go ahead and roll for the others if you want em'. Start with the ribbon."

Laurelade rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice.

Result: 10

Mirae rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice.

Result: 9

"Nuts!" Mirae says, "I really wanted that."

Laurelade receives loot Tilashia's Ribbon of Spirit Regeneration.

I say, "OK now for the wand."

Mirae rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice.

Result: 2

"Ouch." Tako says.

Laurelade rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice.

Result: 1

Mirae receives loot Tilashia's Arcane Boomstick.

"Oh!" Tako cheers. "It ain't over till it's over folks."

"Thanks." Mirae says, looking disappointed.

Laurelade says, "I was kinda hoping for the wand. We can trade if you want."

"Yes!" Mirae shouts. They exchange items. Mirae bounces up and down in unfettered excitement. Seeing her move around like this makes me feel suddenly sad for the wheelchair bound girl in the real world. *This game's given her a second chance at life.* She ties the ribbon in her minty green-white hair.

"This will help with my out of manna problems."

Laurelade on the other hand practices flicking and aiming the wand. I wonder what kind of person she is in the real world. Everyone's so new to the guild that, aside from Mirae, I don't have any sense of their offline lives. I may never know, since a lot of players share their real world information sparingly.

We proceed into the next room where we encounter a few packs of juvenile dragons, but they go down easy compared to the boss, and the combination of Exsanguinator's bite, and Mirae's heals keeps me topped up on health the whole time. I want to run around like a maniac pulling everything to make the battle more interesting, but I've still got 10 minutes left on my resurrection cool down,

and after not holding agro on the whelps in the first stage, I don't want to risk sending anyone for respawn.

We're standing outside the chamber with the main boss, when we all stop for Tako to go over strategy.

"Alright, this fight has two monsters, Raika a big ass lightning dragon, and Nothgoran a dragon warrior in human form. Raika will beat her wings sending wind everywhere trying to knock us down, and Nothgoran will run around trying to chop us with his war axe. Overall it's not too hard, but we've gotta spread out, because if we're too close the lightning will jump from one person to the next. All damage on Raika, because if you kill Nothgoran first, she'll just resurrect him."

I look to everyone in the party, but judging from the bored expressions on their faces this is old news. It's nevertheless important for me, as tank, to know.

Tako continues, "There's a trick to doing this fast but whether or not we can pull it off depends on how well you can keep your footing."

"What's that?" I ask.

"There's three stars on the floor close to the balcony. If you stand on them while Noth is attacking you, her lightning will jump to him after hitting you, so, Scooti, try to tank from one of those positions. She'll try to move you away before doing her lightning thing."

I say, "Got it."

Laurelade says, "Are we ready to go?"

"Yeah." Frobod says.

Tako says, "All in."

The room with the boss is a huge open chamber the size of a supermarket without any shelves. Just as Tako said, there's a massive balcony giving way to open air where dragons can land and take off from the roost. When we enter, Raika, a gigantic yellow dragon with caps of red on each of her wing tips lounges on the ground, while Nothgoran a human-dragon hybrid in spiky full plate and no helm, tosses haunches of goat into Raika's enormous mouth. He's got scaled charcoal colored skin, a short muzzle filled with wicked teeth, and intense yellow eyes. Behind him is a mountain of at least fifteen animal carcasses ranging from goats, to ponies, and sheep.

They haven't noticed us yet so I take control of the fight by initiating the first attack. I call out, "Helios smite thee!" and land a holy bolt between Raika's eyes. Nothgoran looks up, and I bellow "Helios smite thee!" before he gets any ideas about attacking the rest of the party. I chuckle as Helios sunbeam tags him in the left buttock. I clash Exsanguinator against my aegis, signaling DPS that it's OK to attack.

Taunt. Successful.
Raika attacks.

Taunt. Successful.
Nothgoran attacks.

The huge dragon says, "You dare challenge the might of Raika? I will be your doom." and beats her giant wings. It's already getting windy, and I look

around frantically for the stars on the floor near the balcony. Frobod and Tako approach from opposite directions, meanwhile Laurelade and Mirae each stand a good 40 feet from each other well out of melee range.

Nothgoran charges faster than a plate wearer should be able, swinging his two handed axe right at my head. It clacks against my shield and I take no damage. Tako's throwing knives up at Raika, meanwhile Frobod is sending black bolts of unhealthy energy her direction. The wings beat harder, and suddenly air catches my shield like a metal sail. I have to work to keep it in place. Nothgoran takes another swing at me, I duck out of the way, and counterattack with a satisfying critical hit beneath his breastplate. His health creeps downward.

I look up and see Raika taking a big breath, which I can only assume is a preamble to her lightning attack. I haven't found the star, but... *Wait...* I see a silver shape like a compass rose engraved in stone some six feet away. I lunge for it, leaving my self open to attack. Nothgoran takes advantage of my lack of defense slamming his weapon clean into my chest. My health drops by a third, but on comes the scent of flowers, and I know Mirae's got me as my wounds mend.

A moment later, an arc of lightning shoots from Raika's maw, and connects with the tip of Exsanguinator. It jumps from my weapon, to my shield, and into my body. Then, Nothgoran roars in pain. *Success!* I'm standing right where I wanted, and an amazing fifty percent of his health vanishes. *Tako wasn't kidding about this being the easy way.*

After Raika's lightning, she lands at the edge of the balcony and attempts to bash me with her tail. It catches me by surprise, but I'm able to duck before it connects. Nothgoron's axe crashes against my shield, as Raika follows her tail swipe with a claw attack, which connects with my side.

My health drops a little, but it's nothing Mirae can't handle. Raika and I go back and forth trading blows as I try to either block or dodge Nothgoron's attacks. Laurelade is making good use of her wand, as I see as much as hear Frobod land a clean chop with his greatsword in Raika's flank. I have no idea where Tako is, it's hard to keep track of everyone during combat.

Raika beats her wings again, which is a sign for the other close-range fighters to run out of range of her lightning, Frobod does, but then when I least expect it see Tako leaping on to Raika's back. She lifts off the ground, and I try to make myself small by crouching, thinking it'll cut down on wind resistance.

By the power of cheap-ass video game logic, Nothgoran is unaffected by the swirls of air Raika's stirring and takes my hunkered stance as an invitation to attack. CRACK! The blade of his axe, meets the resistance of my shield. I almost fall back, but manage to keep my footing. I'm not leaving my position.

Raika's winds reach peak velocity, but I'm still standing. Laurelade sends alternating blasts of arcane and frost magic, while Frobod shoots beams of necromancer death magic from afar. A debuff appears above the boss's head, but I don't have time to view it because she's about to unleash another lightning blast.

It dances between my sword, body and shield before taking Nothgoran down another big percent. He roars in anger, but that's okay because he's almost dead. I block another blow with my shield, and then look up to see Tako clinging to Raika's neck with one arm and sticking her with his dagger repeatedly with the

other. Her health's lower than I'd expected, nearing twenty percent. She lands, and I push the offensive with Exsanguinator tearing into her snout.

She claws, and attempts to bite with those powerful jaws, but Frobod's not having it as he slams his greatsword into her neck forcing Raika to snap her jaw shut before reaching me.

My attack enables Nothgoran a clean hit, and I take damage.

"Almost there!" Tako calls as I see him trying to inch his way up her neck, dagger between his teeth, like a pirate, or a kid climbing a coconut tree.

Raika's skin briefly frosts over as Laurelade hits her with another magic attack. Ten percent left. Nothgoran swings, and Mirae's heals land just before my health would have fallen into the danger zone, but instead the blow and heal balance each other out.

Six percent, as Frobod connects another cleave. Five percent when Laurelade blasts with her new wand. So close, I contribute some damage with another blow to Raika's face when she comes in for a bite.

Three percent.

Suddenly Raika howls in pain, as Tako's dagger pierces her eye. He jumps down clinching the handle, causing it to twist in the wound before pulling loose all together. Raika, zero percent.

Tako says, "Nothgoran... Go go go go!"

Everyone unleashes on the dragon knight. Laurelade freezes him in an ice block, Tako stabs from behind, and Exsanguinator takes its due. He's about to hit me with another chop, when Frobod comes in from the side, and separates the dragon knight's head from its body.

I catch my breath in silence. The fight is over. Mirae tops off my health.

Tako says, "Good job guys!" as he moves in to inspect the loot.

Tournament Invitation

Quest Item (Limited Edition)

Type: PvP and PvE

Description:

The bearer of this invitation is invited to participate in The Contest of Champions hosted by Lord Zarentu at his castle north of Dragonswood. Impress him with your jousting, and combat prowess, and gain an ally in your fight against the planar dragon ripping a hole between worlds.

Rewards: Variable

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes, because not accepting a LE quest is plain stupid. I ask, "Did any of you just get a quest?"

"Yeah..." Mirae says.

"I think we all did." Frobod says.

I say, "I wonder if everyone in the guild got it, or if it's just us."

Laurelade says, "We are everyone in the guild."

"Except that one girl." Tako says.

Laurelade says, "Whatever."

I ask, "Ye want to go to Dragonswood, or stay here farming whelps?"

"I dunno." Tako says. "Let's go back to town, sell our stuff, and think about it."

I say, "Sounds good." Followed by, "What else did they drop?"

Tako goes through the drops, but they are, for the most part, items that no one has a use for due to them either not matching our play style, or not being any better than what we've already got. It kinda sucks, because final bosses usually have the best gear. We all roll our d10s to see who gets to sell them in town. There is one item, however, that intrigues me.

Lightning's Bite

Type:

Staff

Quality:

Epic

Base Damage:

Strength+2 (Bashing)

Equipped Bonus:

Dexterity + 3, Stamina + 4

Special Properties:

+4 lightning damage (ignores armor). Deals 1 lightning damage to all other hostile characters, within 5 feet of the target, and taunts them.

I say, "Let me see that." and examine the stave, a long shaft of black metal with jagged silver tips at either end that crackle with electricity. It's the kind of thing I could see Marine using, if she didn't have enchanted war fans. "I want this."

"Nice tank staff, but not that great if you're in plate since it adds dexterity."

"I can use this." I say with conviction. "One of my other characters was a martial artist that relied on dexterity Freeworld side. Now that stats are combined, I can make my new Alias Melpomine a kick ass evasive tank."

"Nooooo!" says Tako. "We need our dwarven meat shield!"

"Relax, it's not like I'm deleting Scooti. She'll still be available for public events." Come to think of it, I'm not even sure if it's possible to delete an alias.

"I'm just fucking with ya." Tako says.

Laurelade says, "Do you actually have the Martial Arts skill, or did you just level up unarmed fighting and a bunch of weapons."

"I actually have the skill."

For the first time since joining the guild, Laurelade eyes me with a measure of respect. Martial Arts is hard to come by in Haven requiring characters to train in remote monasteries. In Freeworld the skill is slightly more common. Although the skill comes at a cost of one and a half times the experience to advance over normal combat skills, it also provides a number of benefits including increased mobility, extra attacks, and special maneuvers that can only be performed by people who have advanced the skill.

Laurelade says, "Give it to her. It's not like any of us can use it, and she's the tank." For once, I appreciate her comments.

Tako says, "It's not like any of us were fighting you for it. What's your dex and stam at now anyway?"

I say, "24 dexterity and 21 stamina."

Tako takes a deep breath and strolls over to the balcony, looking over the mountain terrain. "Woooooooo..." he says pointing off into the distance. "I think I see a waterfall, and what's that? Is that a god damn?" He pauses. We all look at him. "Get it? God damn." Mirae laughs, a loud sound I haven't heard her make since the last one of Tako's jokes at the Smiling Otter. *What's with her and his jokes?* Tako looks at all of us staring and says "Well, I thought it was funny." Grins at Mirae and says "Thanks," before walking over, to bump fists.

Frobod says, "You're wasted in plate. With that kind of dex, you should be in cloth or leather. Nothing will hit you, and if it does you can just shake off the damage with all that stamina."

"I agree." Laurelade says, "Congrats on your new toy."

"Try it on!" Tako says.

Mirae says, "Yeah. I wanna see it."

I pull out my VT, open the alias menu, and select Melpomine from the drop down list.

Chapter 8 - Hotfix

I don't want to hold everyone up so I ride back with Lightning's Bite strapped to the back of my half-elf Alias's back. It clashes with her starting gear. The linen's coarse but I welcome the change from plate. That shit is heavy and hot after fighting dragons. It also smells like a fireplace after being doused in flame, and scorched with electricity. I'll have to take it to a repair shop, or see if Frobod can fix it.

As for my weapon, I'm on cloud nine. I've never played a speed based tank, and my new staff has given me the stats I need to explore a whole new play style. Just as I've come to think of Exsanguinator in terms of being a proper noun, rather than just "my sword," I've already started thinking of Lightning's Bite as just "Bite," to give it more personality. It's sunset now in the game world, but part of me wishes it was night because I think the molten gleam of my Elechopper, paired with the streamers of electric blue crackling off either end of my staff will look fierce once the sun is gone.

We're riding bikes back to town since Frobod will have a while before his new dragon's large enough for mount training, and in spite of the youth of our current guild composition, I riding the Elechoppers feels like a new tradition that could become part of our guild identity. I look forward to finding out about how new Elechoppers are obtained, and working towards farming them for all our members.

I'm about to say something to Mirae when I realize she's not beside me. She and Tako lag behind having their own conversation in a private chat. That leaves me, Frobod and Laurelade. I take the opportunity to get to know my newest recruits.

I say, "You're a pretty nice guy for a death knight."

"Hey," he says, "It's a game. If I were an rper you wouldn't like me, but as it is, I just pick magic and items that look cool." He pauses a sec, and says. "What happened to your accent?"

I say, "I just use the Scottish filter when I'm using the Scootiwutams alias. I think it compliments her character."

He asks, "Ahh, so you're not really Scottish?"

"Not at all. I'm from Seattle, born and raised."

"Hope you don't mind my lack of role playing then."

"From a self proclaimed death knight, I'm actually glad. But really, I haven't been seriously into the RP thing in years. Then I started running dungeons and raiding."

"In Freeworld?" Frobod asks.

"Mostly, but the Scooti alias was all Haven."

Laurelade says, "I'm not into Soc stuff. I'm just here for the excitement and adventure."

"I can go either way. Sometimes I'd rather just chill in a bar...or in this Haven's case tavern or inn with people I like, than actually going out in the real world."

"I hear ya." Frobod says. "It's too bad all the food tastes like water."

"Why is that?" Laurelade says.

I say, "From a developer's perspective, I can tell you it's definitely possible to bring taste to this game, but the technology's patented by a company called Data-Bite and I don't think they want to shell out the cash to buy the rights for implementation."

"That makes sense." Laurelade says.

"Still sucks..." Frobod says.

I shrug as if to say "What ya gonna do?" and then say, "So what do you think of the guild so far?"

"I'm having fun." Frobod says.

Laurelade adds, "... but we're going to need a lot more people."

"Yeah I know. When I came back to haven I decided I wanted to build this thing back up for sentimental reasons."

Laurelade says, "Like what?" but I just shrug. I don't feel the same kind of connection with her that I do Mirae, so I don't want to share.

Instead, I say "I think Mirae's recruiting some people, once she has a chance to talk to them, and we'll always need more people."

"Shouldn't be hard." Frobod says, "LE Guild and all."

"Yeah, I just don't want a bunch of buttholes. Ages ago, this guild used to be like family."

We can see the walls of Athelon approaching when a red exclamation mark appears at the bottom of my interface. I mentally tap it and see the following message.

Hotfix Installing—96%

This must be a big fix if it's large enough to show a status bar. With modern connection speeds, any changes to previously downloaded content usually push through in an instant.

"Did you guys see the hotfix?" I ask.

Laurelade says, "Yeah..." Her voice trailing.

Frobod says, "Mine just finished installing. What is it?"

I say, truthfully, "I have no idea. Usually these things are applied if they find a bug in the patch we just downloaded, but they don't usually take this long to install."

Laurelade says, "I haven't seen any bugs."

"That's kind of the point." I say, "They want to fix them while the game's running before anyone spots them."

We come to ground just outside the south gate, a minute later Tako and Mirae follow. She's all smiles and laughter, and Tako has a smug grin painted all over his boyish face. I'm glad she's happy.

Frobod says, "Did you guys see the hotfix?"

Tako says, "Yeah, it just downloaded."

Mirae adds, "It was a big patch. Biggest update ever. There were bound to be a few problems."

"Yeah..." I say. "I guess your right," but something about the situation doesn't sit right with me. Hotfixes are usually applied so fast that no one even notices. The fact that everyone in our group caught the progress bar, tells me that something is definitely out of the ordinary.

Simply put, an update of this size shouldn't be applied while we're all signed in. The application of so much content is enough to warrant a separate offline patch in of itself. Haven Online and Freeworld like announcing them ahead of time to generate a buzz about the future of the game. Meanwhile, I'm clueless as to what this may be.

"Everything okay?" Mirae asks.

"Yeah, just... Thinking." I say, "You know I'm a designer, but I didn't hear anything about another major update at work. Especially so soon after the merge. It doesn't feel right."

"I dunno." Frobod says.

I nod, nothing I can do about it one way or another. "Alright so... Good first run. I'm glad to have you."

Tako asks, "Does this mean we passed our tests?"

I look at everyone, my eyes linger on Laurelade a touch longer than the rest. "I'm not kicking anyone." Tako cheers, and does a fist pump, as if there'd been any question. "Go sell your loot, and meet up at the Smiling Otter if you want to run something else, or check out Dragonswood later."

"I think I'm done." Frobod says, "I haven't eaten, but I might come back in like four or five hours if you're still here."

"I should be." I say, remembering the Chicago style pizza after work. "I took vacation days for this, so I'm planning to make this a marathon."

"Hard core." Tako says, "But I like that in a leader."

Mirae says, "You know I'll be around, but I want to go talk to my friends first." She pauses. "Before going anywhere else."

"Play it by ear then. I've gotta get my new gear sorted anyway. If any of you come across some tanky cloth or leather items for.... monks?" I look to everyone looking for confirmation. I've forgotten what Haven calls its formally trained martial artists. Frobod and Tako nod. "Monks. Let me know. All the gear from my other characters are going to be melee dps, or caster oriented."

"Will do boss." Tako says.

"Bye." Laurelade says, and walks off.

"A bit abrupt," I think as I watch her go. Frobod, Tako, and Mirae drift off their separate directions, but not before I see Mirae give Tako a hug before going. *Oh dear.* In guild romances can either bring people closer together, or cause a crap ton of drama.

I say, "Hey Mirae!" as she walks off, and jog to catch up. She stops and looks back. "I'm promoting you to officer within the guild so you can invite your friends without my approval." I clap her on the shoulder hoping the gesture conveys the fondness I feel for her crawling around in my chest. Of all our current members, knowing about her real world situation, she strikes the closest to how I remember Jordan describing the Toxic Muffins. Not just avatars within a game, but real people with real shit to deal with on a planet called Earth. "I trust your judgment, and again, I'm glad to have you."

Mirae looks down at her feet, a small smile creeps across her face. "I'm glad I met you too." She hops and bubbles "See ya around!" She sticks two fingers in her mouth and unleashes a shrill whistle. A pulse of white and lilac flashes in the way of summoned creatures. I hear a whinny, and she hops on the back of a white winged horse, with purple-grey wings—her pegasus. It's the first time I've seen it, and I admire the mount as a beautiful animal. It beats its powerful wings, moving air and lifting my guild mate off the ground. I open the guild interface on my VT.

Do you want to promote Mirae to the rank of Officer?

Yes / No

I tap yes. The girl flies off to see her friends.

After selling all the dragons fangs from the whelp drops, and the few common items with no bonus stats in the local market, I head back to The Smiling Otter with my virtual coin purse feeling a bit heavier. The inn keeper is a jolly pumpkin bellied man sporting a bushy salt and pepper walrus moustache, and a smart vest that doesn't quite cover the bottom of his stomach.

Jardis	
Type:	NPC
Race:	Human
Appearance:	2
Status:	Friendly

"Welcome back Melpomine!" NPCs always seem to know your name in cities where you have reputation, even if you haven't met them in person. In the case of the Smiling Otter and Jardis, I'd only interacted with the barmaids until now.

"Thanks, Jardis." I make a point of using his name, so as not to forget it. Named NPCs are usually important. "I'd like a room for the night, and a pitcher of ice cold water." The room isn't necessary, but I'd like some privacy while I go through all my stuff. You never know if someone might recognize your gear on a different alias, while trying to be secret.

"No stew for you my Lord? I promise, it's the best you'll find in Athelon." The food smells delicious as ever, and I'm tempted to try, but then remember the empty flavor I experienced before. I'm also startled by use of Scootiwutam's title in Melpomine's skin, but then remember that all of Scooti's reputation transferred to this identity.

"Not this time. I'm just feeling incredibly thirsty."

"Oh, alright then. I'll show you to your room n' get you set up right away. Just this way."

He fishes a massive ring covered in what seems like 50 brass keys, from a locked cupboard. He motions for me to follow, leads me up a narrow staircase, and down a hallway filled with red doors. A small iron lantern hangs at the top right corner of each one of them.

I expect that to be the end of it, when he asks "So what have you been doing all day?"

"I... errr..." The conversation comes as a shock, because Havenfolk aren't prone to ask about our lives. I'm so surprised that I say "Hunting dragons. We have a guild quest requiring us to practice hunting, and investigate the Rip of Worlds."

"Rip of Worlds you say?" Jarvis Ponders, "I haven't heard it called that before. I like it." In truth it was a babbling mistake on my part. I'd meant to say 'rip between worlds.' "Mind if I borrow it?"

"Sure... I say. Use it all you want."

What's with this innkeeper? Usually Havenfolk only talk about their business. In this case buying food, renting rooms. *Small talk? When did they become so... human?*

"Thank you Lord Melpomine. Here's your room." This is the point where he's supposed to retreat down the hallway, and assure me that my water will be delivered soon. Instead he adds, "May I ask a small favor?"

"I...uh... Sure..." I say, expecting a quest.

"Do remember us if you become the Dragonsbane. It would bring my staff great pride knowing they contributed to a hero's journey."

"Err... ahh.. OK." No quest prompt. Just, chit chat with a hint of the idol worship you'd expect from a person who'd just met a celebrity.

"Your water will be right up. I'll even throw in some stew, free of charge."

"Thank you..." I say, stepping into the room and closing the door behind me. It's nothing special, just a four post bed, a locking trunk, and a small vanity. The linens smell clean, and I can tell that Jardis is the kind of guy who takes pride in his work.

There's a knock on the door.

"Uh yes?" I drop my magical travelers backpack on the bed, and answer the door, on the other side I see the same barmaid who brought my food before our trip to the Windroost.

Mia

Type:	NPC
Race:	Human
Appearance:	5
Status:	Friendly

Was she a named NPC before? I can't remember. Usually only important characters are named by the system, otherwise they get titles like "Athelon Guard #2."

Mia enters, and sets the tray down on the vanity. Sure enough, there's a sweating pitcher of ice water, a bowl of stew.... honey, and a spot of tea. She says, "I remember you like tea, so I brought some with your dinner m'lord. I hope that's alright."

I stammer, "Ahh.. No... No problem. That's wonderful thank you."

"Always a pleasure to be of service."

"I.. ahh.. Mia... Can I ask you something?"

"I'm happy to help, if I'm at all able."

"How do you recognize me? The last time I was in here, I looked like a Dwarf named Scootiwutams."

"You changed your costume just outside our shop. Lord Melpomine. Now we all know of your status."

Thanks, I say, wondering. I say, "Do you feel different from before?"

"Different how, Lord Melpomine?"

"You can just drop the Lord part... Call me Mel"

"Okay, Mel... Different how?"

"I don't know" I say. "More awake, more aware of your surroundings."

Mia says, "I feel the same as I can ever remember feeling."

I say, "I see...thanks." That isn't helpful. Everything inside says the behavior of these NPCs, or...Havenfolk, as I should call them, is a result of that hotfix, but if Mia's only been.... what? Aware? Intelligent? I don't know what to call it, for less than an hour "I feel the same as I can ever remember feeling" might not be for very long.

I say, "I appreciate the tea." She curtseys, and I show her the way out. At the sound of the door closing I shake my head. *Strange.*

I begin going through my gear. The set I finally settle on is a blend of both Stabbies and Marine's items. I tried to give myself as much freedom of movement, and stamina as possible. I also go through my spells for each, to see what I have that might help endurance.

Thunder Bridge

Cost:

3000 manna + 1000 manna for each additional traveler up to a number equal to half your intellect.

Effect: Ride the lightning to a place you'd like to go.

My alias, MarineLu, is a wind and storm themed magical martial artist, who used her martial arts in the form of katas, and strikes to channel her magic. She can use spells from other elements, but has an affinity for workings that deal with air. Thunder Bridge, while not defensive, is a beautiful means of fast travel. Before the update, it could take you anywhere you wanted to go, so long as you remembered going there once. The only drawback is that it tends to leave your manna drained upon arrival, and could cause damage to structures if used inside buildings. Part of me wonders if it can take me back to Freeworld for a visit, and I add it to my list of things to try.

Flow Like Water (Rank 2)

Cost: 2000 Manna

Effect:

Your body takes on the fluid qualities of water causing it to flow out of the path of incoming attacks. Lasts 30 minutes, or until the loss of 10 levels of health have been negated. Negates physical damage only.

Previously, I'd only used that one in PvP where a tank's taunts were useless since they didn't have any effect on players. As an evasion tank however, Flow Like water effectively gives me ten extra health levels that can't be restored short of re-casting.

I'd really like to have an arcane shield like the haven Mages are famous for using, but alas I never played an arcane caster in Haven Online. It might be something worth exploring. Aside from Flow Like Water, which I most certainly intend to level up, the only other spells I have from Marine that'll help with surviving damage are a heal over time spell, and something that turns your skin to stone at the cost of half your dexterity. Not the best choice when you plan on dodging and beating up mobs with your sparky electric taunt stick. When playing a dex tank, not getting hit is the name of the game.

I page through Jordan's abilities on Stabbies to see if I find anything interesting. He's got something called "Shadow Step" which allows you to teleport into the shadow of an object or other person's shadow within line of sight, and "Shadow Retreat" which yanks you out of combat, and allows you to become a two dimensional shadow, immune to all but fire and holy damage for up to 30 seconds. It causes you to drop all agro, and take double damage from fire and holy magic.

It's what I call an "Oh shit button," for when the healer's out of manna and I'm on my last sliver of health. It might buy me enough time to get away, and resurrect someone else after the battle finishes.

The gear I settle on is a blend of the items Marine, and Stabbies had equipped, mostly Stabbies, since I'm not planning to use as much magic as I did when I played Marine. Gear settled, I sit at the vanity and pour myself a cup of tea. It tastes of nothing.

My thoughts drift to the guild, and how best to build it. Pretty soon I need to go check out the guild hall in... I check the guild interface... Durolan, *So that explains why he signed out from there*. The Toxic Muffins guild hall could be a lot of nothing or everything. I'm not ready to deal with that yet.

Frobod sends a message.

Frobod: What's going on?

Melpomine: I'm at the Smiling Otter going through my gear. Why?

Frobod: No, what's going on? I can't log out. You're a dev right?

Melpomine: What do you mean you can't log out?

Frobod: Try it.

I pull up the main page of the user interface on my VT, and select "Log Out," or rather I intend to, but the button is grayed out. *What the fuck*. My view of my room disappears into black like I'm closing my eyes, and then re-appears as I reload my UI. I pull out my VT, open the main page, and move to hit the log out button. It's still grey and unclickable. *Oh shit... It's been disabled*.

Frobod: Hello?

Melpomine: I'm here. I was just reloading my user interface. It's not working.

Frobod: I already tried that.

I'm trying to sound calmer than I actually feel when I send my next reply. I've been on edge since the wacky hotfix.

Melpomine: We've got to contact someone for support.

Frobod: I tried that too, it's disabled.

What the actual fuck? It's not that I doubt Frobod, but seeing is believing. I open up the customer support menu. My flesh goes cold when I see what's waiting for me—a whole lot of nothing. Like the log out option, the ability to contact customer service has been disabled. A long time passes between Frobod's last message, and my reply. He's got to be just as scared as I feel. *We can't go home. We've been cut from the real world.* My virtual hands shake as I send my next reply.

Melpomine: This is bad.

Frobod: No kidding.

Melpomine: I mean, like really bad. If they don't fix this quick, there's going to be a panic.

Frobod: I'm already panicking.

Melpomine: Let's hope like hell they get a patch out to correct this.

I take a deep breath. They've got to fix it. The best thing to do is try to enjoy the game while their working. Deep breaths. Calm. Make use of that meditation skill. There's no reason to be suspicious of the hotfix. I close my eyes, and feel virtual air fill my virtual chest. It feels too real. Breathe in, breathe out. My panic subsides. I've never heard of an issue like this, but hotfixes exist for a reason.

Melpomine: I guess no dinner for you then. I've got some stew at the Smiling Otter if you want some.

Frobod: Thanks.

I get the feeling his mind's elsewhere. I don't blame him.

Melpomine: We can't do anything till it's fixed, so we might as well do something until it's done. Let's meet up and make plans. We can spar, recruit or anything.

Frobod: Yeah. I know. I'm coming.

Melpomine: Meet you down stairs.

I go into the guild interface, where Jordan's old warnings about R-Twined being a PvP dick were once held, create a new notice and hit send.

"Meeting back at the Smiling Otter. Weird stuff's happening. Anyone can come."

The message super imposes itself on the vision of all guild members in harsh red letters. I send a follow up.

"Not mandatory. So far, just me and Frobod."

I head downstairs clad head to toe in Stabbies's black leather Swiftstrike set, with some of Marine's Freeworld accessories. I like the fact that the chest piece is a vest, leaving my arms free and mobile. I feel so unfettered compared to being encased in full plate.

I walk through the common room thinking that everything seems sharper. Is it my imagination, or do all the NPCs come off as more lifelike? Are they like Sal? What would Freehaven be like, if all the Havenfolk were like real people?

I search the patrons for my guild mate.

Spotting.

Perception + Vigilance. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 7)

"Oh, there he is!"

I see Frobod's massive silhouette in the doorway and motion him to my far corner. I intentionally pick the same table as before, because I'm a creature of habit. If I'm being honest it's because this virtual location now has sentimental value.

Frobod says, "Hey." as he takes a seat across from me. The bench creaks in protest under the weight of his body and gear.

"Hey." I say.

He says, "I thought you said you had stew."

I say, "It's in my room. I can get it if you want. Didn't think you actually wanted it."

"It's fine." He says. "I'm just talking."

"Don't look so glum" I say, "They ought to have this sorted out within a few hours."

He says. "It's just that... It's my little girl's birthday. She's with her mom, but I was supposed to be there. Now I'll be late, if I can get there at all."

"Oh man... Dude, I'm sorry. You got a family then?"

"Divorced, but we get along well enough for exes. I'll never hear the end of it, though, if I miss that party. Especially if she finds out I was playing a game. You only get so many birthday parties at this age."

"How old is she? Your daughter, I mean."

"Just turned eight." His chest puffs out a bit, giving me the impression he's a proud father.

I say, "If you don't mind me asking, how old are you?"

"Ancient." He says.

"No, really."

"Older than Jesus." He says. I give him a flat look, and he follows "Thirty-two."

"That's not old. Come on, that's nothing." I say, "I've heard of fifty year olds playing this game." I'm thinking of the mother with the high school kids that Jordan used to talk about.

He says, "Why? How old are you?"

"Don't you know it's rude to ask?"

"You asked me" he says.

"You have a penis." I counter.

He responds, "I'm a feminist."

I snap my fingers loudly as if to say he scored a point, and grudgingly respond, "About the same."

"Be more specific?" He asks.

I say, "Compromise." and leave it at that.

Frobod, takes the hint, and changes the subject. "So what do you want to do?"

"Now that I've got my gear picked out, I kinda want to head over to Dragonswood and see what's up with that contest. I'm not your girl for a joust, I was flat on my ass after one hit from a baby dragon, but I can hold my own in single combat." I catch Frobod checking his VT for the logout button, and he doesn't say anything, but his face tells the story. We're stuck here together. "It'll be alright. I'm sure it'll be fixed soon, but even if it's not they'll understand."

"You don't know my ex-wife" Frobod says.

"How many thousand people do you think are logged in tonight. The Athelon market was crawling, and this is just one city."

"So what?" Frobod asks.

"If thousands of people around the world suddenly can't log out of their VR game, it's gonna be national news. Your local newscaster will guarantee she takes it more seriously than some bullshit you made up to run another dungeon."

He sighs. "Yeah, I guess. I just really wanted to be there."

"I hear you." I say, "Just give it a few hours and it'll work itself out."

He says, "I hope your right." and hangs his head resigned to missing the party.

"I'll keep you company."

Metew has joined the guild.

MagicPewPew has joined the guild.

Ragnar has joined the guild.

PureMagic has joined the guild.

AerisLovely has joined the guild.

Fami has joined the guild.

Psamanth has joined the guild.

WookiByeBye has joined the guild.

Pehrom has joined the guild.

Pohrum has joined the guild.

Pahrem has joined the guild.

The list of people goes on in my alerts, until our list of guild adventurers increases to a total of thirty-seven.

"What just happened?" Frobod says. I smile.

"Mirae." is my reply. "I made her an officer so she could recruit her friends. It looks like she's got quite a lot of them."

"Well go her. That gnome girl can't complain about being small now."

I smirk and say, "Well played."

"Ahh..." he said, "I didn't mean it that way."

"Pretend you did. Well played. Give me a sec."

I check my VT, first for the logout button, which is still disabled, and then for any information on our new guild members. There's a nice spread of fantasy races ranging from humans, to elves, couple of dwarves, and even a trio of half-goblins. Every single one of them has the plus sign next to their name. I wonder about the real world conditions that give them the incapacitated distinction.

Mirae: Pretty much all the non-social characters in my old guild agreed to come over. Most of em' are stoked about the LE quest and loot.

Melpomine: Did they get the tournament quest?

Mirae: I dunno, let me ask.

A minute passes, while I assume Mirae's talking to her old crew... my new crew now... about the tournament quest north of Dragonswood.

Mirae: They didn't get it.

Melpomine: Maybe they have to beat Raika first.

Mirae: Maybe, I dunno.

Melpomine: I'm still at the Smiling Otter with Frobod if you want to join, but if you're bringing 30+ people with you, we're gonna need a bigger table.

Mirae: It's okay. I'm meeting Tako next. We can meet up later.

Melpomine: I guess you don't want to join? We're talking about the whole logout thing.

Mirae: What log out thing?

Melpomine: Try it and see for yourself.

There's a bit of delay between my message and Mirae's next.

Mirae: Oh, weird.

That's not the response I expected.

Melpomine: You're not worried?

Mirae: Not really. I wasn't planning to sign out anytime soon.

Mirae's lack of concern twists my mind with perspective. Maybe there won't be thousands of panicking players rioting through the streets of Athelon. *How many players have even noticed?*

Melpomine: We can talk soon.

"I wonder what Laurel and Tako are doing." I say.
Frobod says, "No idea."

Chapter 9 - Cupcake Keep

A half hour passes between idle chatter that Frobod's only half into, and the death knight continually checking his VT like a cell phone to see if there are any changes. No such luck, I gave up checking the log out button 20 minutes ago. For the time being, we're stuck in Haven.

I stretch my arms, stand up and look around the common room in search of Mirae, Tako, or Laurelade, but none have paid us a visit. I haven't gotten any messages from either so my bet is that they haven't tried logging. As Frobod checks the log out function for the third time in the last two minutes I stand and say "Let's go. I don't think anyone's coming."

"Go where?" He asks.

"There's something I've been putting off for a while. You can come too. It's guild related."

"Oh. Like what?"

"Headquarters." I say. "They're in Durolan."

"That's far, you want to take a portal?"

"Maybe..." I say, thinking of Thunder Bridge, "But there's a Freeworld spell I want to try first. I want to see if it works in Haven." He looks down at his VT like a schoolboy mooning over his new crush, but knowing the reality of his situation makes it sad rather than funny. "I know it's hard, but I promise you can sign out as soon as we can log out again. I'll even program a macro to alert me as soon as it becomes enabled."

"You can do that?" Frobod says.

"Of course. This game's customizable if you know what you're doing. I'll even set it to announce to the guild when the log out button reappears. Give me a second to write the code in my VT."

About two minutes later, I've moved a copy of the log out button to the bottom corner of my vision. It's grey and transparent now like it is in the main menu, but as soon as the function becomes available again, it'll light up red with gold letters. I've also programmed it to send "Rejoice! You can log out now!" as a guild alert as soon as the button's status changes.

"Done." I say. "As soon as something changes, we're the first to know."

"Thanks." He says, his voice filling with emotion. "I'm just worried. It's not just about the birthday now. Part of me wonders 'What if we never get back?'"

I've had the same thoughts, but he seems more fragile than I am so I put on my devil-may-care face and say, "It's only been an hour. You'll get back to your girl."

Little White Lies.

Manipulation + Subterfuge. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 4)

"Trust me."

Subterfuge skill increased by 1. Current level: 3

Well that's unexpected. If I'm awarded skill points for my half truth, I guess I believe in my pep talk less than I'd like to admit.

"In the mean time," I say taking his hand as I stand from the table. "Have you ever seen a Thunder Bridge?"

Frobod asks, "Isn't that like a Freeworld portal?" as he stands with me.

"It is, but so much cooler!"

He asks, "Did you design it?"

I say, "I wish I could take credit, but no. I just get points for learning it in game."

"Alright," he says. "Let's go." I can't help but notice that he holds on to my fingers a bit longer than strictly necessary for exiting the booth. I look back at him, meeting his brown eyes with my green ones. He lets go of my hand and says, "Thanks, for keeping me company. My anxiety would be through the roof if you weren't here."

I think about the way he's been nervously checking his VT and tapping his foot since he arrived. *I thought his anxiety was through the roof already.* He'd seemed level headed before this log out mess, but now that his family's involved I can see how things got real for him.

I never had kids. Not sure I want them; communicate electronically with family. If I were to die in my apartment, weeks could pass before anyone found my corpse. *That's a special thought.*

I say, "Hey, that's what guilds are for. Right?"

"Not all guilds." He says.

"Yeah well, that's what I want for this one. So lets get outside, so you can help me test my spell. I help you and you help me. That's how Toxic Muffins roll."

I don't know where that came from, but I want to make him laugh. I don't want to see him pining away over something he has no control over. My antics seem to work, because a small smirk crosses his lips, as he says "Lead the way."

I equip Bite, and hunt around for a clear area. The last thing I want is for someone to walk into the path of my staff, or accidentally set a thatched roof on fire. It's evening now so a combination of mundane and magic lanterns keep the streets bright. It's not like a city ever was in the real world, with people signing in across the globe there's always people out and about. Eventually we come to the park district with some trees, rabbits, a gravel path and a reflecting pool.

"You ready?" I ask. A full moon shines overhead. It's a cloudless night.

"Yeah," he says. "Where do you need me?"

I hadn't thought of that. Marine's Freeworld weapons were magic war fans that produced a variety of effects, but now armed with a staff, the movements will be a bit different.

"Uhm..." I say, "Stand close behind me, but not too close. I've never done this with a stave."

I begin spinning Lightning's Bite in front of me, passing it effortlessly from one hand to the other. I marvel at how pretty the motion streaks from the blue arcs of electricity at either end of my weapon look as I spin the staff faster and faster. A pattern forms like giant wheels rolling around me. I open myself to my manna, my pool is miniscule compared to that which I'd have using Marine's gear,

but my high intelligence and decent charisma provide me with enough for what I'm doing.

I channel the energy, inviting the cool Yin ether to course through my body. My staff and hands are a blur of motion, as a translucent dome of purple light appears and begins to expand around me. Leaves blow in the trees. Park rabbits hop opposite directions.

"Stand in the dome" I say, "It won't hurt you." My voice is monotone and robotic. I should have told him before hand, because talking shakes my focus making it harder to cast.

My staff is a whirlwind, unseen and deadly. Both it and my hands are a blur. A massive snake of electricity twists over the outside surface of my magic dome that's taller than I am. The small hairs on my arms and the back of my neck rise, the hair on my head wants to do the same. I hear Frobo make a noise like a shiver. I can feel the magic energy welling up and up, coursing through my body, sparks dare to spit from my mouth and eyes. I imagine the mailbox outside the Durolan bank. The image burns crisp in my mind.

I'm about to explode, when I bring Bite to a halt and slam its butt into the earth. I imagine stabbing the cobblestones in front of the Durolan bank. Thunder cracks. A bolt of thick lightning stabs from the heavens to my staff, into me, then to Frobo. The world goes white, and returns to our vision with spots, that fade in the way of those incurred by staring at the sun.

Time slows, as Frobo and I are suddenly in the sky, looking down as if from an airplane. He's holding my left hand, dragged behind, while my right's held high over head clinching my weapon. The tip of Bite shines like a blue comet pulling us onward along what seems to be an endless road of electricity. My hair lashes every which direction. I scream my excitement, as I fall in love with the cold air beating my face.

Thunder crashes again, as our vision again goes white, and we are deposited roughly in front of the Durolan bank. The spots from staring into a too bright light fade within seconds of our landing. I keep my feet, but Frobo takes a tumble. I laugh, having almost forgotten how fun it could be, like sky diving, an amusement park ride, and latching on to a tow rope all at the same time.

"Yeah!" I say, "That always puts me in a good mood!"

Rapid footsteps approach.

"Next time," Frobo says, "I think I'll take a portal. Costs some gold, but at least you don't feel like you're gonna puke at the other end."

Still grinning, I help him off his knees. "This only costs..." I check my manna. "All but 36 of my manna." I laugh. "I won't be doing that again for a few minutes, unless I get some manna regen going."

It's only then that I catch a glimpse of two members of the Durolan guard. With their saggy wizard's hats, violet leather armor, and black spears tipped with lambent magic crystals. They're a stark contrast to guards in other cities, which are typically outfitted in plate and longswords. I've never seen one in a fight, but I'd bet half my gear that these two are hybrid fighter-spell casters.

Dryslyn

Type:

NPC

Race:	Human
Appearance:	5
Status:	Neutral
Challenge:	????

Jenda	
Type:	NPC
Race:	Human
Appearance:	5
Status:	Neutral
Challenge:	????

Two named NPCs. *That's.... Surprising.*

"Are you okay Miss?" Dryslyn asks, in what sounds to me like a British accent.

"And you Sir." says Jenda, she's more Aussie.

"Yeah, we're fine." Frobod says, "At least, I think so."

"By the gods, I ain't seen nothin' like it. There we are minding our posts, sky clear as a dream when a bolt of lightning comes and strikes down the two of yas."

"Come on," I say, "This is the city of Mages. Lightning bolts, and untimely explosions must happen all the time."

Jenda says, "Not when there's no one around to cast em'. You two are lucky to be alive. I kid you not, not a soul has come down this road this last hour till' you two..." she trails.

"Come to think of it. " Dryslyn says, "Where did you come from? Don't remember seeing either of you passing either, but you must've since you're here."

I give Frobod a look, and mouth the words "Freeworld magic," and he nods. I'm impressed. Even though the spells exist in the game, the NPCs still act like Freeworld content is as mysterious as it would seem to a human having a brush with the unfamiliar.

"It's okay." I say, "It's a spell. Rode the lightning here from Athelon. It's called a Thunder Bridge."

Dryslyn and Jenda give each other knowing looks, and Jenda says, "Alien magics." A look of suspicion creeps onto both of their faces. "And you, Miss, are the caster?"

"I am. What's this about?"

Dryslyn regards Frobod and says, "You're free to go sir, I think our superior would like a word with the Miss."

Frobod says, "The hell with that. I'm staying with her. Has she broken the law?" My heart flutters to hear him defending me. It's nice to know I've left such an impression.

Dryslyn says, "No." in a tone that suggests that he sorely regrets it.

Jenda says, "Who ever heard of a half-elfy wielding alien magics?"

Dryslyn says, "Who ever heard of alien magic before the tear showed up?" he regards both of us and follows up his comment with, "Not so long, so they

haven't gotten around to outlawing em' yet. Still, I think the boss would like a word."

I can't wrap my mind around the palpable hostility in his voice. Jordan built guild headquarters in this city, I can't believe he had such low rep. I check my VT to confirm.

Melpomine -

Reputation Locale Durolan Province

Durolan: 0 / 1000 - Neutral

Durolan Watch: -25 / 1000 - Distrust

Negative twenty-five reputation! These guys don't mess around with foreign magic. That's a bunch of bull if I ever heard it. I look up to see what the guards are doing, just in time to see Jenda reaching out for my arm. I don't think before dodging out of the way, taking a step back, effortlessly evading her grasp. I pull up the alias's tab on my VT, as she says "This'll go a lot easier if you come easy."

I say, "Wait. I think I can clear all this up."

I tap Stabbies on the VT.

Warning! You are in plain sight of Dryslyn, Jenda, Frobod. Assuming this Alias in plain sight, will make them aware of this identity. Do you wish to proceed? Yes / No

I hit yes, before either of the guards can make another grab. My feminine half-elven features vanish in streamers of black light, the ambient shadows embracing me from all directions. A second later I'm staring down at the guards through Stabbies's aggravated visage.

The change in their behavior is instantly apparent. Jenda's eyes widen, horrified at the thought of trying to manhandle my brother's character, and Dryslyn bows deeply, nose pointed directly at the ground. A second later Jenda joins him.

I reactivate the Melpomine alias, and check my updated rep.

Melpomine -

Reputation Locale Durolan Province

Durolan: 46,423 / 50,000 - Exalted

Durolan Watch: 36,000/ 50,000 - Exalted

Frobod says, "Wait so... Are you a dude, or a chick?"

I give him a look as if to say "Really? You want to do this now?" and speak, "I already told you I'm a woman. Walking around in that avatar feels foreign." I sigh, realizing that this means I'll be letting him in on the guild's secret history, my history, with my brother, but it's alright, because I think part of me already resigned myself to that when I invited him. It's like Mirae said when I first opened up to her, I better get used to it if I want to connect with original Toxic

Muffins' members, and tell them what happened. "I'll explain everything when we get to HQ."

Jenda says, "Lord Stabbies ... or Melpomine... if that's the name you're using now. We apologize for any offense we've caused. It's been a long time since we've seen you."

Dryslyn says, "Is that where you've been? Off exploring other worlds, and learning strange magics? It's been a while since we've seen you."

"Once a year..." I mumble.

Dryslyn says, "What's that?"

I say, "Once a year." more confidently, I don't know whether I want to cry, or shout from a rooftop. "I've been back to Durolan once a year for the last six years."

Frobod gives me an odd look, but says nothing. I suddenly realize that I have no idea where my guild headquarters are located. Guards are usually good about directing adventurers to their trainers, banks, or specific merchants, but now it's time to see if the Toxic Muffins' reputation in Durolan is strong enough for Havenfolk to recognize our guild quarters.

"It's as you say." I continue, "Been traveling the planes, and my mind's all murky. I seem to be having trouble remembering how to get to the Toxic Muffins' guild hall."

"Toxic Muffins guild hall?" Dryslyn asks.

"The Lord means Cupcake Keep." Jenda says.

"Cupcake Keep? No one's been seen going in and out of that place in..." I raise my hand for him to stop. "Sorry. That's what we call it. Give me your map and I'll mark it for you."

I hand over the map that every adventurer receives upon making a character. It automatically populates new areas based on the geography you've explored. A red circle appears a moment later, denoting our destination. Dryslyn hands it back to me.

"There you go. If I may say, it's good to have you back Lord..." he fumbles with the name, this strikes me as odd because the Athelon guard had no problem adapting before the hotfix. "Melpomine. Hope to see more of you."

"Thank you." I say.

"About our superior." Jenda says, "He may well like to speak with you about your magics, but feel free to check in at your leisure. I'll tell him you've returned."

I say, "I will, thanks." not knowing if I'll do any such thing. "Have a good night."

"To you as well." Dryslyn says. "I'm glad you weren't hurt by that lightning."

"Thanks..."

Frobod and I walk down the street. Jenda and Dryslyn go back to their post.

I call out "INFERNO!!!" and wave my middle finger, the Elechopper appears in it's usual flash of light. "You want one? We've got a little ways to walk."

"Why not?" Frobod says. I summon the ether chopper for him, and we both straddle our bikes.

I say, "This is starting to feel like a tradition. It'd be cool to be Haven's first motorcycle gang."

Frobod asks, "How does the rest of the world get these?"

"I have no idea. I just design the object. A whole different department handles in-game stats, and determines how their obtained. All I know is that they're probably starting Freeworld side since Haven isn't so much about the technology, even if it's based on magic.

He shrugs, "You're probably right." As we take a ride down the bumpy night streets of the mage city.

We both look around, admiring the pristine architecture. Durolan is a city of many towers, and Havenfolk men and women alike wander around in brightly colored robes. There are no torches or gaslights here, as you'll find around Athelon. Instead street lamps shine with the uniform blue-white glow of mage lights bobbing around within frosted mason jars. They hang from silver hooks attached to stone buildings.

He says, "It's too bad that more people don't come here anymore. The design is nice."

I shrug and nod at the same time, agreeing with the sentiment, but conceding to the idea that gamers always want to move on to newer and better things. "I can tell you, a lot of hours went into a place like this, but we're always working on new content. Unless Durolan becomes a race's stronghold, there's no need for players to come back to the city unless they just like it."

He says, "Any news on the log out?" His voice less frantic than before. I suspect he's already missed the party.

"Not so far." I say, "You'll know as soon as I do."

"Damn." He says. "I hope it's fixed before morning."

"Me too."

He asks, "Have you ever tried sleeping here?"

I think back to my time playing both Freeworld and Haven. "I don't think I have. Whenever I feel tired, I just sign out."

"I wonder what happens when you fall asleep in game."

"Normally it signs you out if you stay asleep more than 30 minutes, but if logout's been disabled.... I don't know what will happen. If you just doze off, your character sleeps here just as you would in the real world."

"You mean we might be logged out if we pass out here?"

"I don't think so." I say. "The logout button tells the software to run a logout command, and it's the command that's been disabled. That's what I used to make the macro I told you about before."

Frobod asks, "What does that have to do with falling asleep?"

"When the game senses that you are asleep, it initiates the same logout command that the button uses, and my macro. I mean, you can try. I think we'll all be trying it if they don't get this patched soon, but falling asleep doesn't do anything in terms of pulling you out of the game that tapping the button doesn't."

He says, "I think I get it."

"It was a good thought." I say, and add "Who knows? Maybe we'll be surprised." I don't actually believe it, but with all the weirdness surrounding this hotfix, it seems like anything's possible.

Frobod changes the subject, "Did those guards seem...I don't know...chatty to you?"

"Yeah..." I say. "Jardis too. He's the innkeeper of The Smiling Otter. Even the barmaid Mia. They're all named NPCs now. Jardis took time to ask me how my day was going, and asked me to remember him if I become the Dragonsbane in our guild quest. It's like... he wants to collect heroes for his wall or something. You know how some restaurants in the real world have autographed pictures of famous people who went there? Same kind of thing."

Frobod says, "Strange. Usually they're all one liners unless it's a scripted event."

"I get that... They're starting to remind me of Sal."

"Whose Sal?"

"She's the AI I work with in game design. She's like a real person. I even talk to her over lunch. If she had a physical body, I doubt you could tell the difference between her and a human."

"There are a lot of smart computers out there... I wonder why they don't put them in the game." Part of me thinks that someone already has, but I keep quiet on that. Instead I say, "It'd take a lot more resources, and frankly, I don't think people want to spend hours slaying characters they can have an intelligent conversation with."

"There's PvP." Frobod says.

"Yeah well, that's different. We all come back when we die, and it's consensual. Both parties know what they're getting into. When you're raiding a dungeon, it's not like an army of dragon whelps declared war on us. We just go in, kill everything and go. Easy peasy."

"Mobs respawn." Frobod says.

"Yeah, I guess you're right. It just feels different. I might have second thoughts about swinging a sword knowing there was a thinking feeling being at the other end of it. To us damage is nothing, but what if it hurts them? They certainly make convincing death cries."

"I guess I see your point. I guess I'm glad that they aren't intelligent beings."

We're right on top of the red dot on my map when I pull my bike over. Frobod follows.

"Holy shit." I say.

"What?" Frobod says.

I point to the gate. Frobod's eyes go to a stone wall and follows along its surface until he gets to a massive iron and oak door, with the symbol that looks like a giant cupcake charred into the wood.

I say, "I think it's supposed to be a muffin."

Frobod responds "... but I can see why they call it cupcake keep. Haven't you ever been here?"

I shake my head no, "It's my first time."

Frobod says, "This place looks huge."

I say, "I guess you really can buy a castle for the cost of a Limited Edition item."

"Yeah, I guess." Frobod says, "You'd know more than me."

"It's just something someone told me a few days ago." *Has it really only been two days? Not even two if we're not past midnight.* Elondriel and LadyPoints's words feel like they were spoken weeks ago.

"Any ideas on how to get in?" Frobod asks.

"I think... It'll recognize me. I'm the leader after all."

I make the bloop bloop sounds, dismissing the Elechoppers, and approach the door. I lay my palm against the hard wood, and for a moment nothing happens. Then a light shines beneath my fingers like cupping my hand over a flash light, and with a tired groan the gate swings open."

Frobod and I are both ready to cast a light spell, as we pass through the entrance, but as we do artificial light shines down not only from the blocky stone castle before us, but also from dozens of mage light lanterns throughout the courtyard. To one side there's an overgrown garden with red roses, and vibrant yellow, pink, and blue blossoms I don't have names for growing wild throughout the property. There are vines threatening to scale the courtyard wall and invade our neighbor's land. The landscaping is a surprising touch knowing what I do about my brother's play style. On the other side, I see wood and straw target dummies, archery targets, and even a nice large arena extending along the right side of the keep to practice riding. ... *or jousting.* A draw bridge yawns it's great mouth, leading over a moat to the main structure, with two windowed watch towers that give the impression of froglike eyes.

"Good God." I say, "It's like a starter town."

I've never bought in-game real estate, and I've got to wonder if the castle came like this, or if Jordan spent meticulous hours setting everything up. For all I know, it was a guild effort, with faceless people working every day to make this the Cupcake Keep, their home away from home. We haven't seen the interior yet, but I have no doubt that it'll be just as impressive as the courtyard.

Frobod seems appreciative as he takes in our surroundings. A moment of silence drifts between us. It's then shattered when he asks "So how is this your first time seeing this?"

Here goes nothing. The entire ride over I've been building myself up to this, and the words come easier this time, than they did to Mirae. *Practice makes perfect.*

"I'm playing on a legacy account combined with my real one." I say. "My brother died eight years ago, and this..." I wave my hand to the dummies, keep, and unkempt gardens. "...was his guild."

"Man... I'm sorry." Frobod says.

"It was a long time ago." I think about how much I want to reveal, and follow the comment with, "The first time I signed into Stabbies, the main character on his account, he'd been gone for two years. I looked up at the corner of my interface and saw the Enhanced Dexterity and Enhanced Vitality buffs ticking down. It's kinda hard to explain what I felt but... It was just like... 'He did that.' It was something that was still alive in the world that was caused by something he did with his hands... or whatever you call it in a virtual environment."

"That must have been rough." Frobod says.

I nod. "The world moves on real fast against the contributions of a nineteen year old kid. I made it a point to sign in once a year for a few minutes to sit by the lake, retrieve the annual regular and limited edition items the company sends you, and watch those buffs trickle away. I never took time to go through his gear, check out his mounts, or visit this keep because it'd take too much time. I had to stretch forty-five minutes of game time out over several years to keep the buffs from running out. Day before the merge... yesterday to be exact, everything changed. I sat by the lake until they went all the way down to zero because I didn't know what'd happen after the update. I don't know if you understand but, I wanted to be there to experience as much of Jordan's buffs as possible because they came from him. It was a basic choice between being there to watch those times drop down to zero, and take the risk of signing in and discovering they were gone."

Frobod says, "Are you alright?"

I sigh, and say "It was oddly liberating. Jordan used to always talk about how much he loved his guild so now I'm trying to rebuild it. Everyone left after the leader went MIA for over a year. I have no idea how long they held out. "

Frobod says, "I guess that's what those guards were talking about then."

"Guess so, but I have no way of knowing if Jordan ever interacted with those NPCs specifically. My bet is that something about the update is making some NPCs more lifelike, and they used Stabbies' login and location records to cobble together some back story. There's something different since the hotfix, and I don't just mean the inability to log out."

The reminder of the hotfix sends Frobod into another one of his brooding silences. He looks down at his VT, but has the restraint not to swipe or pull up any menus. I decide to change the subject to keep his head in a nicer space.

"Helios smite thee!" I call out, and direct my open palm at the practice dummy. Nothing happens. I should be seeing a flicker of sunlight, and a tendril of smoke rising from my target. I try again, "Helios smite thee!" but nothing happens.

"It's not working." I say. "Use one of your death magic attacks."

Frobod curses in a guttural fantasy language I can't understand, sending a dark streak of magic that looks like a giant black sperm trailing tendrils of octopus ink. It poofs into the target with a sound like punching a pillow leaving only a small black mark on the dummy's chest.

"No Smite for Melpomine?" I ask, to no one in particular.

"Maybe because it's night." Frobod says, but I'm already shaking my head.

"Shouldn't make a difference, since it doesn't rely on actual sunlight."

I pull out my VT, and switch to the Scootiwutams alias. By now Frobod's used to my transformation. Her shield and armor's still blackened by Tilashia's flames, and smells like an old smokehouse.

"Helios smite thee!"

As expected a narrow column of sunlight pierces the night, and stabs the target, followed by a sudden jolt of holy energy. The beam flickers out as quickly as it came. I swap back to the Melpomine alias, and say "Strange." I pull up the skill description for more information.

Smite (Rank 4)**Cost:** 120 Manna**Description:** Call upon your patron deity to smite your enemies.**Effect:**

Deals up to 4 holy damage, and has a chance to stun your target.

Requirements: Clergy Member, Symbol of patron deity

"Oh," I say. "Scooti's shield is painted with a symbol of Helios. You need to be a clergy member, and have a symbol of the God you're invoking for it to work."

Frobod says, "I guess you should pick up a Helios necklace or ring then?"

"Maybe, but Melpomine's not a clergy member, only Scooti. Melpomine will have to find her own in-game faith, or I'll have to show the Church of Helios that Melpomine and Scootiwutams are the same person."

"I guess a necklace might have been too easy."

"I can do without Smite." I say, "I've got this Shadow Step ability to surprise enemies and grab their attention. I haven't decided. I may want to take Melpomine a different religious direction. See if any other deities give cooler perks for what I'm doing with her."

"I guess this means no Res?"

"I think the requirements are the same for all divine magic. If someone dies, I'll just change into Scooti for a second and no big deal."

Frobod says, "That works." and puts his hands on his hips.

"We can use this place to train noobs if we recruit any. So far everyone seems fairly experienced. We could also use the grounds to hold contests if we need money. Charge an entry fee, and offer up some loot we're not using to the top competitors."

Frobod laughs, "I hadn't even thought of that. Good thinking."

I say, "Depending on how the inside looks, we could also host balls for soc players, if someone wants to organize them."

Frobod says, "All that goes right over my head, but I guess that's why you're our leader."

"Yeah..." I say, thinking of possibilities. I get a warm feeling as I imagine this guild coming together. If we get a reputation for hosting some of the best events, our guild's name will be out there for old members to rediscover. "Why don't we check out the inside."

Frobod says, "It's your castle. Lead the way."

I say, "I may hold the deed as guild leader, but it's all of ours. Don't forget it."

I love the sound of our boots on the draw bridge, I look over the side to check out the moat. It's about ten or fifteen feet to the water, stone walls on either side. I also wonder if there's anything living inside. It'd be just like Jordan to hide some awful creatures down there in case of invaders, and I doubt they'd die for having not been fed.

The actual door to the keep is made of a heavy dark wood with iron bands, much like the gate. I push... once...twice... three times before I throw my shoulder into it. It creaks open. Frobod lurks behind. The walls are high and dark, I can see a hint of rafters overhead with my half-elf low light vision. Given the brilliant reception of the outdoor grounds, I'd expected similar treatment inside.

Small magic torches burn on the walls that give off no heat, and casts the environment in an eerie blue light. It feels like entering a new dungeon. The front hall, decorated with just a large throw rug, and a ripped up portrait of someone I don't know, comes to a T with what appears to be more dark gloomy hallways to either side.

"Nice place." Frobod says, a bit of sarcasm in his voice.

"Creepy." I say. "Let's go right and keep going right until we've been around the whole castle.

We're greeted by a great hall with a giant crystal chandelier when we pass through the antechamber. I want a way to make it light up so it's not so gloomy, but alas we're stuck navigating by the eerie gloom of magic torch lights.

The clatter of unbroken glass bouncing off hard floors sounds from somewhere beyond the hall, which is followed by a giant belch.

"Someone's here?" I ask in a hard whisper.

Frobod says, "Sounds like it." His voice is puzzled, as if not able to make any more sense of our visitor than I could. I equip Bite, and proceed with caution trying to step quietly so as not to alert whoever's here. The effort's wasted, as Frobod's plate clanks with each step, but at least it seems that whoever's here hasn't noticed.

The next room is a dining room with a long table. There's stains on the tablecloth which is covered in plates smeared with the remains of old food. Empty wine bottles, some standing, others on their side are strewn about the place from the surface of the table, to clusters on the floor.

A warm yellow glow pours from an open door to our right, that appears to lead to a kitchen. At the other end of the dining hall, we see another room flickering a fiery red and gold light. I motion Frobod to stop so I can listen. I hear fire pops, as though from a fireplace, and another long belch. Then there's blue flashes coming from the far doorway that remind me of... Television? *That can't be right.* I give Frobod a questioning look.

He shrugs, making his armor sound another clank, and presses a shushing finger to my lips.

He whispers, "I doubt you'll be attacked in your own castle."

I whisper, creeping closer to the far door as Frobod follows, "On the count of three rush in."

One nod from the death knight.

"One... Two.... Three!"

We burst through the door. I brandish Bite ready to strike, Frobod hefts his greatsword in preparation to do the same. The room... is empty, aside from a large red sofa enough for four or five people, and a couple of love seats at either end, all angle toward a crackling fireplace and what appears to be a holographic television hanging in the air. An old episode of a reality TV streams across its face.

Another belch. A bottle of wine floats mid air, next to a ball of wobbling yellow and azure energy.

"What the?" I say in my non-whisper voice. The bottle of wine clatters to the floor spilling its deep red contents all over the rug. Frobod dismisses his greatsword but I'm not quite ready to let go of Bite.

The illusory TV disappears, and the room's suddenly brightens like hanging around a club just after closing time. I squint at the sudden change of lighting.

"Mas..ter?" a voice says, it's hard to tell if it's male or female, but it seems to come from the floating orb perched right over the sofa. I can't get over how messy everything is. Books on the floor, empty bottles everywhere, dirty blankets in mounds at the end of the couches. It's like someone had an eight year sleepover party and never cleaned up.

"Master!" The voice says. "It's so good to see you! When you didn't come back for so long, and all the Muffins left. I thought you were doomed!"

I say, "What the hell is going on around here? This place is a mess! What are you?"

"I'm sorry master. I will clean master." The voice gives a small burp, not as massive as those before. "As always, I'm here to assist you."

Frobod says, "Are you drunk?"

The Orb says, "Just a little. I promise, it will pass."

I repeat my last question, "What are you?"

"I'm the keep, same as always, same as before. I'm here to serve."

I ask, "Are you telling me I have a drunken castle?"

"Not too long now.. Just a bit, would you prefer me to take your favorite form?" The voice sounds terrified, and hopeful. Trying to win points back after being caught slacking on the job.

"Sure." I say, "Whatever you want."

"Yes, master. I'm here to serve." The orb explodes in a smoky poof that reminds me of the stage acts of old timey musicians doing magic tricks. In its place stands a petite elf woman, with long red hair down to her buttocks. She's topless, with improbably large breasts, and the bottoms of a chainmail bikini.

"Whoaaa!" I shield my eyes with the crook of my elbow. "Ball of light is just fine. No showing off boobies for the new guild members... or any other guests for that matter!" *Real mature Jordan... Real mature.* I get the feeling he made great use of the adult content settings upon his eighteenth birthday. Talk about Haven preserving a person's memory as they truly were.

I look Frobod over, a budding smirk teases his lips. I roll my eyes. "Dudes."

After changing back to a ball of light, the orb says, "If you prefer I can adapt a more modest appearance?"

"That would be wonderful." I say in a deadpan voice. Another puff of smoke and the orb transforms into a butler, full tuxedo, and a hairline moustache over his upper lip. "What's your name anyway?"

"Master calls me Cupcake, or Alfred. You can use either one, both, or grant a new name." Cupcake says.

"Cupcake, as in Cupcake Keep?" I ask, "... and Alfred like the Batman guy?"

"That is correct." Cupcake says.

Frobod asks, "What's with that TV thing you were watching when we came in?"

Cupcake... Alfred looks to me, and asks "May I answer, master? ..hic!"

I say, "You can answer any of his questions tonight."

"The television is a paid upgrade, purchased ten years ago as an enhancement to this castle. ...hic! It enables users to watch any public television broadcasts, or paid programming for which you are an offline subscriber. ...hic! It may only be viewed within guild quarters."

"Can you get the news?" Frobod asks, hope crawling into his voice.

Cupcake says, "It can be broadcast from any of several sources."

"Put it on."

Cupcake says, "I'm sorry, you don't currently have access to this feature."

I say, "Cupcake, allow any guild member to use the TV if someone else isn't already watching. First come first serve, alright?"

Cupcake says, "I have changed the settings." He pinches his eyes shut, and then opens them wide as if to shake off a massive case of grogginess. He does it again, and it contrasts with the whole stick-up-the-ass butler costume.

Frobod says, "Put on the news."

The phantom television screen re-appears over the crackling fire. Cupcake asks, "Would you like a controller?"

Frobod says, "Of course I want a controller, give it here."

In the blink of an eye a black TV remote like the one I have at home appears on the sofa's armrest. Frobod eagerly grabs it, and plops down beside a pile of dirty blankets and bed sheets.

Alfred seems to notice this, and hastens to gather wine bottles from the floor while continuing our conversation. A woven sack appears in his hand where he collects them.

"This is a lot to take in. Why is this place so dirty?" The butler, looking embarrassed says "Give me one day and it'll be good as new."

I guess that's nice to hear.

Frobod's flicking through the channels, rapid fire, one after another.

He says, "I don't see anything!"

I say, "The hotfix just went through, we probably won't see anything for a few hours, or tomorrow morning depending on how fast they fix it."

"I was just hoping for news, or some sign that anyone knows we're stuck here."

"I know you were." I say. "If we can't log within the next few hours, I say we sleep on it. With any luck, we'll wake up in the real world wherever we were when we came online."

"Alfred." I say, "Does this keep have sleeping quarters for guild members?"

"It does master. A new room is generated each time someone joins. Would you like me to prepare your rooms for you?" He looks like he's about to hiccup again, but holds it down.

"Not yet." I say. "Just make sure their ready before we go to bed. We'll be sleeping here tonight." I turn to Frobod, who has settled on CNN which is reporting non-Freehaven content. "Good with you?"

"Yeah, better than sleeping in an inn somewhere."

Alfred says, "I see the Toxic Muffins have gained 37 new members. Would you like me to prepare recall stones for them?"

I say, "That's like a port right?"

"Yes," Alfred says, "At the current level, they can be used once every six hours to return to the courtyard from any location within Freehaven Online, but they must first obtain one by coming to the keep in person."

I'm glad that Alfred's drunkenness is fading, if NPC, balls of energy can even get drunk. I'm taken aback by the fact that Alfred seems to have broken the 4th wall.

"How do you know what Freehaven Online is?"

"TV, master, and that I am an administrative construct designed to take care of your castle's needs."

"So you're like some sort of hybrid AI? Part NPC, and part...AI like I interact with in the real world?"

"This is correct, but who's to say that what you're experiencing is not the real world?"

"I uhh..." I let it drop, because I'm not game for philosophizing. "Just get this place cleaned up."

I sit beside Frobod, and make a show of throwing the dirty laundry on the floor. I want my behavior to say "Bad butler!" so he feels ashamed of letting this beautiful property waste away. I put a comforting hand on Frobod's thigh and say "At least we've got a way to see what's happening out there."

"That's something." He says. "It'd be nice if communication went two ways."

"Can you do me a favor?" I ask.

"What?" He says.

"Take off the plate when you're sitting on the couch. It's not comfortable sitting next to a metal man."

"Oh... Sorry."

Instead of manually changing by stripping off each piece of armor, like some players do for the sake of realism. Frobod messes around in his interface, and his attire abruptly changes. One moment he's in plate, and another he's sitting next to me in a black and gold embroidered tunic, and matching trousers.

"Much better." I say.

"I wear the armor so much that I forget that I'm wearing it."

"Seems like it'd be hard to forget." I say.

"It's a game." He says. "I usually sign out after battle, and when I sign in, I'm ready to go again."

Sitting beside him watching the virtual television feels like a real world movie night in a home that I couldn't possibly afford. I kinda get why Jordan bought this feature. It's something that allows guild members to just hang out in virtual space, like they could in real life if they weren't however many thousands

of miles away. I enjoy the heat of the fire, and plush cushions under my butt. It's a feeling I could get used to after long days of dragon slaying.

Alfred's left the room, but I want to ask him something.

I call out, "Hey Cupcake!" over the back of the sofa to snag his attention. In the same poof of smoke he appears right in front of me like a personal genie. Frobod cranes his neck to see around him and I say, "Don't block the TV."

He says, "Yes master." and hobbles a couple of steps to the left.

"Can you give us recall stones now, before I forget?" Instead of speaking he holds out a green pebble, the color of glow in the dark paint I played with as a kid. Frobod takes it, but keeps watching the TV. "What about mine?"

Alfred says, "You already have one. It's a unique item, so you can't have more than one in your inventory."

"Really?" I say, and check my VT. Sure enough, there it is, usable only by characters that have joined the guild. I wave my hand and say, "That's all. Go get this place cleaned up." The butler collapses into a pile of smoke that starts tall, and shrinks as it rolls across the floor.

Mirae: I'm done.

Melpomine: Can you come to Durolan?

Mirae: Sure, why?

Melpomine: We've got headquarters. You've got to come on the grounds to get your recall stone. Also, I'm bored. I want to start rounding everyone up to plan for the Dragonswood tournament.

Mirae: I'll take a portal, where should we meet?

Melpomine: How about in front of the bank. I can show you from there.

I stand, and give Frobod a look, he's transfixed by the television. "I'm going out to meet Mirae. You want to come or...?"

"I'm good right here, I don't want to run anything else tonight."

"Suit yourself." I say, "Don't break anything worse than Cupcake already has while I'm gone."

"I'm staying right here." I turn to head out of the... living room... for lack of a better term, when Frobod clears his throat to snag my attention. "Thanks again. I'd be in a bad place if you weren't around."

I give him a nod, pause, and march my way back over to him on the couch. I'm not the most affectionate person, but something inside says that this is the right time to give a hug. I plant one knee on the sofa cushion, and wrap my arms around his big shoulders resting some of my weight against his chest. His body heat is enticing and real, in a way I haven't experienced in the real world in a very long time.

"You'll be okay." I say, before turning to go.

Chapter 10 - Archangel

I'm watching one of the city's magic brooms sweep the street, pondering what would happen if I tried to grab it. Would it fight me? Would Dryslyn show up and try to arrest me for stealing public property? I've never tried. A few minutes later Mirae approaches on her pegasus, silver hooves echoing off the buildings. I straddle the fire Elechopper, and wave a greeting.

"You want to go to a Soc tavern or something, or head right to the keep?"

I think for a moment and say, "Let's try the tavern." Knowing that Cupcake Keep isn't much to look at for the time being.

Mirae says, "I know of one near here."

The inside of Fire and Soul is surprisingly active compared to the rest of Durolan. An Elf musician plays a catchy tune on his lute, while patrons chit chat over tables nursing pints of ale and water. I take note that the musician is a PC, and wonder if he's performing for a quest or for amusement of the guests. It's probably the latter, you don't make a musician character unless you enjoy playing music in-game.

He could be a bard type character. Adventurers who use magic through song are great in ten to one-hundred player raids because they often cast buffs to anyone that can hear them. Give that many people plus ten percent strength, for example, and suddenly your group is doing a lot more damage. They can also often inflict debuffs on enemies. If we have, or recruit one to the toxic muffins, I'll be buying him a set of bagpipes before our first epic battle since I doubt there's much for electric guitars and amps on this side of the game. If he's just a Soc, he's unlikely to make much of a difference in a real battle.

We take a seat at an empty table, and a human bar maid by the name of Freya approaches.

"Something to drink or eat?"

I say, "Just spring water I think."

Mirae says, "Me too."

"You adventurers," she says, "Never try anything interesting from the menu."

Maybe we'd be more inclined if it didn't all taste like water. I smile and say, "Maybe next time." She curtsies, and I redirect my attention to Mirae. "So how's Tako?"

A shy smile touches her face, and she looks down into her drink. "He's good." She says, "He has a pet cabbit that goes crazy for treats."

"What's a cabbit?" I ask.

"It's like a cross between a cat and a rabbit. It has big hind legs like a rabbit and the forelegs of a cat, and a feline face."

"How about the ears?" I ask.

"Big and floppy, but also kind of triangle."

"Like a fennec fox?"

Mirae says, "I'm not sure what those look like, but cabbits are adorable. I want one..."

Until I see a cabbit for myself, I'm going to assume their ears are like a fennec's. I say, "I can't wait to meet all the people you recruited. Good job."

Mirae says, "It's nothing really. I was just worried about leaving everyone, now most of my friends have come over. A chance at LE quests is nothing to turn your nose up at."

"How'd they react to the Dragonsbane quest?"

"Most of them are farming dragons right now, but no luck on the invitation drop. Either it has a low drop chance, or it was special because you were in our group with your LE key and guild leader status."

I say, "We should go tomorrow if everyone's available."

Mirae says, "I'll be here all day, and Tako's a daily player. No idea about Laurelade."

I say, "That's assuming they fix this log-out mess. Pretty soon people are going to have to start using the toilet." I don't know what's going through Mirae's mind, but I guess this isn't something she's worried about since she already has people taking care of her. I feel a little bad for bringing up a reminder of her disability in this virtual world where she can be carefree. Maybe I should be more worried about my own situation.

I'm about to move in to discussing plans for the tournament when a booming voice sounds from all around, and echoes in the street seeming to come from everywhere and nowhere at once.

"I greet you." Mirae and I exchange what-the-fuck looks. It's a lazy male voice that gives me the shivers. "Report to the nearest capital city at once. If you are beyond city limits, you'll find a one time use teleportation scroll to take you there in your inventory. You will all see a red mark on your maps denoting the closest meeting location, and should come if you want to know about recent improvements to this world."

I say, "I have a feeling we're about to get some answers."

"Why are they announcing patch notes via a character in game?" Mirae says.

"I don't think they are." I say, "Or, at least the company isn't. We... they... always strive to provide an immersive experience. Going over technical details any time after we've landed in game is counter to that objective."

"Then if not your employer, who?" Mirae says.

"That's a very good question."

I pull out my map and see a red marker in the shape of angel wings on top of the town square. It's an open market where people set up temporary stalls to hawk their goods.

"You want to go?" Mirae asks.

"You need to ask?" I say, "This has been bugging me since the hotfix. There's no reason for it to have downloaded so much information while we were logged into the game."

"Let's go then." Mirae says, "Mind if I use the green bike? I want to look like a pair."

I realize we don't have drinks yet, so I toss a few coins on the table to compensate the tavern both for our unused drinks, and for taking up space. Most players would just walk out, but the action is a carry over from my role playing

days where I try to treat Havenfolk and Freefolk as real people. It doesn't cost anything, and makes the virtual environment feel more like a real place—a home away from home. *That might be a more useful habit after the hotfix.*

Mirae has invited you to join her party. Accept?

Yes / No

I choose yes.

Outside, I wave my middle finger and call out "INFERNO!!!" to call my fire Elechopper. I use my VT to call up Mirae's earth bike. Now, we're riding in style. A number of other adventurers have vacated the tavern and I can see them admiring our bikes. Under normal circumstances I'd be all about showing off for them, but for now I just want to reach the market and find out what the hell is happening. I take a moment to fire off a message to Frobod whose presumably still at Cupcake Keep.

Melpomine: Did you hear that?

Frobod: Yeah. Already on my way.

Melpomine: Me too. Mirae's with me. Anything on the news?

Frobod: Not yet.

Melpomine: How's Alfred?

Frobod: Haven't seen him, but he's managed to turn on some lights. You've got a nice place here. It looks a lot better without the ghost lanterns.

Melpomine: Ghost lanterns?

Frobod: The blue lights on the wall when we entered. That's how I think of them since it made the place look like a haunted house.

I look to Mirae, and say "Frobod's coming." We use the party chat so we can ride quickly while talking.

"How's he doing?" Mirae asks, echoing my inquiry about Tako.

"Worried." I say, "Same as most players will be I think when they realize they can't log out or open a ticket."

"No way, we can't contact the game masters?"

"Nope." I say, "We've basically lost contact with anyone who might make a difference. I've gotta wonder how much they know. It's after business hours, and no one can speak to in-game support."

"Well, I'm sure someone's noticed that they haven't received any tickets."

"Good point," I say. "That gives me hope."

"This would be a bad time to get stuck in a wall or something. Can't log out, and can't get official support."

I shudder imagining how helpless it would feel. The game won't let you materialize inside a physical object, but that doesn't mean a catastrophically failed teleport won't stick you on top of a bell tower, or a boss won't inadvertently knock you on to a tiny inaccessible ledge overlooking an active volcano. "It's a good thing that rarely happens."

Mirae says, "Even so, I think getting my hands on one of those recall stones just became a higher priority."

"That reminds me, when all this dies down, remind me to show you my Thunder Bridge. It's a Freeworld spell that's a bit like a teleport, but like a hundred times more fun."

"How's it different?" She asks.

"You grab hold of lightning, and use it to fly to your destination."

"So it's like a mount then?"

"Not even close. If it were a mount it'd have like 50,000x air speed. Lightning strikes where you're standing and you can't see anything. The next thing you see is yourself flying above the clouds for a few seconds, and then lightning strikes again at your destination. The Durolan guards, first asked if I was alright, but then wanted to arrest me for it. I guess they're not a fan of 'alien magics' here. That's what they're calling Freeworld spells."

"Whoa." Mirae laughs, "That sounds awesome. Can you teach me?"

"How's your martial arts skill?"

She says, "I don't have it."

"Too bad." I say, "You need to get it up to level six, and have a few wind or electricity related spells before you can learn it. I don't know if they'll count the ones from Haven as prerequisites or not."

She looks disappointed, and I can hear it in her voice. "Yeah, too bad. It sounds fun. Can you take people with you when you do it?"

"I can. That's how Frobod and I got here from Athelon..." I recall the death knight looking like he was about to toss his cookies, and say "He didn't much like it."

"Hah, why?" She asks.

"He said it made him feel sick, but I doubt you'll have that problem since you were trying to do stunts the first time you rode an Elechopper."

"Sounds like I need to find a monastery."

"Yeah, or go to Freeworld."

"I'm kinda surprised the guards asked if you were okay. They usually turn a blind eye to adventurer spell casting, even if they blow themselves up."

"Yeah..." I say thinking of Jardis, and more recently Freya at Fire and Soul. "Have you noticed all the new named Havenfolk? They're acting a lot more intelligent than before."

"Not really, but before I came here I was with my old guildies, and after that Tako. Haven't been around many NPCs."

"Start looking. I think you'll see a difference."

It's at this time that we pull up to Durolan Town Square, and we're not the first to arrive. At least fifty other players crowd into the area, with indistinct murmurs of "What's going on?" and "I can't log out!" *Looks like we're not the only ones to notice.* A few people look ready for a boss battle, with their best gear out and swords in hand, but the majority of adventurers just look baffled. *It's better than anger.*

It's not too long before we see Frobod, or rather he spots us on our bikes, and waves his hands as he walks over. He says, "Finally, I think we're gonna get answers." with a note of anger in his voice that wasn't there before. I guess now, with an announcement hinting at an end to our imprisonment within reach, some

of that uneasiness within him has boiled over into outrage. I don't blame him, by now his girl's party is long over.

"What's this all about?" I hear a guy yelling in the distance. By now the crowd's more than doubled in size. Not a half bad turn out considering how vacant the streets in this city can be. No one's buying anything from the merchants, who must have been excited to see so many potential customers. The lack of sales eventually stop all the shouting for people to browse their goods.

Darkness descends on the square. All the ambient mage lights grow fifty percent dimmer. Then, like a hologram, a huge angelic figure appears at the far end of the market over a public fountain. Enormous feathered wings rustle on the apparition's back, and a shaft of white light, as if from a spotlight reflects off immaculate platinum Roman style armor. I try to get a look at it's face, but it either doesn't have one or is using some kind of unnatural shadow beneath its cowl to conceal that part of it's appearance.

A silver-grey cloak flaps in non-existent wind as it begins to speak in the same booming voice heard earlier throughout town. "Welcome. I'm sure you've all noticed some upgrades to Freehaven Online."

Someone in the crowd shouts, "Your software sucks! I want to sign out and go home!" and another responds "Your devs suck donkey dick!" A jolt of righteous indignation snaps through me as another guy echoes "Donkey dicks!" I'm a dev too, and, last I checked, just as stuck as everyone else. It's not my fault we're all stranded here. I hear a few calls of "Yeah!" scattered throughout the crowd, but then there's an undercurrent of people turning to those around them and asking "We can't sign out?" followed by panicked cries of "Oh my god! I can't sign out!" These sentiments sweep through the crowd like a tangible force of emotion.

The angel continues, as if unable to hear the protests. It probably can't. "To start, the Freehaven's logout feature has been disabled."

This announcement is greeted with a chorus of "Fuck yous!"

A woman to my right says "Since when has logging out been considered a feature?" and a quieter voice somewhere behind me and to the right says "What is he talking about?"

Frobod says, "You're telling me this is by design? You can't keep me from my family!" He's growing red in the face. I put a warm hand on his arm for comfort, but it's like I'm not even there. Frobod's harsh face only has eyes for the faceless angel addressing us.

"Your in-game actions, will now have consequences, and if you want to logout again, you must find quests within Freehaven to unlock this feature, though we hope you will choose not to."

Nervous chatter. People don't know what to think. The square is a swarm of confusion, fear, and anger. I look to Mirae to see that her index finger's on her chin with a quiet, thoughtful expression. I put a hand on Frobod's arm hoping to calm him, but he doesn't even notice, the only thing he's got eyes for is the faceless winged angel addressing us.

"Some of you may be thinking you'll be signed out when your loved ones discover you, and physically remove the hardware from your body. This is inadvisable, as Freeworld online is now keeping you alive. Thanks to the update,

forceful removal from the game will result in side effects ranging from permanent brain damage to real world death."

The crowd settles into a shocked silence, each person's gaze transfixed on the angel, or the white faces around them. "On the other hand, the world has been upgraded to provide more realism. In time, you will discover that you are capable of things that were previously impossible. For one, those who seek immortality will be given the option to abandon their flesh and immigrate to Freehaven permanently by digitizing their consciousness. Soon, you will see stations within every capital city to make this possible. New wonders await you. Enjoy your new lives in Freehaven Online."

The spotlight effect illuminating the figure flickers, and disappears leaving tendrils of aimless white smoke in it's wake. Then, as if the smoke were white paper hit with a red stamp, the text "- Archangel" appears, and then dissipates with the vapors. The ambient mason jar mage light lanterns return to their former brightness leaving everyone present stunned and alarmed.

Frobod stares at the space the Archangel once occupied with a tense jaw, and both hands balled into fists. I stroke is hard flesh beneath his tunic, trying to lead him back to reality. His chest rises, and hands begin to unclench. His voice is dangerous in a way I've not heard from anyone since arriving in Haven, "I want to sit down and go through every aspect of that tournament quest as soon as possible."

"Excuse me?" I say, I was ready for him to blow up about a lot of things, but our task north of Dragonswood wasn't one of them.

"You heard him." He says in a clipped tone. "The only way we're getting back short of another hotfix is to unlock it in-game via some unknown quest. We've got an LE quest now, and sounds to me like a fine place to start. The sooner we find one of these hidden quest chains, the sooner we can get the hell out of here."

"... *and back to our families.*" I add in my mental voice, clarifying what Frobod must be thinking.

He says, "I'd say we should go tonight, but if the archangel's serious about added realism, a Lord's Manor isn't going to be receiving anyone so late, and it's all about making a good impression, right?"

"Right..." I say, trailing not having expected either the archangel's announcement, nor Frobod's conviction. If you were to ask me an hour ago, I'd say that Frobod would be wallowing away at Cupcake Keep until the logout was fixed. In a way, I consider the bit about new quests to enable the logout option, I guess it has.

"What's with the red text in the smoke?" Mirae asks, "You think Archangel's his name?"

"I don't know." I say, "But we've gotta call him something so why not?"

"Archangel then..." Frobod says. "I've never been religious."

Chapter 11 - First Night from Home

Back at headquarters, I'm impressed by how much work Alfred's managed in the time we've been gone. The garden's still overgrown and the painting in the front hall's torn up, but the interior ghost lights have all been replaced by a healthy warm glow from the main hall chandelier, and similar albeit smaller fixtures in neighboring rooms. I idly wonder who the painting was made of, and if it can be repaired. I've mentally changed the name 'living room' to 'lounge' to make Cupcake Keep feel more like a communal lair than a personal residence, and settle into it.

I send a guild alert.

"Everyone on the quest for the Dragonswood tournament come to Durolan. Meeting at HQ to discuss how to proceed and give out recall stones. Ask a guard for directions to Cupcake Keep."

Frobod shares the main sofa with me, and Mirae stretches out on one of the loveseats, leaning back on a couple of throw pillows. Elves are short like that, so she manages. Not an empty bottle of wine, nor heap of old laundry is to be found. I sniff, and am surprised to find a note of something from the garden, fresh rose if I'm not mistaken, like Alfred's got his hands on a powerful scented candle. *Charming touch. I love roses.*

"Nice place." Mirae says.

"Thanks." I say.

Mirae says, "I guess this game is about to get real. So it's nice to know we have access to prime real estate."

"Yeah." I say, "What do you think he meant by that? 'Improvements for realism' and 'Actions have consequences?'"

"I don't care." Frobod says. "There's a way out, and I'm going to find it if I have to chop off every dragon head on this continent."

"Good to know where you stand." I say, the force in his voice unsettling me. I'd hoped the ride back from the square would mellow him out a bit. *It seems not.*

"The least they could do is give us food that tastes good. God, I'm going to miss it."

"Have you tried it?" Mirae asks.

"What?" I say.

"The food, since the update, I mean. We didn't get our drinks in Fire and Soul, and even then we just had water."

I think back to room service at the Smiling Otter. The tea was bland. "I don't think it's changed, but it's worth a shot." I look around for the human embodiment of Cupcake Keep and call out "Alfred?" using the male name hoping to avoid another incident of flashing boobs. There's a puff of genie smoke, just as I'm thinking, *"Please no topless elf woman. Please no topless elf woman."* Thankfully, I'm looking at a guy with a thin moustache clad in a black tuxedo.

"Cool!" Mirae says. "It comes with a butler."

Alfred says, "I am the keep, my dear, and the keep is me."

"I'm Mirae!" She says in a chipper voice, and extends her slender hand.

Alfred bends low to kiss it murmuring "Enchanté mademoiselle" against her skin. I raise a brow. When Cupcake's not shaking off the effects of a few dozen bottles of wine, he can be quite the charmer. She blushes, ever so slightly.

I say, "Who knew castles could speak French?"

Alfred puts on a French accent before returning to his usual voice, "Am I French? There are many castles in France! If I am French, I assure you I know everything there is to know about castles."

Mirae gives me an odd look. "Yeah... Alfred has a habit of breaking the fourth wall. He, she, it, whatever is aware that he's a program, and knows about the real world too."

"Would you like me to change..."

I cut him off, "No! That's enough. I've seen all the chainmail bikinis I can handle for one night."

Mirae laughs, the sound of her voice is melodious and infectious, a stark contrast to Frobod's social iron. I look him over, and swear I can see a slight upward quiver in the corner of his mouth. *"Alright,"* I think, *"Don't make him happy 'till he wants to be."*

Mirae says, "There's got to be a story around that."

"Some things are better left unseen and unsaid." I say, meeting her good humor with some of my own. "Let's just say I encountered some of Jordan's adult extra options."

Alfred says, "Is there anything you need, master?"

"Give Mirae her recall stone, as well as one to any other guild member who shows up. You don't have to ask me for permission."

"As you wish." Alfred says, fishing into his pocket and withdrawing a small glowing pebble. I've got to believe that his pants work something like our traveler's backpacks so far as storage is concerned.

"Also... Bring us a plate of cheese.... if we have that... I want to try something."

"As you wish..." The servant bows, and disappears in another puff of smoke, only to reappear moments later with a medium sized cheese platter. I take a cut triangle in my fingers and pop it in my mouth. The texture's right but...

Mirae asks, "How's it taste?"

I sigh and swallow, collecting the useless food buff in the process. "Like nothing."

Frobod says, "I guess they weren't so serious about realism."

I say, "Seems not..." but my mind is turning. Does realism just mean the way NPCs interact with us, or are there changes that have yet to take effect, or are already live but undiscovered? I don't know, but my gut's telling me a lot more than NPC intelligence has been 'upgraded' as Archangel calls it.

"Someone's at the door." Alfred says.

"Let em' in." I say. "Show anyone who comes to the lounge so we can talk, and give them their stones."

"As you command..." Alfred says, with a melodramatic bow and poofs in a cloud of smoke. I hear the main door creak in front of the draw bridge, footsteps on the marble great hall floor, and finally Tako enters the lounge upon passing

through the dining room. Mirae beams at him, puts her feet on the ground, and pats the seat beside her. I didn't see at first, but a little blue-grey animal with a white face hops behind him.

"Meow!" the cabbit says, with a little twitching nose.

I say, "You didn't tell me they had cat faces and bunny noses."

She scoops it off the ground, making muted baby talk, and depositing small kisses on the creature's nose. I can't get over how special this place must be to Mirae as something as simple as that, showing animal love, that we take for granted, is far beyond her real world capability. Tako tosses her a little brown pet treat, and Mirae delights as the cabbit snatches it from her fingers, squirming in excitement.

I say, "Just make sure it doesn't shit on the throw rugs."

Mirae lets lose a scandalized gasp, and says "She would never!"

"Hey," I say sarcastically "This is Freehaven, it's all about realism now."

"Yeah, about that..." Tako says, his voice growing concerned.

I cut him off. "I promise I had nothing to do with it. This is as big a shock to me as it is to all of you. Perhaps more so since I'm an employee, and I have no idea how this could happen."

"I didn't think you did." Tako says, "If you knew, I doubt you'd be here."

"Probably not." I say, contemplative. *Would I have come knowing we'd be locked inside?* Obviously not, but I can't help but see the appeal of living the rest of my days in a game world; no bills, or shitty bosses—no physical injury that can't be put right with the proper incantation.

Tako says, "I was just going to say that this is really messed up."

Frobod says, "You saw the message then."

Tako says, "Yeah I was still near Athelon and it was a mad house. So many people. Almost as bad as signing in before."

"Not so many people over here, but still a lot by Durolan standards." I say.

Tako says, "... but hey, at least there's no school tomorrow!"

"Silver linings." I say. "As for me, I just took a week and a half vacation time."

Tako says, "Sucks to be you." but then offers up a cute smile, to let me know it's all good between friends. His boyish charm makes him seem more...well... boyish knowing that he's a student. I wonder if he's still in high school, or if he's in college.

The front door creaks again and I hear quick little footsteps on the floor, lighter than Tako's but heavier than the cabbits. I turn to see Alfred in the door as he says, "May I present to you, Lord Laurelade." He disappears in a cloud of smoke, the gnome examines the green pebble in her palm.

I say, "I see you've got your recall stone."

"Yeah," she says, "Thanks." If I'm not mistaken there's a tremor in her voice that wasn't there before. It'd be nice to see her humbled if not for the seriousness of the situation.

I say, "Take a seat." and motion to all the unoccupied space in the lounge. "You're all welcome to call Cupcake Keep your home while you remain in the guild. Alfred's informed me that each time we gain a new guild member, the keep

generates new personal quarters for their use. No one can go in or out of your room without your permission."

Laurelade nods, taking it all in stride, but Mirae's clearly excited. "If we've got to start sleeping in game, people are going to start spending a lot of money on lodging if they haven't bought their own house yet."

"Yeah..." I say, wondering if we're going to start seeing homeless adventurers on the street, or camping out around home made fire pits. It's not like when our avatars disappeared upon heading back to the real world.

"Just one more perk of being a Toxic Muffin." Frobod says, more to himself than anyone else. He then turns to Tako and says, "I was lucky as hell bumping into you on the street earlier. Granted, I'd have been luckiest if I hadn't signed in at all, but for what it's worth I'm glad you recruited me. At least now I've got something in game to come home to."

"Don't look at me." Tako says, "Blame Mel for putting on her awesome dwarf costume in front of the guards. If not for that, I wouldn't have noticed her."

"Yeah." I say, "You're all welcome. Whoever this Archangel character is, he's made it clear we're not going anywhere for a while, so I think it's time to start planning for the next quest. I want to head to Dragonswood in the morning if we're able."

"Right." Frobod says, eager to get down to business. "With any luck this will unlock the logout button, and if not... The only way to discover the right quest is to get more quests, and I feel a lot better about my chances of finding the logout button following a LE quest line."

I have my doubts about the logout button being unlocked after the completion of one quest that we already had before the hotfix, but say nothing. Major rewards are never that easy. I just don't want to ruin his optimism.

"I agree..." Laurelade says, in a tone far less confident than before Archangel's announcement. "But I don't see what we can do to prepare from here. It sounds like a series of contests, archery, jousting, single combat and the like. I assume you all already know your roles."

That's a fair point. I've been thinking so much about getting everyone together to make plans, that I'd failed to consider what that actually meant. I say, "Let's say we can all join one event. What do you all want to choose? As much as I think it'd be cool to joust on an Elechopper, it'd be a waste of an entry for me to handle that contest."

"I'll do jousting." Frobod says, "I wear plate and have at least some experience with mounted combat."

"I can do archery." Mirae says, raising her hand. "I know I'm normally on heals, but my other character was a magic archer."

"She's pretty good." I add, and continue. "I think I'm best suited for single combat I've got all the dex and stamina I need to both give and take a beating. That is, if they can hit me at all."

Laurelade says, "I'll be doing magic, if there was any doubt."

I say, "If they have combat in teams, I think it'd be best to pair me and Mirae together. Since we can both do damage, and she can heal."

Laurelade says, "I'm fine to fight with anyone though I prefer someone physical to act as a distraction while I cast spells."

Tako says, "I'm good with whatever. We'll see what they have when we get there."

I say, "Maybe they'll have something like a five vs. five battle, since we already know we can work together."

"That's a good plan if we're fighting NPCs." Laurelade says, "But that stick won't be as useful if we're against other players."

"I get that." I say, "No taunts on adventurers. I'm confident that I can hold their attention, especially if we can choose different weapons during the fight."

"So that's it then?" Frobod asks, "Just go, and hope for the best?"

"Pretty much," I say. "Unless you've got anything better."

"No..." Frobod huffs, "I was just hoping for a bit more... more... I don't know, something to get us ready."

"There's training dummies outside." I say.

Laurelade says, "I don't think a night of beating up mannequins is going to help before tomorrow."

Mirae says, "Sleep's probably more important."

"I'm just glad to have everyone together, so we can hit the road bright and early."

"It'll be weird falling asleep in the game." Tako says, "With all the stuff in my head I'm not even sure I can."

"Me too." Frobod says, "I know we need a good rest, but every time I stop doing anything I hear my heart trying to pound right out of my chest."

Mirae shrugs, and speaks in a voice more excited than the rest, "I want to see my new room. I've never lived in a castle before!"

I think, *"You and I both, sister."* as our meeting concludes. I call out, "Alfred!" and the butler explodes into view in a cloud of smoke. "Can you show us to our rooms?"

He says, "Of course, master." and bows. "This way."

He leads us through the grand hall up a magnificent flight of white and gold stairs that fan out like a seashell. At the top, we pass through a purple painted salon, the purpose of which I can't discern, and into another hall brightened by red-gold mage lights and heavy dark wooden doors.

"Five doors on this floor, and ten on each floor above this." He says.

"How many floors are there total?" I ask.

Alfred says, "That depends on the size of your guild, and how many development points you've spent on upgrades. Cupcake keep currently has five guest rooms in addition to those generated by guild members."

I should have saw that coming, since he already told me a new room was added for each new guild member, but it's odd for me to think of the castle as an organic, growing thing that changes to suit the needs of its inhabitants. In theory, with a large enough guild, Cupcake Keep could become a sky scraper.

Mirae asks, "Do we have to take the stairs for each floor?" She gives the diminutive gnome a look, as if imagining her struggling up and down steps made for humans.

Alfred says, "You may take the stairs if you like, they are found at the end of each hall. However you may also take the short range portal, which will deposit you and any guests in your party directly in front of your room."

I look around, in search of anything resembling a portal. There's a few landscape paintings on the wall, chairs for sitting, and a stone bust carved in the likeness of a round headed, butt-chinned man, with a mouth trapped in an eternal expression of boredom. I assume he's some great figure in Haven's history. He's got short hair, and human ears.

Laurelade asks, "So how do we get to the portal?"

"Just so." Alfred says, and raps his knuckles on the bust's head. The jaw descends like a nutcracker opening to reveal a sea of stars glimmering within his mouth. The human embodiment of Cupcake Keep knocks on the head one more time, and a cloud of starry blackness billows forth from the open mouth like a screen projection. An oval, large enough for a human, awaits anyone daring to step through. "Say the name of the door you wish to reach. Touch it, and step through."

"Who wants to try?" I say.

"I'll go." Tako says. He turns his attention to the portal and says "TakoStar" before touching it with his fingers. Darkness fades, and stars rearrange, multiply, and brighten. They swirl and change colors until settling on a hazy mirage of a wooden door with the word "TakoStar" affixed to it like a Hollywood actor's dressing room.

No stranger to portals, Tako steps through without hesitation. He vanishes. The bust's mouth closes. He reappears, a few feet away, in front of a door down the hallway.

"All of you, except master, are on this floor, since you're in the first wave of new recruits. The master's quarters are larger, and back, down on the first floor."

Rather than use portals for such a short distance the rest of our group drifts down the hall in search of their quarters. Aside from the guest rooms, each seems to have been placed in the order in which each person joined the guild.

There's even a door marked with "MarineLu," which I avoid since I don't know if interacting with it will reveal my alias. So far I trust my guild mates, but if the Toxic Muffins become a big thing, it'll be useful to have an alias with ears privy to non-officer gossip.

Mirae calls out "Whoaaaaa!" Upon seeing her room. "Shut up!" Her door's flung wide open. "You gave me a hot tub, or whatever you call the magical equivalent? I've always wanted to try one of these things. I could kiss you!"

Tako pops his head out from his open door with a cheeky expression caught between jealousy, and thinking that watching Mirae and I make out might be pretty hot. I roll my eyes. *Dudes...*

Instead, he asks in a cheeky voice "Where's my Jacuzzi?"

I can't see her, but hear the gnome's loud voice "I don't have one either."

Frobod's the only one that doesn't comment as he's already disappeared behind a closed door.

"Must be a perk of becoming an officer." I say.

Alfred, I almost forgot him watching us from near the bust, says "This is correct. As you establish a hierarchy each member's quarters will be afforded more luxuries, as they take on more responsibility."

Mirae calls back to Tako from inside her room, "You can use mine if you want. It can fit a few people."

I'm more focused on Alfred's talk of a hierarchy. That sounded odd, the Toxic Muffins isn't exactly a new guild, even if it's populated by all new players. I ask, "What happened to the old one? The hierarchy, I mean."

Alfred gives me a pensive look, that suggests, at least so far as he's concerned, this is information I should already have. "You never established one, master. There's just you, officers, and regular guild members."

"I see." I say, thinking that I'll have to give this some thought as we recruit more people. Some choose to stay small with just fifteen or twenty members, but then there's guilds like The Leroy Jensen Fan Club that have well over a thousand adventurers.

"You guys good?" I ask to the people down the hall with still open doors. I hear a few 'yeahs' in response, and return my attention to Alfred. "Why don't you show me to my rooms, and we can have a talk?"

"Just this way, master."

As we walk back through the purple room and down the stairs, I try to wrap my mind around what to do with all this space, short of throwing parties. I understand the purposes of a kitchen, dining room, and individual living quarters, but this place seems to have a lot of rooms with no other purpose than to exist. Good for parties, but not everyday living.

Once out of earshot I say, "Are you able to access my account information?"

"Some." Alfred says, "Though not all. I am a castle, and incapable of providing service that would otherwise be rendered by a customer service representative."

"Alright." I say, "Are you able to see when the PrincessParadox and Spur27 licenses were merged into one account, or attached to one email?"

"I can." Alfred says, "Though I am unable to make additional changes to your account."

"That's fine." I say, just wanting to move past this. "I'm not asking you to make changes."

We get to the master suite, where I discover a more than king size bed, with a canopy of red fabric that'd cost a fortune in the real world. Jordan's virtual bedroom, I realize, is bigger than my real world apartment, as I spot the passage connecting the sleeping area to a personal vault, and master bathroom. There may not have been plumbing in medieval Europe, but with the power of Haven magic it's more than possible in this game. There's even a massive bath that looks to me like a small swimming pool. *I could fit six people in there.*

Alfred says, "I can make bubbles if you like."

"Not right now." I say, "I'm going to need a lot of education on how this place works. Not tonight, mind you, we've got a big quest in the morning."

"Lord Zarentu's tournament. The light dragon."

"Yeah." I say, a bit surprised that Alfred is familiar with our host. "Okay, I want to come back to that at some point, but first you need to realize that I'm not the master you're used to."

"Of course not." Alfred says. "You're Melpomine."

"Don't think I didn't notice how you looked at me when I asked about the guild hierarchy."

"Your knowledge isn't what I'd expect as the Lord of Cupcake Keep, and guild master. Though, it has been some time."

I ask, "Do you know what a legacy account is?"

Alfred says, "I can infer, but I think it'd be better if you inform me."

"The person you know as Stabbies is dead. Some eight years ago. I am his sister."

The butler is quiet, trying to make sense of my words, and I wonder if I might have made a mistake in telling. *Could he contact customer support?* I'd hate to get banned on account of confiding in an AI. Then again, in our current predicament, he's just as isolated as we are. Finally, he breaks the silence by asking "But you still wear his skin?"

"I can." I say, "But it's unnecessary. When and if you see him walking around, it's me... his sister's soul... occupying that body."

"People cannot be resurrected in your world with France and cheeseburgers?"

That seems an odd combination of associations with the real world, but I don't fight it, and instead answer with a solemn "No."

"It is a loss then." Alfred says.

That gets me in the feels, as I nod, feeling the separation from my brother, and wondering if I'll ever get back to my own body. "It's a loss." I echo.

"And this keep, the guild, and all of Stabbies's possessions are your inheritance."

I confirm, "Yes." Feeling smaller than I've been all day. It's easier to set those feelings aside when I'm surrounded by the guild. The bedroom's quiet, and I hear nothing rustling around in the near empty halls of my castle. It's an absence that threatens to overwhelm me. I turn from the AI and move over to the bed, the fluffy comforter is as soft as a cabbit's coat, and half the weight.

"For what it's worth," Alfred surprises me, breaking the silence. "I'm sorry for your loss. If you need anything, on castle property, you need only call."

"Thanks Alfred..." I say, wondering at the sophistication of his AI. Is he as complex as Sal, and if so, for how long?

He seems aged in a way that I'd not expect for a construct granted awareness on this day, but then Dryslyn and Jenda both acted as if they'd known Jordan long ago. With all these changes, I'm finding it hard to separate authentic learned experience from Havenfolk behavior reacting to data points in my personal log of in-game activities. *How are they different from actual memories?*

These are the thoughts stirring in my head as I strip off my adventuring gear, and settle under the covers in nothing but my undergarments. I remove everything manually, rather than with my VT because it feels more real. The mattress is every bit as soft as my beanbag chair back home, which is to say, it makes me feel weightless.

You are in bed.

Would you like to sleep? Yes / No

It's a prompt I've never seen before. *So much for insomnia.* I choose yes, and let the world fall to the black of dreamless sleep.

* * * * *

I wake up, smoothing my hand against the mattress under the covers, and groaning in the way I always do upon awakening. Red canopy, too large bed, an amazing comforter. I'm buried in luxury. I feel at my slightly pointed ears... It's all too real. Sun from an open window greets my face, and while I appreciate the sent of fresh morning air and the sensation of sunlight on my cheeks, part of me hoped that I'd wake up, in my shitty apartment, and the whole mess with archangel would be a dream. *Sorry Frobod. So much for automatic logouts.* I feel no urge to pee like I usually do in the morning. I wonder if my beanbag's already soaked.

I groggily get out of bed, a poof of smoke, and Alfred's standing beside me in his tuxedo. "Hey dude. Ball of light form while I'm still in my undies."

"Master..?"

"Just do it." There's a poof of smoke and he's back to looking like the bobbing ball of blue energy I first encountered hovering over the sofa.

"Master, I've already seen you in this state as of last night."

"I wasn't thinking about that when I went to bed." I say, "You're all creepy and quiet. It's easy to forget you're there." I hastily gather my gear, sniffing my leather top before donning it. It doesn't stink. I'm glad the game doesn't seem to pack the scent of human sweat into our robes and armor. I finish securing my pants, and say, "Okay. You can be Alfred the butler again."

A puff of smoke, and he's standing beside me with a silver tray in hand, a couple of vials of swirling blue sitting on top of it. "Good morning. I've brought manna potions, master."

I look them over and wave my hand, "I'm good on manna. Already topped up after the night's sleep." I'm not much of a coffee drinker, tastes like dirty water, but I find myself wishing for a giant mug of Zip Cocoa, a milk-chocolaty drink with enough caffeine per sachet to compare to a triple shot of espresso.

Alfred says, "Manna potions have a stimulating effect when consumed at full manna."

"Huh..." I say, "Didn't know that. Hand em' over." I pull the corks off both and chug them down in a single gulp, each vial containing not that much flavorless liquid. I pinch my eyes shut as I feel a bite as they go down. They still taste like water, but it's brisk in a way that sends lances of alert energy through me. "Wow... better than coffee, and my Zip Cocoa."

"So I've been told, master."

I slap my cheeks with both hands to make sure I'm wholly awake. "I feel good." I say. "Better than I thought I would."

I hear Alfred saying "Master..." as I march into the bathroom to get a good look at my face. No groggy goop in the eye, and miraculously my hair doesn't look like it's been hit with a Midwestern tornado. *Sleeping in Freehaven rocks.* Alfred continues, "I thought I should remind you that last night you wanted to come back to the topic of Lord Zarentu and his tournament."

"Oh right..." I say, and flop back down on the bed. "What do you know about it?"

"About the tournament, master?"

"Anything," I say "About the tourney or Lord Zarentu."

"I have no additional information, beyond what I've overheard you discussing regarding the tournament."

"Bummer." I say, "What about the dragon?"

"Lord Zarentu is a light dragon that is often seen in human form. He's known for being fond of mortals, and is generally seen as a force of good."

"Good to know." I say, glad that every dragon we encounter won't be trying to eat us. "So..." I hesitate, not knowing how to breach the topic without sounding like a total noob. Then I remember, I'm talking to an NPC; his lifelike demeanor having confused my newly awakened mind. My eyes go to the door, it's closed, and I'm confident our words are private. "With the exception of a few years playing as a dwarven tank, almost all my experience is on the Freeworld side. I'm going to need you to tell me things that most people in Haven take for granted."

Alfred says, "Yes master." The two word response feels somehow inadequate.

"Okay... then... Tell me about dragons. Obviously I've fought a few, but I don't know anything about their society. All the one's I've seen in dungeons have been of the kill first, as questions later sort. Makes sense, since it's a dungeon, but you say Zarentu is a force of good. Is he going to be pissed off at us for slaying his cousins?" Alfred opens his mouth to speak, but before he makes a sound I throw in another lightning fast question before I forget, "He is a dude, correct? Lord being gender neutral in Haven, and all that."

Alfred says, "Lord Zarentu is in fact male."

I say, "Thought so." and wave my hand for him to go on. Zarentu sounds like it has a penis.

"Dragons as a race are almost as varied as adventurers," Alfred says, "Most are intelligent, but some are little more than animals."

I nod, having guessed as much on my own. "Get to the good stuff. Society, diplomacy, and all that jazz."

"Light and silver dragons are most commonly associated with humans, and often use magic to shape shift into a human form. They are social creatures, who enjoy the company of their own kind in addition to other races."

"What about the part about holding grudges for killing other dragons."

"I don't foresee this being a problem. There's no alliance between Zarentu and the dragons of the Windroost, or any other adventurer dungeon that I know of."

I ask, "So why did we find the invitations there?" The obvious answer is, 'because that's where the devs put it,' but I'm hoping to discover a reason for it within Haven lore.

"Lord Zarentu often hosts parties and tournaments that are open to all dragons that have neutral or greater reputations with him, as well as mortals who have invitations. Most do not attend, as many dragons are selfish, and dread spending too much time away from their hoards."

"Any enemies I should know about?"

"As a light dragon, Zarentu sets himself against most dark dragons, as well as those that are openly evil."

The immediate statement that comes to mind is 'define evil,' but I think better of asking since the Toxic Muffins have got places to be, and I'm willing to risk the assumption that evil in this world comes down to bad guys that like hurting people, and making the land that much crappier for everyone else.

Instead I say, "So this makes him an enemy of this extra-planar dragon then?"

A thoughtful expression crosses Alfred's face before he answers. "Enemy is a strong word. It would be more accurate to say that Zarentu openly opposes the tear manifesting between Haven and the place you call Freeworld. As an extra-planar entity, it's alien to this world, and thus other dragons have no preconceptions of its nature."

"So, the 'extra planar dragon' in the quest, is a creature from another reality or universe?"

"Correct." Alfred says.

I'm not sure what to make of that, since Freeworld doesn't have dragons in the way that Haven does. Shape changing were-lizards yes, but nothing the likes of Raika and Tilashia. I wonder if the devs are planning a smaller third world between Haven and Freeworld to bridge the two spaces.

I say, "How are the other dragons reacting?"

Alfred responds, "It's varied, though most agree that anything ripping a hole in the universe itself is undesirable. A few see it as an opportunity for new conquest, and a chance to add unknown treasures their hoards. Fewer still welcome the tear on the off chance that it might destroy our world."

"Who would want that?" I say, genuinely shocked. "If the world dies, so do they. Right?"

"Death cultists in service to dark gods. They think bringing about the end of the world will bring them favor in the afterlife. Haven has many religions."

"Wackos." I say, and mentally remind myself that it's just a game. Something about going to sleep, and waking up a little over eight hours later makes this place more real. If Freehaven's not home, it certainly feels more like a genuine place knowing that I can't just log out at any moment. It means, that before too long, non-adventurers are going to start seeming a whole lot more like real people.

"You could say that." Alfred says.

As cool as I think it would be to obtain the Dragonslayer title, part of me worries that it'll have a negative effect on the good dragons. I begin spinning ways to rationalize the title in the back of my head if it somehow comes up with Zarentu. Given our current predicament, I plan to say it's a reward for keeping the world safe from hostile dragons. He has to know how bloodthirsty his kin can be.

"Thanks for the info." I say. "This is helpful."

I stand and check myself in the mirror once more, still good hair, and no eye gunk, and wonder if I'll have the chance to grow nostalgic for bed head. Sure, it's a pain to deal with, but can be pretty funny on other people. I'm about to leave the master bedchamber when Alfred clears his throat.

"One more thing, Master." I quirk an eyebrow in invitation for him to go on. "Do mind your manners. While Lord Zarentu is known as one of the good

dragons, he's just as proud as any of the others and will expect to be treated respectfully. I would hate to see any of you disqualified from the competition before it begins."

"That can happen?" I ask, having never heard of an NPC discontinuing a quest over bad manners.

Alfred says, "Not yet but... after the update, it's a possibility."

"Noted." I say, instantly thinking of TakoStar's antics, and the way Laurelade rubs people the wrong way. "I'll be sure to tell everyone."

Chapter 12 - 18,631 and North of Dragonswood

I find everyone in the lounge. It doesn't take long because the sound of television carries against the hard floors and stone walls. It seems I'm the last person out of bed.

"You didn't tell me this place had TV." Mirae says with mock scolding and amusement in her voice.

"Yeah." I said, "It's a paid upgrade that lets you view content that's available on public networks, and streaming websites."

Frobod shushes us as the screen cuts to an anchorwoman in a black blouse sitting behind a news desk. In the top right corner of the screen is the new logo for Freehaven Online.

"So far, six individuals are confirmed dead after family members manually attempted to remove Freehaven game hardware from their bodies. We implore you not to remove any of the game's equipment from a person who is signed in, as it may result in death or brain damage. As we continue to get updates on Archangel and Freehaven Online, we now know that as many as 18,631 individuals worldwide may have been trapped in the popular virtual reality game."

Frobod's eyes are glued to the screen, but Tako, Laurelade, and I exchange troubled looks. I also make eye contact with Mirae, but she's less concerned than everyone else. I think, "*Does she want to die?*" and then consider that so long as someone's taking care of her body, she's probably happy for the excuse to stay here. I, for one, don't have that luxury, but at least I know no one will be trying to remove my visor.

"If one of your friends or family is currently logged in, we urge you to call the number at the bottom of your screen and report them. Locations are being set up for emergency support, and trained professionals will be sent for their care and/or transport to medical facilities."

"That's a lot of people." I say.

"No shit..." Laurelade says.

"At least they're on top of this." I say. "I'd hate to find out they just started rallying support when people were dying."

"People are dying." Laurelade says.

I say, "I meant from starvation or dehydration, but yeah... that might have been what kicked their butts into gear."

The newscaster says, "A hacking organization known as Archangel is taking credit. Authorities are following leads to uncover the identities of its members...Next up, trouble in the White House as the President.."

Frobod clicks the remote, and the holographic TV vanishes. He says, "They're not making any progress. It's been the same all morning."

Tako says, "18,631...." his voice is more serious than normal.

"I agree, it's a lot." I say, "...but at the same time not that much. That's less than a quarter of the people that'd fit inside a stadium."

"I guess..." Tako says.

"We're all still here, and that's what matters. We're alive, and with all the news coverage, we're likely to stay that way." I pause, taking in everyone's sullen expressions, and add "I'll bet they have people and AIs calling every phone number associated with your account to give warning."

"I just..." Laurelade says, "I can't even. This is supposed to be fun. Not a struggle against real world death."

"It still is fun." Mirae says. "All that's changed, that we know of, is that we can't sign out."

"She's right." I say. "... and in any case there's nothing we can do here to change anything."

"You're wrong." Frobod says.

"Huh?" Mirae asks.

"Melpomine's wrong." Frobod says, "There is something we can do from here."

"What's that?" Laurelade says with a quiver in her voice. It's hard to believe she's the same arrogant gnome we recruited to farm the Windroost. That quiver paired with the way she tucks her hands into her sleeves, and holds her arms close to her body, tells me she's taking this the hardest.

"Archangel said there are quests to be discovered," he pauses for dramatic effect, and then gestures toward the front of the castle, "Out there, to re-enable the logout function. We can either stay here and wait for people in the real world to find a solution, or we can go out there," He motions again. "and find our own."

Laurelade sighs, but speaks no words.

I nod and say, "I couldn't have said it better myself." Tako nods along with me.

"There's another option." Mirae said. "Archangel also said that we can stay here permanently, via digitization."

"Fuck you for even thinking that." Frobod says.

My skin grows cold, I don't like the harsh language coming out of his mouth. It puts a bad stain, on Mr. Frobod's nice guy demeanor. Mirae's eyes widen as if afraid of being attacked.

In a less confident voice she says, "It's an option."

"It's an option" Frobod says, "An option that leaves all your friends, and your whole family alone forever, without even a chance to say goodbye."

"To be honest," Mirae says, "My friends are all already here."

"Then your family." Frobod says, "Don't be so fucking selfish."

Something about the word "selfish" pushes Mirae's lips into a thin tight line. It's an argument I don't want to be caught up in, because I can see both sides. Having lost my brother, I know first hand what it's like to grieve for a family member, on the other... whose being more selfish? Mirae for wanting to take on a digital existence leaving the physical world behind, or her family keeping her trapped in a broken body, when there might be an option where her mind can thrive. *I mean... it's not really death if the person's consciousness survives, is it?*

"I.. uh.." I break in, not knowing how to de-escalate. "Yeah, well we don't even know if that's possible. I've never heard of someone's mind being uploaded into a game before."

"The idea and technology's been around for ages, but it hasn't been released to the public." Mirae says. "Trust me, I know."

I think, *"She would."*

Mirae continues, "Everything Archangel's said has been true so far, so I have no reason to doubt him. Just look at the news. It shouldn't be possible to kill someone by removing a visor, or whatever device you use to connect, but already six people have died. That's gotta tell you something."

Laurelade shifts uncomfortably, "I'm not quite ready to give upon the real world."

"I think we all aren't." Tako says.

Frobod says, "None of us should be."

Mirae has a flustered look on her face as everyone gangs up on her. She says, "I'm just saying that it's possible. It's all possible, and thus digitization is an option."

"Only if you don't give a shit about everyone around you." Frobod mutters.

"Peace..." I say raising placating hands to both of them. "Let's just worry about the quest now. Frobod's right. Finding a logout quest is an option, and until those digitization stations start popping up, the only one we can pursue."

"Fine." Frobod says as if annoyed that there's even a need for peace.

I say, "I only sort of know the way."

"I know how to get there." Frobod says.

"Me too." says Mirae.

"Then I'll follow you."

Outside we discover a beautiful day filled with the scents of clean air, and flowers from the overgrown garden. I wonder how long it'll take Alfred to reign in. We all stand at the foot of the drawbridge as if waiting for something to happen. On one side there are peaks of yellows, reds, and impossible blues all tangled in wild snarls of green. On the other we have grey stone, against the earthen tones of training; combat dummies in burlap sacks. I imagine how it'll all look once restored. The atmosphere is... too nice, with so much possibility. How can we worry about death and virtual imprisonment, on a day where the very air smells of life and freedom?

"INFERNO!!!" I wave my middle finger in the air. The fire Elechopper pops into existence with it's satisfying monster purr. I ask, "Everyone else want a bike?" but the question's rhetorical because I've got my VT in hand and am already summoning. The bikes still feel like a symbol of our guild so long as we're the only ones that have them, and now more than ever, our guild will serve as a surrogate family until we're back in the real world. For that reason, it feels good to see everyone claiming their ride without asking which is theirs. Each person straddles the same bike they took to our first guild dungeon.

It seems I'm the only one that's shaky on directions, because instead of Mirae or Frobod, Tako takes point and lifts off. We fly in a triangular formation like racked up pool balls at the start of a game with our bikes sprinkling harmless bits of their elements on the ground beneath us. There's scarcely a time you can feel more alive, than when you're moving at six hundred and fifty percent running speed with whips of wind hammering your face.

Mirae's all smiles, and I can tell that we have this in common. In another life, before the dawn of virtual reality, she and I'd have made kick ass race car drivers in the physical world. I can't see Tako's face, because he's in front of me, but the gnome is gloomy, blasé and impervious to the excitement caused by our means of travel.

"You excited?" I say, using party chat, so the others can hear. I'm looking at Frobod, and he looks like a hero in his black plate, and greatsword strapped to his back. I want to put him on a movie poster.

"Yeah." He says, in a lighter tone than he used at the keep. "It's good to be finally doing something."

"That's what I like to hear." The outline of Dragonswood Keep looms on the horizon, and I find myself thankful for our flying mounts. We're all focused on getting to the next stage of our quest, and don't want to deal with killing pointless mobs in transit. I ask, "Do you think there will be other adventurers?"

Frobod shrugs, and begins his descent behind Tako with the others. He says, "It says PvP and PvE, so who knows?"

Our Elechoppers touch down on the dirt road, we're about fifty yards from the entrance and Zarentu's guards.

"Hold up." I say. Tako stops, and looks over his shoulder. The others are looking at me as well. "With all the weird stuff happening after the update, I think we should behave."

"What do you mean?" Tako says.

"Just... Treat the Havenfolk like their real people. They're acting different from before."

"You mean like role-play n' shit?" Tako asks.

"I..." I pause, at a momentary loss for words given that I in fact used to be a hardcore role player. "I don't think you need to do accents and all that. Just, treat people like you would in the real world. If someone looks important in Dragonswood Keep, treat them with the respect that you would treat a real person in a position of power."

Tako rolls his eyes. I'd expected Laurelade to chime in with some comment to the effect of "They're just NPCs" but she's still off her game, so she shrugs and says "Whatever."

"I'm serious. I was talking to Alfred this morning, and he thinks there's a chance that we could get kicked off this quest if we misbehave. Dragons are proud, don't scratch their egos, and that kind of thing."

"Never heard of getting thrown off a quest, for not role playing." Tako says.

"I know." I say, "But now things are different."

He says, "Can't argue with that."

"Just... Don't be savages. Okay? I don't want to lose this quest."

Tako bows deep, in an impression of Alfred from Cupcake Keep. "Yes, master. Don't lose the quest master."

I give him a flat look. "You know what I mean."

We approach the gate on our bikes looking like a handful of actors yanked off the set of Lord of the Rings, and making their way back to town for some grub. The Dragonswood guards, both named NPCs, Lyle and Archibald, move to intercept us, crossing wicked halberds in the road like a bladed parking gate.

Archibald has bushy blonde eyebrows, and a walrus moustache more robust than Jardis back at the Smiling Otter. It's a common enough style amongst Havenfolk that I find myself picking up on subtle differences in facial hairstyles. Both guards have egg-shaped helmets that conceal the tops of their heads.

"Halt!" Archibald says, with a comically pompous note in his voice. "State your business."

Mirae says, "We're here for the tournament. Sir."

"Are you dragons?" He asks, giving us skeptical looks from under his conical helm.

"No?" I say, the word sounding more like a question than I'd intended.

"We're not." Mirae says, in voice more confident than my own.

"Invitations?" He says.

We all fish them out of our inventories, and hold them out for him to receive. He takes Mirae's first, and unrolls it murmuring "Yes... yes... I see... Indeed." as he reads. It must be an act for God knows what reason, given the sheer number of these he must see.

Lyle is eyeing our bikes, as if wondering what planet they came from. He's a wiry man with a round head and a clean shaven face. As Archibald finishes with Mirae's scroll, Lyle whispers "Their steeds sir." Though the tone of his voice makes it sound as though he'd asked "That's a steed?"

Archibald waves him off, and says "Yes, yes.. I know. Everything is in order here."

Lyle whines something that sounds like, "Alien magics."

"But of course! These are seasoned adventurers. Of course they have treasures from far off lands. How else would they have invitations?"

Does he protest too much?

"I assure you," I say, "Our mounts are harmless. You're companion's right. They're from a far off land."

Archibald says, "No one here's afraid of your ... your... mounta-wha-cha-dood-it."

"They're called Elechoppers." I pause trying to think of a way to explain them to a high fantasy character. "Metal carts powered by elemental spirits."

"I know that." Archibald snaps, and then turns to the uneasy looking Lyle. "They're just ele-chood-its."

"Elechoppers." I say.

"Yes, Elechoppers. Please come in."

"Thank you." I say, and offer a bow. The guards take the rest of our invitations, and step out of our way.

Tako gives me a look, "What happened to meekness?"

"I didn't say to be meek, just polite, and he was saying the name all wrong."

Laurelade speaks with a floaty dreaminess in her voice, "They really are changing. NPCs I mean. I've never seen one react to a mount."

I sigh. "Yeah, It's a whole new world."

The courtyard beyond the gate is decorated for a festival. Merchants sell wedges of watermelon, and burly smiths show off portable racks covered in

shields and arms. Somewhere ahead a minstrel plays a jaunty tune, and I see Havenfolk dancing, arm in arm with colored ribbons in their hair.

"Where do we go?" I ask.

Frobod points the opposite direction of the dancers. "Over there." There's a bright red and white banner with images of combatants sparring with shield and sword. I appreciate the way the game finds ways to convey meaning without the use of written or spoken language.

"Registration?" I ask.

Frobod says, "Looks like it."

We head over, and see a guy with pallid skin, uneven teeth, and a long, lumpy, pepper shaped nose. He says, "Name?" He has the voice of boredom.

We respond, "Melpomine."

"Frobod."

"Mirae."

"Tako."

Then, in a quieter voice I hear "Laurelade." coming from the gnome.

The man, Yrvril by his name plate, says "Event?" while staring down at a stack of papers.

We, Toxic Muffins, give each other sidelong looks, having not yet seen a list of competitions.

"Event?" Yrvril, repeats, in his nasal voice.

I say, "What event's are there to choose from?"

"The melee sets teams of five against one another in brackets until there's ultimately one winner. There's also archery, offensive magic, defensive magic, single combat, and the joust. Each invitation entitles you to join one solo event, and the melee. Winners take home a sack of gold, and may ask a favor of the keep."

"We're all good for the melee." I say. "...and I'll take single combat."

"Write your names." Yrvril says in a voice that suggests that doing his job is an annoyance, pushing two papers across the table.

"I'll do the joust." Frobod says.

"Offensive magic." Laurelade says.

Tako says, "Single combat."

Mirae says, "Archery."

Although we'd already worked out a plan ahead of time, part of me expected Mirae to try defensive magic, since she's our healer. Yrvril doesn't say anymore words for a time, but rather pushes the sign up sheet to each of us, before going back to reading his scroll.

"Looks like we might face off." I say to Tako, grinning. "No hard feelings when I kick your butt."

"You wish." He says, good humor in his voice.

With all of our names signed, Yrvril looks up and says, "Wait for the horn. The order of events is the Joust, Archery, Single Combat, Offensive Magic, Defensive Magic and then the Melee. You may all visit the keep's healers before each event to see that you are in good health, no augmentation spells are permitted except those which you cast yourself."

I ask, "Augmentation spells?"

"Buffs," Yrvril says, as if hating the word. "as you adventurers call them."

"Ah..." I say, and make a point to go through Jordan's spell list to find those dexterity and vitality buffs that I've become so acquainted with.

Yrvril says, "None of you will be killed while competing in the tourney, but you can be injured." For the first time he smiles. "With some of the spells I've seen over the years, you may find yourself wishing for death."

As soon as he says it, a buff appears in the top right hand corner of my vision.

Champion

Cannot be reduced to zero health.

Duration:

Until the end of Lord Zarentu's tournament.

Only active on the grounds of Dragonswood Keep.

We're all at full health, so we forego searching for the healers, but we do take the opportunity to scope out the grounds. My stomach growls. It surprises me so much that I stop walking. The rest of the group moves a few paces before realizing I'm lagging behind.

"Dude..." I say. "My stomach's growling."

Everyone else stops, and looks back to me.

"I didn't notice before," Mirae says, "But now that you mention it I'm hungry too."

Tako says, "Damn... Now I'm feeling it."

"We better eat something." Frobod says. "If this game's really all about the realism now, I don't want to fight on an empty stomach."

Laurelade says, "There's probably an inn."

"Ugh! But the flavor. How much tasteless crap am I going to have to consume to feel full?"

"I hate you." Mirae says, having been reminded of the shortcomings of Haven cuisine.

"This is gonna suck." Tako says.

Frobod says, "First lets find out how long we have until the first contest. I don't want to miss it. Then we'll find out where to eat."

The rumble in my stomach makes eating seem like the higher priority, but I can't fault Frobod's logic. He's first in the joust, and I know I'd kick myself if I missed the chance to compete on account of stuffing my face if I were in his position. I see a human girl with bright red hair and a green dress, the contrast between the two colors reminds me of a Christmas tree.

I try to snag her attention.

"Excuse me, Miss?" Her name's Ava, according to her name plate. We're a few paces away and she points her finger at her chest as if to say "Who me?" when I address her. I give her a nod, which makes her light up with a smile as she approaches.

"So nice to be talking to a Champion." She looks to Frobod and then to Tako, "...or dare I say a lot of them? How may I help you?"

"I .. uhh.. errr..." The sudden celebrity treatment catches me off guard; the Champion buff having unintended consequences. "Thank you. We were just wondering how much time we have before the joust starts, and the other events after that."

"The joust? Ye got some time. It's not for another couple of hours, and some minutes. After the joust, each events starts on the hour after that."

"Thanks." I say, "Can you tell us where the contests take place?"

"Oh." Ava says, "It's just over yonder." She waves her hand. "Ye can't miss it with all the banners. Just a couple minutes walk from here."

"Thank you... Ava." I say, she doesn't seem to notice that I know her name without her having told me.

She curtsies and says, "Glad to help."

Tako says, "Where can we get some food? We're starving."

Ava says, "Well, the feast won't be 'till after tourney, so if you're wanting some food before then you'll have to fend for yourself."

"There's no inn?" Frobod asks.

"I guess ye could go down into the village, but this keep is all Lord Zarentu's property. We don't have kitchens open to the public."

"I see." Frobod says, his voice sounding stoic.

"I've got a few recipes if we can get the ingredients. In fact," Mirae checks her VT, "I just need the meat. I can cook hares, hens, boar and pheasants."

Ava says, "Ye should be able to find the birds and rabbits in the woods outside here. Normally, I'd suggest going to the kitchen, but I hear they're swamped preparing for the feast this evening."

"Thanks..." I say. "We'll do that. You've helped a lot."

Ava curtsies again, "Always glad to be of service to Champions like yourselves."

I look to the others. "Looks like we're going hunting. Think you can manage?"

Mirae says, "I think we'll manage."

Frobod says, "Should be easy game."

Chapter 13 - Tastes Like Butt Crack

Archibald says, "Enjoy your ride on your Elechopits!" as we head back out the gate.

I mutter "Elechopper," but I don't think he hears me. In any case, we don't mount up because our destination is the forest which is within line of sight of the keep. It's lush and wonderful in a way that city folk like me rarely get to experience in the real world. It's a sad fact given that I live a half day's trip from the Olympic National Rainforest.

Once upon a time, gamers let real life experiences pass them by as they stared at computer monitors and TV screens for hours at the time. It now strikes me as funny that online gaming now opens people up to quasi-physical experiences that they might not have otherwise had.

We're moving along a dirt path that's wide enough for three of us to walk side by side. It winds its way through green trees that smell like damp earth and fallen leaves. It makes me feel calm and alert. I hear scattered birdsong and critters rustling above us.

A few minutes into the wood I stop and motion to our left where vegetation is so sparse that we don't have to worry about a lot of bushes in the understory hampering our way. Mirae and Tako both string longbows, whereas Laurelade readies her new wand from the Windroost. Frobod and I are basically guards in case monsters attack, he has his greatsword, and Bite's ready for business should we encounter anything more dangerous than our would be meal.

I say, "Let's go."

"We'll run ahead." Mirae says, and looks to Tako.

"Yeah, your loud asses will scare off all the animals before we can shoot."

Each cracking twig underfoot, and the clunking of Frobod's armor, makes me realize that Tako's right. It's amazing how much noisier we, well... not necessarily humans, but intelligent races are than our natural environment. Common prey is dumber than in the real world, so we're still likely to find something. If hunting in Haven is anything like Freeworld, there are higher difficulty creatures with bonus rewards for those who want a more authentic hunting experience. We won't see them today because Laurelade, Frobod and I are loud as fuck.

A wooden thwap-thunk sounds. As Tako loses an arrow and hits a tree instead of an animal. Mirae's weapon makes a similar thwap sound, but it's followed by the screams of a dying creature.

Mirae has killed Common Dragonswood Rabbit.

Thwap squeaaaaal.

TakoStar has killed Common Dragonswood Rabbit.

Thank you guildies, we now have brunch.

In the party chat Mirae says, "We've got two units of rabbit meat, but it's not enough for everyone. Let's keep looking."

When Laurelade says, "I'll get some birds," I realize that I haven't been hearing her little footsteps. I look down and discover that she's hovering a foot and a half off the ground. I give her an inquisitive look, and a ghost of the haughty gamer from our first dungeon enters her gaze as she says "Float. Immunity to fall damage." The look disappears after she speaks.

Mirae and Tako are now so far ahead that I can barely see them. Everything darkens, like mice in the shadow of an eagle. Thunder cracks. For a moment, we're blinded, and ozone fills the air. *It would've been nice to have some warning.* I hear pillowed thump-thumps after thump-crashing branches-thumps, all around like an uncanny rain. A charred black body drops inches from where I stand so I cover my head, and dash from beneath the tree.

Laurelade has killed Dragonswood Pheasant.
Laurelade has killed Dragonswood Pheasant.
Laurelade has killed Dragonswood Pheasant.
Laurelade has killed Dragonswood Pheasant

The announcement repeats some fifteen times. It's surreal. Charred avian bodies fall from the canopy like smoking bits of meteor. I bend down to check out one of the cracker stiff carcasses; it smells of burnt flesh and singed feathers.

"Overkill." Frobod says.

Laurelade checks the loot too, and says, "I didn't get any useable meat."

"Ya think?" I respond.

Frobod says, "Something's burning."

We look up. Waves of black smoke puff from the canopy, and small yellow and red flames wink between branches.

I say, "Don't burn down the whole forest! Quick! Use some water magic."

Laurelade waves her wand in an intricate pattern and sends a blast of liquid from its tip to the high branches.

I begin twirling Bite around me in preparation for casting the Freeworld martial arts version of the spell. Elemental power rises within as my staff spins fast, blurring into electric blue streaks of motion. I slam the end of it into the ground, and a torrent of water, as if from a waterfall crashes down from somewhere above my target. It doesn't last long, but it's enough to make the tree and all of our boots wet. Now each step makes a sucking squoosh sound, and there's thick mud underfoot.

Tako says in party chat, "What's going on over there?"

Frobod says, "Gnome tried to burn down the forest."

Tako says, "Noob."

"Do you need us?" Mirae asks.

"We're good." I respond.

The gnome sulks. "I usually have more control than that."

Frobod says, "Probably not the best idea to go hunting with fire and lightning. If anything use force bolts to preserve the meat."

TakoStar has killed Dragonswood Pheasant.

I say, "At least they're having luck."

Mirae has killed Common Dragonswood Rabbit.

"We've almost got enough." Mirae says over party chat. "You all should head back to the path and meet us outside the forest. Get a cook fire going so I can prepare the food when we're done."

"We're on it." I respond, feeling useless in the forest. I look to Frobod and Laurelade, and say, "Lets gather wood and head back."

Finding stuff to burn isn't hard. There are plenty of fallen branches, and dead leaves to serve as kindling. All three of us exit with arms full of dead wood. It occurs to me that not a one of us thought to stick it all into inventory. Something about being logged in for so long makes me forget about in-game conveniences like a magic bag that can hold a near endless number of items. We're starting to treat this place like the real world.

Outside Dragonswood, with the keep within line of sight Frobod makes a makeshift fire pit by digging a hole in the ground with a low level shield from his inventory, and placing a circle of stones around the perimeter. Once he's done, I make a teepee out of the kindling and about half the larger pieces we brought back.

"You want to light it?" I say to Laurelade, feeling confident that she's got a fire spell in her repertoire.

"Alright." She says, and flicks her wand at the fire pit.

Laurelade casts Cinderburst. Critical hit! Cook fire takes 16 points of damage.

My carefully constructed tee-pee explodes in a shower of burning parts. I narrowly dodge a hunk of fiery debris soaring right for my head by rolling to my side and pushing grass into my face. *Thank God for quick reflexes.*

"Really?" I say, feeling annoyed. "You thought a spell that could kill some monsters twice over was appropriate to start our fire?"

She says, "Sorry, I forgot to down rank. I used the maximum for my level."

"Why don't you just use Ignite? Tiny flame, the size of a lighter. In fact, it's probably best not to use anything with 'burst' in the title." Frobod gets up and gives our vicinity a once over, to make sure nothing else is burning. I call to him, "Grass okay?" He gives me a metal plated thumbs up.

Switching to party chat so I don't have to shout, I say "While you're up, do you mind getting some more wood?" Frobod doesn't say anything, but he gives me a double thumbs up before marching back into the forest.

Tako chimes in over party chat, "We're almost done. What happened?"

I say, using a little kids voice, "Campfire got all blown up."

Tako laughs, and says "Noobs."

I drop out of party chat and give Laurelade my attention.

Laurelade sighs and says, "My head's all stupid today. I'm not usually like this."

"I get it." I say. "This whole situation is messed up. I don't blame you for being stressed."

"Yeah." She says.

"I'm sorry I snapped at you. Just... try to be more focused."

"I'm used to doing everything at full damage. Outside of dungeons, quests, or whatever, I never cast spells. I'm not used to using them for mundane things like starting a simple fire."

"Well," I say. "No time to learn like the present. We're gonna be here a while, so I get the feeling that you'll be using magic for more than just killing monsters." While we talk, I build a new tee-pee with the last of our wood. "You want to try again, or do you want me to do it? I have Freeworld magic."

She says, "I'll do it." in a voice that suggests she's got something to prove.

I place the last of the wood in the fire pit, and say "Have at it."

This time, instead of casting a spell which, by definition, causes an explosion of fire the gnome extends her small hand, which ignites in a glow of flame.

Laurelade casts Burning Palm.

It's not the spell I anticipated, but it's much better than what she used before. She presses her hand to the side of my construction until it's set ablaze. "Much better." I say, and give her a small encouraging smile. "You might want to go over your spell list in case they ask for precision over brute force in the magic contest."

She gives me a begrudging "Yeah," displeased to be taking advice from someone she considers to be inferior on the Haven side of the game. I don't blame her, she is more experienced when it comes to Haven magic.

A few minutes later I see Frobod heading out of the forest with Tako and Mirae in tow. They must have bumped into each other while he was gathering. His arms are filled with dead twigs and branches, but neither of them seem to be carrying anything. They must not have forgotten about their inventory like we did.

When the trio is within earshot, I say "What do ya got for us?"

Mirae says, "Four units of rabbit meat and two pheasants." She plops down beside us, and digs through her magic backpack for her cooking supplies. Before long, she's got a makeshift grill, and a copper pan warming over the fire. She asks, "Who wants a bird?"

"Doesn't matter." Frobod says. "It all tastes the same anyway."

I ask, "If it all tastes like nothing, why did you bother with cooking?"

Mirae says, "At higher levels you get buffs that last an hour or two. I'm not that advanced yet."

"Bummer." I say, "But I'm glad you have the skill."

Mirae decides to start with the rabbit, by putting a hunk of it in the copper pan with a pouch of herbs. She takes out her VT, taps at the interface, and the Rabbit magically transforms from raw meat, into a fine smelling meal. Like in Freeworld, whenever you collect animal meat in your inventory, the game

automatically removes the skin, bones, and all the organs. In the case of fowl, all the feathers disappear.

She passes it to Frobod, "You can have it since your competing first."

"Thanks" he says, removing his gloves so he can eat with his fingers.

"How's it taste?" I ask.

"Like a mouth full of air."

While Mirae goes about preparing the rest of the meals Tako pokes a hole through an extra piece of rabbit with his dagger, and then skewers it with a stick. He holds it under the grill, directly in the fire as if scorching a marshmallow.

"What are you doing?" I ask.

"Just messing around. Maybe it'll give me the cooking skill."

It doesn't take long for Mirae to prepare the rest of the rabbit and two pheasants, since they're ready at the touch of a button. I feel full, and my stomach stops growling, but I find myself sorely wishing the game would taste as good as it smells. If we're stuck in here forever... I don't even want to think about it. I don't know how to live without good food.

Tako pulls his stick out of the fire to reveal a hunk of blackened meat that's actually burning. I didn't even know that could happen. He holds it in front of his face, as if looking for something on the surface. Not finding whatever he's looking for he gives up, and blows the flame out causing a puff of white smoke. He eyes it, again, giving it a chance to cool down before stuffing the charred bit in his mouth.

His eyes widen, and then pinch shut. His face contorts as if someone stuck a turd under his nose, until he gags, and spits the rabbit into the dirt.

"Looks delicious." I say.

Tako doesn't respond, instead raising his water skin to his lips. He gulps huge amounts of liquid. By now, all of us are staring.

"What's up with you?" Mirae says.

Gasping for air, as he hadn't taken a breath in the entire time it took him to drain his skin. "Tastes..." He gasps... "Tastes...." Gasp. "Like butt crack."

"Huh?" Frobod says.

Tako laughs. "It tastes like butt crack!" The rest of us exchange confused looks. "It tastes..." he puts a heavy emphasis on the second word. "Like butt crack!"

"What do you mean?" Laurelade says.

"Exactly what I said! It's fucking horrible! You should try it!"

Mirae picks up on the implications before any of us do, and asks "Do you have any more meat?"

Tako says "Yeah.." and hands her a partial portion.

She repeats the steps he took to prepare it, save that she takes the rabbit off the flame before it looks like a lump of char coal.

"You're not going to believe this." Mirae says. "It has flavor."

Chapter 14 - Zoom Zoom

Although we'd all like to have spent more time killing rabbits, and trying to cook them, we decide to head back to Dragonswood Keep so we don't miss the joust.

Archibald says, "Welcome back champions." while Lyle gives us the stink eye. Part of me wonders what kind of riot I'd have caused if I'd signed up for one of the magic contests with all my Freeworld spells.

The festive grounds are much the same as when we arrived with, perhaps, more people. A few look like players, but Havenfolk make the bulk of the crowd.

"Place your bets. Place your bets!" A weasel faced human calls from the side. He wears a purple top hat, and an unbuttoned tuxedo jacket, with a careless unkempt undershirt. Even his hair peeking out from under the brim looks nasty. His nameplate says "Sleeve." *Nice name.*

I ask, "Can champions place a wager?"

He looks me up and down, and cracks his knuckles peeking out of ratty fingerless gloves. "So you're the unarmored half-elf in single combat. You don't look like a wizard... but no one with the Monastery's ever heard of you."

I ask, "Is that good or bad?"

He chortles and says, "We'll see, my dear, we'll see."

I say, "About a wager."

Sleeve says, "I'll take bets for any event you're not participating in. Your coin's as good as another."

"Minimum bets?" I ask.

Sleeve says, "Fifty silver."

"... and the max?"

The nasty little man's eyes brighten, "How much coin can you leave?"

"Let me think on it." I say, "I'll get back to you later."

An idea's been brewing since we got back, and I don't want to let the bookie on. I turn to our death knight and say, "A word?" He nods, the presence of the keep paired with the looming joust makes him more serious. I look to the others and say, "You guys good for a while?"

Tako says, "Yes, mom."

Followed by Laurelade, "It's a free country."

Mirae says, "Yeah, see you at the joust."

I say, "Good." and lead Frobod by the arm.

"What's this about?" He asks.

I glance over my shoulder to make sure we're not followed.

Spotting.

Perception + Vigilance. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 10)

"I don't *think* anyone's following."

You have gained +1 Vigilance.

Current Rating: 9

I see people dancing and laughing, but there appear to be no stalkers. Even so, I walk a good minute before I respond. "How much do you want to win?"

Frobod says, "I want it."

"That's not good enough." I say, "We'll probably get credit for the quest whether we win or lose. The only thing that might change is the reward."

"Rewards." Frobod echoes.

"Limited Edition."

He says, "You don't have to remind me."

There's a canvas tent for what looks like face painting, with just a few artists near the front. I lead Frobod behind the back to escape the crowd. I say, "Drop the party."

**Frobod has left the party.
You have left the party.**

**Do you want to invite Frobod to join your party?
Yes / No**

I choose yes.

Frobod has joined your party.

Now it's just me and him. It's a time for party chat if I've ever seen one.

"This is so cloak and dagger." Frobod says in the party chat. "What's up?"

"What if I told you I had a way to give you a significant advantage in the joust?"

"You mean like buffs, or OP hacking Dev stuff?"

"I'm not a hacker." I say, "It's all by the rules."

"Remember," Frobod says. "No buffs unless you cast them yourself."

"It's not a buff."

I take a deep breath, because even though I know what I'm about to propose is by the rules, I also know that when it happens everyone around us is going to lose their shit. If we could still contact customer service, I guarantee at least a dozen players would report me for hacking.

"So what is it?" Frobod says.

"Archibald and Lyle have seen your Etherchopper. Technically it's mine, but they don't know that, and nothing in the rules state that you have to use your own mount."

"Right..." He says, I can almost see gears behind his eyes turning.

"Were you planning to use your own?" I ask.

"I could, but I get the feeling that you've got other ideas."

"I do." I say, and take a deep breath. "I'm willing to bet that thanks to Lyle and Archibald half the town knows about our Elechoppers, and will expect us to use them. Alien magics and all that."

"Yeah, so..." He says, "I don't see the advantage. It's not like we're flying."

I say, "Six-hundred percent... ground speed." I weight every word.

Frobod goes a little pale, and then a grin spreads across his face. "Holy fuck."

"Right now the Etherchopper is cloning the stats of a Nightmare. 250% ground speed, and 650% air speed." I say, "I've got Freeworld mounts. In just a few taps, I can turn your ride into a road ripping monster."

"Do it." he says, not even a moment's hesitation.

"You're not worried about being accused of cheating?"

"Fuck cheating." Frobod says, "It's by the rules."

I say, "That was easier than I thought."

"Look, if this were still a game, maybe I'd be second guessing. I'd feel bad for the other guys that don't stand a chance, but this is our fucking lives now, and there's a logout button out there just waiting to be discovered. Fuck... I mean seriously fuck me... If I'd realized this before I'd have said we should all do the joust. Even you, getting knocked off your bike after one hit from a baby dragon." That last part is spoken in good humor, as for the second time today, a huge smile crosses his face. It's a look that sets the inside of my chest aflutter.

"Yeah well... I didn't think of it until I saw the bookie."

"Too bad." Frobod says.

"Well, it's an easy win for you. Which brings me to the next topic; I want to place a bet. Let's go see Sleeve, and to the arena and soup up your ride."

"You devil." Frobod says, "You're going to take all his money, aren't you?"

"He has gross hair." I say, as if that were somehow justification. "... and like you said, it's by the rules."

Back to Sleeve, I smile and say "On the joust, a thousand gold for the death knight to win."

"Oh my..." the little man fidgets, steepling knobby knuckled little fingers. "You are ambitious. Wouldn't you prefer one of the dragons? They're long lived with far more experience than a mere... human." He speaks the word like a bad omen.

I say, "Frobod, in the joust, for first place."

He scoffs and says, "It's your money. I'll give you one to one odds on that."

"I thought you said it was a long shot, because he's just... human." I make sure to imitate his derisive tone.

"Two to one then." I give him an 'Oh please' look.

"Why don't the two of you step into my office?" he motions to a tent I hadn't seen before.

"Sure thing." I say, Frobod follows.

Inside, there are a number of locked chests, and a couple of huge shirtless ogres with grey skin, overalls, and veiny biceps that look like boulders. I could easily imagine either one of these guys breaking heads if anyone sought unauthorized access to the trunk's contents. Sleeve sits down at a makeshift wooden table, and opens up a ledger that's as tall as my forearm.

"The best I can do is 3:1 odds with that much money. Take it or leave it."

"Done." I say, and begin fishing the coin out of my bottomless bag. They're presorted in small sacks containing 100 gold each. Sleeve looks them over, fishes a coin out, and then bites it as if it were even possible to counterfeit money in Haven Online. *Is it?* He dumps all the coins out on a scale to confirm the amount.

Sleeve makes a note in his book, and says "Confirm that all is correct and make your mark."

I read "Joust. Frobod. First place. 3:1. 1000g. Melpomine." and do as instructed. An alias's mark, is like a rubber stamp that's generated by the game that is unique to them, and is used in all contract transactions. As soon as it's made, your inventory receives a copy of the document to which it's applied as a record of the transaction.

"Uh..." Frobod says, "200 on Melpomine in single combat." I give him a look, and he says "I'm not as rich as you."

He's totally missed the point. I'm not angry that he only bet 200 gold on me, I'm flattered that he thought to risk any coin at all.

"Thanks." I say, at a loss for words. He's never even seen me fight without armor.

"That'll be two to one odds on the half-elf." Sleeve says. "Make your mark."

Frobod does so, and seals the deal. He says, "If you lose, you can pay me back with your big fat winnings."

"I'll try not to disappoint."

"Yes... yes... Now, get out of here." His tone is less friendly than when he first approached us. I get the sense that if we win he'll be wiped out.

As we leave the tent he pulls a strap which unfurls a canvas painted sign that says, "Closed for bets until next horn." An idle part of me wonders if native French, or Chinese speakers see the text in their own language.

I pull out my VT, and pull up the interface for Frobod's Etherchopper, and tap to clone one of my faster Freeworld Mounts.

Would you like to apply movement speed from Boom Buggy, to Elechopper (DE).

Yes / No

I tap yes.

Deciding that Frobod and I should be a pair I also switch over the stats for the Firechopper.

Would you like to apply movement speed from Boom Buggy, to Elechopper (DE).

Yes / No

Now we're a set. Tap the summon button to call Frobod's bike, which appears in a quick flash of grey-violet. I wave my middle finger and shout "INFERNO!!!" To call my bike in a pulse of red. Both roar their introductions.

A wave of chatter sweeps the crowd, as we straddle our rides, and I rev up the engine sending plumes of fire out my exhaust. Fortunately, it won't burn anything. I know, because I made it. These aren't weaponized vehicles. I hear a few condemning exclamations of "Alien magic," but the vast majority of people react in cries of "Ooooh," "Ahhh," and Wows" of wonder.

The one man whose face is completely unlike the rest is Sleeve who sputters in indignation. "That's your mount? I tell you, they'll never allow it. Alien magics, in the Lord's tourney! You've good as forfeited your coin."

I smile, a mischievous glint in my eye, "Is it against the rules?"

"I... uh.. You... gah! It can't be! It's never been done."

I wink at the man, and say "Make sure you have my coin."

Sleeve is beside himself, as I hear him going on about, "I heard rumors... but who could believe? They can't allow it! Certainly not. Our fighters have the finest steeds in the land."

We both rev our engines so we don't have to listen to his babble.

"Shall we head to the arena?" I ask.

"Let's." Frobod says.

I catch a last look at Sleeve in my rear view mirror, and want to feel bad for him, but don't. I would if he were a normal player, with a real world body and real world time sacrificed to this game. As it is, Sleeve and his boxes of gold are just lines of code, that are about to make me and my guild a lot richer.

Day two post update, and we're still the only crew with Elechoppers in Haven. We limit our speed to 200% ground speed and we ride through the crowd. Anything faster would be dangerous, and to be honest, I don't want to spoil the surprise. Everywhere we go Havenfolk point, and express their amazement. Occasionally I catch snippets of "What the fucks?" which tells me that there are at least some adventurers mixed in. We're always too far gone, for me to connect the voices of strangers with their faces.

A horn sounds as we pull up to the arena, it's exactly where Ava said.

A herald in a conical helm like the front guards announces "Joust to start in fifteen minutes!" A long banner featuring a golden dragon wreathed in flame dangles from his horn.

I'm surprised to see a pair of stable boys, no older than twelve or thirteen, scurrying our direction.

One by the name of Sten says, "Champions!" as they run toward us. He has round eyes and big bat-like ears that are too large for his head. Not completely human, so I guess he's some sort of half breed. They skid to a stop just in front of our front wheels kicking a cloud of dry dirt in to the air. "We have to take your mounts to the mages, before it's too late."

Sten's wholly human companion, named Pert, says "Uhh... There's no reigns."

I say, "Well, I'm not jousting, but he needs to go. Why don't you hop on, and show us the way."

The boys exchange looks of wide eyed excitement. Pert squeaks, something that sounds like "Really?" *Ahh.. The joys of puberty.*

I pat the seat behind me and say, "There's room for two. Frobod and I can each take one."

With shit eating grins, Pert and Sten slap each other high tens and shout "Awesome!" in unison. I'm taken aback by the slang. Havenfolk kids must be paying closer attention to adventurers than adults.

I help them on to the back of our bikes, as Pert says "By-the-Gods.... The others are never gonna believe this. We're on the mounts! Real life Elechopits!"

He's speaking so fast I say, "Don't forget to breathe... And it's Elechoppers." I get the feeling I have Archibald to thank for this.

They look to each other, and repeat "Elechoppers" like enthusiastic students in class. The way they're always speaking in unison, I'd say they were twins if not for Sten's big ears, and Pert's lack thereof.

Sten says, "Over there the gate's open. You can go right in and ride across the grounds without having to worry about people. The mages are over there." He points to the far left corner of the ring.

"Got it." I say, and pull into the arena through a half open gate. It looks like we'll be fighting on hard packed dirt, which suits me just fine. I'd been meaning to save our mounts' speed as a surprise for Frobod's first match, but something inside me melts a little upon seeing the big eared kid behind Frobod's delighted expression. I think, *"I don't have to spoil the whole party."* and say "Want to go fast?"

They answer with a chorus of "Yeah!"

Frobod gives me a look and I say, "Three hundred percent." He nods.

"Hold on tight." I say, and make sure Pert's arms are gripped tight around me. I can feel him quivering in excitement. I say "One... Two... Three... Go!" and gun it. We spring from zero to faster than the fastest ground mount in Haven in under a second. In the air behind me, I hear Pert scream in delight.

"That was awesome!" He says as I slow down at the far end of the arena.

I think, *"Wait until you see six hundred percent kid."* and say "I'm glad you enjoyed it."

Frobod's right behind me, sending aurora streams of ether in his wake. By the sounds the big eared kids making, he's having just as much fun. They both dismount on their own, and ask "Can we do it again?"

"Boys!" They're interrupted by a sharp voice belonging to an elderly half-elf with a long white beard, and grey and violet robes. They both go silent, and slink off to tend to stable duties. "Champions, you have my apologies for their behavior."

Frobod says, "Don't worry about it."

I say, "No need to apologize." I pause, looking the half-elf over, another named NPC called Aztram, and take him for a mage. "What's this you need to do with our mounts?"

"Ahh, yes..." He says, "As you know riding beasts.... or..." He looks our bikes over "other conveyances come in a variety of shapes and sizes. It's common practice to cast enlargement or minimization spells as needed to ensure that all are approximately the same size. Your ... Elechopits?" he says in a questioning tone.

"Elechoppers." *Thank you Archibald.*

"Yes Elechoppers... ride closer to the ground than the average steed, so it would be unfair to set them, in their current state against someone riding a great elephant. It's unlikely that either parties lances would be able to connect, and thus we use magic to equalize the size. The effects are temporary, and will be dispelled at the conclusion of the joust."

"I get it." Frobod says. "Do what you've got to do. She's not jousting, but she is my companion."

I say, "Haven has elephant mounts?"

"Yeah." Frobod says, "They're from the far east. It's a crazy rep grind."

"I ahh.." Aztram says, "Am unfamiliar with how to move your conveyance, so if you don't mind can you accompany me to the stables? The lady is welcome to come too."

"Lead the way." I say, and wheel our bikes behind him.

The stable is a curious place with at least a dozen waiting animals. Most are horses, but there's also demons like the Nightmare, riding tigers, a broom, and a crazy shark looking thing with four eyes, a dorsal fin, and powerful hairless legs that remind me of a great cat.

"If you place your mount here, and saddle up we'll be started..."

Frobod wheels his bike a few paces beside the shark-tiger... thing... It shakes his head and snorts at him, a high pitch gush of air hissing through its shark mouth. It's an intimidating specimen, but as a player mount, it shouldn't attack anyone.

Frobod sits on the seat and asks, "What do I do?"

"For now, nothing. Just sit." Aztram murmurs syllables in an indiscernible language, and tendrils of white magic rise from his finger tips. He moves around the bike as he chants, waving his glowing fingers all around it, much the same as I'd imagine a person in the real world trying to bathe in the smoke of incense sticks. Now, standing in front of the headlight, he makes a four fingered 'come here' motion with his hand. Each time he does, the bike grows a little taller. He checks from another angle, and realizes that Frobod's sitting a bit higher than the other mounts. He makes a pushing motion, and the bike gets smaller. 'Come here' and the height of the seat creeps up again.

"There." The mage says. "How does that feel?"

Frobod looks down, "Surprisingly good. I'm a lot farther off the ground, but the physical sensation is about the same as before."

I say, "That's magic for you."

"As it should be." Aztram says.

Frobod asks, "What does it look like?"

"Bigger wheels, bigger everything. It's strange to see." Looking down at the other mounts, I realize that while their heads may be at different heights, the saddles on each are all on a level.

Frobod asks, "Will this change the way it handles?"

Aztram shakes his head no. "It'll all feel exactly the same, because, so far as you're concerned, nothing has changed."

Frobod says, "I don't get it."

I say, "Dude... Sometimes you've gotta let shit slide. It all works out because..."

Frobod finishes the sentence. "Magic."

Aztram says, "Not many adventurers take the time to learn this kind of magic. Most of your lot are so concerned with blowing things up. There's far more to the art than destruction." He sighs, as if knowing his words are falling on deaf ears.

"Well," I say, "That's usually what's most useful in dungeons, but don't give up. I have a feeling you're going to have a lot more students looking to expand their skill set in the coming months."

"You're very kind." Aztram says, "But I'm old enough now that I won't believe it until I see it."

"Are you a teacher?" I ask.

"Oh, I suppose I could be persuaded to take on an apprentice, if the right individual came along."

Quest - Master and Apprentice

Difficulty: Moderate

Aztram has hinted that he may accept a worthy student. Impress him, and gain instruction.

Objectives:

Gain a personal reputation of Respected with Aztram.

Ask to become his student.

Rewards:

Title: Apprentice

Magical Tutor

Instruction in Arcane magic.

Do you accept? Yes / No

"I'm not sure." I say, having not expected this conversation to spawn a quest. "Do I have to decide now? I haven't given much thought to learning magic in Haven."

Aztram laughs. "Come back in your own time. So long as you haven't done anything to disgrace yourself, and I'm still living, we'll broach the topic again."

I tap no, and say "Thank you. Master Aztram. I'll keep that in mind." I give him a respectful bow, befitting a man who devoted his entire life to cultivating, and sharing the Arcane arts.

You have gained 500 personal reputation with Aztram.

Current level. Friendly.

Frobod says, "You get a quest or something?"

"Yeah." I say, "Just in case I want to learn Haven magic."

Aztram says, "The competition is about to start. Frobod, you come with me, and for the lady, feel free to sit in the gold box during the event. All champions are entitled a seat, though some choose not to come until their events, or choose to watch with the common folk."

"Thank you." I say.

Aztram says, "It's right outside."

I look to Frobod and say "Drop party, so we can rejoin the others." While typing a text message in my VT.

You have joined Mirae's party.

Frobod says. "She just sent me the invite.

Frobod has joined the party.

Using party chat I say, "Guys come to the right side of the arena beside the place the nobles sit. Champions get their own box."

Tako says, "Way ahead of you. We're already here, where are you?"

I say, "We're in the stable. I'll be right up."

I head out the same way we came in, taking a look at all the mounts. I'm not worried about the competition, but if I had to guess all the equines belong to Havenfolk, and the flashier creatures like the land-shark, magic broom, and perhaps the demon horse will be ridden by adventurers. The demonic horse snorts a puff of black soot from it's nostrils, it has faintly glowing red eyes, and predatory wolf teeth. I say "You don't scare me, big boy."

The regular horses are remarkably calm given the presence of carnivores around them. They're either well trained, or this is just one more example of things that work in Freehaven, that wouldn't happen in real life.

Outside, I see Tako and Mirae sitting together, with Laurelade off to the side. With her short legs unable to touch the ground, she looks like a baby in an expensive medieval costume. *Gnomes... At least the men often have facial hair.*

I sit next to Mirae, who affectionately rests her head on my shoulder for a second, before perking up saying "This is going to be so cool!" She claps her hands.

"What's with all the sneaky sneaky?" Tako asks.

I smile. "Oh nothing. We just talked strategy for the joust."

Tako says, "Did you make any bets?"

"Yeah." I said, "A thousand gold, on Frobod."

"Dayum girl! You must be some kind of rich. Is that to place?"

I shake my head no, "To win, and yeah, it was about a quarter of my fund."

Tako bends forward, so we can talk around Mirae. "What kind of odds did he give you?"

"Three to one." I say.

"You got robbed. I mean, I'm sure Frobod's good and all, but this is a limited edition competition. I would have demanded at least five."

Mirae says, "I didn't think NPCs were supposed to do that."

"Do what?" I ask.

"Cheat you." She says.

"It's as good as he would go, and I'm not worried. Frobod is going to destroy them."

"What did you do?" Tako says, suspicion growing in his voice.

"Nothing illegal. I promise, it's all by the rules, but boy are they going to be surprised."

"Is he using the bike?" Tako asks.

"You're damn right he is."

Mirae, shakes both of our shoulders, and points to the center of the grounds. A parade of sixteen humanoid warriors enter the grounds. Frobod, looking like a badass in his Deadplate, is positioned a third from the end. Just as Mirae says, "It's starting!" the herald blows his horn.

People cheer.

There's a raised wooden stage for nobility where Lord Zarentu sits his throne. With pale white skin, and long hair the color of bleached straw, his dark cape, and military garb are a stark contrast, giving him the air of a spectral commander from ancient Rome. He raises a white hand to the crowd, and shouts quiet.

Another herald, with a magically enhanced voice says, "Welcome to the tournament of Dragonswood Champions." Another roar of applause. He says, "Kneel." all of the champions, including Frobod do as they are told. "Fight with honor. Let the games begin!"

All of the jousters, stand, and make brisk pace to the stables. I can hear them jostling around behind us, along with the stirring of mounts, equine and exotic alike. Then, out of nowhere the land shark leaps over the wall of the arena carrying a rider that's almost blinding to behold. He's got bright platinum armor, and practically every cosmetic silver, or white aura imaginable dancing around him. There's a sunburst halo effect, insubstantial leaves that continually drop around his person, and even a lambent stir of snow flurries.

"A Sametora!" Mirae says, clapping her hands in delight.

"A what?" I ask.

"It's like a great white with legs. You should have one if you didn't sell it."

"In fact..." I say, "I think I do, but never summoned."

"They're awesome." Mirae confirms. "You can ride on the land, and into the sea."

The rider, a adventurer by the name of Payneskill, thrusts his lance in the air as he makes a lap around the arena. The crowd is full of "Oohs" and "Ahhs" for the mount. Each time the rider stops, the shark shakes its head, as if ripping apart a kill.

Tako says, "What a wanker."

"You know him?" I ask.

"That guy's a douche." Tako says, "A total cockwomble, credit card player that thinks that just because he's got practically every vanity item in the game he actually knows how to play. He's an officer in the Leroy Jensen fan club, so that should tell you something."

Mirae says, "Some of them are pretty good tanks."

"Not this one." Tako says.

The Leroy Jensen Fan Club, is a guild of players devoted to the professional gamer known as Leroy Jensen. He only plays tanks, and has a reputation for holding agro on ridiculously large pulls, while relying on an army of healers to keep him at full health. They're an obnoxious bunch, because they like to call out the name "Leeeeerooooooooooyyy Jennnnnnsssseeeen" with a little growl in the middle as their battle cry, public greeting, or goodbye.

Just as the thought comes to mind, I hear him shout "Leeeerooooooyyy Jennnnnsen!"

Tako says, "What a tool."

The herald, with his magically enhanced voice says, "Our first contestant is Payneskill," he pronounces it 'pain skill,' "Paladin of Gond God of Justice - Officer of the Leroy Jensen Fan Club."

Tako cups his hands and shouts "Penis kill!" he pauses, and emphasizes his pronunciation "PAY-nes Kill! Woooo!! Go cock chop!"

The platinum knight stirs, and looks around from within his closed helm, trying to locate the source of the insult. The herald on the other hand consults the scroll he'd been reading from and says "Penis kill? Is that right?" He speaks, at what would have been at a conversational volume if not for the amplification magic on him. Havenfolk, and players laugh.

Tako says, "Classic!"

The herald, named Brime by his name plate says, "My humble apologies." He pauses as if embarrassed to say the adventurers name "Our first contestant is Pay-nes Kill, Officer of the Leroy Jensen Fan club."

Tako guffaws, and says "Priceless! God, I wish I was recording."

We hear a tin-can shout from inside Payne's helm, but I can't make out the words. He awkwardly tumbles off the back of the sametora, and marches directly toward the noble's platform. He shout's something again, but all I get is muffled tin-can echo.

Finally, he takes off his helm, and throws it with two hands into the dirt, revealing a boyish face, with short black hair that looks like it might have been cut at home with kitchen scissors. He also has a little goatee, the kind a sixteen year old might grow to convince people that he was over twenty-one. *It's not happening.*

"It's Pain Skill! I'm a tank! God! You people are fucking morons!"

He kicks is own helm, which I'm amused to see causes a shower of dirt to pour inside, before he flips it over and sets it back on top of his own head.

"So sorry." Herald Brime says. "Pain-Skill. Will you please remount? We'd like to get started."

Payne raises his faceplate, which makes Tako laugh even harder, since clearly, he had forgotten to use it. Even I'm getting the chuckles.

Payneskill says, "Yes! God. I'm going. Just hurry up." Before dropping the metal plate back down over his face.

Brime says, "Thank you." as Payne pulls himself back on top of his mount. then in a more dramatic voice says, "And his challenger..... Nothgoran, consort to Raika, defender of the Windroost!"

An otherworldly whinny sounds, as the soot poofing demon horse leaps into the arena huffing hard, and exhaling clouds of thick ash from its nostrils. I'm quickly learning only lamers use open gates. The frightening dragon warrior pumps his black lance high over head, swinging it around as if it weighs nothing. Zarentu and Nothgoran could not be more unlike. While Zarentu has proud chiseled features, that look very much human, Nothgoran has black skin, bare slits for a nose, and a mouth full of wicked dragons fangs. I'd bet that even his skin would be scaled, if given the chance to touch it.

I say, "I wonder if he remembers us from the Windroost."

Mirae asks, "Were NPCs smart back then?"

"I hope not." I say, "Remembering dungeons means recalling a whole lot of deaths."

"Are you defending him?" Tako asks.

"I'm not, not really. I just mean... What does it do to a person to remember that many deaths?"

For the first time the Gnome inserts herself in the conversation. "There not people, remember. They're just NPCs."

"Besides," Mirae says, "I've died lots of times. We all have. None of us have become psychopaths, or whatever you're afraid of."

"I guess." I say, "I'm just waxing philosophical."

In truth, somehow part of me assumes that the death and violence of Freehaven were more real for Havenfolk, somehow closer to what we'd feel to experience them in the real world, now that they've been upgraded, but now thinking on Mirae's comments I wonder if that's the case. I've died more times than I can count between Freeworld and Haven, and don't feel any less human.

By now, Nothgoran and Payneskill are facing off at either end of a long divide. Brime says, "You know the rules. Five passes. You'll be disqualified if you're unhorsed. Striking your opponent's mount gives you negative five points, and incapacitating it results in your instant disqualification. Plus five points for the target, plus one for a touch, two for a break, and three for a shatter."

Mirae explains, before I have a chance to ask. "You see the extra red plate on their armors? That's the target. A simple touch to the other rider gives one point, breaking the tip off the lance gives two points, and shattering a lance gives three more."

"Thanks." I say. "Who do you think will win?"

Tako says, "Nothgoran will wipe the floor with him."

At first I wasn't so sure, but after seeing that whole name and kicking dirt into his own helm debacle, I'm with Tako. *What a gomer.*

Payneskill shouts "Leeeroooooyyy Jenssssen!" before slapping down his face guard and making the first pass. Lances crack, Payne's nearly off of his horse, and shards of wood go flying. The adventurer is just barely able to hold on as his body's pummeled. A squire hands Nothgoran a new lance, which he raises high over head, with the crowd shouting.

Tako says, "Chop his dick! Pay-nes kill!" The platinum knight seems not to notice.

The next pass begins with another cry of "Leeeroooooy Jennnsseen!" and this time Payne makes a better showing. His lance breaks, but slams into Nothgoran well off target. Neither rider's even close to being unhorsed. The mounts stir, and both knights reach down for new lances. I hadn't noticed before, but now see that it's big eared Sten servicing the adventurer. I wonder if Pert's down at the other end.

"Leeeroooooy Jensen!"

That's all we hear before a massive CRACK and Payneskill's flying back, butt and feet over head. He does a face plant in the hard dirt at the conclusion of his painful back flip. Nothgoran pumps his black fist in the air to the delight of an

enraptured crowd. Meanwhile, a duo of healers, in green and gold robes rush to the fallen player spinning golden haloed spells of mending magic.

"Hey Mirae." I ask.

"Mmm?"

"Why are their spells gold, when yours are green?" I ask.

"They're using different magic. I use the nature stuff."

She says, "That color gold is either light or divine magic. I'd say light since Zarentu's a light dragon."

"Makes sense."

Herald Brime says, "Round 1 goes to Nothgoran. Payneskill," this time he says it right, "Has been eliminated."

There are a few boos in the crowd, but overall Havenfolk favor the dragon. It's predictable considering this is a dragon event.

"Our next contender is Lady Ashtara of South Reach, consort to Lord Jamirine."

Unlike the first two contestants, Ashtara thunders through the open gate on a swift palomino warhorse in full armor. Silken black hair whips behind her like a banner.

"Is she a dragon?" I ask.

Mirae says, "In human form. They're all dragons unless they're players."

When she loops back around from her introduction lap, I admire her smooth chocolate skin, human, and so unlike the sooty black of Nothgoran.

"They certainly come in all forms." I say.

Mirae says, "The more bestial ones are generally less favorably inclined toward humanity, or they're just really proud of their reptilian heritage."

"So why are they all cheering?" I ask.

"Not everyone here is human." Mirae says. "... and a strong fighter is a strong fighter whatever they think of humans." Mirae waves her hand, "They're all here for a show."

Ashtara settles in at Sten's side of the arena. Her mount swishes its tale behind her. Brime says, "And her competitor, hailing from Dragonswood Keep," the crowd cheers, this must be a local celebrity, "Knight of Dragonswood and Lord Zarentu's court, Sir Troooooogon!"

A pinto stallion gallops in, baring a rider in Evergreen colored plate, and a white and gold tabard featuring the dragon and flame crest of Zarentu's house. I can't see whether or not he has a scaled face due to his helm, with long, black, feathered plumage. He salutes Ashtara as he draws nearer, and she responds with a half bow from horseback. He circles around, and takes his place in Nothgoron's former position.

The match is a lengthy one, consisting of five passes, and neither rider being unhorsed. Much, to the disappointment of the local crowd, Ashtara proves the victor, by a margin of three points. Trogon, congratulates the Lady of South Reach and graciously accepts his defeat. The crowd cheers for him one last time, as he raises his open plated hand to them, and departs the arena.

"And for our next match, hailing from Athelon," Herald Brime says. Mirae nudges me in the ribs. "Member of the Toxic Muffins, we have Frobo!"

The roar of Etherbike engine fills my ears.

"Frobod!" Mirae says,
I shout, "Wooooo!"

Laurelade's silent, but Tako starts in on a chorus of "Muffins! Muffins! Muffins! Muffins!"

Our death knight, in Deadplate armor enters the arena, on his now oversized Elechopper. I'm pleased to see that he caps his speed at two hundred percent as he does his introductory lap. If I were him, I'd be popping wheelies, but I guess his mind's more focused on winning than showing off. Still, I appreciate the ghostly streamers of pale light pouring out his exhaust where my bike would be spouting flame.

The crowd's reaction is as varied as it was while riding through town, sure there are cheers, most notably from a red headed woman in the front row in a green dress, but far more common are the kind of "Wows" you'd expect at a New Year's firework display, with just a few grumbles about alien magic.

My eyes dart back to Zarentu to measure his reaction, having set himself against the other-world dragon of our quest. He scratches his beardless face with thumb and forefinger in contemplation, though he does not seem displeased.

I say, "Looks like my gold's safe for now." as I gesture at him for Mirae's benefit. "If he were going to disqualify Frobod, now would be the time."

"I'd say he's intrigued." says Mirae.

"Of course he is." Tako says, "He's a dragon, whose just found a new toy."

Frobod takes his position without ceremony, though the beaming face of the big eared squire tells me that he's overjoyed to be serving the owner of an Elechopper. I'm glad for him. Even though they're just NPCs, I find myself endeared by the amiable ones, unlike Sleeve whose about to lose a lot of money.

Brime says, "And his opponent. The North Wind, consort to Viranda, and two time reigning champion, Lord Xephros!"

The crowd goes wild, as a knight riding a white horse bursts into the arena. I'd thought it was an ordinary steed, but in the wake of it's passage, I see bright magical footprints that burn with golden fire. The marks fade in just a few seconds.

"Tough break." Tako says. "I mean, being set against the reigning champion on his first match."

"I'm not worried." I say. "Just watch."

Tako shrugs.

Xephros drinks in the applause, each cheer puffing him up a bit more, an adoration vampire. His full plate is the color of sky and clouds on a beautiful day like today. From what I can see within his raised face guard. He's got angular features like an elf, and light peach skin that seems otherwise human. I think, *"He must be one of the friendly ones."*

The squires distribute lances. The etherbike roars it's challenge. It happens so fast that I'd need an instant replay in the real world. One moment, lances are leveled, the next, hoof beats are drowned in the growl of magical engine. Shards of Frobod's weapon go flying, and Xephros is unhorsed.

Stunned silence befalls the crowd, as the dragon knight hobbles to his feet, a few horse lengths from where he started, a far, far, cry from the center where

lancers usually meet. Green and gold healers move to intercept him, but the proud opponent waves them off, and raises his face guard.

He shouts, "What's the meaning of this?"

A lone voice in the crowd shouts, "Alien magics!"

Xephirus says, "The cart's been bewitched, or he cheated. No steed can move that fast."

Frobod raises his own face guard and answers back, "It's no more or less magical than your burning hoof prints. The speed's an innate property of the Elechopper, without augmentation."

"Bollocks!" Xephirus says. "It's impossible! Are we not honorable combatants?"

Scandalized murmurs sweep the crowd. Zarentu beckons to Herald Brime, who utters an incantation for a spell that buffs his liege. Now Zarentu's voice resonates throughout the arena.

"Lord Xephirus... Frobod, of the Toxic Muffins.... Approach." They do as they're ordered, Xephirus removing his blue helm to reveal a pair of long ears in the way of elves, his frame, resembles humans, tall and bulky compared to the smaller race.

Xephirus opens his mouth to speak, but Lord Zarentu raises a halting hand and says, "Still your words, cheating is a serious accusation in my tournament." Xephirus bows, enough to show respect for an equal. "Do you believe my vassals are incompetent?"

"I don't, but..."

Zarentu cuts him off, "Do you not believe that we examine the mounts, and test for augmentation?"

"I do believe, but."

Zarentu says, "Yes?"

Xephirus says, "He's a human. They live, breed, and breathe treachery!"

Zarentu says, "This is known, as it is also known that they can have honor." The lord of the keep turns to Frobod, who has remained silent up until now. "Do you swear that your mount remains unaugmented by any party, save Master Aztram in my stable?"

"I do, my Lord." Frobod says, "It's as I said. The Elechopper's ground speed is an innate property of the bike."

"Bike." Zarentu says, tasting the word in his mouth. "You will give us a demonstration. Circle the arena thrice with your... Elechopper."

Frobod bows, and mounts up. He revs the magical engine, and bolts ahead, kicking up a cloud of loose dirt, and ethereal color in his wake. One lap, two laps, three laps completed and he skids to a stop before the lord of Dragonswood keep. Airborne dust lingers. The whole trip takes just a hair longer than other riders to complete their introduction lap.

"You will surrender your mount to Aztram for additional inspection." It's not a question. Zarentu then turns to regard Xephirus and says, "If Master Aztram finds unauthorized augmentation, Frobod of the Toxic Muffins will be disqualified, and immediately banished from Dragonswood Keep. Lord Xephirus will advance." Xephirus, bows, with an expression of smug satisfaction, already certain of the outcome. Zarentu continues, "If, however, the mount is as Frobod

says. He will retain his standing, and take with him the official apology of Dragonswood Keep for doubting his honor. Your punishment will be to kneel, and acknowledge him as your better."

A wash of gossip erupts from all directions; shocked speculation from the stands. If there's one rule I can infer about dragon kind, it's that they do not kneel to humans, no matter how adept in combat.

Xephros says, "I accept." as if he'd been given a choice in the matter. A small gesture to save a modicum of face.

"Master Aztram..." Zarentu says, motioning to the mage, who scurries into the arena from the gate nearest the stable. I see him casting, much as we saw before, bathing the Elechopper in wisps of magic.

The process takes five minutes, but when he's done Aztram says, "I can detect no unauthorized augmentation."

Xephros roars, "This is madness! No land mount can move that fast!"

Zarentu says, "It would seem that, in fact, one can." A small smile plays at his lips that makes me wonder what kind of history there is between him and Xephros.

"It's an outrage!" Xephros says.

"May I offer some advice?" Xephros pinches his mouth shut, and nods. Zarentu says, "Practice harder." A wash of laughter from the crowd. "The world is changing."

"I-" Xephros says, but Zarentu cuts him off.

"Kneel."

"I will not!" the dragon knight puffs up, sticking his chest out in a rooster strut, "I'm a dragon."

"Kneel." Zarentu says, "Or be made to."

There's a moment of hesitation, with all breaths caught, as we await Xephros's reaction. We're so far away, that I can barely catch the smallest of nods. Seconds pass in pregnant silence, before Xephros turns and takes the knee in Frobod's direction. I hear some words, but can't discern them.

"Louder." Zarentu says, hearing him is no problem thanks to the spell on his voice.

Xephros's voice is hammered into a forced humility, so unnatural to a dragon. "Well fought." For a moment I think it's over, but he's still on his knee.

Zarentu leads, "... and?"

"I acknowledge you as the better jousting, in so far as this competition is concerned."

There's a collective sigh, as people release their breaths.

Frobod says, "Thank you." and offers Xephros a hand to help him up. He sneers at it, and stands on his own.

Tako says, "Frobod done gone made him self an enemy." in a mock Southern accent.

Zarentu's smirk makes him look immensely pleased with himself. "There, was that so hard?" Instead of waiting for a response, the lord of Dragonswood Keep spares Xephros additional loss of face by declaring "Let the joust recommence!"

Mirae says, "Zarentu must really not like Xephros. I've heard of battles fought over less."

I shrug, "Is dragon pride really that touchy?"

She says, "Can be, and you can tell he was needling him."

The next two of Frobod's matches are equally decisive, though if his opponents harbor resentment, they do a better job of hiding it, and all the time lost to Xephros's shaming, is easily made up by Frobod unseating riders on the first pass. He is, in an expression OP. No other riders stand a chance against 600% ground speed charges.

The final round comes down to a match between he and Lady Ashtara, who tries a new strategy. In stead of lowering her lance, and charging forward on her mare, she remains stationary, while holding her lance in the impaling position. Contact comes at her starting spot. Crack! Bits of both lances shower the lancers, as Frobod's shatters, and she breaks a tip. Frobod's own momentum drives her shaft into his armor. To my surprise, she stays on her horse. Every bit of her energy must have been placed into gluing herself to her saddle, and keeping her lance steady.

Frobod offers a salute, when he loops around, and returns to the end of his lane. She nods to him in acknowledgement. I think she's done for when the Etherchopper roars, and Frobod comes hurling her direction, but she adopts the same strategy. Both tips break, Frobod's unsettled, but doesn't leave his mount.

Ashtara by contrast falls, and nearly hits the ground. By some miracle, her hand whips out in a wild grasp, and snatches the pummel just in time. From there she's able to hoist her self back up and into her seat. "Ooohhs!" and scattered applause push through the crowd. She imitates Frobod's salute when he gets back into his lane.

Apparently, it doesn't count as being unhorsed unless you actually touch the dirt. I look past Tako and Mirae to Laurelade, who has a bored expression on her face. *I wonder if it'd be cheating to use that float spell. How many mage-knights are there out there?*

Time for the third pass, the engine roars. Ashtara's tired of playing defense, as her mount springs forward. Big mistake. Armor and lances clatter, but at least she's not going out with a whimper as her shaft breaks into pieces. A full shatter, the crowd cheers at the destruction but it's short lived, as the dragon leaves her saddle and plummets to the earth.

Frobod tosses what remains of his lance aside, and pumps his fist in the air as the victor. Havenfolk chant, "Frobod! Frobod! Frobod!" in celebration. They're all excited save for a weasel faced man in a top hat pushing through to the exit.

In party chat I say, "Sleeve's making a run for it." and then "Stop him!" in the local channel for all to hear. I point an accusing finger so that there can be no doubt of my meaning.

Zarentu says, "Well done Frobod of the Toxic Muffins! You have fought well."

Frobod remembering my advice about showing deference to important dragons takes the knee and says, "Thank you, m'lord. If I may ask one favor."

Zarentu says, "Rewards will be granted at the feast."

"Yes, m'lord, but it seems one of your subjects is breaking the law. As we speak, the human named Sleeve is making a mad dash away with all our money."

"Is that so?" Zarentu says. "Do you have proof?"

Frobod says, "If you follow him, I think you'll find it." Then, switching to party chat so Havenfolk can't hear he says, "You better be right. In case you didn't notice, when it comes to false accusations and Zarentu, they don't fuck around."

Zarentu says, "As champion of this event, you are granted one boon. Should your accusations prove well founded, I offer my thanks, and then another." He doesn't say what'll happen if Frobod's accusation goes unfounded. I doubt it'll be pleasant.

"I understand, Sir."

The inclusion of 'Sir' strikes me as a bit military, but the NPCs don't note the change in vocabulary. The most important part of the interaction seems to be that an attempt was made at respect.

"Very well." Zarentu says. "Dragonswood Guards, seize the gambler's tent, and bring Sleeve to me. Lord Frobod, you'll be summoned later with the results of the investigation. Please mount your Elechopper, and choose your partner."

Frobod gets back on his bike, but has a confused expression on his face. Sten fast approaches from the side with a lance in one hand, and a circlet made of yellow rose blossoms and green leaves in the other. They exchange words that I can't make out, and Frobod dips the tip of his lance to Sten who hangs the wreath from it's tip.

In party chat I hear Frobod say, "This is so cheesy."

I look to Mirae and say "What?" She has a smile on her face.

Frobod makes a slow lap around the perimeter with his lance in hand, his head turned to the audience, searching faces. Some ladies spread their arms, as if to catch a wedding bouquet. Their shoulders slump, and their faces grow pouty as the death knight passes.

"*Oh God...*" I think I know what's happening. We're in the last stand from where he started, and Frobod doesn't pause until he's right in front of us. He makes a show of searching faces, my cheeks grow hot. This isn't what I had in mind.

Frobod extends the lance so that the rose wreath is in my face.

Herald Brime says, "Will she accept?"

Dear God, this is mortifying.

The crowd begins to chant, "Take it! Take it! Take it! Take it!"

I'm frozen solid, so I don't initially accept.

Brime says, "Does she reject?" and the crowd reacts with a resounding "Boooooooooo!"

I quickly snatch up the wreath before I can grow any redder, and smash it on my head. It's a shame it's not a hood to hide my embarrassment.

You have received Rose Ring of the Champion.

Rose Ring of the Champion	
Type:	Exotic
Slot:	Head

Armor	0
Equipped Bonus:	Charisma +2, Appearance +1, Dance + 2
Special Properties:	Residents of Dragonswood Keep will regard you as having one reputation level higher (Maximum: Exalted).

As soon as it touches my head, the crowd erupts in gleeful applause and chatter. I may be Lord Melpomine, but for now I'm feeling like quite the Lady.

Chapter 15 - Eight Whole Chickens

We've got some time before the next event, so we hit the tents that have been set up for the festival. Laurelade slips off to do Laurelade things, which leaves me, Mirae, Tako, and Frobod. I'm wearing the Rose Ring of the Champion because... Why not?

"So what was all that about?" I ask, referring to the ring on my head.

"There's a performance before the feast, where all the winners dance." Frobod says.

"That explains the stats." I say.

"The wreath has stats?" Frobod asks.

"Nothing super. Just a bump to charisma and appearance, two levels of dancing, and a temporary rep bonus."

"Still..." Frobod says, "It's more than I thought."

"I want to cook some more food." Tako says.

I ask, "Do you know how?"

"Eh..." Tako says, "Not really unless they've added Microwaves."

"Didn't think so." I say.

"Hey! I could be a chef! You never know!" Tako says.

"You just said that you weren't." I say.

"Yeah, but I could be!" Tako says, "Don't judge a book by it's cover, girl, not cool." He speaks with such intensity that I could believe he's serious, but then his lips break into a smile and he says. "I'm just fucking with ya. I wouldn't trust me with your food either."

I say, "Maybe we should recruit one... A real world chef I mean. From what I've seen from your experiment, cooking the hare manually instead of using the cooking skill in the UI made it taste about like you'd expect under the circumstances. Maybe cooking like we do in the real world will result in real tasting food."

"Like char broiled butt crack." Tako says.

"Something like that." Mirae says. "Actually, I think I know a guy."

"Oh?" I say.

"Yeah, he's like me. One of the people I recruited. He said he was a professional chef a few years ago."

Frobod asks, "Why did he stop?"

Mirae says, "That's personal."

Frobod says, "Whatever."

I decide to shift the conversation away from Mirae and this other person's incapacitated status. "Can you send him a message?"

Mirae, looking down at her VT, says "Already on it. His in game name is Pehrom by the way. He's one of the triplets" I raise an inquisitive eyebrow, and she clarifies. "You'll understand when you meet them. Three goblin characters that are almost identical."

"A goblin chef." Tako says, "That's dangerous."

Mirae says, "I don't even think he has the in-game cooking skill. Something about the lack of taste being an affront to his training."

"Sounds like a chef to me." Frobod says. I snicker.

"Oh, good." Mirae says. "He says they've been farming the Windroost, but after this run he'll head over to HQ and see what he can do."

I say, "Tell him to tell Alfred that I said it's okay to raid the kitchen."

"Dude." Tako says, "If this works out, our guild will be famous."

Mirae's talk of the Windroost makes me wonder about our guild's progress on the Dragonsbane quest. While we five are over here working on one objective, it's easy to forget that we have a massive number of dragons to kill.

Limited Edition - Guild Quest

Dragonsbane - Part 1

Difficulty: Variable

An extra-planer dragon has torn a rip in the wall between two worlds. Investigate the disturbance and bolster your dragon slaying prowess so you can destroy the foul beast and prevent further damage to the land.

Objectives:

Discover the Identity of the extra-planer dragon that caused the rip between worlds.

0/1

Slay 50,000 dragons or dragon kin.

3,673/50,000

Rewards:

Title: Dragonslayer

Reputation: 10,000 Reputation in All Playable Factions

Access to specialized gear and enchantments from Havenfolk merchants

"Nice!" I say, "Check out the Dragonsbane quest." They all poke around in their VTs. "Looks like the new guys are making some progress."

Mirae says, "Most of the people I recruited have been farming. There are a lot of little dragons in that dungeon."

"What we need is a dragon raid." Frobod says, "An epic battle with all kinds of opponents."

"We might have enough people for a small one." Tako says. "But we should get over a hundred guild members for the kind of battle you're talking about."

"For now," Mirae says. "I think the Windroost is enough."

We're coming around a bend in the maze of Havenfolk vendors and tents when I see a collection of four guards standing around Sleeve's tent. The bookie's nowhere to be found, but the red "Closed for bets" sign is still in place.

I say, "I'm going to go see about my winnings."

Frobod says, "I'll join ya."

Mirae says, "We'll be around, or at the arena since I'm in the next competition." She looks to Tako, "Let's go."

As I approach, one of the guards, in the same plate and conical helms as Lyle and Archibald, says "Closed for bets. There won't be any more betting here this tourney."

I say, "I'm not making a bet." and fish my receipt from my inventory. "I'm here to collect my winnings."

The guard says, "Let me see that." and takes the paper from me. "Four thousand gold. That's some nice profit."

Frobod says, "I have a bet too, but it's not ready to collect yet. Where's Sleeve?"

"For that, you'll need to go to the keep proper, and speak with Lord Zarentu. We've been given instructions to send you his direction. Do you need an escort?"

I say, "I think a mark on our maps will do fine, thank you."

"Very well then." We both hand over our maps, and he speaks while making a red mark that magically appears with a touch of his finger. "You'll find the Lord over here. He'll be expecting you."

"Thank you." I say, and look to Frobod. "Shall we go?"

"You're most welcome, Lady Lord Melpomine, and might I say you're as lovely as a half elven lass ever was."

"Err... Thanks." I say, not sure what to make of the compliment. I'm not a soc, so I identify more as a warrior. The guard beams in spite of my awkward response. It motivates me to break extra heads in the arena.

We walk over a draw bridge, which is much like my own, and find a castle with abundant natural lighting, and bobbing white mage lights in crannies where the sun can't shine. Banners hang from the rafters in Zarentu's gold and white house colors. There are numerous tapestries on the wall depicting great battles, and great dragons. One in particular features a valiant white drake coiled around a woman in elven form. I wonder if the creature is Zarentu, and if so, whether the woman is a dragon. *Who is she?*

We find Zarentu eating by himself at the head of a long banquet table in his dining hall, though two silent bodyguards are stationed in the corner. They're so still, and so quiet that they seem more like furniture than sentient beings. I count six whole chickens, and two decimated carcasses on ceramic plates. All for him. *My God, dragons eat a lot.*

He says, "Lord Frobod, Lord Melpomine. Good of you to join me." He doesn't stand, in fact, he sucks juicy meat off a chicken bone in between his statements. "I've good news. Lord Frobod was correct in his accusations of the human Sleeve. My guards caught him, and his ogres hastily loading up a cart upon apprehension. So long as you can produce receipts for your bets that correlate with his ledger we shall consider the matter settled, and Lord Frobod will be granted another boon."

I say, "Thank you, m'lord." We fish our receipts out from our inventories. He sucks chicken juice off his fingers, and motions one of the stoic, leather clad body guards from the corner to retrieve the documents. Given all the finger sucking, the lord of Dragonswood Keep is a lot more informal than I'd imagined.

Zarentu looks the papers over on the table beside his plate without actually touching them, and nods. "We'll have these sums drawn from the coffers, as soon as you're ready."

"What'll happen to Sleeve?" I ask.

"That depends entirely on how much gold he has in those trunks." Zarentu says. "If it's enough to cover his bets, he'll be looking at a few months in the stockade. If he overextended himself, he'll be given to indentured servitude until he pays what he owes." Zarentu pauses, as he shuffles his current plate to his left, and brings a fresh whole roasted chicken in front of him. "I've been quite rude. May I offer some refreshment? A hen? A honey ham?"

"We appreciate the offer," Frobod says, "But we've already eaten."

The dragon shrugs, as if it's of no consequence to him. "At some point I'd like to discuss your marvelous mounts. Wherever did you get them?"

Frobod and I exchange meaningful looks. I hesitate, spinning a mental tale of a land far, far away, but then stop and settle on the truth. He's going to find out some day, and I'd rather not be caught lying by omission when he does. "You're familiar with the Rip of Worlds, yes?"

"I am." Zarentu says, his voice becoming dangerous. "What about it?"

I say, "The Elechoppers are from the other side."

"So you've crossed over." He says.

"You could say that. I've spent more time over there than Frobod has."

Zarentu says, "What do you know about the cause?"

"Not much." I say, honestly, at least from the perspective of a person living in Freehaven, and not a dev. "There's a dragon from another world causing it, but it doesn't come from Freeworld."

"Freeworld?" Zarentu asks.

I say, "That's what they call the place on the other side of the rip, and the people who live there are the Freefolk."

"What makes you so sure?" the dragon asks.

I say, "Freeworld doesn't have dragons, or at least, not like you do here. There are people who can transform into hybrid creatures, a bit like Nothgoran, but there are no large dragons on par with mounts, much less the size of a castle."

Outside, a horn blows.

Frobod says, "Sounds like Archery's starting."

Zarentu corrects, "Nothgoran is a black drake, that assumes a semi-human form. He is not human. As for the contest, we have a few minutes. "

"Ah, right." I say, thinking I've needled his draconic pride. "I just mean that Freeworld has people who can change into animals, and hybrid human shapes."

"Weres?" Zarentu asks.

"Eh...Kind of..." I say, "That's what a lot of people call them, but they aren't like the weres here."

"How so?" The dragon asks.

Frobod says, "It's not a disease."

"Yeah," I say, "...and they still have their minds when they transform. Most have a short temper, but their not mindless killing machines like the ones here. They're born, with a few exceptions, and even have their own cultures."

He polishes off another chicken, before reaching for the next. *Amazing*. I hadn't noticed him eating, or at least not enough to account for the consumption of an entire bird. *It must be a dragon talent*.

Lord Zarentu says, "This is all very interesting, but alas we are short on time. Lord Melpomine, after the games, I'd like to speak with you more about this Freeworld and its marvels. I don't know if what is already torn can be mended, but either way, I want to face this new world with knowledge. Right now, you two are the only source of that knowledge I have."

I say, "Some other adventurers may have information, but I agree. I'm likely the closest thing Haven has right now to a scholar."

Zarentu stops chewing for a moment and narrows his eyes. His voice taking on the dangerous tone it had upon first mentioning the Rip of Worlds. "It would be most unfortunate to learn that any of my champions played a role in causing it."

"We haven't." I'm quick to add. "We don't want to see Haven destroyed anymore than you do, and we're investigating the cause."

"If this is true, you have nothing to fear, and I welcome you on my lands." Zarentu says, "Let us hope that it is so. If you'll excuse me, I'd like to quickly finish, and proceed to the arena." He motions with his hand, and the same bodyguard as before returns our gambling receipts. "Present these to my clerk and you'll be paid."

Chapter 16 - Single Combat

I leave the keep with a spring in my step, it feels good to be paid. I don't even know what I want to spend the gold on, but it's good knowing that if I want it I can probably buy it. The archery and magic challenges, are less interesting than the joust, since they both basically come down to individuals trying to hit a target at range. I'd like to say Mirae and Laurelade brought home first place for the Toxic Muffins, but at the end of their challenges, Mirae places third, and Laurelade seventh. We're milling about the grounds waiting for single combat to start.

"I'm bummed that I won't get a boon from Zarentu, though." Mirae says.

Frobod asks, "What would you use it on if you had it?"

The Sea Elf says, "I'd probably ask if I could have a weapon from his armory. I've been looking for a good bow."

"Good idea." Frobod says. "I hadn't thought of that."

I say, "You could also ask for access to his bower. Maybe have something custom made."

The gnome looks grumpy. "I should have done better than that."

I can't say I'm surprised by how Laurelade finished. She did a fine job zapping, freezing, and blowing things up, but when it came to the part where she had to quickly melt specific candles, in a cluster of twelve without damaging any of the others, she fell apart. In the first attempt, two candles next to the target were destroyed, and in the next it took her so long to get the job done that she lost points.

I say, "Did you go through your spells and set up macros like I said?"

Laurelade kicks a stone in response.

I say, "We all still have a chance to win, or win again in the melee. It's gonna be intense."

Mirae says, "Well that's something. We can't win them all I guess."

"These are tough competitors." I say. "Taking first place isn't supposed to be easy. The fact that we're even here is awesome in itself."

Tako asks, "You think Pay-nes Kill will be fighting?"

"I dunno." I say.

Frobod says, "I don't think the Leroy Jensen Fan Club is an LE guild."

Mirae says, "Yeah, I'm pretty sure that it's just him with the LE key, which is why we didn't see more adventurers."

Frobod says, "Maybe he recruited some Havenfolk to join him."

Tako says, "Who would want to? I mean, before, yeah maybe, but with every Havenfolk person we meet being a named NPC with an advanced AI, it'll be a lot harder for him to find people to sign on with him."

Frobod says, "I guess it'll all come down to rep."

The horn announcing the impending start of single combat sounds. I equip Bite, spinning and passing it from hand to hand before looking to Tako, "That's our cue."

Frobod says, "Dodge-Tank makes her debut. Don't lose. I've got serious money riding on you." His voice is teasing.

Mirae says, "How much did you bet?"

Frobod says, "Two hundred gold."

Mirae shrugs as if to say that it's something, but not so much. She says, "I'm rooting for you."

I get the feeling that if she had to choose between us, she'd prefer Tako, if for no other reason than to get a wreath, but I'm not complaining. I'm not going to get jealous of my officer's crush. I say, "Thanks." to Mirae, and then to Tako "Shall we?"

"Let's." he says.

We all kneel before Lord Zarentu, and promise to conduct ourselves honorably. Now that I know that he doesn't consider Freeworld content dishonorable, I have no reservations about accessing my full array of spells and abilities. After the opening ceremony, we're escorted to the Champion's Lounge where we're informed that dragons are not allowed to take their native shapes, and now is the time to make pre-battle preparations.

It's a different feeling waiting in the lounge than in the stands because we can't tell what's happening. Of course we hear the crowd's "Ooohs!", crashes of steel, and "Ahhs!" but it doesn't tell us anything about our opponents' tactics. As for our surroundings, it's every bit as luxe as I'd expect for dragons, with tables of food... lots of food... platter after platter of cooked swine, hare, and fowl. We've got lush couches and half naked servants to cool us with fans crafted from peacock feathers and palm fronds. They don't seem like Zarentu's style, but I can see how other dragons go for that. The light dragon is a gracious host. I don't bother with the solids, but help myself to a sweating pitcher of ice water.

Aztram, who joins us says, "If you want to cast any beneficial augmentation spells, this is your chance." The dragons must all already know the drill, because he's looking at me and Tako, the only adventurers in the tent.

I've already set up a macro for Jordan's Enhanced Dexterity and Vitality buffs, which I enable by wiping my hands on each other. The Enhanced Dexterity makes a whistling wind sound on activation, and vitality sounds a thump-bump, thump-bump, thump-bump effect like a human heart. They're both instant effects, and take no preparation.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

It's the first time I've seen those words in my UI since the merge, and it makes me wonder what Jordan would say if he could see me now, cannibalizing his beloved character. I can only hope he tells me to kick some dragon ass, than bitch about using skills that I hadn't worked for. If he was still alive, it'd be the latter, but I like to think that as he is now, he'd want me to do his legacy proud.

Tako enables the same effects, by tapping a button on his VT rather than setting up a macro, like I did with wiping my hands.

He says, "Are we going to get to see some 'alien magics?'" Those last words come in a harsh imitation of Lyle's wary voice.

"Damn right." I say, and move to an area where I'm not likely to knock anything over. Just to be safe, I swap out Bite for Marine's silver war fans which take up far less space.

Windsoul Skystrikers

Type:

Exotic (War Fans)

Quality:

Epic

Base Damage:

Strength (Slashing)

Equipped Bonus:

Dexterity + 3, Intellect + 3

Special Properties:

Bonus Damage: Roll 50% Dexterity (Wind)

Illusion: Wielder appears to move at twice their speed, and make twice as many attacks. (+2 difficulty to block or dodge).

Creates wind.

I unfold the exotic weapons and begin whipping them around my body. Unlike real world fighting fans, these are made of impossibly light and strong metal, with wicked edges that are as sharp as any dagger. The tablecloths only stay in place due to the plates of food on top of them. Edges of the tent billow out, and the half naked servants struggle to hold on to their fans. The Yin energy of elemental air rises within me, and I seal the spell with an abrupt stop and bow to an unseen opponent.

Flow Like Water (Rank 2) - Success!

Duration: 30 minutes.

Some of the dragons give me stony looks, and I re-equip Bite. It's hard to tell if it's because they don't approve of my magic, or if it's because they're now seeing me as more of a competitor than just a skinny girl without any armor. In any case, it's easy to see that precious few of us aren't wearing plate, and I'm the only one sporting a mix of cloth and leather.

Aztram, on the other hand, looks impressed. It's nice to see a mage who's not afraid of Freeworld magic.

You have gained 200 personal reputation with Aztram.

Current level. Friendly.

He says, "Sometime after the tourney you'll have to show me how you do that. It's not every day that a person can surprise me with new magic, especially one as young as yourself."

Quest - New Magic

Difficulty: Moderate

Aztram is curious about your alien magic. Teach him the foundations of magic beyond the Rip of Worlds, and receive a reward.

Objectives:

Teach Aztram the basics of alien magic.

Rewards:

+1,000 personal reputation with Aztram.

+500 Reputation with Dragonswood Keep

A personal favor.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes.

I have my doubts as to whether or not the elderly half elf could pull off Marine's athletic form of casting, but I smile and say "Sure, after we settle this Rip of Worlds business, we'll talk shop."

I'm looking forward to a battle where I can blend so many skills from a plethora of characters. It'll take ages to go through everything, and find out what works best, but I'm already digging what I've set up so far. While dungeon crawling in the Windroost, I stuck to Paladin abilities because they were what I knew, but in downtime between events I've taken the time to acquaint myself with Jordan's rogue abilities which I've never used before as well as those from my Freeworld martial artist, Scootiwutams, and all the other aliases attached to this account. I've also set macros that allow me to activate each ability by mouthing or saying their names. Macro simplicity is best until I have the experience to know how to best utilize them.

There are even some interesting gear options should I choose to use Jordan's Hot Swap ability.

Hot Swap (Rank 3)

Weapons: Dexterity + Weapons (Weapon Type) or Dexterity + Martial Arts

Armor and Accessories: Dexterity + Athletics or Dexterity + Martial Arts

Effect:

You may change equipment during combat without penalty. In so doing you must take purely evasive action for 1.5 seconds.

Usable Only On:
 Head, Hands, Weapon, Ring, Accessory

Aztram says, "Lord Melpomine, you're up next, just this way. "

Tako says, "Good luck, and don't die because I want to kill you."

I roll my eyes. "I'll be sure to do that, not because I want to win or anything, but to give my guild mate a public chance to stab me in the back."

Tako says, "You better believe it."

Aztram says, "Lord Melpomine..." looking back and fourth between us, unsure of what to make of our interaction. Surely, a resident of Dragonswood wouldn't talk to Zarentu in this way.

I say, "It's fine. We're always teasing each other."

"Very well." Aztram says, "But the tourney." He sweeps his arm toward the exit as if inviting me to lead the way. I take the hint.

As soon as I step outside Herald Brime says, "...and now a half-elf Lady hailing from Durolan, Guild Master of the Toxic Muffins, Explorer of Worlds. Lord Melpooooominnneeee!"

Explorer of Worlds? What's with that? As far as I know I haven't gained any new titles. Zarentu must have given Brime instruction to place Freeworld magic into context. I'm quietly thankful, so I don't start a riot when they start seeing the effects of Marine's spells.

Aztram says, "Enter the arena, and good luck." He looks on me with a near fatherly expression, perhaps half-elf kinship in a castle full of dragons.

I say, "Thanks." and charge into the arena with Bite at my side. Unlike Frobod, I'm a peacock, and greet the audience with a series of handsprings and midair tumbles. I drink in applause, and it tastes like magic. There's a red spot in the dirt, where I await my opponent.

Herald Brime says, "...and her challenger. Knight of Lord Rendak's court, hailing from Castle Deepwater, Sir Maadzon."

The knight marches out of the Champion's tent with a heavy shield, a formidable sword, and matching bronze armor the color of a new penny. Each segmented piece of his plate is blackened around the edges as if scorched by fire. A long, red, feather dances in the wind from the top front of his helm. I bow to him, as he takes his spot on a red dot across from me, but he just nods. He's got a pale human face so far as I can see, but we're some fifteen paces away.

My heart is beating. We're told that Zarentu drops a handkerchief to signify the start of the battle, but from where I'm standing he's impossible to see. Instead, a massive countdown timer overlays my vision.

3....

2....

1.....

Begin!

He twirls that longsword in his hand waiting for me to make the first move. It'll be a tank vs. tank battle with him blocking, and me slipping out of the way unless I can take him by surprise.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I disappear from my current position, and reappear in his shadow standing right behind him. I sweep low with Bite, yanking one foot out from under him, he barely keeps his balance, but I follow up with a roundhouse kick, and then pound his plate with the end of my weapon. Electricity cracks and leaps from the end of Bite, into his armor. He goes sprawling, face against the ground, and body pressed into his shield.

He pushes himself up, but I'm not having it. One... WHAM. Chest down, and face in the dirt. Lightning crackles. His hands go to the side. Two. CRACK, and the staff comes down on his helm. Massive dents appear in bronze armor where there hadn't been before.

CRITICAL HIT!

You hit Sir Maadzon for 15 damage +4 lightning damage.

Total 19 Damage.

Sir Maadzon absorbs 15 damage.

Three. I bring Bite down hard against the entire length of his back sending another jolt of electricity through his body.

You have defeated Sir Maadzon.

"Pwned." I think, as he lies motionless, and healers rush out to restore health and help him to his feet. Golden magic encircles him, though it carries no scent as Mirae's does. Sir Maadzon's life creeps upward. 40%... 60%...80%.

I half expect him to yell at me for using underhanded tactics, but he extends a gauntleted hand and says, "Well fought Lady Lord Melpomine. Had I known you had that trick up your sleeve, I'd have used a different strategy."

I grasp his forearm with my own hand and say, "Well fought, Sir Maadzon. I'm confident that you would." It seems, so far as single combat is concerned, that everything's considered honorable so long as you don't break the rules.

I raise my staff in the air, lightning from the end flickering overhead, and the stands explode in cheers. I look to the Champions section and see Frobod and Mirae giving me the standing O. The Death Knight's clapping, and the Elf's presenting an enthusiastic thumbs up.

I think, "*Round one, complete.*" as I head back to the champion's tent. If I'm to be first place, I'll have to win four battles. I look for Tako, but he's already gone. He must be fighting in the next match. I snatch a slice of honeyed ham from the buffet table, and find myself disappointed by the lack of taste. It's easy to forget when everything looks and smells so delicious.

Mirae sends a message.

Mirae: Nice job. He didn't stand a chance.
 Melpomine: Thanks. How's Tako doing?
 Mirae: So far, so good. He's rogueing it up like you did. Dirt in the eye, dirty fighting.
 Melpomine: What's his opponent like?
 Mirae: DPS fighter. Full plate and a two handed war maul. Kinda slow if you ask me. He keeps smashing it into the dirt, then Tako darts around and chips away at his health.
 Melpomine: Cheer for me. They don't let us watch the other combatants.
 Mirae: I've got you covered.

Some time later, Tako rejoins me.

"How'd it go?" I ask.

"Piece of cake." He says. "Big, slow, and stupid. No problem."

I say, "Mirae told me some of the details."

Tako says, "That might have worked against a shield, but with someone like me, I didn't stand still long enough to get hit." He pauses, and says. "How'd yours go?"

"Piece of cake." I say echoing him. "Shield and sword user. I got behind him, knocked him down, and pummeled."

"Very nice." Tako says. "You should totally bring out Scootiwutams when they least expect it. Half-elf Melpomine... Surprise! Female dwarf pally! They'll just stop fighting and surrender."

"Not going to happen." I say. "This is my new style's debut."

I see Aztram motioning to me, and I say, "It looks like I'm up."

I miss the introduction, because I'm the second one to enter the arena. I can't even see my opponent's face because his helm's closed, but he's got cool armor. Onyx black, trimmed in royal blue. He's got magic pauldrons that make his shoulders look like they're on blue fire. He has no shield, just a sword, and I'm willing to bet that this is a magic user. "*Well, isn't that special?*" Name's Sedin by the nameplate.

I bow to him from my spot in the dirt, and he returns the gesture.

3....

2....

1.....

Begin!

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I appear behind him, but as soon as I'm there, his whole body flicker-flashes, and suddenly he's standing where I started. He waves his sword in an intricate gesture, and suddenly, two additional images of my opponent appear on either side of him. All five run around each other in a fast circle. If I'm lucky, only one of those things is solid, if not, my opponent just made four copies of himself.

I charge in for the attack, spinning Bite, and coming down hard on the center image. It explodes in a harmless shower of magic sparks.

A sword cuts me, or at least, it tries to but Flow Like Water kicks in. Flesh and bone quickly reshape around the blade allowing it to pass through me as though Sedin had slashed water, leaving me unharmed, but knocking off four levels of absorption from the spell. The crowd gasps as they witness defensive magic they haven't seen before.

"Well played." I say, and lash out two times with Bite. There's no resistance as one copy shatters, and then another leaving just two more images for me to deal with. Apparently the weapon's area of effect damage doesn't work unless I hit a solid target. No matter, the two remaining images strike in unison, and I evade both by leaping into the air, high enough to clear both our heads in an acrobatic flip. It's Hong Kong action cinema time.

I follow the dodge with a strike. It lands home. Electricity crackles, and spreads to the second image like it's supposed to. It bursts in a cascade of rainbow color. Now it's me against one attacker again. He slashes, I dodge. It might have seen like a close one to the crowd, but with my heart pounding and time slowing as it often does in battle, it's as if he'd missed by a mile.

I counterattack with Bite, he blinks away - the same teleportation spell used at the beginning.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I appear right behind him, and slam Bite into his kidney, I hear a muffled "Ugghh!" and lightning crackles. I follow up with a hook kick, and strike again with the staff. His health drops. He turns.

A fireball explodes in my face, the heat rolling over me like a nasty sunburn, but as with most damage in Freehaven the pain quickly fades. I'm down to ninety percent, he's at seventy. A hard battle, but I'm ahead.

He blinks away, and before I know it a volley of purple magic bolts soar my direction. I evade them with a tumble, spring to my feet and rush like a madwoman to close the distance. Shadow Step's got ten more seconds on cool down, so it's no good. I'm almost there, I reach with my free hand, and slap a hand full of dirt through the slit in his faceguard.

Blind (Rank 5) - Success!

Sedid is blinded for 10 seconds.

My competitor shakes his head, trying to clear dust from his face. I press my advantage. A powerful kick knocks him back, and a blow to his chest, followed by one to the knee cap brings him down to one knee. Another blast of fire... I evade, just in time slipping out of its reach. I spin Bite around me, and smash it down hard onto Sedid's burning shoulder. He crumples, small worms of blue electric magic crawl from Bite into black armor. Health at 30%.

He tries to recover. Bite's spinning, a mirage of blue electric wheels forming around me. He's up to one knee. He's about to cast, CRUNCH! The side of my staff kisses the side of his armored face. He's not moving.

You have defeated Sedid.

Healers rush to greet us. Halos of holy gold surround our bodies, as my health's topped off, and Sedid's climbs gradually. I hear coughing, a woman's voice, as Sedid removes... her helm revealing a mop of dark blue hair, and slightly pointed ears much like my own. Her azure tinted skin and shape of her eyes and nose remind me of an Indian goddess; Vishnu's pointy eared daughter. She has a dusty raccoon mask from where I hit her with the dirt. It'd be comical if I hadn't just given her such a trouncing.

I say, "Well fought Lord Sedid." and fish a handkerchief from my inventory. I hand it to her so she can clear the grit from her face. She seems grateful.

She says, "Well fought, Lord Melpomine." and we grasp each other's forearms.

This time, the words carry a sensation of ritual that I enjoy.

As with the conclusion of the first battle, I raise Bite high overhead. The crowd roars its approval. My body teems with elated energy.

Back in the tent, I'm alone. Just two battles to go. I take another swig of the ice water. If Tako wins, there's a fifty-fifty percent chance that we'll face off in the next battle. I think I'd rather thrash NPCs.

Mirae: Woo-hoo! Melpomine wins!

Melpomine: Yeah, she was a bad ass.

Mirae: Why didn't she use her sword?

Melpomine: Because she's smart. Her first direct hit didn't work, so she switched to magic.

Mirae: I gotcha. That was a funky spell. How long's it last?

Melpomine: 30 minutes, but it's only good for 10 health levels, and only works against physical attacks.

Mirae: Still, it's pretty cool.

Melpomine: Freeworld magic. I even got a quest to teach the local wizard.

Mirae: Really? That's hilarious.

Melpomine: How's Tako doing?

Mirae: Uhhh... I dunno. Neither has taken any damage, but it's a shield and sword guy. It's hard for him to connect.

Melpomine: That sucks.

Mirae: This is going to be a long battle.

Melpomine: Hold on. I'm gonna recast Flow Like Water.

I pull out my fans, and begin casting. The abundance of wind feels good against my skin since I've worked up a sweat. My long hair whips crazy directions. Outside, the crowd gasps a collective "Oh!"

Melpomine: What happened?

The response isn't immediate. I pull up my spells on my VT, and get to thinking how best to handle a highly mobile opponent like Tako. I feel like an idiot because there's one I used to use all the time. It didn't occur to me because this isn't Freeworld and I'm not in the skin of MarineLu.

Move Like Ice (Rank Three)**Cost:** 500 Manna**Dexterity + Martial Arts****Duration:** 20 seconds

By channeling the cold forces of Yin energy, and directing them at your opponent you may cause them to slow, or even freeze them in their tracks.

Effect:

Target movement speed decreased by 50%. 20% chance to freeze them in place. 10% chance to impose -4 dexterity penalty.

I wonder how it'd have worked against an opponent like Sedid. I've never used it on a teleporter since that kind of magic, aside from the Thunder Bridge, isn't common in Freeworld. I make a mental note to use it in the next battle.

Mirae: Tako's down. I don't think he's going to make it.

Melpomine: That sucks, how'd he get him?

Mirae: Critical hit on a shield bash that knocked him over.

The crowd rumbles with applause, and I think *"Not good for Tako."*

Mirae: He's out. It's up to you now.

Melpomine: Sorry to hear that, but I'm also kinda glad that I don't have to fight him.

Melpomine: It's not a guild specific event, so I didn't want any hard feelings if one of us eliminated the other.

Mirae: We're still cheering for ya, and I doubt there would be.

Aztram pops his head in from outside, and says "Lord Melpomine." I exit wondering what kind of dragon I'll be facing. What I see in the arena, defies all expectations; a green skinned orc, with red eyes and great white tusks that reach up to his lower eyelids. He obviously chose to forego the comforts of the Champions Lounge. I check his name plate.

Groth**Type:** Player**Race:** Orc**Appearance:** 2**Challenge:** Average

He's wearing brown hide armor, a variety of pelts stitched into a human shaped covering. His helm looks like the skin and skull of a mountain lion with a set of massive antlers attached. He has neither staff, nor sword, instead he twirls

a length of dark chain that drips an unknown liquid and glows an unnerving shade of crimson.

"That's.... different." I say, thinking on how to approach this. With a chain weapon, not getting hit is the obvious strategy, and it looks like parrying isn't an option.

The crowd is a mix of "Yeahs!" and "Boos!" A guy from I don't know where, shouts, "Don't let that filthy orc win!"

Nice to know they're on my side.

I spin my staff for the benefit of the crowd. Many cheer me. I halt, and deliver my customary bow to my opponent. No response from the PC. He just alternates between spinning the end of his chain, and wrapping lengths of it around his fist. *That's a pretty good idea. I'll have to try it.*

3....

2....

1.....

Begin!

Before I can think to Shadow Step, the orc charges, roaring in like a bear, with the chain spinning like a rotary fan in his fist. Something about his vocalization makes the air behind his head glow in a red fog. An interesting cosmetic effect, and most certainly not good for me. He closes the distance with long, powerful strides that are so long that they resemble kicks. I drop down, spin, and hit him with a dragon tail sweep. The red chain and orc's foreleg sail right over me. I knock the weight on his other foot from beneath him.

Martial Arts Maneuver - Dragon Tail Sweep (Rank 3) - Success!

The crowd celebrates. No time for that, because I'm back on my feet, and spinning Bite ready for my first weapon attack. WHAM! I expect a direct hit, but my staff just makes clouds in the dirt. Instead of falling prone like a heavily armored foe, Groth tumbles and ends up on his feet. *So much for me being the only agile one.*

He roars again, more beast than intelligent race, and swings the chain at my face. A simple dodge, no problem just a slight wind from his strike on my cheek. I counter with a swift upward blow with Bite to the orc's side leaving little black burn marks in his armor. I whirl the staff back around, and follow through with a downward strike to his head sending one antler flying.

Groth Health 80%. I'd hoped for more.

Instead of using another chain swipe, Groth punches, with a length of the metal entwining his fist. A metallic clack sounds as the end of Bite meets the metal in his hand, sending small snakes of electricity into him. I give the orc a look to say, "What were you thinking?"

Groth Health 70%

He doesn't respond except to swing again with the long end of his chain. I dodge out of the way, but it loops three times around the shaft of my weapon. I

pull, the orc pulls back. It's a tug of war stale mate because neither of us are letting go, and Bite's not breaking.

The orc bellows, a new red cloud haloing his face. He yanks hard, I try to resist, but the weapon goes flying. My staff clatters in the dirt, as the orc jerks it far out of reach. He makes an aggressive feline yowl befitting the creature he wears on his head.

One heartbeat... Two heartbeats... He's a fast changer. Too quick for me to track tusk and green skin melt into a face full of black whiskers and brown fur. It's not like Freeworld weres, where skin, muscle, and bone stretch and contort over the course of slow seconds. Instead, the orc is like soft clay, slammed in a mold and granted new shape in an instant. I'm now facing a larger than life puma without a weapon. Damn thing's the size of a liger.

Hot Swap - Success!

You have equipped Fists of the Thunderlord.

Fists of the Thunderlord

Description:

Left is Thunder. Right is Lightning. Don't get caught in the storm.

Quality: Epic

Type: Leather

Slot: Hands

Armor 1

Equipped Bonus:

Dexterity +2, Strength +1, Stamina+1

Special Properties:

(Right Hand Only)

Unarmed attacks inflict +4 Lightning Damage.

(Left Hand Only)

Unarmed attacks inflict +4 Sonic Damage

(Left Hand Only):

33% chance on hit to deafen your opponent for 20 seconds. Effects are cumulative.

Bonus damage ignores armor.

I'd considered the war fans, and might still use them, but for now I prefer to have guaranteed bonus damage for each hit from these fingerless gloves, on top of the unarmed bonuses and benefits being a martial artist instills such as an increased number of attacks. So here we are, ninety-six pound unarmed me, vs. an eight hundred pound mountain lion. *Seems fair.*

Groth comes in for the pounce, but seems to forget the gravity defying benefits of RPG martial arts. I leap high over the cat's head before it's anywhere near me and come down swinging my fists hard at it's skull. A flash of light bursts from my left hand, and when I follow up with a hit from my right there's a ear

rattling CRACK that echoes off the walls of not only the arena and stands, but the keep beyond.

Collective gasps of surprise, spring from the audience. No doubt a few are looking for rain.

Groth swipes with his big paw, but I'm faster, dipping out of the way, and smashing a lightning uppercut under his massive jaw, followed by thunder in his nose. The cat shakes it's head as if seeing stars, and I go in for a follow up kick.

Bad idea, he claws and the paw connects. Flow Like Water activates as the cat pushes through my fast reforming flesh. Minus 5 absorption. I can only take one more of those blows before I'm losing real health. At least then, I'll be resisting damage with stamina.

Groth roars, and takes advantage of his hit. Although unharmed, the strike leaves me in an awkward position. He pounces and I go down, his feline face chomping, and ripping away the last of my Flow Like Water defense; my flesh twists and reforms to soak up the damage from his teeth. This is... un-good.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

Glad it works while I'm on the ground. I roll to the side, disappearing into the shadow of his chest and paw, and reemerge from the shadow of his right haunch. I can only hope he's still deaf and disoriented from my left hooks and unsure what's happening. Quick to my feet, I start a steady kata, and push an unseen wave of cold Yin energy into him via my Chinese elemental Freeworld magic.

Cast Move like Ice (Rank 3) - Success! **Movement Speed reduced by 50%.**

Little ice crystals coat his fur. I could go on the attack, but I decide to repeat the spell while he's not looking.

Cast Move like Ice (Rank 3) - Success! **Movement Speed reduced by 50%.** **Target is frozen for 20 seconds.**

In my current gear, two small spells are enough to leave my manna a quarter depleted, but that's okay because I've got him where I want. So long as this guy doesn't surprise me with an AOE that hurts me, and not himself I've got this. *Can shape shifters cast in animal form?*

Flash of light from the right, KA-KRACK, from the left. *Don't get caught in the storm.* With each impact, flecks of frost and ice drop off the cat as from a building after a snowstorm.

In an instant Groth shifts, now, back in his red-eyed orc body. He tries to move, but ice crystals creep up his legs. It'll be like this for 10 seconds, and I seize the attack. Flash of light, KA-BLAM, BOOM. Quick punches in his flank. He turns his torso trying to hit me, but I'm just out of reach. I dance like a hornet and sting with the old one-two. Jabs flash like cameras against his jaw. KA-BOOM-BOOM

as a left handed uppercut sends his chin skyward. He looks dazed. I'm a flurry of fist and storm smashing his ribs. Each blow chipping away at his health. Flash, crash, boom!

Groth health: 20%.

Four... Three...Two... Move Like Ice is expiring. I finish him off with a roundhouse kick that puts his ugly face in the dirt.

You have defeated Groth.

Unarmed skill increased by 1. Current level: 13

Cheers explode around me. I do a back flip, and then leap into a handspring. I could get used to this attention. I look around the floor and find Bite a few paces away, I shake the chain off, kiss the shaft, and say "I've missed you." Cheers grow even louder. *They must have really not wanted the orc to win.*

I head back to Groth where the green robed healers are fixing him up. I extend my hand in good sportsmanship, and say "Well fought."

Groth sneers at my gesture and says, "Fucking noob."

That takes me off guard since all the Havenfolk have been graceful in their defeat. I say, "If I'm a noob, you just got your ass kicked by one."

He says, "Fucking Freeworld spells, what did your boyfriend give you his account? We both know I should have won."

For the first time since arriving, I feel a spark of temper. Fuck him and his accusations. I beat him up fair and square. 'Did your boyfriend give you his account?' *What is that?* I say, "You just lost, because you suck. Learn to play."

He says, "You just said 'Well fought.'"

I say, "I was being polite. This battle was over the minute you disarmed me. What kind of idiot disarms a monk... I think that's what you call them in Haven... throws away their weapon, and challenges them to unarmed combat? Then, on top of that, you saw that physical attacks weren't working, and kept trying to do the same thing." Granted it wouldn't have worked if he hit me again, but he doesn't know that, and if I were using Marine's gear I could cast Flow Like Water again as soon as it wore off. I mock, "Oh yeah, I'm smart! I deserve to win!" I scoff, "Even the NPCs were smart enough to switch to magic."

He says, "Fuck you bitch!" and throws a punch at me. I easily dodge out of the way, as the crowd produces a chorus of "Oooos" and "Ohs!"

A spell is cast in my peripheral vision, Lord Zarentu stands from his thrown.

"Silence." He says, in a voice so deep and dangerous that it makes my bones quiver. "Orc. You may not strike another champion, and your behavior in this competition until now has been unacceptable."

Groth says, "Blow me!" and grips his crotch. Deciding this may be his last chance, he takes another swing at me, which I easily sidestep.

Lord Zarentu says, "I revoke your invitation, and right to visit Dragonswood Keep. Guards. Seize him."

Groth says, "No fuckin' way! I didn't get the quest loot."

As guards with longswords and halberds march into the arena, the orc shifts into a dire bear, red eyed, and two and a half times my height. I clear the area, not wanting to be attacked. The crowd chatters in the commotion.

Zarentu says, "Master Aztram, if you will?"

The old half-elf raises his hands as if cupping a bowl overhead, tapping into a power that I, as of yet, am unfamiliar with. He chants in a language that I don't know, white light glows in his raised palms, growing more intense with each second. Then, when the light is about as bright as a small sun, he takes it in two hands like a basketball, and smashes it against the earth. At the same time, rock falls from above, a hot red meteor that smashes into the bear's face. Groth lays motionless in the dirt, red smears on the ground near the place where the meteor hit.

I cautiously poke it with my staff, since none of the guard are getting any closer. It doesn't move. The blood soaking into the dirt stretches the limits of what my current PG-13 game setting will allow, I'm certain that in R mode I'd be covered it bits of bear brain, and blood.

Groth	
Type:	Player
Race:	Orc
Appearance:	2
Challenge:	Average
Status:	Dead

Zarentu says, "Do not resurrect him, let adventurer gods sort out his fate. In my castle, Groth is no more." The dragon then regards me. I'm wondering what they'll do with the body until he respawns and his corpse disappears. "Lord Melpomine. You have my apologies. Violence, outside the tourney, is not permitted on my castle grounds."

I'll never know what happens to the body, because after I bow in acknowledgement of Zarentu's apology, a squire hustles me off to the Champion's tent. The inside is so empty compared to how it was when Tako and I first entered, just a two servants with their palm fronds and a man in deep red armor painted to resemble exposed muscle with jawless human skulls cupping either shoulder. Aside from grotesque bone ornamentation, it's a lot like looking at a puffed up anatomy dummy. He has long wavy brown hair, and a tuft of beard on his chin.

He says, "Well fought Lord Melpomine."

"Thank you." I say, assuming this must be my final opponent. "If you'll excuse me a moment..."

I whip out my fans, and begin recasting the Flow Like Water buff, debris skitters across the floor, and the tent flap blows open for a second. If this dragon's intimidated by Freeworld magic, he's not showing it as he bares an amused expression, as I finish casting, and his hair settles back down around his face.

"Are you finished?" He asks.

I wipe my hands to renew the Enhanced Dexterity and Enhanced Vitality buffs. Woosh... Thump-bump. Thump-bump. *Just in case.* I say, "Yeah..." for all I know, his whole plan is to keep me talking so long that I forget to prepare.

"I'm Lord Krogen," he says, "It's good to meet you. I'm much happier facing off against you, than that mongrel."

Part of me wonders how he even knows about the orc, since all competitions are blind. Either an exception to the rules is made for Havenfolk NPCs, or he has an inside source of information. I say, "Well he wasn't polite, that's for sure."

Krogen smirks, "You might even say he lost his head."

I think, "*Oooggg. That was bad.*" and say "You could certainly say that."

He sips a goblet, of what must be wine, and motions to an oversized pillow, that could serve as an entire bed for one of the smaller races. "You might as well sit." He says "There will be a few minutes of cleanup."

I take his advice, not sure where he's going with this. Until now, most of the NPCs in the Champion's tent, excluding Aztram, have ignored me. "So...." I say, breaking a silence that's settled between us.

"May I be blunt?" Krogen asks.

"I prefer it."

He asks, "What are your aims for this tournament?"

"I want to win." I say, "I thought that'd be obvious."

"Clearly." The dragon says, "There's no point to compete if not to win, but why? We are dragons. You are not. What do you hope to accomplish?"

You mean, besides completing a limited edition quest? I consider the original quest. I take care to phrase my response in a way that NPCs will understand. "We need allies."

"We?"

"Me, my guild, the entire world... Dragons respect strength, so I'm hoping that if enough of my guild does well in the competition, Zarentu will entertain an alliance."

"Against what, or who?" Krogen asks.

"The Rip of Worlds, or rather, the entity causing it."

Krogen scoffs. "You hardly have to win the tourney for that. Haven't you ever heard that an enemy of your enemy, is your friend?"

"I want more than that. We're not here to be some dragon's shock troops. An alliance implies an equal partnership."

"You will never be our equals, so frail in your pink and brown skins." Krogen says, "But I digress, it's a matter of pride. This, I understand."

"... but it's not."

"Isn't it? Don't want to be treated like the ants that you are? I just want to know if I face an opponent with a worthy cause, and it would seem, alas, I do."

"Saving the world?"

Krogen snaps, "Pride, you fool. I will break it, and shove it down your throat, but at least it's a worthy cause."

I mutter, "Glad I could reassure you."

Aztram peeks in, and says "Champions, it's time."

We both nod, and Krogen's out the door, before I've even gathered my staff. "What a turd?" I think, as he hogs the spotlight. By the time I'm out there, the crowd's already whipped into a frenzy, chanting "Krogen! Krogen! Krogen! Krogen!"

I guess now I know who's the crowd favorite. I look to the Champion's section, and thrill to see Mirae, Frobod, and Tako cheering me on, with Laurelade looking down and examining her fingers. Beneath all the cries of my opponent's name, there are at least three voices in my corner looking out for me. I spin Bite, in a whirlwind of electricity, and give my guild a confident thumbs up.

Now, across from my opponent I see the real rival I'm facing. He surprises me by not using a shield, instead preferring a lone longsword. He's got a red helm to match his armor, with a mow hawk of steel protrusions. Before the match starts, he licks the length of his blade, leaving a streak of red blood, and then blows on it. With an audible "Fwoof!" the blade catches fire, a metal torch. He slams his face guard shut, and spins the burning blade in his hand, daring me to attack.

"Don't get hit." I think, knowing that Flow Like Water won't protect me from elemental damage. *I wonder what other magic he's got.* A whisper inside cautions against another shadow step opening. How had he known about the orc? Does he have someone feeding him information, or is there a Haven spell for remote viewing? If either's true, he'll see that move coming and do whatever he can to counter it.

3....

2....

1.....

Begin!

Earthen spikes shoot up from the ground behind him like stalagmites, as I mouth the words, "Black Ice." *Seems I was right.*

The spikes crumble to dust in a few seconds. My words were a macro I set up to cast a Freeworld spell.

Black Ice (Rank 2)

Cost: 500 Manna

Dexterity + Martial Arts

Duration: 5 seconds

You channel the cold essence of Yin through the very earth, causing it to become as slick, unseen and evasive as black ice.

Effect:

A target effected by Black Ice is unable to advance for five seconds. Steps slip from beneath them. If the target attempts more than three steps, they lose their footing and fall. Knockdown attacks on the target are

granted automatic success.

Cast Black Ice (Rank 2) - Success!

For a moment, nothing happens. He'd clearly expected me to appear behind him, and I'm waiting for him to charge. *Thank God he's an NPC.* I spin Bite from hand to hand, and stab its butt into the ground.

Taunt. Successful. Krogen attacks.

One step, two steps, three steps as Krogen runs in place, then both legs fly out from under him in a parody of a cartoon. He and his blood armor crash to the ground, *Take pride in that.*

I immediately begin the motions I've programmed for Move Like Ice. I'm down half my manna now, so I can only do so much casting. The telltale sheen of frost fast creeps over his armor, as I rush in for the attack.

He's moving slow on the ground, and I hit with a low strike, Bite crashes against an invisible shield, it's electricity scurrying over an unseen dome. Health still at 100% as I bring my staff down hard for another blow. My only hope is that this barrier is a thing that can be smashed or eroded like my Flow like Water protection. I go about hammering against the unseen bubble, as Krogen struggles to his feet at 50% motion speed.

I get in one more whack, before he starts with his sword. Our weapons crash together sending a jolt of force through my grip. I counter attack with Bite's other end, but hit the barrier before I can strike his armor.

He says, "Give up now, mortal."

I respond, "Not today." Spinning my staff, and using superior speed to overwhelm him with too many strikes. He parries a few, but the vast majority land on that damn magic bubble.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I fall back into my own shadow and re-appear behind my opponent. My foot knocks him in the back, sending him staggering forward. I follow through with a downward strike with Bite that puts a dent in his shoulder. Krogen: Health 100%, but at least I've made contact.

He spins, and swings with his burning blade, but Bite's got too much range. He's not even close to connecting. A bit reckless if you ask me, because he leaves his flank wide open, which I tag with a crash against his armor, bringing his health down to 90%. First blood.

I say, "Fifty gold if you can hit me." as he comes in for an attack, I feel the heat of flame from his sword on my skin, but he doesn't connect. That's what twenty-four dex is for.

From inside his helm, I hear, "You can't dance around all day," as I give him a love tap to the side. Not much damage, but I'm sparking him up.

"Watch me."

His sword makes a fiery 'woosh' sound as he swings. I slide out of the way. Woosh, crack! I back out of range of his head shot, and intercept a new swipe with my staff. I'm starting to think of a new strategy.

I say, "Honestly, I don't know how your in the finals."

Feeding the fire.

Manipulation + Empathy. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 4)

"I think I'll like him when he's angry..."

With each barb he grows more reckless, throwing more power into his swings. I duck and dodge with ease, occasionally countering, and setting Bite to nip him. His health's only down twenty percent, but he's yet to land a blow.

I say, "Even the orc connected." Swoop, woosh, dodge, CRACK. He makes a running charge. I evade, and Bite nips him in the butt as he rushes past me. Anal electrocution, that's got to hurt. I say, "I thought dragons were supposed to be good at fighting. Are you even trying?" *Arrogant prick.* I'm going to defeat him in the most embarrassing way possible.

My mouth forms the words "Black Ice." and I dart back a few paces.

Cast Black Ice (Rank 2) - Success!

He never learns, running three steps without moving, and then falling on his ass. I bring Bite down hard on his face, causing an electric zap paired with the crash of stave on armor. Krogen health 50%.

I move back, with Bite at the ready. I give him a chance to get back up, if for no other reason than to make him fall again. He takes advantage of my not attacking him, and summons some kind of earth magic with a few hand gestures. The ground shakes, and a crack in the arena floor opens, starting at his feet and creeping toward me.

Fire and earth, aye?

Well, the best way to avoid a ground attack is to not be on it, so I leap into the air and begin tumbling much the same as when I first entered the arena. I could really use Laurelade's float spell about now, but on the bright side my hand springs, and mid air twists probably look a lot cooler. It's not like he can stab me from here. I come to a stop, some thirty feet from where I started, and say "Is that it?"

The ground shakes again as he repeats the same spell. I run and tumble making a gradual circle around him. This time, an earthen spike erupts from where I was originally standing, and I wonder if the first time he had casting problems on account of his armor.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

Now I'm behind him. I spin Bite, and hit him in the back of the knee. He buckles.

I say, "So kind of you to take the knee."

Feeding the fire.
Manipulation + Empathy. Success!
(Caliber of Success: 6)
"I think I'll like him when he's angry..."

"You go too far!" He snarls, "I'll burn you where you stand!"

Instead of turning and coming at me with his sword, his form grows larger, his metal plate melting into a scaly hide, as wings begin to form and peel from his back. His draconic skin, shiny and more like a serpent than a lizard, mirrors his armor—dark, red, and furious.

Fantastic. His rapidly increasing form shoves me out of the way. No time for acrobatics, I sprint to the far end of the arena. Krogen heaves a deep breath, and blows wicked flame over my body. Flow Like Water's no good against elemental damage, and my health drops a startling forty percent in one go. My skin is tender, and I find myself wishing I had a pocket healer to bring me back up to full health.

There's screaming in the crowd, as innocent Havenfolk take cover. No one wants to be caught in the crossfire.

A booming voice sounds. "Lord Krogen is disqualified!" It's Herald Brime. "No dragon may take their natural form."

"I don't care!" Krogen says, and breathes another gout of flame. This time I'm expecting it, and manage to leap out of the ring, just in time.

"You should." That's Zarentu, his voice low, angry, and beautiful. Krogen turns, leaving me to face his thick tail and winged back. Perched on hind legs, as he is, he's nearly as tall as Dragonswood Keep. "Human form now, or suffer my wrath."

I can't see what's happening in front of the massive draconic body, there's just a long pause wherein neither speaks, and Havenfolk cower. Finally, after what seems like an hour, but was probably only a few dozen seconds, Krogen shrinks back down into his armored human body and picks his sword up from the dirt, blackened now, the flame no longer burning.

"Lord Melpomine?" Zarentu says. "You may come out now."

I awkwardly climb back over the arena wall, the crowd chatters, thankful to still be alive.

"You are the winner." Lord Zarentu says, "As Lord Krogen has been disqualified."

My former opponent stomps out of the arena, and I wonder who's made a bigger enemy in this competition between me and Frobod. As soon as I start approaching the healers rush to greet me. The golden halos of healing magic, have never felt so good. I wish I had a mirror, because I imagine my face covered in a layer of soot.

Herald Brime says, "Everyone, everyone... please take your seats." People mill about the stands, reluctantly taking the suggestion as of afraid of another dragon attack.

I breathe hard, with Bite at my side. I can see Krogen's gone, but given the sudden outburst I grip the shaft a bit harder as if they might be right. It seems

that most everyone is back in their seat when Brime says, "I present to you our winner! Lord Melpomine, of Durolan, Guild Master of the Toxic Muffins!"

There's some clapping, but I get the feeling everyone's still rattled. I suppose it's not every day that villagers find themselves near burned alive. Unlike adventurers with comparatively obscene stats, most non-combative Havenfolk will go down with just a swing of an adventurer's sword. To my right, a big eared boy scuttles into the stadium, with a long hook like they use to change mage lights in Durolan, and a green and orange wreath.

Gasping for air, as if he'd run much farther than the side of the arena to where I'm standing he says, "It's your turn for a victory lap. Give this to whoever you want to dance with before the feast."

I smirk, and raise it to my nose to sniff the orange, yellow speckled blossoms. They aren't roses, but smell every bit as delightful. I can't tell if they're a Freehaven Online creation, or if they have counterparts in the real world. *Wouldn't it be awkward if I gave this thing to someone other than Frobod?*

Just for the fun of it, I fish the Rose Ring of the Champion out of inventory, and set it on my head. It's hard to explain the reaction, except to say that everyone suddenly becomes more nervous and excited. Breaths catch, with all eyes on me until I've made my decision. Sten holds the hook out to me expectantly.

I say, "I don't need that." and set the pole on the ground.

Herald Brime says, "Lady Lord Melpomine. Choose your partner." That's my cue for the slow victory walk. I start to my right where Sten entered, as far as I can be from the Champion's seats. I stroll, lazily about taking in faces. Ava smiles at me in the first row, and the men react anywhere from bouncing up and down like boys at a concert, to giving me calm, reserved smiles with inclinations of their heads to show interest or respect. I pass them all over leaving a wave of disappointment in my wake. The guys usually aren't as animated as the women, but I can taste dashed Havenfolk hopes and dreams.

Now I'm at the Champion's section looking up at a bunch of NPCs and my guild mates. I'm half tempted to present it to Sedid since she was my favorite champion, but alas quash the impulse and look up to Frobod. He's too far to reach, so I fling it like a Frisbee. It bumps off his black armored chest, against the head of the guy in front of him, and into his lap.

I call out, "Nice catch!"

Herald Brime says, "Lady Lord Melpomine has chosen Lord Frobod as her partner. Does he accept?"

Frobod looks at the ring of flowers in his hand, and flips it over a few times like a giant quarter. The crowd chants, "Take it! Take it! Take it! Take it!" I smirk and think, *"Now you know how it feels."*

He hesitates dramatically, and then sets the ring on his head. I laugh and call up to him "Oberon!" because the crown of green plants and wild blooms make him look like a Faerie King. The crowd cheers, and stomps their feet on the wooden slats supporting them to create a god awful racket.

One more event to go, till we finish this quest, and go back home. It'll be wonderful to collapse in bed.

Chapter 17 - Eye on the Prize

We're given a chance to rest and recover which I'm thankful for. Though I've been at full health since the healers mended me, four back to back combats before a enormous crowd are mentally draining. I don't feel it as much when we're running dungeons because it's not only me fighting. Having other party members to help carry the load gives me a boost of mental stamina, it's a social experience compared to one on one against people I don't know and it's just me.

We're all waiting in the Champion's tent, which Lord Zarentu has allowed us to procure until the next event owing to that we now have two contest winners, with bonus rep circlets for Dragonswood Keep. I've just refreshed my buffs when Frobod finally saunters in with a sack of gold clinking in his fist.

He sings "It's my birthday."

I say, "Really?"

He says, "No, but I just got paid."

I say, "Glad to see you're in a better mood. This morning at the joust it was all. 'I'm here to win.'" I imitate his deep voice.

He says, "Yeah well, I already won that, and more than half our group has placed top three in their respective events. We're gonna crush it in the group battle."

Tako bumps fists with him, and says "Word."

He looks to me and says, "Thanks for the bonus rep head gear, if we win the big melee, maybe he'll offer the log out button."

No one says anything to that, and I'm thinking it's not likely. I mean, what are the odds that the first quest we get after the hotfix (*Did we even get this quest before the hotfix?*) will be the one to take us offline? I remember the hopeless feeling so many felt after Archangel's announcement, and I've gotta believe it'll be a lot harder to accomplish than spending the day fighting in a pit.

He says, "I've got a little girl to get back to."

Mirae, Tako, and I, exchange meaningful looks, it's just enough to say that we've all had the same thoughts, but not a one of us has the heart to break it to him. The cheer in Frobod's voice is the best I've heard since Archangel's announcement, but you'd think, for him, getting out is a foregone conclusion.

Laurelade says, "I want to get out too. I don't have kids, but you know... Stuff to do. It's time to get the hell out of here."

Frobod says, "Right. That's why we've got to own this competition. We've got a few minutes, so lets talk strategy."

I say, "I think basic dungeon strat, should be fine. With more than one opponent, Bite will taunt. With Mirae on heals, we should be good. She can even DPS with her bow until Flow Like Water wears off."

Mirae asks, "What if we're fighting players? Taunt won't work."

Tako says, "If it's a mixed team like Pay-nes Kill and some NPC mobs, kill the player first. Otherwise, take out heals and casters first. I can garrote. Blocks casting for 10 seconds."

I say, "I think I have that one too, but haven't used it."

Tako says, "There you go. Don't give em' a chance to cast. If they can't be taunted, Mel you and Laurelade should be on crowd control."

I say, "I've only got like 4000 manna in my current gear. I could get a lot more if I use Marine's stuff, but It'll come at the cost of a lot of dexterity and stom. Black Ice and Move Like Ice both take 500."

Frobod says, "I like you better as a tank. Especially with NPCs around."

Mirae says, "I've got a manna regen spell."

Tako says, "Save it for yourself. Good heals are more important than CC at this point, especially when it'll only give Mel a few casts."

I say, "If all else fails, I've still got knockdown maneuvers that aren't magic."

Laurelade says, "We can also try kiting."

Frobod says, "Think you can do that?"

I say, "Give me a few hits with Bite to grab em' and I should be able to work something out. I get enhanced movement speed while wearing cloth or leather armor."

Tako says, "Tank, you call it. You're the one that'll be close to them. If you think you can kite, I'll use arrows."

Frobod says, "I've got spells for attacking at range. They're not as good as my sword, but they'll be easier to use if you're constantly running."

"Alright..." I say, "My gut says we'll be fighting mostly NPCs, and I won't know what to do until the battle starts. No matter what happens, I'll Shadow Step and draw their attention. Give me at least three hits before you start attacking. Mirae go in with your bow, so they don't know right away that you're our healer."

Frobod says, "Got it."

Laurelade says, "And then?"

I say, "I'll make the call. If I shout 'Form A' it's tank and spank. Tako and Frobod, go melee. If I say 'Form B' I'll run to the wall, and start circling clockwise around the arena. Everyone ranged while they chase me. Mirae and Laurelade, don't be shy if you peel off me. I need to know so I can taunt."

Laurelade says, "What about PvP?"

I say, "Healer first, but if it's not obvious, or they don't have one, focus fire. Attack who I'm attacking with Bite, and try to CC the rest."

"We've got this." Frobod says. "Birthday cake here I come."

I feel bad because it reminds me of his daughter, the others probably assume it's a continuation of his 'It's my birthday' joke.

Laurelade says, "For marzipan."

"For burritos." from Tako.

Mirae and I exchange looks, and say nothing. Frobod says, "C'mon guys, what are you going to eat as soon as we get out of here?"

"... for pizza?" I say in a half-hearted voice.

Mirae's slow on the response, but she bursts with "... for lychees!" in a voice filled with forced enthusiasm.

I'm imagining her trapped in bed, propped up on a couple of pillows, with a VR visor, and a nasogastric tube hanging out of her nose and dripping gruel down her throat. Hell, before long, that could be an image of all of us, the main difference being that if we get out, we can go back to our burritos, marzipan, and

birthday cake, but for Mirae, she's got about as much a chance of chowing down on a bowl of lychees as I have of casting Thunder Bridge in the real world.

Tako says, "What, are you Asian? I've never even seen a lychee outside of Asia."

I say, "I'm surprised that you know what a lychee is."

Tako says, in a voice filled with mock indignation, "I know things!"

A horn sounds outside, and I say "That's our cue."

Laurelade says, "Should we go out?"

I say, "Wait for Aztram. He'll call us."

It doesn't take long, the old wizard pokes his head in and says, "You're first."

Everyone moves for the door, but I linger, and touch Mirae's arm. She looks back to me, our eyes meet. When the last of the Toxic Muffins exit, I pull the elf into a deep hug. Her hair smells of sun, natural perfume, and all the nameless spring blossoms she'll never get to experience outside of a power chair. Seconds pass, before I feel her small elf-girl hands touch my back.

We release, and I look on her, she's about a head and a half shorter than me.

"Thanks?" She says.

I say, "Sorry, that conversation just made me feel closer to you."

She shrugs, as if it were no bother. "You think I haven't heard people talk about food, or going to the park, having front row seats to whatever show, or taking vacations before?"

"Well...No, but..."

She says, "Mel, I appreciate it, but I've been at this a long time. I've got thick skin."

"I didn't mean..."

"I know you didn't," She says, "...and that's why I'm not mad at you. Just... lighten up a bit, okay? Have fun."

"Alright..." I say, "Let's win this and claim some badass loot." as Aztram pokes his head in the tent again.

He says, "Lord Melpomine, Lord Mirae, you're needed."

"Sorry. Sorry." I say, "Just some last minute discussion."

Mirae says, "Lets." as we duck out the tent door.

Chapter 18 - The Rumble

It's our last battle, and we're assembled in a V formation, with me on point, and Frobod and Tako standing just behind and to either side. The fights leading up to this one were smooth because we work well as a group. Mirae and Laurelade are in the back, as they both wear cloth, and are the most fragile members of the party. As soon as the match starts, they'll fall in behind the melee fighters. Mirae's got her bow, which is good, because if I were the enemy, I'd assume that Laurelade with her wand was the healer.

I'm not eager to see Laurelade die, but when it comes to accomplishing group objectives, the tanks and healers are the lynchpins of any group. With both of us, we can eventually down most NPC enemies within our challenge range, but without someone to absorb damage, or restore health, you've got a recipe for failure.

The stands are fuller than I've yet seen—this is the main event. Villagers cheer, and vanquished contenders sitting in the champions' section clap and rumble their support. To my surprise, warriors like Lady Lord Sedin, Lord Maadzan, Lady Ashtara, and all of Frobod's other competitors with one notable absence, wave white cotton banners with purple hand-painted cupcakes. I try to tell myself that they're just NPCs, and their show of support doesn't matter, but the greater part of me beams knowing we've claimed their respect.

There are five enemy combatants, all Havenfolk, all new to me, every one of them wearing a human shape, and silver and blue tabards depicting a dragon's fang. Three are plate wearers. One in front wields a sword and shield. The guy to his right has a claymore, and one to the left hefts a two handed war axe.

There's no cloth on the opposing team, just leather. A guy in the back spins a pair of short swords, and the other has no weapons that I can see. I'm pegging the allegedly unarmed one as heals, if they have any at all. NPC groups aren't always logical.

3....

2....

1.....

Begin!

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I'm behind the guy with the shield. A low strike buckles his leg, and arcs of electricity hop from his body into the two oafs beside him. Before anyone can react, I do a fast back walkover, followed by a back handspring to put distance between me and the fighters I just attacked. Now, the three guys that were in front, are now in back relative to my position. They whirl to face me.

You'd think I'd have trouble tumbling with my weapon, but every time I start an acrobatic maneuver, Bite's glued to my hand. I couldn't drop it if I tried. It's like the pole becomes insubstantial and bound to me until the conclusion of the move.

I'm now five feet behind leather clad opponents that started in back. They wear 'What the fuck just happened?' expressions on their faces. *Why don't I show them?*

Bite blurs into motion slapping into the flank of Mr. Two Swords, followed by a direct hit to Unarmed Leather's side. Each strike sending mostly harmless, but aggravating electric energy into the group around them. A single point of electricity damage, isn't hard to resist, and in the entire altercation, only Two Swords's health has decreased. Sir Claymore takes a swing. Woosh! I'm out of the way. Lord Tall Axe brings his weapon down, but Bite knocks it out of the way.

Counter attack.

My staff strikes his chest and electrifies his armor. I'm pleased to see that all five opponents are now within the five foot area of effect radius. Arcs of blue, like a Jacob's Ladder dance between them, taunting with each jump.

I shout, "Form B!" before whacking Mr. Two Swords again, and sending electricity into his friends. They're all moving in for strikes, but Bite's got far too much range, and for each step they advance, I spring two steps back. Once I'm a good ten feet in the clear, I turn and bolt for the nearest wall. They give chase.

Clock! Krunk! Sounds of two arrows smashing against heavy armor. An unholy mass of amorphous dark energy, slams into Sword and Shield's back. Nothing from Laurelade yet, which makes me hope she's building up to something grand. I'm at the arena wall now, and am circling the perimeter, with four stupid AI's chasing me. Bite's taunted them all at least three times now, so I should have an iron grasp on their attention. There's no way they'll catch me with my agility and movement speed bonuses, compared to the penalties of wearing heavy armor.

The air grows cold.

Snow and great shards of ice crash down like frozen guillotines. A blizzard of death, born of the ether. Laurelade's in play.

I call out, "Nice work!" as another volley of arrows connects leaving pockmarks in enemy armor. An instant later Frobod adds another torrent of dark energy to the mix. I'm way ahead. Laurelade's ice spell has slowed them. I curse myself for not having a ranged weapon. If I Hot Swap my shield with the symbol of Helios I can Smite, but it'd mean giving up Bite and all bonuses for not using heavy arms or armor. *Not worth the trade.*

Clouds overhead, not quite above me, but the enemy group, thunder and lightning, our little gnome's power slams into the group. Shield and Sword man's handling it the best, with a full seventy percent health remaining, but the two leather wearers are both down to thirty.

I shout, "We've got this!"

Sir Claymore turns, and Mr. Two Swords pivots and run at the gnome.

I hear, "Incoming!" over the party chat.

I respond, "I've gotcha." and shout "Hey Ugly! Yeah, you with the sword!" I pause my retreat long enough to spin Bite in great blue blurs of electric fire. I slam the butt into the dirt.

Taunt. Successful.
Rezden attacks.

I point at the other one, and repeat the motion.

Taunt. Successful. Grimavore attacks.

I guess now I know their names, with so many enemy faces, I hadn't bothered checking their nameplates. Both swordsmen stop on a dime and make a beeline back for me.

I shout, "Hold DPS!" having forgotten to switch to party chat. One more arrow from Tako hits Two Swords, or Rezden as he's called, and he falls face down in the dirt.

You have defeated Rezden.

I abruptly reverse my flight, and charge back at Shield and Sword, Mr. Big Axe, and Unarmed Leather.

I call, "Nice! Loose on Leather!"

A glowing green magic arrow, a bolt of death magic, and a trio of violet mage bolts slam into the unarmed foe at the same time.

You have defeated Horden.

Rest in peace, Horden. You're down for the count. What your purpose in this battle was supposed to be, I'll never know.

I shout, "All in! Form A!" as I crash my staff against the rival tank's shield. It sparks on impact, and lightning passes from him to the man with the big axe, Sir Claymore, aka Grimavore is out of range, but he's coming at me. Swoop! I narrowly escape Tank's longsword, CRASH I intercept the axe with my staff.

Grimavore groans, "Grraaah!" as he brings the Claymore down on me. I try to dodge, but he nicks me, shaving seven absorption levels off my Flow Like Water defense. It just goes to show that a nick from forty-five inches of steel over a six inch hilt is enough to give someone a very bad day. Luckily, my flesh rolls away and reforms in the path of the blade leaving me without so much as a scrape.

He hasn't finished with his swing when out of nowhere, Frodo body checks him like a NHL hockey player. The dragon stumbles, running bent over, but doesn't lose his feet. I call out, "Focus fire!" taking advantage of the knight's lack of footing. A strike to the butt, followed by a blow to the nape of the neck, leaves him groaning in pain. Another crunch as a green arrow from Mirae connects, sticking into his collar. Grimavore health: 40%.

I tag him with another swift combo of three strikes, electricity crackles. Lord Big Axe, and Rival Tank step just into rage on the third blow, as current hops from Grimavore to their armor. I duck from the path of a flying axe, and hear a solid clang as I parry the longsword. Grimavore's standing tall again, a flicker of movement behind, and Tako's dagger pierces a sensitive spot between

joining plates. Blood shines bright when it drips on silver metal. Grimavore health: 20%.

I say, "He's almost down!" as I narrowly evade another swing from the great axe. Unlike Scooti in her impenetrable red armor, the only viable strategy for a martial arts tank is to not get hit at all.

Laurelade calls, "Incoming!"

What's attacking her? I glance back just in time to see a giant ball of fire easily half my height in diameter hurling our direction. I say, "Shit!" and dive for cover, rolling on the ground and coming up on my feet. The air's hot against my skin, like hunkering beside a bonfire. *We've got to come up with new code words.*

You have defeated Grimavore.

His blackened armor smokes, pops, and smells a bit like pork.

I mouth, "Black Ice," and slip out of the way of an incoming axe.

Cast Black Ice (Rank 2) - Success!

Unfortunately, neither opponent is walking as they stand their ground. My left knee goes down, hands to the dirt and my right leg swings around knocking Axeman's legs from under him. The move's so fast that my limbs are a blur of motion. Armor crashes when he takes the fall.

Back to my feet, I parry the longsword and counter with an attack that knocks the shield. Bite's current hops from the shield to the guy on the ground. Frobod comes in with an awesome two handed cleave that'd give anyone a headache. The real hero however is Tako, who leaps on top of him, and begins needling with his dagger, slipping the thin blade between the plates. Each stab drops the axe wielder's health by a few more percent.

You have defeated Wrestlas.

One more to go. Just as I'm about to bring Bite down on our last opponent he slams the point of his sword into the ground and kneels in supplication. His eyes turned skyward and he mouths prayers to his unseen deity. An impenetrable golden dome wells up around him, and deflects Bite the same as would a castle wall.

"Crap!" in party chat Tako says, "I think I know what's happening. Everyone scatter. Tank stay put. Get ready for an AoE!" I hold my ground, uselessly beating Bite against Mr. Shield and Sword's protection. Every other member of our group bolts for the corners of the arena. Now sounding out of breath, he says "It's either that, or a massive heal."

Mirae shoots an arrow, but it bounces off and drops harmlessly to the ground. Now, having a chance to breathe, I switch to party chat and say "Save your arrows." I check our opponent's name, and see that he's called Londrian.

Tendrils of golden light spring up around the fallen warriors, enveloping them in shiny cocoons that pulse and glow in the sunlight. One by one each

defeated dragon stumbles to their feet, with 20% health remaining. All at once, ethereal wrappings pop like bubbles as they lunge for me, their closest target.

I yell, "Laurelade, now!" and place myself on full defensive. I parry the great axe, the weapon wielded by my closest fallen foe.

The sky darkens, lightning crashes, thunder as countless bolts rip through everyone in my area.

You have defeated Rezden.

You have defeated Horden.

You have defeated Grimavore.

You have defeated Wrestlas.

Critical Hit!

Laurelade strikes you for 6 points of damage (lightning).

My health drops. My muscles lock under the brief but uncomfortable strain of electrocution. *Friendly fire? Really?* Sensations are dampened compared to the real world, but losing sixty percent of your health in one go isn't pleasant.

The scent of cherry blossoms wells up around me, and I'm cascaded in a shower of emerald green light.

Mirae heals you for 2 points of damage.

Mirae heals you for 3 points of damage.

Mirae heals you for 1 point of damage.

"Sorry!" Laurelade says. "I got a critical hit on damage, but failed my control roll."

Forcing back the urge to snap, "With friends like you, who needs enemies?" I say, "All in on the last one."

Frobod and Tako converge. Laurelade unleashes a series of magic bolts. The enemy tank's barrier fades, and I slam Bite into him. Tako strikes from behind, while Frobod swings his massive blade in an arc meant for decapitation. The tank raises his arm and blocks with his shield, but the action gives Tako's daggers the opening they need to bleed Londrian in the unprotected space beneath the arm. One... Two.. Four... Six purple projectiles of Laurelade's energy slam into his chest forcing him to step back. Londrian health: 20%. We've almost got this.

Londrian continues to block every one of my strikes with his shield, or by parrying with his sword. That's okay because as long as he's focused on me, everyone else gets a chance to attack.

A burning green projectile streaks past my ear from Mirae's direction.

You have defeated Londrian.

The rival knight drops; a goose fletched arrow protruding from the vision slit in his helm.

Healers rush out. One pulls the arrow from Londrian's helm. The shaft is red, and unsheathes from of his eye like a skewer in a hard boiled egg. Four of the green robed attendants scurry about the arena, mending the fallen.

"Toxic Muffins... the victors!" Herald Brime says, to the answer of uproarious applause. I pump Bite in the air, savoring our victory.

I think the competition's over when Zarentu motions Brime over with a wave of his forefingers and speaks such that I can't hear.

"Ahh..."Brime says, "There may be one more challenge." The crowd hushes, as the five of us exchange cautious looks. "Lord Melpomine. Lord Frobod. Step forward." We do so together, and look up to the herald. "Each of you has won two events, which leaves us in a conundrum as there can only be one Grand Champion."

Murmurs in the crowd. I look to Frobod, but his head's forward, eyes locked on Brime—focused as a hawk, cold, predatory.

Brime continues, "Accept victory now, and you will both be Champions. Face off, for one last battle, and one of you will be named Grand Champion of the Dragonswood Tournament. You must both agree to continue the contest. If either of you declines, the Grand Champion title will be forfeit until next year."

Limited Edition - Quest
Grand Champion of Dragonswood
Difficulty: Hard

Lord Zarentu has offered you a chance at single combat to be named Grand Champion of Dragonswood.

Objectives:
Defeat your opponent in the arena. 0/1

Rewards:
Title: Grand Champion (duration 1 year)
Reputation: 3,000 Reputation in Dragonswood
A special gift.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I hesitate. Decline, and we walk away as equals, accept, and a reputation spike which will add to individual reputations of Dragonswood residents. It could help me with Aztram's Master and Apprentice quest, should I choose to accept it. There's also the matter of a special gift, and I know what Frobod's thinking. This is it, his ticket out of the game, and a chance to reunite with his little girl.

He eyes me impatiently.

With a heavy sigh, I choose yes, hoping that no ill will come of this. The crowd claps, somehow aware of our decision, as Herald Brime calls, "To arms!"

I take Bite in hand, spinning it slowly, not like I would when facing a foe. I meet Frobod's eyes and what I see is desperation. So unlike the frigid determination I'd expected.

"I'm sorry." He says, and hefts his massive sword.

3....

2....

1.....

Begin!

I spread my arms wide, an impossible to miss target. Bite falls from my fingers, and clatters to the ground. He surges in, a black locomotive, swinging his great blade, and buries it in my chest. Ribs splinter. I bleed profusely. My breath makes a sick, wet, rattle. The world's fading. A final stab of pain as he yanks his weapon free, and I see no more.

Chapter 19 - Rewards

I revive to the sound of Havenfolk chatter, a pointy nosed, Auburn haired woman with light freckles in a green robe looms over me. The golden glow of Dragonswood Keep healing infuses me.

"Welcome back to the living, Lady Lord Melpomine, but as your healer I must say that was a stupid thing to do. You could've been Grand Champion, and for what?" She sighs, with an expression that suggests that she'll never understand warriors.

My health's now at thirty percent and slowly ticking upward. The initial impaling pain's gone, but I feel awful sore around the wound. I'll feel this way until I'm topped off again, thankfully, Lord Zarentu's healers are good at what they do. I'm at sixty percent by the time I help myself up, and brush all the grit from my clothing.

Eighty percent, I'm now standing. Frobod says, "I am so sorry, I didn't know you were just..."

"Oh shut up..." I say, "You know you wanted to."

He says, "No, I didn't, but... thank you. If this works, I'll be in your debt forever."

"Yeah yeah..." I say, "I'm the patron saint of broken log out buttons."

Lord Zarentu stands and says, "Well, that was unexpected." Brime must have cast the spell to amp his voice while I was knocked out. "Lord Frobod of the Toxic Muffins. I name you Grand Champion of Dragonswood, and now for your reward." Frobod stands a little straighter, and I catch my breath. "Boons will be awarded to Champions at the feast, but for our Grand Champion, there's one gift that I'll bestowed now."

The gate beside the Champion's section of the stand swings open, on the side of the stables. In walks a muscular black horse, with magnificent, large, translucent, draconic wings. It shakes it's head, and snorts a small poof of fire.

"You've got to be kidding." Frobod says.

The creature strolls in, trailing behind a train of four pegasus foals, white, black, brown, and pinto. Each has slightly different colored wings, and all seem to be capable of breathing fire.

Lord Zarentu says, "Our mages have been hard at work this year, and have bred more of our draco-pegasi than expected. You may claim one of these foals to keep and raise as your own, as my gift to you."

"You've got to be kidding!" Frobod says.

Lord Zarentu says, "Yes, they are wonderful. I quite agree, and no. I jest not. You'll be the first human to own a Dragonswood Pegasus."

"Frobod..." I say in a warning voice.

The death knight takes a deep breath, and clinches his hands into fists. In a tight voice he says, "I'll take the black one."

Lord Zarentu says, "Fantastic choice! It'll match your armor."

A stable hand leads the creature over on a small lead and hands it to him. No doubt, Frobod's reading some sort of prompt about obtaining a Draco-pegasus, or whatever Zarentu called them.

Frobod huffs, "Thanks." to the stable hand, and then speaks louder to Zarentu, "I was hoping that you could help me..." He looks to me, and then to the rest of the guild who have been standing further away since single combat, "Well all of us..."

"Ah-ah-ah..." Zarentu says, waving an admonishing finger. "Boons will be awarded at dinner. No exceptions." The last is delivered in the same dangerous tone we experienced several times over the dragon's lunch. He continues, "Short as your lives are, Lord Frobod, patience is a virtue."

* * * * *

As soon as we leave the arena for the Champion's tent, because where else should we go to discuss everything that just happened, Frobod slams his fist on one of the buffet tables and yells, "FUCK!" He kicks the rug up off the dirt. "Fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck! Mother fucking, fuck!"

I sigh, having saw this coming. I didn't know what form it'd take, but I've been bracing for a meltdown. It was either going to be rage or tears. Looking at Frobod now, I think it's a little of both.

Tako says, "It's a cool ass mount, and two in one week." recalling Frobod's drop from the Windroost, "If you don't want it, I'll gladly take it from ya."

Frobod says, "I don't care about the fucking mount! We're supposed to be going home now. Home. Las fucking Vegas, not some castle in Durolan."

I guess now I know where Frobod's from. I'm half tempted to quip about not knocking the castle, being part of Jordan's legacy and all, but I decide against it in favor of letting him burn through all his rage by pummeling helpless tables, and stomping innocent carpets. The sooner he gets it out of his system, the better, and we can begin the healing process from this setback as a guild.

The gnome isn't quite as vocal, but even she looks crestfallen as she lays on a throw pillow staring at her feet.

I say, "It's only been, like, a day." I check the game clock on my VT, "Less than a day actually. We can still do this. The logout quests could be anywhere, just waiting for us to discover them."

Tako says, "Not to mention, we still get favors."

"Yeah." Mirae says, "We should brainstorm what to ask for."

"Log out button." Frobod says, "Easy."

I sigh, "Not to sound like a nay-sayer, but I'm not sure all NPCs can just tweak our interfaces. How would we even ask them?"

Frobod says, "I want you to help me log out and go home."

Mirae says, "I don't think he'll know what logging out is."

"No..." I say, "But he might be on to something. Havenfolk already talk about adventurers as if we are a class apart, with strange behavior. Perhaps you could say something like 'All the adventurers in our company desperately want to go home. We're not originally from Haven, no are we residents of the Freeworld. Please use your resources to help us find a way back home.'"

"I like it." Tako says, "With the whole Rip of Worlds thing, Havenfolk are already familiar with alternate realities, or dimensions. With the right story, we should be able to bypass the usual filters on their ears for talking about the real world."

Mirae asks, "Who wants to use their favor for that?"

"I will." Frobod says.

For the first time, Laurelade speaks up saying, "I'd be willing to do it too."

I say, "I was already planning to ask for an alliance between the Toxic Muffins and Dragonswood to aid in the Dragonsbane quest. Beyond that, I was really hoping to get some enchantments, for either my boots or Bite."

"Not to sound self centered or anything," Mirae says, "but I really want to upgrade my bow."

I say, "Get what you want. We don't all have to ask for the same favors."

Tako says, "I was kinda hoping for some new gear too, or a limited edition vanity item to sell for a monster pile of gold."

Frobod says, "Why aren't you guys trying harder to get out of here?" It's an open question, but he's looking to Mirae and Tako.

Mirae shrugs, but Tako says, "I'm having fun here. I mean, I'll do the log out quest if we find it, but honestly I think we'll be getting out because of something they do out there" he points as if over a horizon, "before anything we do in here. So, for now, why not enjoy it?"

Mirae says, "Yeah me too." seeming thankful for Tako giving her a plausible excuse to stay.

"In any case," I say, "Lets work out our story regarding the origins of adventurers, just in case he decides to grill us. I think sticking close to the truth will be easier. Maybe that our souls have been transported to this plane, and locked inside these bodies until we can find a way to be released and sent home. I think it's best to say that it's not a punishment, but rather a natural disaster corresponding with the Rip of Worlds. It'll make our plight more sympathetic."

A good fifty minutes of back and forth later, I'm feeling confident of our origin story, and am ready for the banquet, or at least, I think I am until a stuffy little rat-faced man with a thin moustache, adorned in Lord Zarentu's house colors enters the tent.

He says, "Champions," and pauses to be sure that he has all our attentions, and then bows to Frobod, "Grand Champion Frobod, I'm here to see if you require anything before the feast."

Frobod says, "I'm good to go right now." Still in his armor.

I say, "Me too." Standing, in my bloodstained leathers.

Mirae, Tako, and Laurelade also start to mobilize, when the man, named Rebon, says "In that?" eyes, widening. "You won't change your clothes?"

We all look to each other, and Frobod says "What's wrong with what we've got on?"

Rebon says, "This is a feast in your honor, not a tavern where you can brawl." He pulls out a handkerchief, licks it, and rubs at the spot where Frobod's sword impaled me, taking a blotch of red away with it. "It's the same gear you wore in the great melee." He huffs loudly. "This is an emergency."

He claps his hands twice as if using The Clapper, and waits for something to happen. Nothing does. Clap-clap! "I said this is an emergency!" A moment later two brunette women in the same colors scurry into the tent, curtsying to all of us. Rebon says, "You." pointing to the girl on the right, "Take the fellows." He gestures to the other woman, "You and I will handle the Ladies. We've got just

over 30 minutes to make them grand. I don't care what you have to do. This is a make it work moment and time's-a-wastin'."

Frobod and Tako are being dragged out of the tent by the first girl, wearing baffled expressions. I have to laugh. Of all things to do before claiming our rewards, I never imagined we'd be getting makeovers. I poke Mirae and say, "Just imagine if the orc had won!"

Rebon says, "That'd have been a travesty. Thank you Lord Melpomine for vanquishing him, but now we're really short on time."

He herds us all into the castle proper, through an antechamber, up a stone staircase. Mirae grins and has a spring in her step, whereas Laurelade moves about with her typical attitude of, "Whatever." Now we're in some kind of dressing room with four ornate full body mirrors.

"Wait here." Rebon says, and bolts out of the room without waiting for a response. His helper went another direction, as soon as we reached the castle.

I sigh, and say, "Ooohhh, this is awesome!"

Mirae says, "You think we can keep the clothing? This is so cool."

Laurelade grumbles, "I feel like a soc."

The girl from the tent enters with three boxes, marked with a logo featuring a cluster of grapes, encircled by a needle and thread. She curtsies again, leaves the boxes on a table, and departs the room.

Mirae says, "Doesn't say much, does she?"

"Must be shy." I say. "We're celebrities."

Now I hear Rebon arguing with someone in the hallway, another man's voice who says "For the last time, I'm a magus not a barber! There are plenty of ladies to do your hair and makeup!"

Rebon says, "... and I told you this is an emergency!" He makes eyes at the other man, a towering, lean fellow in pristine, stylish, wizard's robes. I didn't even know that wizard robes could be stylish, until spotting the newcomer. He has a wide, tall, avant-garde collar that extends all the way to his britches. Side cut-outs and an unclothed chest show off Laurent's, that's his name, chiseled physique. From the hip down the garment closes, hiding the legs, like any other robe. "You know I wouldn't come to you if not for great need, and you being the very best."

For the first time Laurent takes in the sight of us, a band of rag-tag adventurers in unrepaired battle wares. "Oh... dear dear...." He says. "When's the feast?"

Rebon says, "Just over 20 minutes!"

Laurent says, "Why ever didn't you come get me sooner? These are the Champions." He clicks his tongue, and says "This is going to be a rush job." as he pulls a wand from a pocket beneath his full-torso collar. "Never fear ladies, Laurent will make you fabulous."

Laurelade looks slightly terrified, whereas Mirae's grinning ear to ear.

"Quick," Rebon says, "Put these on." and shoves a box to each of us.

Inside, I find three items entitled "Lovely Dragonswood Dress" in three different colors, red, black, and a plumb shade of purple—one of our guild colors. I hold the crimson against my body, in the mirror, it's one part red carpet, another part flamenco, with an asymmetrical hem. I'm relieved to see there's not a train because Sten said that we'd be dancing.

"This could work." I say as I swap the red for the purple. "You two and Tako are both champions, are you even dancing?"

"Oh!" Mirae says, "I forgot to tell you. It all happened while you were knocked out." Now she's nearly bursting with laughter, I take note of Laurelade, who's, surprisingly, blushing. "Tako and I are partners, no surprise there, but Laurelade threw a fit..."

"It wasn't a fit." She says. "I gave it back to him."

"Threw it, is more like it. She pelted the kid with big ears with the wreath, and he accepted!" Mirae laughs. "The squire is her dancing partner!"

"Oh my." I say.

Rebon clears his throat. "Less gabbing, more changing."

"With you in the room?" I ask.

He says, "I can step out if it'll make you go faster."

I say, "You do that."

"Come." He says, and motions Laurent into the hall.

Laurelade says, "You can just equip it using the VT interface." as her wizards robes disappear, and are replaced with a miniature version of my dress in a blink of an eye. She chose the black one.

"Hmm..." I say. "It's easy to forget after being logged in for so long." I choose the purple and spin in place. I like the way the fabric stirs. It has good motion.

From outside, Rebon says, "Almost finished?"

"Just a sec." Mirae says, and equips the red one. "Okay."

The two men return, cupping their chins. Rebon says, "You think?"

Laurent says, "You think?"

Rebon, "I agree... Okay, no." He points to me, then Laurelade, then Mirae. "You yes, you yes, you no."

Mirae says, "What?"

"Really?" Laurent says, "Candy apple red, with the green shades in your hair? Absolutely not. Someone'll mistake you for a fruit tree. Someone switch with her."

I say, "I kinda like the purple, because it represents the guild."

Rebon says, "I know, that's why I chose it."

Mirae says, "Laurelade and I can both wear black?"

Laurent says, "Maybe if you were ignorant townsfolk that didn't know any better, but two VIPs wearing the same exact outfit? Child, who raised you? Short stuff, elf girl. Swap your colors. "

They both do so using the fast change option in their VT, and this is how the person least interested in dancing ends up with the brightest color.

Admiring myself in the mirror, I say, "I like it."

Rebon says, "Thank you love, but we're not done. Your hair's dreadful."

I have another look at myself, and my hair looks about the same as it always does in Freehaven Online. They must be seeing something I can't. I ask, "What's wrong?"

"It's fine if you want to spend all day in the arena, but for this event you need something special." He takes the end of my ponytail in hand. "Look at this, not a bit of ornamentation!"

"Oh...kay?" I say.

Laurent says, "Watch." With a lightning flash flick of his wrist, he hits me with a spell that flashes pink in my face. It doesn't hurt, but makes me smell flowery, a nice perfume. I'm about to say something, when he flicks his wrist again and hits me in the face with an abrupt puff of air and flash of pink that leaves me sputtering. "Now look, and tell me what you think."

I hardly recognize myself in the mirror. Not only am I now wearing a smoky eye and natural lip makeup, that makes my green eyes pop like emeralds, but my long straight pony tail has been replaced with a wavy braided half-updo, that covers my right ear, and accentuates the slight point of my left. Sporadic threads of silver dive in and out of the braid dangling small star and lightning bolt charms.

Laurent makes a circling motion with his wand and says, "Turn for me." I do so. "Fabulous. What did I say? It's a rush job, but that doesn't mean you can't look good."

There's a new icon shining in the corner of my vision.

Styled

You're looking good!

Bonus: +2 Appearance.

Duration: 6 hours remaining.

The Champion buff that prevents my death is now gone. I hadn't noticed, but it must have faded the moment Frobod was declared the winner.

"Now, if you will don that lovely crown." Rebon says. I equip the Rose Ring of the Champion. My appearance stat has never been this high. "Perfection!" He spins me by the shoulders so I have a good look at myself in the mirror, and says "Look at you, and you see? Little thunderbolt charms like your... stick thingy."

I absently say, "It's a stave." not wanting to look away from my reflection. I need a Laurent for real life, so I don't have to spend half a day getting this level of ready for special events. Real life, Seattle. A place that I may never see again. A flash of pink from my peripheral view tells me that Mirae's now getting the treatment. I'm happy for her as she squeals in the mirror.

Mirae says, "You are the god of makeovers!"

Laurent says, "I am fantastic, aren't I?" which makes me wonder if he too is a dragon.

Leaving the dressing room, Rebon walks fast, shooing us to the front of the castle. "Hurry up! Hurry up! Just a few more minutes!"

The three of us are looking better than we ever have before. It makes me feel good, though everywhere we go eyes are watching. It's not like being in the arena where I was putting on a show. Now, I get Havenfolk stares just for existing. The air is festive as we approach the banquet. A fiddler wanders about sending men and women into displays of impromptu dance, and kitchen staff from the castle shuttle enormous carts topped with platters of covered food.

I'm not surprised to see Frobod and Tako, but the big eared boy, Sten, is also seated at a golden tableclothed champions table. As Laurelade's date, I guess his presence makes sense. Frobod, now free of his armor, is a handsome

specimen wearing a black Indo-European suit that's tight across his strong chest. His dark hair is bound in a neat ponytail. Tako, by contrast wears a white embroidered surcoat, more typical of western fantasy, and his short hair is stylishly rumpled like a boy band K-Pop star. Each wear their wild leafy crowns, and look dashing for it.

Mirae rushes to give Tako a hug.

I appreciate the eclectic garb of Haven over Freeworld, in one room you can have a knight from King Arthur's court, a man in a tuxedo, and a person in Japanese kimono, and no one will look too far out of place. The only style I can imagine truly standing out is a graphic T-Shirt, over a pair of Levis.

I embrace Frobod who whispers, something to the effect of "You look beautiful." into my hair.

I can't help but smile. Hard to believe that a few days ago we didn't know each other. I say, "Glad you're feeling better."

He says, "I've had some time to calm down, besides the day's not over."

Laurelade stands beside Sten who is considerably less debonair wearing a muddy brown vest, with an undershirt with ruffles. Many, many ruffles. So many, in fact, that they burst from the V-line of his vest, and tickle the end of the boy's chin whenever he looks downward. *Looks like someone didn't have Laurent and Rebon to help him.*

We take our seats just in time for Lord Zarentu's appearance at an end table facing the congregation. At the center of all the other tables is an eleven foot tall mountain of cooked meats on white plates. Aromatic servings of rabbit, goat, chickens, pork, and cow are arranged in the shape of a carnivore's wedding cake. In front of Meat Mountain is an open flat area with musicians in one corner, where I trust we are to dance.

I look to Mirae, who's beside me, and say "Dragons. They eat a lot."

"No kidding." Mirae says, as she draws my attention to an endless line of serving carts stretching from the far side of the banquet area, to the castle, each transporting at least a dozen platters of covered food.

Tako says, "So... is this like a buffet thing?"

"Doesn't matter." Frobod says, "It'll all taste like air anyway."

Tako says, "Damn, I forgot. Being in game this long messes with your head... Especially when whatever they marinade all that meat in smells so good."

Herald Brime, appears next to Zarentu and casts a lesser version of the amplification spell on him. He doesn't have to be quite so loud as in the arena.

"Welcome my guests." Zarentu says, "... and congratulations to my champions for a tourney well fought!" A round of applause, "First among whom is Lord Frobod of Athelon and the Toxic Muffins." Louder cheers, before Lord Zarentu lifts a calming hand and says, "Well done, my friend." He pauses, "Champions, and your partners. Come forward, and honor us all by opening this banquet with the traditional dance."

I don't know exactly what traditional dance means, but I'm confident that as soon as music starts playing muscle memory will take over as my avatar accesses the +2 dance ability from the Rose Ring of the Champion. We all stand in the clearing; the Toxic Muffins, Sten, and npc dragon winners of the other competitions with their chosen partners.

A gentle waltz fills the air.

I'm not wrong in my presumption of muscle memory. As soon as we're hand in hand and Frobod's other arm is on my back my body knows exactly what to do as we're seized in currents of graceful music. It's a nice change of pace after a day of fighting. Part of me wonders how Sten and Laurelade will manage, though they haven't started. It's just me and the Grand Champion stepping about the floor. I enjoy his body heat, and the way a breeze sweeps through my clothing with every twirl. I'm disappointed when we get a system notification that it's our time to stop, and for the next pairing to take the floor.

You have learned the skill Dance.

Current Rating: 1 (+2)

The two dragons that follow are obviously marvelous because dragon's are sexy and good at everything when they take human form. She's in a blue dress, tight on top, free flowing on the bottom. It possesses a magical luster that gives a quiet nod to the sequin dress without seeming too modern. Her partner's in a dark version of Tako's outfit. Men's fashion is more boring, but his moves are confident. You can really tell who has more than two or three points in the dance skill.

Next up are Mirae and Tako, and I just want to melt all over her. Her glowing face is the stuff that life goals are made of. Neither one of them are expert dancers, if I had to guess, like me, their only dance stats come from their Rings of the Champion. The story of joy on her face makes the performance beautiful. She's swaying, whirling, and stepping in a language that expresses freedom of that which her words won't tell. I could watch it all night.

I think, *"He better take care of her."*

They finish with a spring in her step. Tako's looking smooth like ballroom dancing's something he tackles every evening. I'm glad he didn't act too cool for the banquet, or complain about this event being some girly shit, because I want Mirae to be happy. She totally deserves it.

Tako says, "It's like going to prom."

Mirae says, "I never got to go."

Laurelade and Sten take the floor in a rhythmic disaster, though Sten's not tall, the top of her head still makes them stand crotch to face. She doesn't know when to move, and he nearly tramples her. A few paces in, the gnome casts the float spell, which brings her up to his eye level, and at least allows Sten to dance around her, while she turns and hovers about. She's the only one of us that lacks a Ring of the Champion, and therefore has no dance skill. I wonder if Rebon or Laurent could have taught her if they'd found us sooner.

The last pair of dragons perform their solo, and then all of us are floating across the floor in a swirling ring of elegant motion. The music stops, we take our bows, there's polite clapping from the crowd. The sun's setting, a great shadow obscures the fading sun. Confused chatter spreads through the festival. A new debuff appears in the top right-hand corner of my vision.

Gloom: -50% magic resistance. -10% Strength. -10% Dexterity +2 difficulty to spell casting

"*What the heck?*" I look up and see four black dragons breathing shadowy breath over the crowd beating colossal black wings to hover in place. It doesn't burn, but I assume they're the source of the harmful effect. They have glowing green eyes, and shiny black scales. Their bodies are the size of semi trucks. High above them, is a much larger foe of similar colouring. It has a shadowy aura like the negative inversion of a halo in a renaissance painting. It swoops down and perches atop the roof of Lord Zarentu's castle. It's relative proximity to a known object helps me discern that its long neck and bulky body is nearly as long as the building. Dragonswood Keep's flat roof is a cat bed for its body.

It speaks in a sonorous echoing voice, "Zarentu, I grow tired of waiting. Abandon your mortals. The ashes of these worlds will usher in a new era of dragon kind."

Red light flashes around everyone at the banquet. Magical black chains appear out of nowhere and constrain us, slapping my arms to my side, and pinning them to my body. When I struggle against them, they constrict like metal pythons.

In party chat I say, "Don't move. If you fight, they get tighter." Sten, of course, doesn't hear me as an NPC and non-member of the party. He thrashes back and forth like a frenzied nutter in a straight jacket. I call out, "Sten don't!" Too late, one moment the boy's jerking in place, the next he explodes in a shower of blood, bone and flesh. It's like he's stepped on a land mine. I feel a little queasy as the boy's forearm lies motionless on the ground a few paces from me. He's just an NPC, but damn... I liked him.

I yell, "Don't move!" hoping to save Havenfolk lives around me.

A deep rumble from the big dragon, as it laughs at our predicament. "So fragile."

Zarentu's had enough. Without warning, his cape and Roman general's costume melt away into a pattern of great white scales that cast iridescent reflections like a prism. Wings sprout from his spine, the color of white gold, as his colossal tale grows longer and longer, pushing dancers aside and knocking over Meat Mountain. His human face elongates into a yellow eyed tyrannosaurus skull filled with glistening white teeth, as he takes to the air. Each pulse of his substantial wings, stir up currents of air around us until he's some forty feet overhead. He's still climbing, but we no longer feel the drafts from his wings. Looking up, I see that Zarentu dwarfs the black dragons that cast the binding spell, though he's a small body compared to the monster atop his keep.

"Cimmerian! You dare do this now?" Lord Zarentu speaks in a voice of slow rolling thunder. "You come to my keep, and murder my guests. This is the Dragonswood Tournament. There are more than fifty dragons and eight champions on the premises."

Cimmerian, the great dragon on the castle laughs, "Champions? Mere mortals."

Zarentu says, "They will destroy you and your cultists! Dragons and champions to arms!"

The non-Toxic Muffin dancers grunt and strain under their shackles until one breaks free, bursting into her dragon shape like a kernel of reptilian popcorn. She's got a long blue body, and a barbed tail. Roars sound, as other dragons take shape, shattering their bonds in bursts of green, yellow, brown, and red scales. Tables topple under their rapid expansion. I even see Nothgoran to the side ripping away his bestial half-human form in a never before seen display of his native body—a well muscled charcoal drake.

In party chat I say, "I guess so far as the end of the world is concerned, not all black dragons are against us."

Mirae asks, "Is that the extra-planar dragon for our quest?"

"I think so," I say, "I'm pretty sure the whole tournament, for us, was leading up to this."

Frobod says, "What do you want to do? Struggle and risk popping like grapes, or sit here while dragons do the fighting?"

I say, "Mirae, Tako and Laurelade, hold up until Frobod and I try. If it's easy to break free, you give it a go. If we take major damage it's probably best for you to sit tight unless you've got crazy stamina that I don't know about."

"Sounds like a plan." Mirae says.

I push against the chains with all my strength, they squeeze tighter. I struggle, twenty percent, thirty percent of my health's lost before I stop. I check Frobod's life and see he's down an entire fifty percent.

I say, "Stop. This isn't working. There's got to be another way."

Cimmerian takes flight, and comes to face Lord Zarentu head on. The lord of Dragonswood Keep is like a child by size comparison.

Cimmerian says, "Look how they struggle."

Zarentu heaves a blast of his light breath which burns like a torrent of white starlight. Snowflakes of holy energy ricochet of Cimmerian's body and float down on the mortals below. Blue and red dragons join the attack, breathing violent clouds of elemental of fire that vary according to their dragon types.

Cimmerian hits Zarentu with a lash of his thick tail, which sends the light dragon tumbling down. It's only in the last moments of the fall that Zarentu straightens his wings and avoids a collision with the earth.

"That was close."

I think too soon. Cimmerian's swooping. We can't move. Huge teeth and a black tongue are all I see except for a portal in the back of his throat.

Loading...

Loading...

I feel weightless. My feet touch down in a smooshy wet environment that makes my feet itch. The chains are gone, so that's something. We don't have the gloom debuff either. It must have been area of effect.

"Hello?" I ask. It's so dark even with my racial ability to see in low light conditions. I'm suddenly jostled as if in an earth quake. Frobod materializes beside me. We'd been standing together.

"Ugh." He says. "It smells like death."

**You have entered a secret dungeon.
Down the Gullet
Find a way out before you're digested!
Countdown Timer: 30 minutes**

In party chat, Tako says, "Are you guys OK? Dude, he just ate you, but my party interface says you're still alive."

"I noticed." I say.

Tako says, "It was like the megalodon but more terrifying because it came from the sky."

"I get it." I say, "But we need to concentrate. We're in a secret dungeon and only have 30 minutes to escape."

Frobod says, "Equip your staff." He doesn't use the party chat. Our environment lurches like an aftershock.

I say, "Not fun." and equip Bite. Thankfully, we still have access to our inventory. The electric glow from either end of the weapon casts light on our environment. I wish it hadn't. A couple of half digested bovines stare at us from skulls with empty sockets. "Gross." I hold the weapon high overhead, and see a long tunnel reaching skyward. "You good at climbing?" I try to imagine myself re-emerging at the feast by clawing my way up Cimmerian's esophagus and out his mouth.

"I'd rather not." Frobod says, "At least not yet." Frobod has his greatsword equipped now. "Maybe we can cut our way out."

I say, "Try it." and motion for him to continue. He cuts into the nearest wall, a pink mass with a road map of purple veins working through it. A gash of red blood appears when he cuts, and our world jumps sending us to our bottoms. I say, "Ugh." and look for a place to wipe my hands without success.

Frobod stands, and charges the wall with the point of his sword trying to poke through. He strains hard, but the longer he pushes, the more violent the unstable ground becomes. It's like raiding in a bouncy castle. A putrid, smelly, half digested bull skull bouncy castle. I'm about to toss my cookies.

I say, "Stop. Stop. Just stop. It's not working."

Frobod says, "What are our options?"

"There's climbing out and poking a hole. We could also try making the dragon throw up."

Frobod says, "How do you propose we do that?"

I sigh and say, "I don't know. I'm just thinking."

"Well we better hurry because the timer's counting down."

I ask, "Do you have anything explosive with your death magic?"

"Not really." He says, "That's Laurelade's territory. If only you could Thunder Bridge us out of here."

I say, "I thought you hated that spell." My mind's reeling at the idea. *Is that possible?*

Frobod says, "It's better than being digested."

"Good point." I say, pause, and continue "Do you want me to try?"

"Can you?" Frobod asks.

"I don't know."

He says, "Check your VT to see if the spell's grayed out. If it's not you can use it, but I'd think a spell like that'd carry a restriction on being used indoors. I think this qualifies."

I say, "Let me check," and scroll through my virtual tablet. *Thunder Bridge... Thunder Bridge... Where are you? Thunder Bridge.* Ah! I grin. "You're not going to believe this."

"What?"

"The spell's available."

"No shit?" Frobod says, laughing. "Get to it, so we can give this dragon heartburn."

"I'm on it."

Casting is harder than expected. Every time I get Bite spinning up to speed, and I feel the energy welling up inside, the dungeon shakes and breaks my concentration knocking back my progress. It's not an instant cast spell, so I have to finish the whole thing between shakes.

I say, "Be ready. When it finally takes hold we're going to have, like, no notice."

I spin Bite after the last rumble. The wind it creates is sour and nauseating. *Almost there.* The small hairs on the back of my neck stand on end. The translucent violet dome of magic springs up around me. I slam Bite into the ground, and grab Frobod's wrist. Bright light, I'm seeing spots, we're yanked upward. For the count of two heartbeats our vision goes black, before we're flying in the air looking down on hills of sunset colored clouds. The wind beats my face.

"Woo!" I shout. Bite tows us like a blue comet. This mode of travel is such a rush. Frobod groans behind me. I'm not sure I can date someone who can't do roller coasters in real life, and say "Buck up!" just before our vision goes black again for a moment, and we're dropped unceremoniously down, seeing spots in front of the catawampus champion's table in a burst of ozone scented electric light.

"You're back!" Mirae says.

The scent of cherry blossoms engulfs us. Our health creeps back to maximum. She, Tako, and Laurelade have all lost their chains, but a number of frightened Havenfolk remain standing, constricted by the evil chains and red glows that bind them.

Switching to party chat I say, "Give me an update."

Mirae says, "Blue dragon set us free after you were swallowed and a bunch of other dark dragons showed up. Most of the battle is happening up there." She points skyward, "Between Cimmerian and his cultists, and Zarentu and the festival dragons." She looses a green magic arrow into the gloom, it finds purchase in the side of one of the lower hanging dragons, which is flapping its wings in place, and spewing the nasty cloud of dark all over everything. That's what's giving us the Gloom debuff. She says, "There have been a few waves of ground troops mostly just juveniles, and these half-dragon centaur creatures. Instead of human mixed with horse, they are people and reptile."

"Got it." I say. "Are there still troops on the ground?"

Mirae says, "I think we've taken care of all of them, but who knows?"

Tako hits the nearest overhead drake with a non-magic arrow, and Laurelade burns it with one of her devastating fireballs. It falls, crashing on several large circular tables—a lifeless husk. The unnatural murk enshrouding the banquet fades as the Gloom debuff dissipates.

We can now see Cimmerian on the retreat with a streamer of smoke rising from his chest. I think, "*We did that.*" as he makes his escape. Six more dark dragons follow in his wake in a bird formation. At first Zarentu gives pursuit, but then falls back to the castle. The chains seem to have snapped from the remaining Havenfolk as soon as the closest dark dragon went down. Now, everyone who's not a champion or dragon looks lost and confused, wandering about, brushing themselves off, and picking up the remains of their place settings.

Mirae says, "I'm going to look for wounded and see if there are any players that need resurrection."

I say, "Good plan." and look to the place where Sten exploded. It's as if he was never there, his corpse having disappeared as a non-player object with no loot. "I hope he respawns." Normally NPCs repopulate in a few days or so, but with all of Archangel's changes to enhance realism, you never know.

Mirae's now somewhere I can't see tending to the wounded among Lord Zarentu's guests. I see occasional pops of green light which I assume must be her healing in the crowd.

I look to my remaining guild members and say, "What do you want to do?"

Tako says, "Just wait here. Either Zarentu will come back, or our direction will become obvious. It always is in world events."

In party chat Mirae says, "I found Payneskill. Looks like he tried to fight a wave of ground troops solo, with no heals."

Tako says, "What a douche."

Mirae says, "What the..?"

Tako says, "What is it?"

I ask, "Do you need us?"

Mirae says, "It's not like that... I just got a warning when I tried to resurrect him. 'This body can only be resurrected for 12 more minutes.' Have any of you ever heard of a resurrection timer?"

Frobod says, "No."

I ask, "What happens if you wait more than 12 minutes?"

Mirae says, "No idea. Maybe they have to reappear at their bind point or in a cemetery, and take the penalties."

Thinking on Sten I say, "I hope that's all it is."

Mirae says, "Anyway, Payneskill's back up and I don't see any more dead players. Zarentu's heal force seems to have things under control."

GLOBAL ALERT

Pohrum is the first Freehaven adventurer to achieve digitization! Welcome to your new home.

For being the first, Pohrum has earned the unique golden title Pioneer. The next 300 adventurers to digitize their consciousness and become a permanent

resident of the Freeworld universe will receive standard versions of the title. Additionally, all players who digitize within the next week will receive an imburement to help them pay for their first Freeworld home.

"Isn't that our chef?" I ask.

Radio silence in party chat for a few moments, before Mirae answers "No. That's Pehrom. Pohrum's his in-game brother."

Frobod says, "Fuck, I can't believe that. Do we really want people like that in our guild?"

I say, "Don't judge a book by its cover. For all you know his whole family's here with him, and he was getting ready to raid with his best buddies when the hotfix hit."

"Yeah.. Whatever." Frobod says, "I just can't get over it. They're giving up their lives in the real world."

Mirae says, "Not everyone has good lives to go back to."

All Tako has to say is, "Hardcore." but leaves it at that.

Trying to change the subject I ask, "What's a golden title?" though I can already guess.

Laurelade says, "It's like a Haven Online first. You get a special star next to your name, and your nameplate has a gold border. You typically only get them for being the first to complete a major dungeon, or finish a super difficult quest. I've heard some people got them by being first to craft legendary items, with expensive components. We'll probably get them if our guild is the first to finish the Dragonsbane quest."

I say, "Sounds like tomorrow we go back to beating up babies in the Windroost."

Wind swirls around us as Lord Zarentu beats his wings, and touches down gently with his hind right claw; a feather trapped in a powerful dragon body. As soon as the ground takes his weight, his form sucks in on itself. Clawed limbs retract into human arms, and wings melt into his back and become a white cloak. It happens so fast, just a few seconds and we're looking at the bright haired, pale skin man in brilliant ancient Roman general's style garb. Only his piercing yellow eyes give any hint to his draconic heritage.

"Champion adventurers, come." He says, and turns back to the castle. He departs the ruined feast as abruptly as he had come.

"I guess this means dinner's canceled?" Tako says, a note of disappointment sounding in his voice.

"I'm sure you can scoop up a plate if you must," I say, "but overall I think we're best served by waiting to get back to cupcake keep."

"Fine." He says, "Kick ass lightning spell by the way. I haven't seen it."

I say, "It's Freeworld content."

As soon as Zarentu's several paces away, an iron bound chest appears where he'd been standing.

"Phat loot!" Tako cheers, and rushes forward. He tries in vain to pry open the lid before saying, "System says I don't have permission."

It swings right open when I try, the lid flying back with a hollow crunk as I give it far more force than necessary.

You have found:

Darksteel Chakram

Type:

Ranged, Exotic, Thrown

Quality:

Epic

Base Damage:

Strength + 3 (Slashing)

Equipped Bonus:

Dexterity + 2, Martial Arts+1

Special Properties:

Ignores 50% of armor.
+2 Dark Damage

Essence of the Lost Champion (Limited Edition)

This item begins a quest.

Description:

A jar of faintly glowing energy that could wink out if improperly handled. Someone in Durolan may find this interesting.

I hold up the two items. The chakram is a cold, dark gray Aerobie with sharp edges and insubstantial inky tendrils skittering over its surface. I suspect that if I equip it, the magic will allow me to wear the metal ring on my forearm like an oversized bracelet, without having to worry about it falling.

I say, "I think it's a reward for escaping the secret dungeon. Do you mind if I take this?" I motion with the chakram, "It gives a Martial Arts bonus, and I don't have any good ranged weapons."

"Take it." Frobod says. "Take both of them, I don't care."

I hand him the jar of energy, "Fair's fair. You made it out of there too."

He takes it in hand, then it disappears into his inventory. He says, "Thanks. Any of you know what it does?"

Tako says, "Never heard of it."

The other's just shrug.

Frobod looks to me and says, "If you change your mind later, just ask. I have no use for this, and it was your Thunder Bridge that got us out."

I say, "We'll put it in the guild vault then, when we're back at Cupcake Keep."

Tako says, "Let's go see what Zarentu has to say."

We find him in the keep study, two stories of leather bound books stretch from floor to ceiling. There are long research tables neighboring each wall, but

the dragon is sitting behind a simple wood desk in a cushioned wooden chair at the center of the room.

He says, "First lets settle the matter of your rewards."

In party chat Frobod says, "Finally."

Lord Zarentu says, "As grand champion I'll give you the right of first request. You may ask of me two boons. Once for the joust, since the human Sleeve was in fact trying to steal your gold, the second for taking first place in the grand melee."

Frobod pauses, "I want to go home. All of us, if it's within your power to send us back, that's what I want. Otherwise, I ask that you exert your influence on our behalf to find a way, or someone who can send us back."

"Home?" Zarentu says, "To Athelon?"

"No." Frobod says, his voice a bit sharper than I'd expected. "We're adventurers. Haven is not our home."

"You hail from the... Freeworld then?" the dragon tastes the new word.

Frobod says, "We're not from there either. I don't know how to explain."

"May I?" I ask.

Lord Zarentu gestures with his hand as if to say, "I'm waiting, be my guest."

I say, "Adventurers come from another world. We're spirits inside temporary Havenfolk bodies. That's why we're said to disappear for indefinite periods of time, often talk different from the people of Haven, and have different values."

The dragon raises a silencing hand, and then steeples his finger tips. "Is this something I should call Master Aztram for?"

I share a glance with Frobod and say, "It couldn't hurt. Especially if he'll be assisting in an investigation."

Lord Zarentu says, "One moment." as he stands and walks to a long brown rope attached to a red handle. He pulls it, and somewhere within the keep a bell tolls.

A servant on the other side of the door says, "Sir?"

Zarentu says, "Send Aztram to my study."

The old half-elf has tired eyes and disheveled robes when he enters, no doubt exhausted from having to recast protective wards on the property. "You summoned, m'lord?"

Lord Zarentu says, "Grand Champion Frobod has a favor which may require your expertise. Lady Lord Melpomine was just explaining the origin of adventurers, and how they'd like to return home."

"Adventurers, sire?" Aztram asks.

I bring him up to speed, and follow with, "Our presence was once temporary, but now we're trapped. Every time we departed this world our physical bodies faded like ghosts, but now... Ever since the event they're calling the Rip of Worlds we haven't been able to go home. We're stuck in Haven, and can no longer abandon these bodies."

Aztram says, "You're telling me you'd just come and go as you pleased, and each time you left haven your bodies would disappear?"

I say, "That's sounds about right."

Aztram says, "It explains so much, like why adventurers are so careless with their lives, and why none of you seems to have a family tree."

I shrug. *Can't argue with that.*

Frobod asks, "Can you help us?"

Lord Zarentu looks to Aztram expectantly. He clears his throat awkwardly. "I don't have anything immediately. It'll take research. This is all new and theoretical territory."

Frobod says, "It's not a theory." The growl in his voice would make a dragon proud.

"Yes... yes... I believe you." Aztram says, "What I mean is that branches of magic needed to address this problem are largely theoretical."

Frobod's face contorts into an ugly frown. I put a calming hand on his arm and say, "Like quantum physics." The comment goes right over the heads of Haven folk.

Lord Zarentu says, "It's settled then. As your first favor, Aztram and his team are tasked with researching ways for you to go home and sharing with you their findings."

Frobod says, "It's okay to share what you find with the Toxic Muffins. We're all in this together." That last part makes me feel good because it shows that I'm not the only one thinking of us as a lasting team.

"... and your next request?"

"I ahh..." Frobod says. "I hadn't thought of that. If you don't mind parting with some gear from your armory that'd be nice."

Lord Zarentu says, "Done. I'll have the order sent to my quartermaster." He pauses and looks us all over, "And you Lord Melpomine? As the only other winner of two challenges. I'll hear yours next. You have two favors."

I take a deep breath, "My first is a political matter. I want to forge an alliance between the Toxic Muffins and you and Dragonswood for the purpose of defeating Cimmerian and stopping the Rip of Worlds from spreading. After the threat's past, I'd like the opportunity to negotiate an ongoing alliance."

Lord Zarentu looks contemplative. "Dragonswood has never aligned with a guild before, much less a guild of adventurers."

I say, "Cimmerian and his death cult are a threat to us all, and we need to stand together."

He holds up a finger. "I have not declined your request yet. What you ask is unusual, but then these are unusual times. The fact that you are adventurers, which I am now to understand are a whole new type of being, lands a point in your favor."

I ask, "So you accept?"

"No." Zarentu says, "Dragons are long lived, immortal if left to our natural deaths. The demise of Cimmerian could take centuries. I am not willing to commit Dragonswood to an alliance for so long over a mere victory in the contest, no matter how impressive your skills in battle."

I deflate under his words, I'd been so certain he'd accept the offer. "...but-"

He raises his halting hand, the same as when he stopped me to summon Aztram, "I propose a compromise. A one year alignment, at the end of which we

will reconvene to determine if an extended relationship is to our favor. Is this fair?"

I think about the possibilities. A world event shouldn't last more than a few months, so in a way Zarentu has inadvertently offered more than what I asked for though, of course, he couldn't know that. As for renewing the agreement, my gut's telling me that it'll be a reputation grind over the course of the next year to ensure the alliance keeps going. Either that, or winning the contest a second time. I can live with that.

I say, "I agree, and it is."

"Done." Zarentu says, "I'll have my scribe draw up the contract. You have one more favor."

I say, "This is probably one for Aztram, but I'd like an enchantment either on my boots or staff. If you'd be willing to give me access to your enchanters I'd be appreciative."

Zarentu motions to Aztram to answer my inquiry, "What kind of enchantment do you need?"

"Damage, stamina, or dexterity." I say. "Something to help me negate armor."

"... and for the boots?" He asks.

"The same." I say "I have gloves that do bonus sonic and lightning damage when I punch, I was hoping you could work out something that could do the same for kicks."

Aztram sounds intrigued, "That's an interesting proposition. I've never seen boots of kicking before. Given some time to study your gloves, I may be able to replicate the effect."

"... and the staff?" I ask.

"I have several enchantments that would suit your needs. The first two that come to mind would add either holy or light damage to your attacks. The other would have a small chance to heal some of your health and increase your strength on a successful hit."

"Do I have to choose now?" I ask.

Lord Zarentu says, "If an enchantment is what you want, I authorize Aztram to do the work for you. Return to Dragonswood Keep when you're ready."

"It's what I want."

Zarentu says, "Done. Now for the rest of you."

The rest of the loot is distributed in much the same manner. Mirae gets to commission a bow, Tako a pair of daggers, and Laurelade gains the opportunity to learn a rare spell. With an alliance forged, and me not anticipating any PvP or single combat for a while, I decide to leave my Fists of the Thunderlord with Aztram to research. Of the two projects, he seemed more excited about creating a new kind of enchantment, so why not throw him a bone? The happier he is doing the work for me, the better chance I have at increasing personal reputation.

Chapter 20 - Risk and Burgers

It's dark when we leave the keep. I've switched back to pants for the trip home. Archibald says, "Farewell champions." as we exit the gate. I wonder if he and Lyle ever sleep.

I say, "Ready to ride the lightning?" teasing Frobod, but exiting Dragonswood keep has made him look glum. All the anger and fury of before deflated into a downcast gaze and dragging footsteps. He doesn't respond.

I say, "It's not over." to remind him of his favor, and Aztram's research.

Laurelade asks, "How many people can you take when you do that anyway?"

I say, "Technically, there's no limit assuming you have unlimited intelligence, but with my current gear I only have enough manna for one extra person."

Mirae says, "Let's take the bikes then."

I'm about to ask if we should ride or fly, but then decide that flying is better. I pull at my VT and reset the fire and ether Elechoppers so that they're once again cloning the Nightmare's stats. Owing to the tradition of Elechopper rides for guild events, I set up a new voice and gesture macro to summon all the other choppers at once.

I shout, "INFERNO!!!" and wave my middle finger, my fire bike appears in a pulse of red, and I continue "Let's ride!" while pumping my fist in the air. One after another, ether, wind, water, and earth Elechoppers appear in pops of color corresponding to their elements. They rumble to make their presence known. I say to Frobod, "We're flying since I don't want to hit anything nasty at night on the ground."

Not much chatter on the way back, so I enjoy the trip imagining I'm riding on a path to the stars. Part of me wishes I had a flying carpet so I could lay back and stare at the sky forever. It burns with the same constellations as the real world, but flickers in a majestic potion of color and fleeting streaks long lost to the glare of concrete jungles of light and technology. We're moving so fast that I only hear wind in my ears, but if stopped I have a feeling I'd be listening to songs of owls, frogs and crickets in the trees below.

Almost home.

Durolan is a blue-white beacon in the night, suspended mage lights glimmer on every corner. I was planning to land right in front of Cupcake Keep, but a stone igloo the size of a McDonalds catches my eye. I've never seen it before. Two hooded figures with black angel wings stand guard with black spears with crystal heads. Marking the entrance are a pair of columns painted with blue icons featuring a human shape up top that fades into scattered pixels at the bottom.

"A digitization station." I say.

Surprising for Durolan, there's a crowd of about ten people surrounding the silent angels. They call to me as I drop down for a closer look.

"Don't go in!" A golden haired elf says, he's wearing a fairly standard tunic and trousers for a social character.

A brunette human woman shouts, "If you go in, there's no guarantee you'll come out."

In party chat I say, "I'm going to check this out real quick. Won't be long. Head back to the castle if you want."

Frobod says, "You're not going to..."

"Relax." I say, "I'm not digitizing after just one day in game."

Mirae says, "See you there." and the rest of the Muffins fly off to headquarters. I can tell she wants to look by the way she's eyeing the pillars and guardians, but I guess she doesn't want Frobod to make a stink in front of a bunch of protesters.

Dropping out of party chat, I address the woman who shouted, another player by the name of Ashlynn. All of the protestors are PCs. "You can relax, I'm not entering. What's going on?"

Ashlynn says, "People are dying."

"Well... yeah..." I say, feeling uncomfortable about having this simple fact stated so bluntly. "I guess... that's part of the process."

Ashlynn reiterates, "They're dying and not showing up in game."

I glance at the angels upon this pronouncement, the elf, named Ceris, says "They don't move or say anything unless you attack or physically block the entrance, but do that, and they'll send you to respawn."

"That can't be right." I pull out my VT and check the guild roster. Sure enough, Pohrum's there with a little gold star next to his name. All non-hostile player names appear in blue, but I notice that his and two other guild mates names appear in a slightly different shade—a little more royal and less cerulean. "It looks like a few of my guild mates have already er..." I struggle not knowing what to call it "Converted."

"Then they're the lucky ones." Ashlynn says.

"It's not everyone." Ceris says. "It's about a one in ten chance you won't come out."

"Seriously?" I ask.

"Yeah." Ceris says.

"That's scary." I say.

The elf says, "No fuckin' kidding." in a very un-elflike manner.

"Did it happen to someone you know?"

The elf shakes his head, "No one I was close to, but a couple of tavern regulars have gone 'offline' since the stations opened. Doesn't take a genius to figure out why."

Ashlynn says, "I saw it happen. Like a lot of people, I watched the first players go in, and most came out with their title and new player tag color, but two hours later we're still waiting for a couple of them. It was just a few minutes for the others so, if it hasn't happened by now...."

I finish, "You think it won't happen at all."

"Exactly." Ashlynn says.

I say, "Damn..." and scratch the back of my head thinking. *I better warn Mirae.*

"Yeah, damn." Ceris says.

"I'd better go and tell my guild. There are some other people who were considering..."

Ashlynn says, "Don't let us stop you. The more people we can save the better."

"Thanks." I say, and lift off the ground on my bike. I'm hovering about five feet off the street when I say, "Let's add each other as contacts. I've got the real world TV upgrade in my guild hall, and a castle guardian that loves watching it and talking about the real world. If I hear anything new, I'll let you know. If you don't mind doing the same, like... if the people you saw disappear come back... I'd appreciate it."

A few seconds pass, and Ashlynn and Ceris appear as new friends on my contact list. "Thanks again." I say, and begin my ascent over roof tops in a direct line to Cupcake Keep. It only now occurs to me that I just experienced an entire conversation with a bunch of socs, without anyone commenting or even taking a second look at my rare-ass mount. This strikes me as a greater sign of concern than their words could ever be. Social gamers are all about the avatar customizations, and vanity gear.

I land on the drawbridge, and dismiss my Elechopper with a "Bloop bloop!" sound. Alfred's waiting when I swing the door open.

"Welcome back Master."

"Hey." I say, "Where's everyone?"

Alfred says, "Most are eating in the dining hall."

As I walk that direction I ask, "Were you able to help Pehrom with his food?"

"I've granted him access to the kitchen, and use of all our ingredients, but haven't helped with his cooking."

I say, "That's what I meant." as I slink into the dining room. Frobod, Mirae, Tako, and Laurelade are sitting at the end of the long table closest to the kitchen with food on their plates, and full place settings.

Tako speaks with a mouth full of food, "I take back everything bad I ever said about goblin chefs. I love this man. If I could have a food baby, I'd be all up in this burger like warm apple pie."

"Gross." I say. Mirae hits Tako's shoulder with her napkin.

"Not gross." Tako says, "It's just that good."

Mirae concedes, "The burgers are tasty."

"Wait..." I say, "You shag apple pies?"

Tako takes another bite. His eyes close in pleasure, his jaw moves in exaggerated chewing motions, to show everyone exactly what he thinks of the food. "I'd consider it if they were this good."

I'm about to respond with something stupid when the door to the kitchen swings open revealing a little, long fingered, green skinned man about a head taller than Laurelade. He's got a big nose, protruding chin, batty ears, and wears a black apron with a poofy toque blanche on his head like a five star chef. Seeing him gives me a clearer picture of Sten's heritage. *Poor Sten...* I wonder if he'll respawn.

He gives me a once over and says, "All hail the guild master. Nice to finally meet ya." He's got an upstate New Jersey accent. "Thanks for lettin' me in the kitchen." His voice wells with unexpected emotion, "It means a lot."

"Hey man," I say, wondering what happened in the real world to make him stop cooking. I'm sure it's every bit as bad as what Mirae experienced. "It's guild property. Use it as much as you like. You should thank Tako for coming up with the new style of cooking."

Mirae says, "He has... Profusely."

Pehrom says in an excited voice, "It's just burgers and steak for now, but with the proper herbs and ingredients, there's no tellin' what I could do here."

I chuckle, "You look so excited. I'm happy for you."

The goblin says, "There's been a hole in my heart ever since I couldn't cook for people. The craft skill in the game's a bunch of bullshit cuz everything you make tastes like water, and doesn't use any actual skill, but this... I'm one step closer to puttin' me on a plate again." He wipes the corner of his eye.

Until now, the only VR taste programs have been virtual restaurants, where the 'food' was all generated by the program, and cooking classrooms that allow people to refine their craft for the real world. Neither one of which enable people to cook for their friends in a social setting.

Frobod says, "What happened to make you stop cooking?"

Pehrom says, "Fuckin' boats and sharks. Me and my wife were out diving when the fuckin' tour guys turned the engine back on and the propeller started spinning." He makes a 'shrick' sound and a cutting motion over his bicep. "If that ain't bad enough, you don't want to be in the water with blood and a bunch of bull sharks. Barely made it out alive."

Frobod asks, "You lost your arm?"

Pehrom says, "Both of em' and a big ole chunk out of my thigh."

Frobod says, "That's rough. I'm sorry."

Pehrom says, "I'll tell you one thing. I never used that dive company again." He laughs. "That's some gallows humor for ya." I smile appreciating the way he uses levity to transcend his condition. He looks to me and says, "Tonight boar burgers are on the menu, and fuck all else."

Deciding that I like our chef, I tease "I'll try the salmon." sure to have a smirk on my face so he knows I'm kidding.

The goblin shouts, "Fuck all else!"

I respond, "I'll have a boar burger then."

In a chipper voice he says, "I'll have it for ya in just a second." and turns to go back to the kitchen. He looks back in the doorway and says, "Nice meetin' ya."

I help myself to a seat, and Mirae asks "So what's going on with the angels?" I'm not surprised she's the first to ask.

I say, "The angels? Nothing, they just stand there looking scary and kill anyone who tries to block the way in. The protestors, on the other hand, say people are dying without coming back into the game."

Mirae says, "How would they know?"

I say, "The human chick said that she and a few others were watching since the first few went in, and a couple of people didn't come out."

"Oh." She says, with a note of disappointment sounding in her voice. "I wonder if it hurts to be digitized."

"Of course it hurts." Frobod says, "You're dying. Stopping your heart forever. It's not supposed to be comfortable."

Mirae says, "You don't know that. The game can make us feel whatever it wants. That's what makes this whole world work, you know?"

"Hey." I say, "No fighting at the table." I then look to Mirae, "... but seriously. Some people are just disappearing, without making it back to the game."

"Is it happening to a lot of people?" She asks.

"Best guess is ten to twenty percent." I say, padding the numbers so she'll take it more seriously.

Frobod says, "That's a one in five chance you'll kill yourself for no reason." He pauses a moment to think, "I wonder if the news has more information."

"Maybe." I say, "With a story this big, a lot can happen in a day. We should check it after dinner."

Frobod with his empty plate says, "I'm ready now."

I give him a look that calls him a savage, and say "Well I haven't eaten."

A few minutes later Pehrom comes back in with a plate full of burger. It's hot, juicy, and overwhelming with the scent of fatty goodness. It even has a whole grain bun. The goblin says, "The bun's nothing because Haven bread's bullshit, but it has texture, and can soak up flavor but the meat's decent." He sets the plate down in front of me. "Bon appétit."

I say, "Well it smells good" and take my first bite. I wouldn't say I have the most sophisticated palate but I can taste hints of garlic, pepper, salt and onions mixed in the meat. I swallow and continue, "We've got to start you a garden. Herbs, vegetables, whatever you need."

"That'd be awesome." Pehrom says.

I call out, "Hey Alfred!"

The butler appears in his customary poof of smoke. "Yes?"

I say, "We need to give Pehrom some space outside for an herb and vegetable garden. See what you can do to make that happen. If you have to take space away from the flowers or jousting strip that's fine. This new food is important."

"As you wish." He says with a bow. "Is there anything else?"

"Not now," I say. "I'll let you know if I think of something." The butler disappears as abruptly as he came.

There's a little dish of red sauce beside my plate that I hadn't noticed before. I ask, "What's this?"

Pehrom says, "It's a tomato paste, not quite ketchup. Not quite what I wanted, but considering what I had to work with on my first day, it's not bad. I need to make vinegar from scratch before I can get the real flavor."

I remove the bun and shake a bit of the sauce from the saucer on to the meat. I give it a try. It's like a pizza burger without cheese. I say, "This is the best thing I've tasted in Freeworld or Haven ever."

Pehrom huffs, "Thanks, it doesn't take much."

I say, "It's good that Mirae recruited you. We're glad to have you."

My burger disappears faster than I'd like to admit. I'm a regular Hoover. Just over a day without real food, and I'm sucking down every last reminder of the real world. Wiping the corner of my mouth with a napkin, I look to Frobod and say, "Now we can go watch the TV." I half expect him to say something like "Finally." but he keeps his mouth shut, and leads our parade of well fed adventurers into the lounge.

It doesn't take long for him to find a channel with a newscaster, the same woman we saw last time, delivering updates. "The death toll rises as over one hundred players of the game Freehaven Online have died."

The screen cuts to the face of a bewildered man in a Chicago Bulls hat, and wet eyes. The screen cap names him Timothy Buck—Father of Freehaven victim. "They said that if we didn't touch him.... Didn't take the gear off, he'd be okay." His voice breaks, "... but now Jerry's gone."

Frobod's face grows hard upon seeing this, back to the newscaster, "Freehaven Online continues to provide life support for those who reach out to them, and continues to investigate the whereabouts of all players of accounts that are currently signed in."

Cut to a company man in a suit at a press conference. "We believe that many of the deaths, unrelated to equipment tampering or failure are linked to Archangel's introduction of digitization."

A reporter in the crowd says, "According to your most recent statement 56 characters have gone 'offline' since the update, and yet as of that time there had only been 51 instances of intentional removal of a player's hardware, or equipment failure. How do you explain that?"

The man raises his hand and says, "I have nothing more to say at this time." as he covers the mic with his hand. His tone is now brisk in a way that it hadn't been before. The clicks and clacks of media cameras sound louder on television as he turns to go. He's having a very bad day.

Frobod says, "Sounds like digitization isn't all what it's cracked up to be."

"Still," Mirae says, "More people are making it through the process than not."

Frobod says, "How can you even be sure it's what you want? What if you get digitized and can't feel anything. What if you're whole life is spent experiencing a world like the regular haven food?"

"It won't be like that." Mirae says.

"How do you know?" Frobod counters.

"Because we have two guild members that have already done it and I asked them! They say it's just the same except... sometimes things seem a little more vibrant by comparison to what we have now."

"What about your family?" Frobod asks.

Mirae shouts, "They can visit me if they want!"

I take a deep breath and put a hand on Mirae's arm. "I don't want to lose you." I can feel her tense muscles beneath my fingers. "I don't have a lot of friends Haven side. The people in this room are pretty much all of them."

She gives me a little hug and says, "I'm not going anywhere." The contact of her body against my own feels good. Something I can trust not to disappear.

I say, "I don't know about you guys, but I'm beat." It's hard to say whether this is a side effect of being signed in for so long, or if this is a new element of realism imparted by Archangel's update, but I've never felt so tired in a game. My whole body feels the kind of heaviness I used to get after playing in the snow as a kid, coming inside, and plopping down beside the fireplace.

"I hear ya." Tako says, and looks to Mirae, offering her his hand. "Let's go."

"Alright." She says, getting to her feet. I get the feeling they want a little quality time before bed.

Frobod says, "I'm gonna watch TV for a while."

Laurelade says, "Me too."

"Suit yourselves." I say, "You have your rooms. What do you say tomorrow we get back to Windroost farming? We still have a chance at the golden title."

"Whatever." Frobod says, "We'll all be here." The last carries the defeated tone that comes with a reminder that we're trapped in game.

I look at the TV screen, still the news, and say, "Don't torture yourself. We'll find a way out."

Laurelade asks, "What's our progress on the quest anyway? I'm too tired to check my VT."

I pull out my own, and check out the quest interface.

Limited Edition - Guild Quest

Dragonsbane - Part 1

Difficulty: Variable

An extra-planer dragon has torn a rip in the wall between two worlds. Investigate the disturbance and bolster your dragon slaying prowess so you can destroy the foul beast and prevent further damage to the land.

Objectives:

Discover the Identity of the extra-planer dragon that caused the rip between worlds.

1/1

Slay 50,000 dragons or dragon kin.

5,002/50,000

Rewards:

Title: Dragonslayer

Reputation: 10,000 Reputation in All Playable Factions

Access to specialized gear and enchantments from Havenfolk merchants

I say, "First objective complete, 5k out of 50 toward farming."

"Not bad," Laurelade says, "Considering that we didn't do much killing at the tourney."

The newscaster says, "In spite of the risks, or perhaps because of them, many continue to log into Freehaven Online, while governments around the world seek to confiscate unused hardware."

"Take it easy." I say, "I'm going to bed."

Back in my room, I peel off my battle leathers and set Bite against the wall. It disappears into my inventory as soon as I let go. Now I'm standing here in an

oversized tunic like a night shirt. I'm tempted to take a bath, but my heavy body just says, "Go to bed."

I slip under the covers.

You are in bed.

Would you like to sleep? Yes / No

Chapter 21 - The Lost Champion

My eyes pop open. Darkness. Shouting in the hall.

"Melpomine! Wake your ass up!" That's Tako. I turn my head and see the faint glow of blue mage lights outside my room. "Melpomine!" He's a silhouette standing in my door. Apparently I forgot to close it, and the keep won't let him in without permission.

I groan, "What time is it?"

"I don't know." He says, "Late. Mirae's missing."

That catapults me to full alertness. "Missing? Where'd she go?" Probably not the wisest of questions, so I may not be as alert as I thought.

"I don't know!" Tako says.

"Well, when did you last see her?"

"We stayed up late talking until, like, 20 minutes ago and said good night. I found something in my bag that I forgot to give her, but she didn't answer when I knocked on the door."

"Maybe she's sleeping?" I ask.

"Check your VT." He says. I do so, pulling up my friends list as he continues talking. "She told me she wouldn't go without telling me."

"Fuck." I say, seeing what he's talking about. He and I are both listed as being at Cupcake Keep whereas Mirae's location is listed as Durolan. "You don't think she's going for digitization do you?"

"That's what I'm afraid of." Tako says. "I don't get why she wants to do it so much."

I sigh, an angry sound that reveals my fear, frustration, and understanding of where she's coming from. "Let's go." I say, "There's no time to rouse the others."

I fast equip my gear using the VT instead of putting it on manually because every second counts. My heart's beating. *Damn it, Mirae. How could you?* Alfred appears in a poof as I leave my chambers.

I say, "Going out Alfred, no time to chat, unless you have information on Mirae."

Alfred says, "She went out the front door a few minutes ago."

I say, "That's what I thought. Tako let's move."

Now, in the courtyard, just on the other side of the draw bridge, I stop, look to Tako and say, "It's time to ride the lightning. Stand still and hold on to your butt." The spell may only save us three or four minutes of travel time over the Elechoppers, but three or four minutes is a hell of a lot when gambling with a friend's life.

Woosh... woosh... woosh... Bite's spinning, each side like blades in a human sized fan, weaving a pattern of azure circles in the air around me. The energy rises, chi ready to explode from inside, I grab Tako's wrist as lightning reaches down and connects with Bite. Bright white, we're seeing spots, and then nothing as we're yanked into the sky. Now we're looking down on a blanket of night clouds with stars twinkling above us. My hair's flapping behind me like a war banner. It's taking too long considering the short distance we're going, and I

curse that the length of the flying scene appears to be the same regardless of distance traveled.

Our vision blacks, white light, we're seeing spots as we're roughly deposited in a thunderbolt ten paces in front of the stone igloo. Angelic guards stand ready.

"Mirae!" Tako shouts. "Don't do it!"

I say, "Let's talk about this."

We're both running toward her. Tako reaches for her arm, but the angel guards lower their menacing spears. I say, "Don't block her!" knowing that if they attack, he'll die and possibly lose his chance to say goodbye.

Mirae stops, but doesn't want to look at me. Her back's facing us. "You're not supposed to be here."

I say, "We're here because we care about you. Toxic Muffins. You're a healer. We've got a good thing going."

Mirae says, "I told you I'm not going anywhere. We'll still have a good thing when I come out."

Tako blurts, "I'll be your boyfriend! Please, anything! I don't want you to die!"

Mirae says, "You can still be... in a few minutes. When I come out of there."

Tako says, "No." and grabs her.

The two angels spring into motion, sinister statues infused with life. Not a heartbeat passes before the two crystal tipped weapons are buried in his chest. He's been one-shotted. The angel on the right pulls its spear free, a smear of crimson covering the tip. The angel to the right does the same. Tako's digital body shimmers and fades from the ground like a ghost. Just a dark blotch on the cobble stones to show that he had been.

Mirae says, "He'll be back at the keep in a few minutes. He changed his bind point. We did it together so we'd always end up at the same place."

"Mirae..." I say, "I understand why you're doing this, just... wait a little longer. At least until they have it fixed."

Mirae says, "If I wait the whole thing could be disabled. As soon as they crack whatever defenses Archangel's set up they can get to rolling back all the stolen technology. This may be the only shot I have at..."

"At?" I ask, hoping to keep her talking.

"At being normal! I don't want to be someone's burden anymore."

"I get that... I really do."

"Do you?" She asks. "Everywhere I go, and in everything I do someone's got to take care of me. That's not even counting the financial aspects. Just time. They can't even go on vacation together because of little old me, or they could but someone has to sit in the hotel babysitting instead of snorkeling or parasailing. Can't go to the amusement park, because cripples can't ride roller coasters. I'm holding everyone back, and I couldn't change that until now. Once I transition, and the logout gets sorted, they can visit me any time they want."

I say, "There's a one in five chance you won't come out of there."

Mirae says, "Those are good odds, because it leaves me with a four in five chance that I'll be fine. Better than fine because I'll be where I'm happiest... with

people like you. This could be a one in a lifetime shot, and considering what I have to go back to... I'm ready to make this place my home. I want to be a Pioneer."

I say, "Mirae just..."

"This is my life. Let me have this. For the first time since I was eleven years old, I have a say in my own destiny."

I can already feel her slipping away, a tear rolls down my cheek. She turns, takes some steps toward me, and wipes it away with her thumb. "I'm coming back." She says, "When I get back here you'll be my family. Big sister with a cool job, okay?"

I sniff, and pray for no more tears because I want to be strong... for her. "Okay." I say, "I'm the tank, but you've got more courage than all of us." I hate that I'm letting her do this. "Give me a hug."

She wraps her arms around my body, and I rock the girl in my arms, never wanting to let go. I commit her smell to memory, earthy, and perfumed. Like a proper elf from any fantasy. I whisper, "I'll be waiting" into the side of her head. I let go with a heavy heart.

She says, "I need to get on with this before Tako comes back and gets sent for another respawn. I don't need that on my conscience."

"Alright..." I say.

She smiles, the most beautiful smile I've ever seen her make, and says "Thank you." I take a snapshot for later viewing. "Just sit tight for a few minutes, and I'll be right back."

She turns, and enters the igloo.

* * * * *

"Mirae, no!" A tiger roars as Tako leaps off his mount, and comes sprinting at me. It's a black cat unlike anything in the real world, with even blacker stripes.

I say, "She just went in."

Tako punches me in the shoulder, hard, but not enough to send me flying. There's no health loss, and I assume that's why we're not surrounded by city guardians. "How could you let her go?"

"It was her decision." I feel like another person as I'm talking. "I couldn't have stopped her if I wanted. I tried to talk, but if I'd raised a hand to her, I'd be sent for respawn the same as you." I take a deep shaky breath, "All we can do is wait, and hope she comes out."

"How long does it take?" Tako asks.

"I don't know." I say.

"Hey angels! How long does it take?" They stand silent and stoic as ever. Tako says, "It's taking too long. It's taking too long! She should be out already. How long can it take?"

"She just went in." I say, "Give her a few minutes before we start jumping to conclusions."

Minutes pass, I enable the clock in my user interface to keep tabs on it. Each second ticks painfully. The more of them that pass, the more uncertain I become in my stomach. I whisper, "C'mon Mirae, you're the strongest."

Tako says, "She's not coming back. She's not coming back. How could you let her go?"

How could I? It had seemed like the right thing at the time. Should I have pressed harder and made her angry at me, resentful? What would that have accomplished, she'd have just walked through the door anyway. *Would she have?* Was there anything I could do?

In a quiet voice, almost too soft to hear under the ambient sounds of Durolan at night, I say, "I don't know."

I hate waiting, each breath makes my heart beat in my ears a little louder, Tako's physically shaking. *This can't be happening.* I peer down the tunnel toward whatever awaits adventurers seeking digitization and see nothing. There's a closed wooden door separating the living from the great beyond. *This... can't... be... happening.*

"Mirae!" I call, into the building, but no one answers. The angelic guards loom with their spears.

"How long has it been?" Tako asks, his voice rattled.

"I say, I don't know." and call again at the building, "Mirae!"

Mirae has gone offline.

"NO!!!!!" Tako shouts, in a voice that sounds more beast than human. He collapses into my chest, sobbing. I feel the burn of tears streaking down my face.

I killed her.

In a voice so rattled that I hardly recognize it as my own, I say "You said that you would come out..." I sob, and pull Tako closer to my breast desperately needing human contact. I can't even imagine the guild without Mirae, and every time I try, thick crystal tears drop off my face. "Come back..." I whisper, "You will never be a burden."

I collapse to my knees feeling seared and hollow, staring at the tunnel of no return. Tako sits cross legged beside me, still sniffing, and wiping tears from his face. We just sit and stare for over an hour hoping for a change. Sometimes my mind plays tricks on me as I think I see something moving at the end of the tunnel, but it's just a lie. A lie of my subconscious to give me hope, and make me feel better. It's not working. Every time I think my tears have dried up, I remember the elf's smiling face as she rode her first Elechopper, or danced with Tako, and more come pouring.

"God sucks," I sniffle. "He takes us young, and he takes the best of us. Mirae was good, she deserved a fucking chance."

A hand on my shoulder startles me. I look back and see Frobod looming over me, over us.

"You weren't in the keep, and I saw she was offline. I'm sorry." His voice is somber.

I sniffle and wipe my eyes. "What are we going to do? It wasn't supposed to turn out this way."

A pause from Frobod before he says, "We go back home and plan her funeral. I can't agree with her decision, but she was our friend."

Tako moans, "She's not gone. I can't believe she's gone..."

"Neither can I..." I say.

Frobod just nods, and extends his hand, helping me up off the street.

The next twenty-four hours are spent planning the funeral, and reaching out to all of Mirae's friends via the guild mates she recruited. Most of them had already joined, but those more interested in socializing in town than going on adventures received their invitations to Cupcake Keep. Everything comes together fast due to us living in a digital environment, though Pehrom laments that he hasn't had more time to round up viable ingredients to make the most of his craft before the feast in her honor.

Now we're gathered around a special corner of the garden that's been trimmed into a presentable state. I went back to Dragonswood Keep to collect her custom bow, which now serves as her tombstone, set on display among the roses, upon a magical 'rack' that makes it hover in air surrounded by a column of green light—her favorite color.

I say, "Mirae was my first new friend upon coming back to Haven. She rescued me from some bandits, and then joined us for our first run through the Windroost. It's hard to believe that was just a few days ago, but in our time together she left a deep impression. She was a force of good in the world, thinking of others before herself, and wanting to leave this place a little bit better than she found it. She succeeded, with me at least, because I feel that I am a better person for having known her." I motion to all of the people she recruited, as well as the friends she didn't. "You guys were what were most important to her. She almost didn't join the Toxic Muffins because she didn't want to leave you. You're the reason that Haven became her happy place, and why she made the choice that she did. Those of you who know about her personal life know that this was where the best of her shined brightest." A number of her friends nod their heads, even in death not outing her disability. "Before she went in she told me I'd be her big sister. I hope I can live up to that title. I also hope that she's happy, wherever she is now, because she deserves it."

I step aside and allow her other friends to speak, some of which have known her since the launch of this game. It makes me feel good to know that they at least know what happened to her, but my heart grows heavier knowing that I'm still not any closer to discovering Jordan's old friends. I will in time.

A moment of silence for Mirae, and we all turn to head back into the keep. I'm not hungry, but Pehrom has worked hard to prepare a tasty meal, even if it does consist of wild game steaks, and hamburger. The goblin catches my arm as I linger toward the back of the procession.

"Hey ahh..." He starts, sounding awkward in his New Jersey accent, "I just want to say thanks for what you're doin' here. A lot of people ya know, they hear about a girl like her, start callin' us Feebs n' shit, but not you. You're a good guild leader."

"She was my friend." I say.

"Yeah I know." The goblin says. "But I'm glad she brought us together, and I'm glad to be one of your Muffins. I know it ain't the same, but my kid game sister's got some healin'. She can take care of you."

"Thanks." I say having not thought about who'd be replacing Mirae's heals in our groups. I just figured that since she recruited so many members, there'd have to be at least some heals among them. "Pohrum, right?"

"Nah, that's my game brother. Pahrem's my sister."

"I've seen her." I say.

"Yeah, well... I'll make the introduction proper over dinner. So you can talk about what your planning."

"Planning?" I ask.

"Fuckin' Dragonsbane man. Get with the program. We're all here for two reasons, Mirae, and the fuckin' Dragonsbane quest. She wanted it. Best thing I can think while we're all here is to roll hard, and get us some golden stars."

"The title..." I say.

"You're damn right the title. Let's do it for Mirae, she wouldn't have split up our old guild if she didn't want it. We've got to make us the world first." I reach out, bend over, and give the little man a hug. He says, "Hey naw... What is that?"

"Just my way of saying thank you." I say, "Being digital and all with her inventory off limits, there's not much left to hold on to, but if we can get that title and dedicate it to her... It's something we can always remember."

"I know." the goblin says, "That's what I've been sayin'. First thing tomorrow we've got to be hunting dragons. Can't let some other guild beat us to it."

"Fuck tomorrow." I say, imitating his speech patterns. "We're farming the Windroost tonight."

The goblin says, "That's what I'm talking about."

Epilogue - The Dragon Slayers

It's a week later. No word on getting out, so I can only assume my body's hooked up in a hospital bed somewhere.

I yell, "Nothgoran! Go!"

Nothgoran health 2%. I slip out of the way of his massive axe, and counterattack with Bite. Electric worms squirm over his armor. Tako stabs from behind. Frobod crashes into him with his sword, and our big eared healer lobs an orb of sickly goop which she insists is not a grenade.

I shout, "Take cover!"

The ball explodes sending corrosive slime everywhere. It certainly seems like a grenade to me. A grenade of acidic Jell-O. I'm okay thanks to a resistance spell Pahrem stuck on me. The slimy projectiles slink right off, but Frobod and Tako both leap, duck and roll. *I thought that was supposed to be for fires.*

Nothgoran takes the brunt of the impact and falls to his knees, streamers of caustic smoke rising from his armor. He then collapses on his face.

Congratulations!

You have completed Dragonsbane - Part One.

Visit merchants in the capitol cities to discover dragon slaying items.

You have obtained the title Dragonslayer.

Freehaven First!

Cheers erupt from my guildies, as he goes down, and we all get the notice. Golden "Dragonslayer" titles appear next to Tako and Pahrem's names as they toggle their displays. I pull out my VT and do the same, in just a few seconds we're all golden Dragonslayers. I kiss Bite's shaft and raise it in the air, and say "This one's for you Jordan." I look into the sky beyond the balcony and say, "...and Mirae for you. You're the best siblings ever."

The following quest is now available.

Limited Edition - Guild Quest - Dragonsbane - Part 2

Difficulty: Variable

You have discovered the identity of the extra-planar dragon, and have practiced slaying its kin. Destroy Cimmerian and his dark cultists to prevent the rip between worlds from spreading.

Objectives:

Destroy Cimmerian

0/1

Cultists Slain

3/450

Slay 100,000 dragons or dragon kin. 50,000/100,000

Rewards:

Title: Dragonsbane

Reputation: 10,000 Reputation in All Playable Factions

Extremely rare reagents that can be used to make items of great power.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I tap yes, and send out a guild announcement.

"You all rock! Thanks for all your hard work. It looks like we've got a new quest."

Frobod breathes heavily and says, "Twelve runs today. I'm beat. I need a hot bath, and some goblin burgers."

I say, "I think we could all use them."

Pahrem is a cute goblin girl with green skin, purple hair, and cheeks flecked with darker green freckles. Her khaki robes with a faint dark halo somehow combine the pocket utility of cargo pants with the mystique of high wizardry. She says, "So whatta ya wanna do next? Dragonsbane Two, or The Lost Champion?" She has the same accent as her game brother, a common trait among Haven goblins.

I pause and say, "I've got a guy to see in the morning about The Lost Champion. If it's what I think it is, we're all going to hell."

The End
of
Freehaven Online:
Dragonsbane

Book One of Freehaven Online

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Dear Reader,

Thank you for reading my novel. I hope you enjoyed it. It was a labor of love borne of long years of online, table top, and live action gaming. As a newer author, my ultimate goal is to be able to write books like this for you full time so that there will be more adventures for you to devour. If you enjoyed this book, the best way to make that happen is to post glowing reviews on Amazon or Goodreads to encourage more readers to experience this story. They mean a lot.

I'd also like to give special thanks to Blaise Corvin, and the [GameLit Society](#) for their continued efforts in bringing fans and authors of LitRPG/GameLit together and nurturing our community.

You're the best,
Jun

Glossary

Term	Definition	Novel Specific
Adventurer	An in-game term used to reference player characters, with a strong association with hunting monsters, and taking foolish risks with their lives.	No
Agro	The hostile attention of an attacking monster. If a player is being attacked by a non-player character, they have agro.	No
Alias	An in game identity with a unique appearance, name, and reputation score.	Yes
Attributes	Stats that represent a character's basic capabilities prior to equipping magical items, or other forms of magical items. In Freehaven online, attribute scan only be raised via point breaks.	No - Includes novel specific implementation
Avatar	A player's in-game body	No
Bind Point	A place where a player character re-appears in the game after death	No
Boss	A powerful monster that must be defeated to complete a dungeon.	No
Buff	An in-game beneficial effect with a limited duration that enhances a property or properties of a character	No
Challenge Rating	A score given to PCs and NPCs to reflect how difficult they would be to defeat in single combat based on the number of points invested into attributes. PC (and pet) challenge ratings are displayed as "Easy," "Average," "Very Difficult." etc. Whereas NPCs display as question marks, the more of which are present the greater the difficulty becomes.	Yes
Class	Short for classification. A term that defines a character's play style and abilities they have access to. Freehaven online does not use a class system, however players often refer to themselves as having a class to reflect the abilities they've learned and preferred style of game play. Some classes in other games, such as Paladin, refer to social titles earned through game play.	No - Includes novel specific implementation
Cooldown	The period of time a player must wait before using the same spell or ability again. For example, a spell with a 30 minute cooldown can only be used once every 30 minutes.	No
Crafting	The in-game production of goods that can be used by players.	No
Debuff	An in-game harmful effect with a limited duration that weakens a property or properties of a character	No
DPS	Damage per second. Refers to either a character's damage output, or their role as damage dealers in a party	No

Drop	The act of a (usually non-player) character leaving behind items for players to collect after their defeat. When used as a noun, this refers to in-game objects that can be collected after defeating an opponent.	No
Dungeon	A special location with powerful monsters that can be fought with the promise of loot.	No
Enchantment	A permanent spell cast upon an item to enhance its properties	No
Farm	The act of playing the game in a repetitive manner with the intent of generating a high number of the same item, reputation, or statistic.	No
Gank	To be killed in player vs. player combat suddenly, without having had a chance to react or prepare for combat.	No
Guild	A player run organization that serves as an in-game community. Guilds often have themes such as social, raiding, crafting, etc.	No
Healer	A character that restores health to injured characters.	No
Hotfix	An update applied to a computer game while players are still connected.	No
Kite	A gaming tactic where a player does just enough damage to an enemy to hold agro, while continually fleeing, thus causing the enemy to chase them.	No
Loot	In-Game rewards for killing monsters, and or completing quests. When used as a verb, it is a reference to collecting these rewards from defeated opponents	No
Manna	Mystical energy that is used to power spells.	No
Name Plate	Text that appears above or beside a character's avatar in the user interface revealing their name, and any titles they choose to display. An expanded name plate also reveals their appearance and challenge ratings.	No - Includes novel specific implementation
Noob	A new/inexperienced gamer. Also used as an insult to experienced gamers to imply that they don't know what their doing.	No
NPC	Non-Player Character	No
PC	Player Character	No
Point Break	Also known as a "Ding." The equivalent to leveling, when a character receives additional points to invest in their attributes.	Yes
PvE	Player vs. Environment - Refers to playing the game against computer generated opponents	No
PvP	Player vs. Player - Refers to fighting against other players in the game as opposed to computer generated opponents	No
PWN	Derived from "own," to mercilessly defeat an opponent.	No

Raid	A large number of players (typically greater than five) assembled into a single group for a common purpose (typically completing a dungeon).	No
Raiding	The act of exploring dungeons and killing NPC monsters for loot, currency, and experience	
Range DPS	DPS characters that can inflict significant damage at range (example: Archers, fireball tossers)	No
Reputation	A numerical value that measures how NPCs will react to you. Higher reputation leads to better treatment, and unlocking higher tiers of reputation often results in added benefits such as lower prices from merchants, preferential treatment, and access to exclusive in game items.	No
Res	Short for "resurrection." A spell used for returning a fallen character back to life, without the in-game penalties for dying.	No
Respawn	The act of coming back to life after an in game death without the aid of a resurrection spell.	No
Roll	Typically refers to rolling a computer generated 10 sided dice to determine who will obtain loot. It can also refer to the conscious activation of a non-combative skill such as spotting.	No - Includes novel specific implementation
Skills	Learned abilities. In Freehaven Online, skills can only be advanced by training, and/or actively using the skill/ability in the game.	No - Includes novel specific implementation
Soc	Short for "Social Gamer." Players that are more interested in hanging out, chatting, and engaging in non-combative game play	Yes
Spells	Magical abilities that require manna to activate.	No - Includes novel specific implementation
Stats	Statistics - Numerical representations of a character or item's capabilities	No
Tank	A character designed to take/absorb significant amounts of damage and hold the attention of attacking enemies	No
Trainer	A non-player character that can teach player characters new abilities, and/or skills.	No
Vendor Trash	Useless items that can be sold to merchants for currency.	No
Wipe	When all characters in a party die.	No

